FABIEN SMADJA

SALES AND NEGOCIATION IN PRIVATE WEALTH MANAGEMENT

Key Strategies, Methods, and Tools for Success

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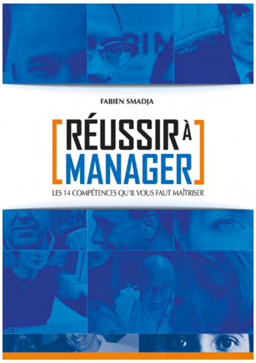
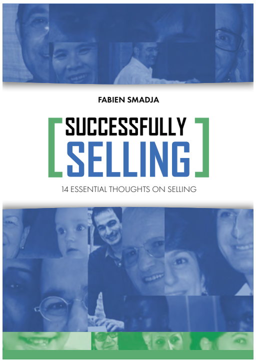


Successfully selling



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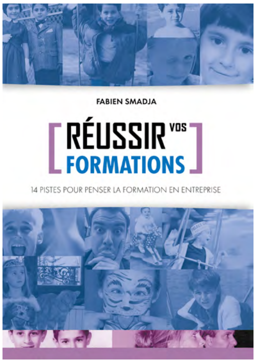

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Preface

For Annabelle and the wisdom of her heart:
the light of our lives.

Sales and negotiation **in private wealth management**

1. INTRODUCTION

Through a lot of hard work, I managed to overcome imposter syndrome. Now, I make a conscious effort to avoid falling into the opposite trap: slipping into the arrogance of thinking I have all the answers.

However, I must remain modest, because, in truth, I haven't invented anything. I've reproduced, reformulated, and refined—but in the end, I've created very little. My role is simply that of a messenger, whose only real merit is to observe, remember, and pass things on.

This book follows in the footsteps of the previous ones; it's a pedagogical account. It brings together all the sales training I've delivered to bankers over the past 38 years.

Some readers, who have been kind and brave enough to follow my work and correspond with me, often ask whether my compulsive need to take notes has ever gone away. I tell them that thankfully, it's still there, just as persistent as ever.

I carried out extensive research and spent many hours at the Uni Mail university library in Geneva. One thing quickly became clear: very little has been written about sales and negotiation in private wealth management. That gave me even more reason to explore it.

This book does not claim to cover financial investment strategies; instead, it focuses on the commercial aspects of client relationships in wealth management.

2. WHY THIS BOOK?

Switzerland may be the global home of wealth management, but we are far from being the world's best salespeople. Our Swiss cultural roots often make us reluctant to engage in direct "selling." recall how private bankers looked genuinely taken aback when, back in the 1990s, I first approached them to offer sales seminars ("Surely you can't be serious, Mr. Smadja!").

That's why I want to do my bit to help wealth managers [1] sell with more confidence, grit, and style. The aim is to help reawaken the commercial instinct within banking institutions.

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1 "Wealth manager" and RM (Relationship Manager) are used interchangeably to refer to the same role.

Organized sales training courses in this sector are few and far between. Business cultures within banks are very uneven across the market. The CWMA (*Certified Wealth Management Advisor*) program has recently raised awareness of this issue, and encouraging progress is now being made.

3. SOURCES OF INSPIRATION

This work draws on many years of experience navigating diverse banking environments, forming the basis for the recommendations and analyses presented here.

This reflects the dynamics of an exceptionally specific relationship. No other commercial relationship is as interconnected as this one. Intimacy is the essential principle and the secret to success, and this is what makes the profession unique.

This is not the work of an outside observer of sales, but of someone who was fully involved – engaging daily with relationship managers across numerous Swiss and foreign banks to challenge and explore the commercial relationship. I interviewed hundreds of wealth managers and met many through my training sessions. I also took part in client meetings as an intermediary or business introducer, and even delivered pitches myself for the partners I worked with at the time.

The material comes from a variety of sources. Like a teacher, I drew on the intelligence of my training counterparts. I have not been able to identify every source I’ve used; please let me know of any omissions so I can correct them.

4. GENERAL CONCEPT

My aim is to restore the prestige of banking sales and to make the act of selling as refined as possible.

You can read this in countless ways, depending on your needs. It’s intended as a flexible learning tool that you can dip in and out of, as and when you want, with each chapter designed to be fully self-contained.

This is where it all begins. read that, you'll need to put everything into practice.

Our test readers say there is plenty to inspire reflection, with a mix of anecdotes, expert insights, exercises to work through, along with five key takeaways at the end of each chapter.

This method is designed to get you moving. I’m sorry to say, reading this book won’t be a leisurely stroll.

Please read approach with the intention of changing something about your attitude to sales. Otherwise, do nothing – and rest assured, if you change nothing, nothing will change!

5. PRIVATE BANKING

This isn't about promoting private bankers (well, maybe just a little), but rather to highlight cultural markers that help explain the current mindset of private banking.

My work draws heavily on the exemplary nature of private banking in Switzerland, a deliberate choice as that’s where the bulk of my experience lies.

This aspect of the Swiss economy could prompt reflection among bankers the world over.

Introduction

Private banking,
a business like no other

La gestion de fortune est une activité commerciale dont les finesses n'ont d'égales que ses contraintes !

TEACHING OBJECTIVES

After reading this chapter, you will be able to:

- Understand the specific characteristics and challenges of wealth management.
- Appreciate the value of complex sales and the intricacies of the sales approach in the banking sector.

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Introduction

1. THE FUTURE OF SWISS BANKING LIES IN ITS PAST!

Gone are the days when private bank lounges were hushed environments where clients discussed their money in whispers. Today, a lounge is a conference room, equipped with all the latest technology.

Nowadays, the younger generations of wealth managers operate in a completely different context and must understand the historical context of wealth management in order to do their job effectively. This is the focus of the following pages.

A Swiss atavism?

If you interfere with banking, you're interfering with one of Switzerland's most deep-rooted traditions.

Expertise in wealth management could only have emerged from such a country. It's in the genes! Trust is woven into its DNA, developed and passed down through the centuries.

Switzerland is one of the world leaders in wealth management, with over 100,000 people working in the banking sector nationwide[1]

In 2020 alone, the financial sector accounted for 35,617 jobs in the canton of Geneva.

The paradigms have shifted in recent years, and the banking system has had to adapt. The aftershocks of the 2008–2021 financial crises are still being felt. Meanwhile, large-scale digitalization is beginning to reshape the way clients interact with their banks.

What have been the most significant upheavals?

- The end of banking secrecy (2013)
- Changes in retail banking
- Online banking
- The rise of digital banks
- Successive tax amnesties
- Tax conflicts and legal proceedings abroad
- Inclusions on tax haven lists (EU, OECD, Oxfam)
- A regulatory avalanche: QI, FATCA (2014), Basel III (2018), MiFID (2018); LEFin/LSFin (2020).

The rankings of Swiss financial markets have suffered as a result.

This means that Swiss banks (particularly those in Geneva) must act quickly by:

- Achieving the necessary scale
- Cutting costs
- Enhancing productivity
- Improving performance
- Strengthening expertise
- Innovating and investing (digital banking/fintech/regtech)
- Being flexible (adapting quickly)

1 Source: ISFB Bilan de Compétences Bancaires (Banking Skills Assessment) launch, 2022.

*"Clients are never annoying;
having none is what's really annoying!"*

The role of private banking in the Swiss economy

Wealth management plays a key role in Switzerland's economy, contributing substantially to both tax revenues and GDP. It is (finally) a "clean" financial center at the heart of Europe, with professionals known for their skills and integrity. Switzerland is a country that naturally thinks in "multi," from multilingual to multimarket, multinational, and more.

Swiss bank employees share the same roots and values: discretion, understated competence, and dedication to others. It's an ingrained attitude, much like that of Henri Dunant, the founder of the Red Cross. This is the admirable side of banking. Truly admirable, as the majority of bankers genuinely embody this culture. But, of course, there's also a less admirable side, and there's no shortage of books written about it.

If you ask a banker (which I've done hundreds of times), "*What's your mission?*" they'll reply, "*We help our clients make money, of course, but more importantly, we help them keep it.*" Making money implies taking risks, while keeping it means managing those risks. The Swiss are very skilled at managing risk.

*Making money is about taking risks.
Preserving capital is about managing risk.*

Gradually, new players are entering the private wealth management sector.

This includes foreign banks as well as insurers setting up in Switzerland. Independent wealth managers, notaries, and specialized non-financial institutions are also joining the field.

In the wealth management sector, traditional private banks have key attributes in reaching new client bases: discretion, security, reputation, brand, network, the depth and variety of their services, and financial expertise.

The "natural" advantages of private banks

Finance has become a way of predicting income by adjusting the necessary risks and paying the right price. The human relationship in finance used to be essential, and private bankers have preserved this relational quality as a key commercial tool.

What are the key advantages of Swiss bankers for their international clients today?

- Clients in Switzerland can count on reliable institutions to handle complaints efficiently and transparently.
- Clients don't care about the political stripes of the Federal Council members; they know the political system is stable and will remain so for a long time.
- The legal system is clear and accessible.
- Banking secrecy no longer exists, but it has left its mark. It has transformed into a culture of discretion with all the behaviors that come with it.
- In Swiss institutions, banking operations run efficiently. This is the basis of service quality and the solution to many problems.
- A bank is series of ongoing delegation and checks.
- There are rarely any unpleasant surprises.

« I LIKE BORING BANK »

A wealth manager was talking to his client, asking what he liked about Swiss banks. The client gave a striking but very apt description of how foreign clients perceive the Swiss banking system.

He said, “There are two things I like about you; the first is that you are boring but reassuring. For me, that’s a quality; I like boring banks because I know that security comes first. You would rather sacrifice technology or even profits for the safety of your accounts, you’re obsessive about it.

The second thing is that you believe financial problems aren’t fatal, but reputation problems most definitely are.

2. A BROAD OVERVIEW OF PRIVATE WEALTH MANAGEMENT

A. AT THE HEART OF WEALTH MANAGEMENT LIES A MAJOR PARADOX

On the one hand, it deals with a vast and comprehensive legal framework, disciplines such as financial mathematics, financial policies, portfolio theories, monetary policies, and public finances. On the other hand, it deals with people who, most of the time, know very little about these areas (on average, 80% of clients are not “knowledgeable”).

B. SOME DEFINITIONS

Whether it's called wealth or asset management depends on the amount at stake, but the goal is the same: to tailor and diversify investments according to each client's and their family's specific circumstances – age, earnings, career, attitude to risk, and tax status.

Les gestionnaires ont coutume de proposer deux types de gestion de portefeuille :

- *Discretionary management:* The client delegates full responsibility for managing their assets to their portfolio manager and the bank.
- *Advisory management:* The manager provides recommendations, but the client retains full decision-making authority over their portfolio.

Managers may have their own management "styles," such as diversified or alternative approaches.

Diversified management: The bank aims to optimize the diversification of the client's portfolio by allocating assets across different asset classes, industry sectors, currencies, and geographic regions.

Alternative management: This focuses on protecting and growing wealth regardless of how the stock market performs. It does this by using sophisticated financial techniques – such as borrowing to invest, selling assets one doesn't yet own, or using complex contracts known as derivatives – to access different kinds of investments.

C. THE OBJECTIVES

WHICH GOALS ARE COMMONLY PURSUED BY PRIVATE BANKING CLIENTS?

- They want to generate the highest possible income and grow their capital.
- They want their capital to remain as "liquid" as possible, in other words readily available rather than tied up.
- They want their capital to be as secure as possible.

What investor wouldn't want all that?

It's almost universally acknowledged among wealth managers that their clients struggle to grasp the paradox of the risk–return trade-off: maximum growth with minimal risk. As such, one of the manager's tasks is to support clients through a difficult decision: determining which investments to prioritize, and what form they should take. The client relationship in wealth management—the focus of this book—is highly specific. Client behavior has undergone significant changes, in two main phases:

- In the post–banking secrecy era, most clients felt empowered and unafraid to speak to their bankers as equals, particularly when it came to discussing fees.
- Technology that provides instant access to all their information.

Clients have become more demanding and uninhibited; they no longer hesitate to compare several institutions. Their understanding of markets and financial products has grown considerably, and they also tend to be more mobile.

They increasingly value a comprehensive approach that addresses not only their financial situation, but also their family and professional circumstances. This is what we call a more holistic approach.

The one-way client relationship is a thing of the past.

Clients expect tailored solutions and innovation; they're accustomed to disruption, which has become the norm. They want real-time access to all available information.

The manager must be creative and offer products that match their clients. Meanwhile, clients see their managers as a tech superhero, as well as a gentleman and a fortune teller. They no longer perceive the manager as the sole holder of financial knowledge but rather as a service provider.

Given these trends, managers should hone their expertise in client relations and the systematic follow-up of every potential lead.

WHAT INFORMATION IS REQUIRED FOR THE RELATIONSHIP TO BE DESCRIBED AS HOLISTIC?

In terms of the capital:

- The amount and the origin of the capital;
- The intended use of the funds;
- The overall wealth portfolio (are there assets held elsewhere?);
- The intended investment period;
- Any planned future contributions.

In terms of the client:

- Their desired level of involvement;
- Their age and nationality;
- The complexities of their family situation;
- Their tax situation;
- Their professional situation.

This emerging profile has a significant impact. It shapes the relationship between the manager and the client, making it more personal and based on trust.

It has a direct impact on how the manager allocates assets to meet the client's ideal preferences. Achieving a balance between return and risk is a complex task, especially when factoring in the client's preferred investment duration—or "time horizon."

Asset allocation involves several levels of decision-making:

- Strategies: Broad decisions regarding currencies and markets.
- Tactics: Decisions on investment vehicles and their duration.
- Final choices: the choice of specific sectors and securities, based on recommended lists of equities and bonds.

The outcome of these decisions is an investment proposal—either tailored or standardized—that takes the client's profile into account.

We'll revisit how profile analysis is matched with investment recommendations; it lies at the heart of the client relationship in private wealth management.

Another factor that is added to this relationship is the manager's legal requirement to disclose the risks inherent in investments[2].

BUT WHAT IS A WEALTH MANAGER LOOKING FOR?

A wealth manager is looking for clients who are wealthy and who have capital to invest. They are employed at a bank or financial institution that provides this services, and aims to become the client's go-to wealth manager (the reference bank).

They sell services, even though some may argue otherwise... Their primary role and career depend on their proactive commercial behavior.

To achieve this, the wealth manager adopts specific behaviors; they must have social skills and be proficient in both psychological and technical areas.

Their customer service approach is in harmony with his bank's[3]. They must possess all the qualities of a good salesperson, know how to anticipate the client's needs, and also have a healthy dose of commercial empathy.

Chapter four will come back to the skills required for such a role.

The wealth manager tries to put their client at ease in order to:

- Move the client from the natural mistrust they may feel toward financial advisers to a sense of trust, earned through concrete actions;
- Turn the client into an active referrer;
- Encourage the client to transfer their assets to the manager's bank.

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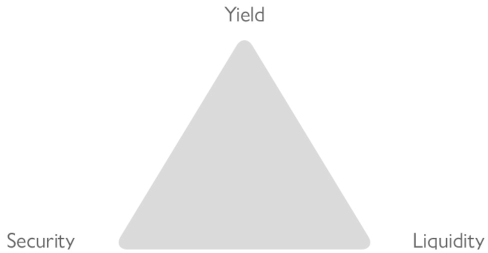
2 As presented by a participant during a Private Banking executive program, 2010.

3 Throughout this book, I will use the term "*bank*" to refer to independent wealth managers as well as any other financial institutions offering financial services.

Wealth managers aim to help their clients strike a difficult balance between the three sides of the well-known financial triangle:



The closer you get to one of these three points, the further you become from the other two!

Four questions for a wealth manager:

- How to turn mistrust into trust?
- What strategy should I adopt to help my client grow their portfolio?
- Why don't we manage all of their assets?
- Are we truly the client's primary and main bank of reference, or are we merely a back-up?

HOW DO YOU SEE YOUR INSTITUTION IN FIVE YEARS?[4]

"The Mirabaud model encourages us to focus on our clients' needs, how those needs evolve, and the desire to pass the bank on to the next generation. My goal goes beyond the five-year horizon you mentioned. We want the institution to be in a better place when we pass it on to our successors. The term 'better' can have multiple meanings. Above all, it's about making it more robust, ensuring it remains in line with the times and clients' needs, capable of ongoing growth, and supported by talented individuals who can help address future challenges. Thinking about the group's long-term sustainability essential."

It's a profession that is opening up to women, albeit too slowly…

It is still a man's world, but I've noticed that women in this profession often bring a greater sensitivity to client relationships.

Swiss banking culture is still deeply influenced by modesty, decorum, and conservatism. Preconceptions about sales and salespeople significantly hinder the level of transparency expected in relationships between wealth managers and their clients.

4 Camille Vial, *Allnews*, December 2, 2022, digital banking magazine.

3. THE KEY CHARACTERISTICS OF WEALTH MANAGEMENT

A. A PROFESSION WITH AN INTIMATE CONNECTION

A profession that calls for discreet indiscretion.

It's one of those jobs that involves "intimate connection."

To explain this concept, let's take the contrasting example of a car salesman.

Typically, this salesperson asks questions to understand the needs of a potential buyer:

Are you looking for a powerful model? How important are safety and comfort? That kind of thing.

A car salesman would never, however, ask questions about their client's past, though ("Are there any children from your first marriage?"). They are not connected to this part of their client's life, and that is completely normal.

They only ask questions to understand the client's requirements, without needing to delve into their private lives. This salesperson is in a state of "disconnection" from the client.

In the banking world, managers are required to work in a much more personal and intimate sphere; they are "in connection." This is why it's essential to address a more personal aspect of the client: their emotions.

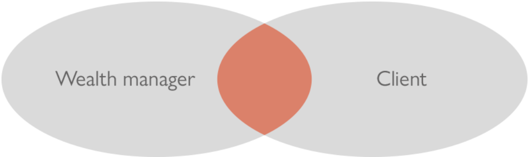
The zone of connection is minimal in the case of a car salesman.

The wealth manager, however, needs to understand their client's personal details, which are inherently indiscreet.

Are there other professions that require this kind of special connection?

A notary or a psychotherapist? Not even them; they don't have all the information a wealth manager needs to do their job properly.

It's the only profession with a legal obligation in this respect (anti-money laundering laws require us to explore our clients' lives in ways that are, by nature, "indiscreet").



What does this connection represent?

It represents the emotional, the shared intimacy, the confidential — the client's private sphere. The client will need to share their fears, emotions, dreams, and outlook with their wealth manager.

This highly intimate relationship creates a unique space between the client and their adviser (the red zone). It is fragile and delicate to build — but the stronger it is, the better it shields the manager from the competition.

The following four points support this observation:

- Markets affect all banks' performance at the same time.
- Banks are subject to the same macroeconomic rules.
- Banks tend to perform similarly.

The real competitive advantage in wealth management doesn't come from technical expertise, but from the quality of the relationship. The real battleground is the relationship, not the product.

B. SALES IN WEALTH MANAGEMENT ARE MADE "A POSTERIORI"

What's the difference between *a priori* and *a posteriori*? The car salesperson is an *a priori* seller, they don't need to know their client inside out to lead them through the sales process. The product is first manufactured, and then sold. This is the case for most goods and services.

In wealth management, it's the opposite. Sales take place after an entire process; establishing trust, developing the relationship, identifying the client's needs, and finally creating the product. This is the process of creating a tailor-made solution.

"First I sell, then I create."

The *a priori* salesperson focuses on the technical aspect of their product.

The *a posteriori* seller prioritizes building the relationship. A great deal of time will be spent on getting to know one another, leaving less time for persuasion and closing the sale.

C. THE SEVEN PARADOXES OF WEALTH MANAGEMENT

Paradox 1:

For more than 35 years, I've asked every wealth manager who attended my private banking sales seminars the same question:

"What percentage of your clients would you consider knowledgeable?"

The responses I've gathered over the years have all told the same story: Around 80% of private banking clients are not knowledgeable.

This mirrors other fields. Take the automotive industry, for example; how many drivers can take apart an engine? Very few. Banking is no different; it's a sophisticated, complicated, and complex world. That's why wealth managers need to be great educators, always ready to explain and simplify things for their clients.

There's a big gap between the complicated products banks offer and clients who have little financial knowledge. Once you grasp this paradox, it becomes clear that competitive advantage lies in the wealth manager's ability to educate, as well as their approach to sales.

Paradox 2:

Another interesting statistic worth mentioning is the breakdown between purely technical discussions (such as about investment products and the client's portfolio performance) and more social conversations. The results are strikingly consistent: 80% of the time is spent on social interaction.

Paradox 3:

Wealth managers, by the nature of their role, talk about money. But money can be a scary subject – not just for clients, but sometimes for the managers too!

Paradox 4:

The wealth manager must confront their own internal **contradictions**. They're expected to be warm and empathetic, yet private banking is shaped by a cultural and economic history steeped in various (macho) beliefs, such as:

– never back down in front of clients

– don't give in; stand firm

– don't lose face!

The wealth manager is dealing with a client with whom they must avoid speculating about a future that is often uncertain.

The client shares only what they are willing to share, with whom and when they choose. They withhold sensitive information, understandably, as they consider it too personal to disclose.

Paradox 5:

The client doesn't always understand their shared responsibility with the wealth manager. When results are unsatisfactory, the client may feel justified in questioning the advice, particularly if the manager hasn't made an effort to keep track of their conversations.

The concept of the *risk-return* trade-off is one of the fundamental principles of shared responsibility.

Paradox 6:

While the manager is focused on client acquisition, they must also be wary, as some files that have been hard-won may be rejected by an acceptance committee. The administrative workload aimed at clarifying and controlling the client onboarding process reflects this.

Paradox 7:

The client does not always recognize the value of banking services (analysis and recommendations). Because these services are intangible, they are surprised at having to pay for the advice.

D. A SPECIFIC CONCEPT OF TIME

The relationship with time is also very specific. The manager is torn between wanting to close a deal with the client and the need to take all the time necessary to build a solid relationship. One guiding principle makes sense: it takes time for a relationship to develop. The manager consistently uses the concept of time in negotiations:

- They work with time frames.
- They help the client imagine the future.
- Since financial decisions can be anxiety-inducing, they do not rush the client into making a decision. A section of Chapter 14 focuses on the manager's time management.

E. THE BUSINESS RELATIONSHIP IS CALLED INTO QUESTION

Not everyone agrees on how important human relationships will be in the future of wealth management. The following four studies have different viewpoints on the subject:

1) A study by LinkedIn and Greenwich Associates[5], conducted with 469 high-net-worth individuals (with assets exceeding $1 million, excluding their primary residence), 77% of whom were over 40. The results showed that respondents were looking for relationships that combined a human touch with technology. Two-thirds of the participants had been with their adviser for over five years. They are "tech-savvy" and are comfortable with machine-managed portfolios. This frees up advisers to focus on more complex client needs. Technology enables clients to communicate with their advisers however they wish and supports real-time access to information: relevant, accurate advice on the markets and sector updates on investments.

This client group is generally more than capable of using social media to find out about financial matters. Sixty percent of millennials still prefer face-to-face meetings over virtual interactions. A significant proportion of this population is open to advisers using technology (on average, 80% are comfortable with it across all stages of the transaction process). The youngest generation shows a high willingness to switch advisers (38%), compared to only 4% among those aged over 70. Millennials also embrace social media in much greater numbers: 62% versus a mere 4% of the older generation.

What stands out in this study is the duality in attitudes: While younger individuals (aged 40 to 59) tend to have a more natural relationship with technology, they still value human interaction for all stages of financial investment analysis. This translates into a desire for real-time information, a preference for automating whatever can be automated, and devoting as much time as possible to human interaction. Social media plays a strong role in helping them assess the relevance of financial advice and information.

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5 LinkedIn and Greenwich Associates, 2021, "Customer Journey in Wealth Management: High Tech or High Touch?", Menaka Thillaiampalam, Daniel Connell.

2) KPMG 2021 Study: "Clarity on Performance of Swiss Private Banks"[6]

The word *sales* does not appear even once in the report. While it's true that the study's objective wasn't to identify how to improve performance, the topic is still conspicuously absent. Revenues have dropped by 30% over a few years, and the key challenges are primarily technological. Banks' ability to stay productive will depend largely on their agility in adopting technology — the main driver of change. On the topic of value creation, the study notes a decrease in staff and operating costs, largely due to a gradual shift toward outsourcing. Value creation for Swiss banks is expected to be digital and agile. There is a clear trend toward optimising client touchpoints. The study even states that "the traditional main bank model, in which the client interface is considered a key success factor, is being called into question." Still, the commercial effort as a development driver is not addressed at all.

3) The ASB's 2021 banking barometer does not cite commercial activity as a driver of banking progress.

4) The EY(Ernst & Young AG) 2021 banking barometer also makes no mention of the client relationship. It's both surprising and telling that these last two studies overlook the commercial relationship as a lever for business growth – neither how it's perceived nor how it's used.

4. COMPLEX SALES IN THE BANKING SECTOR

These two images highlight the difference between complex and complicated. A Boeing is incredibly complicated in its design, but everything can be explained. A plate of spaghetti, by contrast, is complex; you can't identify all the interactions involved.

Complicated sales

Complex sales

6 202 KPMG Study, Clarity on Performance of Swiss Private Banks (August Benz, Thomas Ruhl, Richard Hess, Andrea Luca Aerni).

The wealth manager is as a particular kind of salesperson, practising "complex sales."

Today, there is little academic research on commercial negotiation. A quantitative analysis by Herbst, Voeth, and Meist from 2011, which included 15,000 articles published in 10 different academic journals, states that over the past 45 years, only 0.51% (78 articles) have focused on commercial negotiation[7]. During my research at the university library, I found that the number of doctoral theses in the past 25 years concerning sales (fewer than 10), especially in the specific field of banking, was nearly non-existent.

THE NOBLE ART OF SELLING

All we need to do is observe our children to understand that every human being possesses an inherent ability to sell, whether it's an idea, an outing, permission, or a new backpack. Not only do we know how to sell when the need arises, but we also associate desire, conviction, and wishful thinking with this sales ability. Sales are the natural tool our brains develop to get what we want.

However, once we enter the professional world – and for reasons unknown – this ability becomes clouded by inhibitions rooted in our culture, education, and accumulated anxieties. Fear certainly plays a part, in particular the fear of being judged. There are many preconceived notions, and getting rid of them is never easy. To shake off this resistance to selling, let's go back to the basics: The purpose of sales is to defend an idea, get a "yes," convey, and convince. Going back to the basics allows us to understand the nobility inherent in the sales process.

A. WHAT DO COMPLEX AND SOPHISTICATED SALES INVOLVE?

Definition : A sale is termed complex when numerous actors are involved at once, and the process extends over a considerable period.

A high number of players generates complexity and uncertainty.

Complex sales typically concern solutions (rather than products).

The wealth manager becomes a conductor in complex sales, with the large number of stakeholders requiring them to act as a facilitator and an interface with clients.

At times, they shift between the role of conductor and that of an advocate for their client (which can be tricky and may lead to conflicts of interest).

7 Article by Julien Pelabere and Alice Le Flanchec in the journal *Management & Avenir* n° 102, August 2018.

The wealth manager must fully understand the client's needs, adopting a holistic approach and collaborating with the team to find solutions. They must solve the client's problem before attempting to sell anything to them.

B. THE IMPORTANCE OF TRUST IN COMPLEX SALES: AN INITIAL APPROACH

Building trust in complex sales starts with the bank's reputation[8].

The bank's image is just as important as the manager's expertise. In complex sales, the involvement of numerous actors and variables makes it difficult to establish hypotheses for the client, heightening their sense of **uncertainty**.

The client cannot immediately and clearly see where their own interests lie. Their lack of financial knowledge prevents them from "ranking the various options."

When faced with uncertainty, the option a client often chooses is to procrastinate on their decision. In response, the wealth manager asks themselves the following question:

How can I alleviate my client's sense of uncertainty?

They aim to replace it with the value their proposal offers. They can succeed in conveying this added value through a clear promise, a projection, a trial offer, an experiment for a set period, a guarantee, and behaviors that provide reassurance.

Two other steps help to reduce the client's uncertainty:

- Providing references from satisfied clients (within the limits of banking confidentiality)
- Performing an analysis of the investment's impact on the client.

En aidant son client à se projeter, le gestionnaire contribue à le rassurer. Les changements dans la vie du client sont des sources de crainte qui peuvent freiner la conclusion d'un achat.

By helping their client to visualize the future, the wealth manager plays a role in reassuring them. Changes in the client's life are sources of fear that can slow down the decision to make a purchase.

This is the phase of the complex sale where the seller evolves into an advisor, building their approach on cooperation rather than transaction[9].

C. THE ROLE OF EMOTIONS IN COMPLEX SALES

Emotion contributes to the creation of trust[10].

The key is not to confuse *being friendly* with *empathy*.

---

8 Studies cited in the article from *Management & Avenir journal*, issue no. 102.
9 *Ibidem*, page 120.
10 *Ibidem*, page 121.

Being friendly and approachable is a basic rule of good conduct.

Empathy is a positive emotion the seller actively cultivates to better understand their client. It involves tuning in emotionally to match the client's state of mind.

They feel in order to be felt. The emotional trust they create doesn't seal the deal on its own, but it is a big part of it.

What kinds of actions build emotional trust?

- Staying close to your client;
- Sharing informal, more personal moments;
- Making yourself available;
- Spending time together;
- Supporting them as they think things through;
- Starting out as an external adviser, even if it means stepping away from the bank's interests;
- Making your client's life easier.

Worse than being prejudiced is only seeing what you believe![11]

Source: Diagram inspired by the article by Julien Pelabere and Alice Le Flanchec, Management & Avenir, No. 102, August 2018, p. 125.

11 Source unknown

5. BEYOND THE MIRROR: BUILDING AN ACCURATE CLIENT PROFILE

We will return to the definition of the client profile in chapter nine. Profiling involves assessing a client's situation at a given point in time. This situation may change depending on several factors specific to the client:

- Their income needs;
- Their capital needs at a given time;
- Their personal background;
- Their outlook and attitude to risk;
- Their perception of the la situation;
- Their professional and personal circumstances;

Sometimes, clients have inherent contradictions that should be approached with empathy. Two ratios reflect these contradictions:

$$\frac{\text{What I want}}{\text{What I can do}} = \text{The relationship with the future, balancing desires with what is possible}$$

$$\text{The client's realism} = \frac{\text{Desires}}{\text{Obligations}} \quad \text{What the client wants and what has to do}$$

6. A GROWING BUSINESS CULTURE

A. CWMA

Since 2016, Swiss banks have adopted a quality standard in the form of a certification, CWMA (Certified Wealth Management Advisor), which has become the professional standard for anyone involved in commercial interactions with private clients. These same banks had anticipated the training requirements that the new laws on financial services and institutions (LSFIN/LEFIN) would enforce. This certification includes a commercial component. An oral exam tests the commercial skills of each manager. They must, among other things, provide "*a professional consulting experience*" and "*establish a relationship of trust with the client.*"[12]

The evaluation criteria include the following elements:

- *How to persuade without lowering your prices.*

- *Establishing a long-term business relationship.*

- *The relationship manager (RM) must earn the trust of their client through: taking their needs into account; demonstrating congruence and reliability; fostering a partnership and shared responsibility.*

- *Respecting the client's free will; encouraging reflection and their critical perspective.*

This certification is a significant step forward in raising awareness of the need to move the system toward more commercial proactivity.

12 SAQ Swiss CWMA examination regulations.

B. COMMERCIAL PROACTIVITY

In our book on sales[13], we explained the origins of salespeople's fear and the need, for any organization, particularly a bank, to develop a culture of commercial proactivity.

What are the components of a commercial culture?

- A commercial mindset at all levels of the institution's value chain;

- A shared commitment to high-quality service;

- The ability to anticipate clients' needs and listen to them, the art of pampering them!

Commercial proactivity is a subtle, intangible energy, felt as a positive force that emanates from the actions of everyone you encounter within the same organization.

The client senses this positive energy and is likely to respond to it: They feel more confident, they sense they are in good hands, and they feel supported. With this mindset, the client may turn into an active referral, increase their assets, or bring capital to your bank, accepting a more exclusive relationship. This is the power of this commercial energy—it encourages commitment from our clients.

Regrettably, many in the private banking industry continue to perceive selling as a degrading activity and look unfavorably upon highly proactive sales approaches. There is an apparent contradiction between necessity and reality.

This attitude also underscores our competitive edge, boosting our likability and showcasing our potential. It's this foundation that influences our service quality (natural behavior) and boosts our ability to persuade, highlighting our personality.

C. FROM THE SOCIAL TO THE BUSINESS RELATIONSHIP

The taboos discussed above can inhibit relationship managers, and my advice to sales staff to be more proactive was not always well received. At times, I doubted myself. So, I came up with a strategy to help you take the leap: the Triple YES method.

These three questions encourage you to take the leap:

- Am I acting ethically?
- Am I respecting my professional code of conduct?
- Am I being courteous in my client interactions?

13 *Successfully Selling,* Fabien Smadja, 2025.

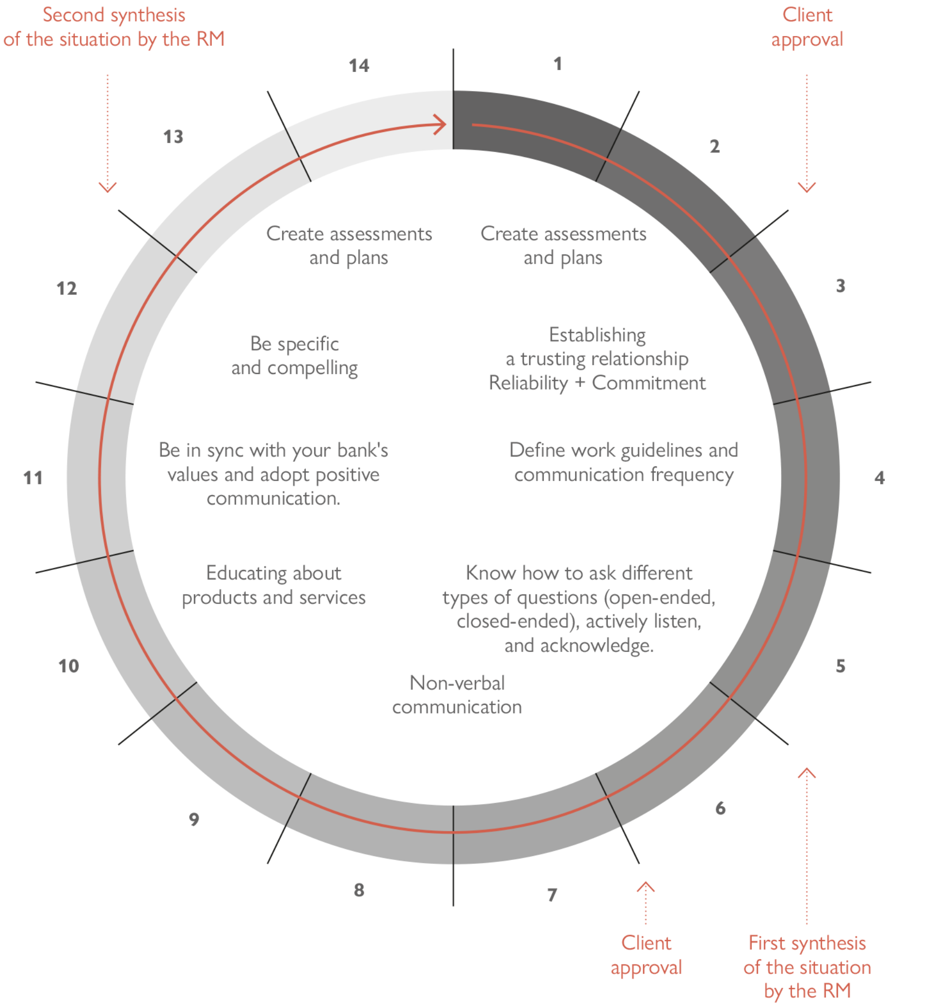
If I can answer yes to all three, I can go ahead. Professional ethics in our sales relationships are expressed through various attitudes:

- Ensure the client's free will is respected;
- Don't apply psychological pressure;
- Be able to say no;
- Confirm each step of the sales process with the client;
- Build a long-term relationship.

THE 10 SUREFIRE WAYS TO LOSE YOUR CLIENTS FOREVER

1. Treat your clients like strangers (even though that's exactly what they are).
2. Don't trust your clients; they're bound to take advantage of you.
3. Never go the extra mile for your clients; they'll start expecting it.
4. Develop strategies that serve only your bank's interests.
5. Never ask your client's opinion. After all, what do they know?
6. Don't guarantee your products or your services. This way, only your client's money is at risk.
7. Whenever a client complains, go on the defensive and find a way to pin it on them.
8. Don't spend a single cent on improving how you serve and satisfy your current clients.
9. Avoid investing in training your staff for better customer service; they'll likely end up leaving for your competitors anyway.
10. Don't bother consulting your team; it's simply a waste of time.

7. THE EDUCATIONAL ROADMAP



1. Initial meeting and a warm welcome
2. Clarify RM and client objectives; structured meeting with an agenda
3. Present the updated bank pitch and its positioning; highlight key benefits for the client. Share the bank's advisory approach.
4. Updated client profile + including risk–return profile: aversion vs appetite, and risk-taking capacity.
5. Update client needs, personal goals and strategies. Overall view of their assets (before private banking).
6. Assets held in other banks, investor history, client potential, and interests. Present, explain, and promote products and services, from general to specific, using the FAB method.
7. Ensure the proposal is relevant and consistent with the client's needs. Make the proposal meaningful.
8. Demonstrate both teaching ability and technical expertise in financial products.
9. The 5 components of an argument: Explanation, FAB, USP, buying signal, objections (traditional and price-related)
10. Signals and closing techniques. Take a proactive approach to closing. Client approval.
11. Summarize the key points of the discussion Discuss the next steps. Manage your time well.
12. A positive and constructive conclusion to a meeting. Ongoing focus on the "When."

The traditional sales process in private wealth management.

Spring into action!
5 key takeaways and an exercise

FIVE KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. **Relationships in private wealth management are always holistic.**
2. **A role that requires deep personal connection as part of the job.**
3. **"First I sell, then I create."**
4. **Complex versus complicated sales.**
5. **Commercial proactivity: from the social to the business relationship.**

EXERCICE

Title: What is your mission?

Aim of the exercise: To deepen your understanding of what motivates you.

Instructions:

- In a few lines, describe the purpose and meaning of your mission as an adviser or relationship manager within your organization.
- Why did you choose this profession?
- What are your three main motivations for doing this job?

1

Frameworks,

methods, concepts, and lost illusions

There's no set formula, only emotional intelligence.
In business situations, think carefully!

TEACHING OBJECTIVES

After reading this chapter, you will be able to:

- Identify sources of inspiration in terms of processes and frameworks.
- Follow steps to structure your sales approach.
- Copy inspiring frameworks and concrete processes.

Contents table
Chapter 1

Here's a statement I've often heard: "In my role as a manager, I don't sell anything; I give advice…" It reflects a cultural inhibition associated with the act of selling.

The wording doesn't matter; what counts is that the advisory process leads to a considered purchase rather than a pressured sale. The more relevant the advice, the more likely the client is to follow it, buy into the manager's value proposition, and ultimately open an account or sign a mandate.

Advice is therefore at the heart of the sales process in wealth management transactions. This chapter will explore some of its key aspects.

I. ADVISORY SERVICES ARE A COMPETITIVE ADVANTAGE – THAT ALL BANKS SHARE!

For clients, the quality of advice is increasingly what sets banks apart. With information so easily accessible, their expectations continue to rise.

As the paradox in this section's title implies, every bank wants to differentiate itself through the advice it gives. Their success varies, as the quality of advice largely depends on the person delivering it.

This is the difference between the *advice quality* (in its form) and its relevance (in its substance).

What does excellent service look like in the banking world?

- The perfect execution of transactions (error-free).
- Preservation of clients' wealth.
- Immediate and accessible information for clients, anytime and anywhere in the world.

What are the specific features of banking advice?

A. IT IS UNIQUE

Our commercial assumption is that the purpose of advice is solely to create value for clients.

It is always client-focused, in contrast to a regular sale, which may be based on the client's impulse (impulse buying) or the salesperson's aggressive behavior (hard selling).

B. IT'S A CONSIDERED SALE that unfolds over an indefinite period. Technical expertise is the cornerstone of this value creation, in related areas such as wealth management, wealth taxation, insurance, succession planning, and so on.

C. IT'S AN ACCELERATOR, a value booster within the client relationship. It must be structured and organized as a process, with the steps of "what to do" sequentially leading to a result with the clients. A process is a sequence of steps designed to achieve a result. It can therefore be modeled for shared use (within the same process) across a bank.

Every manager will be able to follow the model and then move away from it to tailor it to their needs.

The purpose of advice is to be holistic and empathetic.

The two concepts converge, from 360-degree advice to a sales attitude. The term "global advice" is redundant, as advice is inherently global. Advice should be an integral part of a bank's commercial philosophy. As such, the characteristics, structure, and specifics of this advice become the bank's signature, its hallmark of its philosophy.

2. THE NEED FOR A CLEAR COMMERCIAL STRATEGY: PHILOSOPHY AND DOCTRINE

The concepts of doctrine and philosophy are closely related, but they have distinct meanings.

Philosophy seeks to understand fundamental questions about existence, knowledge, morality, and truth.

It encompasses methods and theories aimed at analyzing and interpreting human experience. Philosophy is concerned with general, abstract concepts and is often expressed as such.

A doctrine is a collection of beliefs, principles, or rules defined by a bank. It can come from a broader philosophy, but it is usually more practical and clearly outlined as policies or guidelines.

It is used to give precise guidance and set specific standards.

The role of *philosophy* is to explore general concepts and questions, while doctrine gives a more concrete form to the specific principles that stem from it.

Philosophy sets out broad and idealistic principles such as “the client is at the heart of our concerns” or “we should always be compassionate toward our clients.” Doctrine, on the other hand, defines more specific rules about how to behave and make decisions in particular situations.

By introducing a philosophy, doctrine, and guiding principles, the bank creates a set of shared standards for client advisory. This creates conditions that are conducive to developing the bank’s commercial culture.

ditions favorables à une évolution de la culture commerciale de la banque.

A. FROM DOCTRINE TO FRAMEWORK

It serves as the foundation the organization needs for commercial behaviors to flourish. Managers have a clear understanding of how to deliver this advice and can rely on solid, tangible elements (doctrines).

Once these principles of action are ingrained in behavior as natural reflexes, they transform into beliefs.

At this point, the doctrine can be transformed into a process, an analytical framework, detailing all the stages that advice must undergo before being provided to the bank's clients.

The framework is then translated into a sales method.

You'll love what you sell if you love what your clients own.[1]

3. THE ADVISORY APPROACH

The **advisory approach** is the natural outcome of the bank's philosophy on the commercial relationship.

Moving from the relationship to action on the ground allows the manager to ensure a consistent approach for the client. What they will do is well-supported, coherent, and logical.

The advisory approach is a rational approach to selling in the banking industry. How is it different from the sale of other goods and services, like a sofa or a car?

The advisory approach is a process distinguished by factors that set it apart from regular sales. Here are four of these factors:

- The manager has a legal obligation to provide specific information to the client.
- The immediacy of the result: A sale happens, but it doesn't always mean closure right away. An account might be opened, but not yet funded.
- The process involves many obligatory checkpoints with the client.
- The commercial relationship is governed by a protocol; for instance, the wealth manager is required to check the client’s identity.

A. ARE SALES BEHAVIORS AT ODDS WITH AN ADVISORY APPROACH?

Sales behavior often comes with the concern that overly aggressive tactics may be badly perceived by wealthy clients. But where, exactly, can such aggressiveness find its way into an advisory approach?

Basic principle: Aggressive selling shouldn’t be considered negatively, but as a dynamic and constructive force.

1 Joe Girard and Stanley H Brown, *How to Sell Anything to Anybody*, Touchstone, 2006.

The sale is the goal, the advisory process is the journey, and commercial aggression is the fuel that moves it forward.

Commercial aggression is a refined form of energy that fuels the manager's persistence, encouraging them to explore every avenue with resolve.

The same manager will be able to withdraw tactfully if the client is hesitant or if it's obvious that the proposal isn't appropriate for their needs.

The answer to the question at the start of this section is therefore a resounding NO!

The aim of providing advice is to help the client make the right choices for their investments – but it's not just that. We operate in a systemic environment, which means that if one piece of advice hasn't been properly considered, it could undermine the value of all the others.

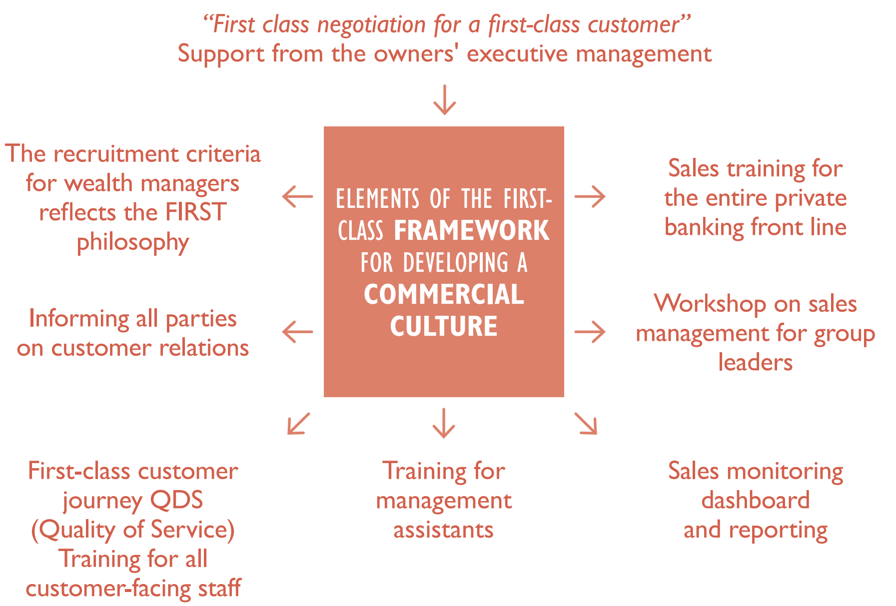
A business model is often systemic

In the introduction, we discussed the concept of a connected profession in the social sense, and here we are again. Advice must cover related and complementary fields like taxation, inheritance, and pension, among others. Systemic functioning also influences the organization's commercial dynamics. Each parameter has an effect on the whole (definition of systemic thinking). The table below illustrates components of commercial dynamics within a bank[2].

THE VALUE OF ADVICE

Advice is intangible and therein lies its problem. The Relationship Manager must never miss an opportunity to highlight the value of their advice (although subtly and at the right moment) by reminding the client of its financial impact: gains made, savings achieved, or risks mitigated.

The following model is systemic, meaning that acting on all the parameters together produces a greater result than acting on each one in isolation (the whole is greater than the sum of its parts). These are the same parameters that can influence the commercial dynamics of an institution.



2 This is a model we created for a banking project called "First Class"

The doctrine is not set in stone, and the model is not compulsory; for the advice to reach its full potential, it must be infused with the manager's personality. The bank sets out guidelines, and the manager personalizes them.

B. WHAT KIND OF ADVICE ARE WE TALKING ABOUT ANYWAY?

Good advice is integrated

The advice must integrate all the different components outlined. The wealth manager should begin by clearly explaining the process they intend to follow, including all the ins and outs. Explaining their approach and getting the client's approval is a crucial part of the argument's rationale.

The advice and its contents

We will explore these processes later in the chapter.

Advice frequency

It's important to set out how often the manager and their client will assess whether the strategies and decisions were appropriate. In the finance sector, it is constructive to routinely question and challenge the decisions made, even if they remain unchanged.

The advisory approach or the sales method?

This process will only be effective if the manager brings it to life with their personality, energy, and sales techniques. In the next chapter, we'll explore the sales techniques that can breathe life into the sales process.

4. THE DIFFERENT CONCEPTUAL APPROACHES TO ADVICE

- Process-based approach
- Life cycle
- Client-centered approaches: the STAR model
- The experience-based business practices model

A. THE PROCESS-BASED APPROACH

In the most conventional sense, the term sales refers to the exchange of goods for money. Selling means wanting and being able to satisfy a customer with a service, not chasing them like prey (like an instinctive salesperson).

Before taking any action, one of the first things a salesperson should know is their sales process, as it provides a structure and a clear path for the wealth manager's approach[3].

The seller can handle the stages of the process they are confident in and focus their resources and attention on the ones they are less familiar with.

3 Cf. *Successfully Selling*, as cited earlier.

A process isn't a dogma.

A process is about creating a path, so you know where you're going, forming habits along the way. There are stages, just like in a health journey.

Just like the Camino de Santiago, the stages come one after the other, both physical and spiritual in nature. The destination is clearly defined, and journey is filled with moments of self-reflection. Each person observes themselves as they walk.

Sales is about otherness, where the salesperson recognizes and accepts their client's differences.

DEFINITION

Definition: Offerness[4] refers to the recognition of another person as different from oneself, while also acknowledging the legitimacy of that difference. It means being open, tolerant, and ready to accept and understand people, no matter their cultural, religious, social, or ethnic background.

The relationship is shaped over the course of this journey, with the process guiding the way toward "commercial otherness."

WHAT ARE THE KEY COMPONENTS OF A SALES PROCESS?

Preparing for the interview

- Our overall strategies and my specific negotiation tactics
- How to secure the meeting?
- How to make a strong first impression?
- How do I prepare my product-related arguments?
- What are my sales goals for this interview?
- What objections might come up?
- Client profile with a record of previous meetings
- General bank documentation and technical product/service brochures.

4 A concept extensively developed by the philosopher Emmanuel Levinas

The course of the meeting

- Welcome the client by creating a comfortable and reassuring environment.
- Adopt a positive attitude.
- Recap the context and the purpose of the meeting.
- Explore both explicit and implicit needs.
- Listen actively and reflect back what you've heard to show understanding.
- Formulate arguments based on the needs identified in the previous stage.
- Confirm the fit between the client's needs and the proposed investments.
- Draw a conclusion that aligns with the course of the meeting (or delay the conclusion and defer the discussion if the connection is unclear)
- Summarize the meeting.
- Use the “active referral” technique.

Follow-up process

- Thank the client in writing and recap the key points discussed during the meeting.
- Consider the next steps and suggest a future meeting date if a follow-up is necessary.

An example of a sales process for a mortgage[5]

The steps follow a commercial and operational logic, serving as a checklist for the necessary sales actions.

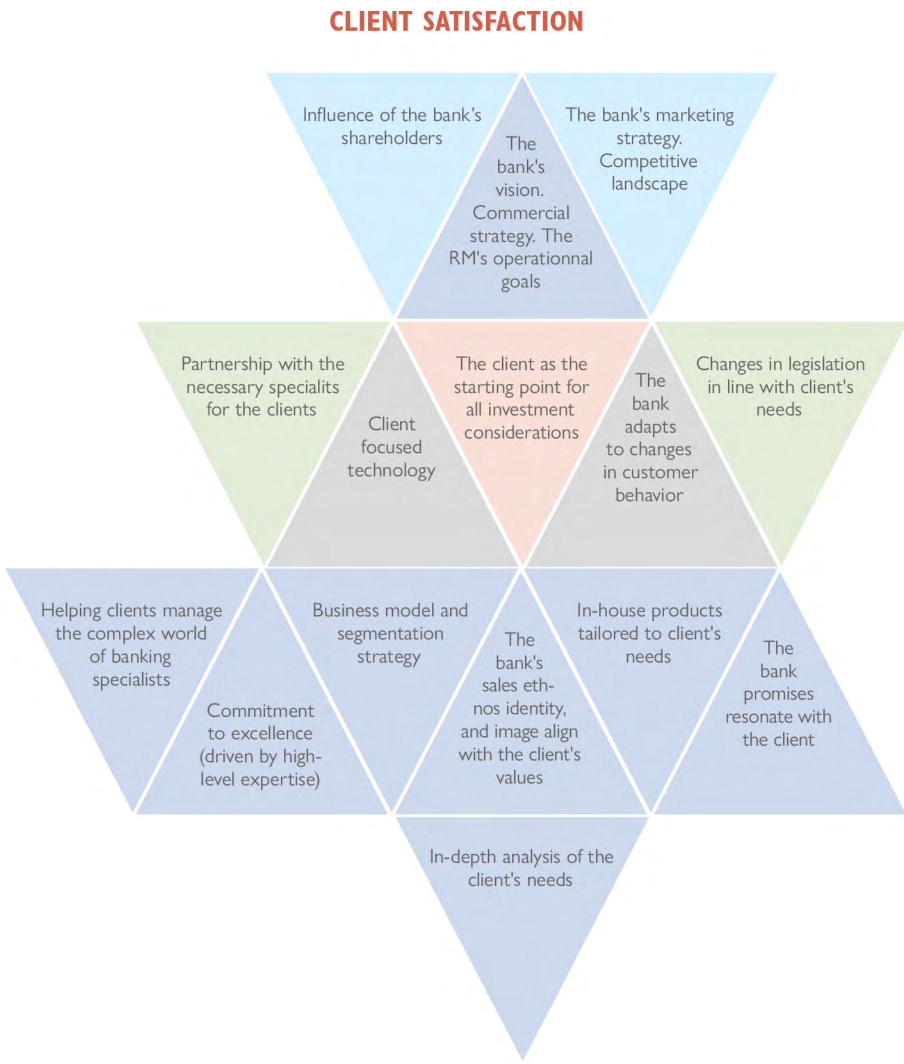
SALES PROCESS FOR A MORTGAGE LOAN

1	2	3
WELCOME	**LEARNING ABOUT THE CLIENT**	**THE PROJECT AND ITS FUNDING STRATEGY**
Welcome	Personal information	Property valuation, collateral value, and agreed purchase price
Introduce yourself and present the bank	Marital status	Valuation – the thinking behind it
Guiding objectives	Equity	Real estate collateral, additional collateral
Brief overview of the project	Additional commitments and reserves	Associated purchase costs
Types of assets	Financial situation	Corporate registry
Client-focused goals		Land registry
		Debt seniority and amortization
		Debt-to-income ratio Affordability: expense-to-income ratio
		Property expenses and costs (think in real-time)
		The timeframe

5 Source: Retail Banking Sales Training, CAF, 2011.

4	5	6	7
PRODUCT PROPOSAL AND CLIENT GUIDANCE	**CREDIT OFFER IN PRINCIPLE**	**NEXT STEPS**	**CONCLUSION**
Our products and conditions	Necessary informations and supporting documents	Making your case Objections and approval	The conclusion: clarifying the next steps
The type of amortization	Identify the appointed notary	Cross-selling	Keep active referrals in mind
Taxation			Arrange a project follow-up
Financial protection			Arrange a sales follow-up
Price protection approach			
Basic rules ok banking operations and a mortage loan			

The influence pyramid: identifying all the factors that can **influence private banking client satisfaction**.



There is no shortage of models available. They help every wealth manager to create their own approach.

B. LIFE CYCLES

This approach allows the wealth manager to tailor their proposals to the different phases of the client's life:

- Specific guidance tailored to each stage of the client's life;
- Products suited to each stage of the client's life;
- Banking services available to clients at each stage in their life.

Whenever an investor's environment changes, the advisor's approach adapts accordingly. These changes may be external, such as political, economic, or financial crises, or internal, linked to the clients' own situations.

Changes in our clients' lives are inevitable, as they progress through different points of the life cycle. The key stages of this cycle are predictable (see the table below) and can be planned for. The goal for the client is to ensure their financial needs are met at each phase of their life.

It's the role of the wealth manager to understand the transition from one phase to another, in order to guide their client through the different stages of this life cycle (column 2).

LIFE CYCLE DIAGRAM

This table was developed from the author's diverse experiences in training programs with banks interested in this concept. It is provided for illustrative purposes only.

LIFE STAGE AND AGE	UNDERSTANDING THIS PHASE	CONNECTION WITH THE NEEDS ASSESSMENT PHASE?
CHILDHOOD AGES 5-12	The child is influenced by the example set by their parents. How did they manage their finances and savings ?	It would be interesting to ask about the family background to understand the origins of some deep-seated beliefs.
THE TEENAGE YEARS 12-18	The teen continues to be influenced as in the first phase. They receive pocket money; how will they spend it? Any odd jobs?	Their emotional memory will impact their decisions. They will have been shaped by certain challenges they overcame. The wealth manager should explore this life phase – it comes with a twofold advantage: gaining insights and prompting the client to recall moments from their youth (which always has a beneficial effect, regardless of their nature).
THE TRAINING YEARS 18-25	The educational path they follow will impact their understanding of the economic and financial world.	Their educational background shapes both their decisions and how they approach investments. The client may be single or in a relationship and starting to plan for a family.
THE EARLY CAREER YEARS 25-35	They are establishing their career and gaining a sense of their own worth. They work to fulfill their career aspirations.	Their professional career is the source of the wealth they seek to invest. They are establishing a family and may have children. They are trying to find a healthy work-life balance.
THE SUCCESSFUL YEARS 35-50	The focus is on success, efficiency, and well-being.	The bulk of the wealth is built during this phase. Any children are now growing up and pursuing their education.
THE MATURE YEARS 50-65	They are at the peak of their career and life—their "golden years." They begin to reflect on the meaning of happiness	They begin to plan the next chapter of their lives more seriously, with a focus on family and retirement. The children have left home.
RETIREMENT AND A SENSE OF CALM + 65	The focus is now on giving back, spending time with family and grandchildren, and passing down their values.	They want to consolidate investments and live with peace of mind. They aim to improve quality of life and enjoy the fruits of a lifetime's hard work.

CAREER PHASE	FINANCIAL REQUIREMENTS AND ADVISORY SUPPORT
Childhood	Not applicable
Learning about life	Buying needs influenced by contemporary trends. Easy access to consumer goods can create frustrations that need to be recognized and factored into their personal story. With the client's approval, the wealth manager can guide the adolescent through financial concepts in a fun and engaging way.
They enter the workforce and gain their first professional experiences. They value innovation and technology and are very active on social media.	They are independent and don't give much thought to their financial future. They have little or no wealth, unless they inherited money at an early age, This is the perfect time for a wealth manager to start educating about finance.
They start seeing their initial results and fulfilling goals. Income is growing rapidly.	First-time buyer. They begin to lay the foundation for their wealth. They are ambitious about investments and have a vision for their future financial success. The manager provides initial financial planning advice and actively engages in conversations to set the stage for future interactions.
At the top of their career and continuing to progress.	They seek to consolidate assets and actively prepare for the next steps. Their wealth is growing, though they have experienced some market fluctuations. Financial management and wealth planning advice.
Consolidation and reaping the rewards of their experience.	They acquire valuable assets and start thinking about legacy. They receive advice on estate planning and tax matters. They are now at an age where inheritance could increase their fortune further.
A different professional perspective emerges. With their career behind them, it's time for voluntary engagement.	Their house could be named "Carefree Home." Estate planning advice.

C. UNDERSTANDING THE CLIENT'S PSYCHOLOGICAL FOUNDATIONS

The manager should consider these life stages to gain a complete picture of their client's identity, adopting the role of a "psychotherapist."

Life stories help explain and even predict what drives purchasing behavior. The different stages of life provide valuable insights into a client's motivations.

A manager who takes an interest in the client's life story will build intimacy, trust, closeness, and a deeper understanding of the reasoning behind their choices.

This **biographical approach** adds color and meaning to the client relationship. It gives the wealth manager a glimpse into the world behind each client. These stories are often fascinating. How did they build their fortune? Or if they inherited it, how did their parents earn it? Were they bold entrepreneurs, or did they take risks during hard times? Perhaps it was a question of inventing something or entering a new market. However the wealth was amassed, it is the story behind it that really makes private banking fascinating.

5. THE CLIENT-CENTERED PROCESS

This process is self-explanatory: It starts with the client's perspective.

This consulting strategy starts by focusing exclusively on the client's goals when assessing their needs.

6. THE STAR MODEL[6]

This is a framework for analyzing the investor profile that goes through the stages of exploring expectations and goals, along with the solutions the bank will offer.

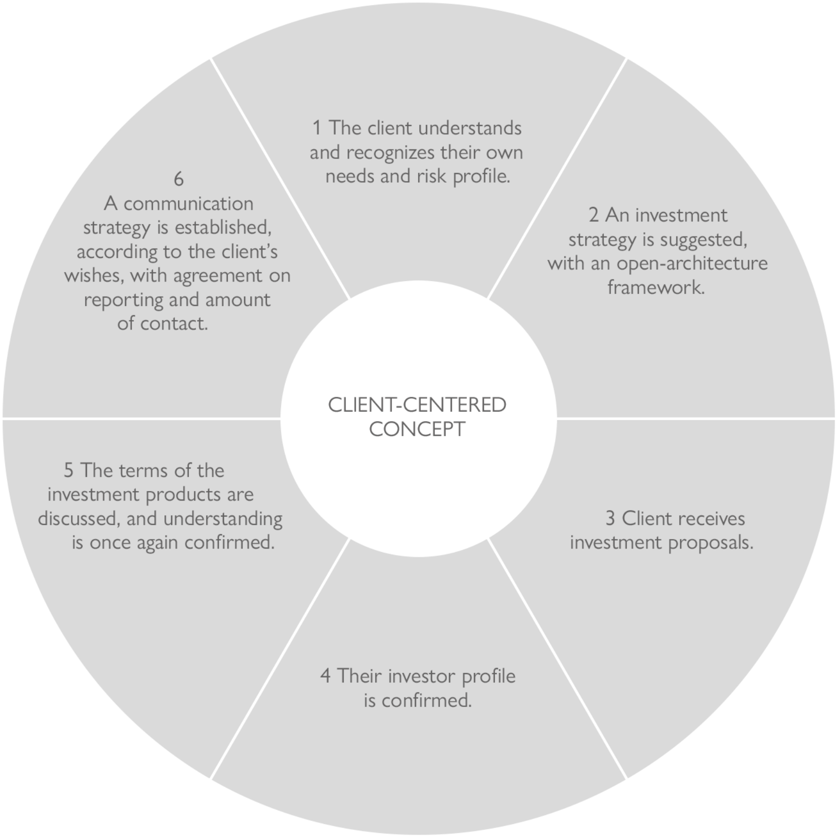
Each stage (or branch) includes four actions:

I ask questions / I understand and validate /
I make a proposal / I implement it.

The fourth step of each branch leads directly into the next branch.

The five steps of the STAR model are shown in the following diagram:

6 This model draws on the investment processes of several banks, as well as on the development of the 'Train to RM' course in 2005


1 The client understands and recognizes their own needs and risk profile.
2 An investment strategy is suggested, with an open-architecture framework.
3 Client receives investment proposals.
4 Their investor profile is confirmed.
5 The terms of the investment products are discussed, and understanding is once again confirmed.
6
A communication strategy is established, according to the client's wishes, with agreement on reporting and amount of contact.
CLIENT-CENTERED CONCEPT


Analysis
Follow-up
Assessment
STAR
Strategy
Identity

STEPS	PURPOSE OF THIS STEP	WHAT THIS STEP ENTAILS
Analyze goals and requirements. Client's identity.	Understand the client and their environment, needs, and financial goals. Create an initial profile.	Ask questions, rephrase them, and confirm the responses.
Financial assessment	Find a balance and alignment between debts and investments.	Analyze the investments that will secure the debts (linked assets) and grow the capital.
The investor's identity	Establish risk appetite and risk aversion (risk profile).	Define the skills the client will need.
Investment strategies	Establish an investment strategy (free assets).	Bank's proposals are tailored to the client's situation
Implementation, follow-up, and review process	Invest the capital and track progress over time.	Decide the review frequency with the client.

In wealth management,
first you sell, then you create…

We'll outline each of the model's five steps in detail.

A. ANALYZE GOALS AND REQUIREMENTS; THE CLIENT'S IDENTITY.

The client's goals and expectations:

- Identity versus identity

The first meeting should be fully dedicated to the client's life, their journey, and their identity. The wealth manager should refrain from discussing investments and should focus solely on presenting their background, as well as the bank.

- The wealth manager's preference analysis

The manager analyzes the existing financial situation: investments, commitments, the structure, and the content of the entire wealth.

Moreover, future factors such as insurance, inheritance, taxes, budgeting, and lifestyle come into play. Investments can vary greatly: management mandates, private equity holdings, real estate and its nature, art collections, and paintings.

It's important to understand the client's personal preferences, as they contribute to the strategic information that guides decision-making.

- Geographical preferences

This means the nationality and culture associated with the place where the client lives and where they travel most frequently.

- Sector preferences

The client's profession will influence this decision, and they will feel more comfortable in the professional sector (and therefore investment area) they have been involved in throughout their life.

- Psychological preferences

Their level of education, academic background, religion, beliefs, and personality are all factors that strongly influence their choices.

A wealth manager needs a precise picture of the client's assets. Good advice depends on having complete information about both the client's wealth and income.

- It bears repeating…

One key aspect of client relationships in wealth management is understanding everything about the client. Incomplete information means the advice may be wrong.

ONE MISSING DETAILS… AND IT COULD ALL FALL APART

A child from a previous marriage—if this information is omitted, it can compromise all estate planning advice. Let's take another example: If assets held at another bank are not disclosed, a similar investment strategy could become dangerous by creating an imbalance in the portfolio (too much risk). The same applies to income, debt, and mortgages: the relationship manager is like a confessor, and everything must be disclosed. The client must share the past, the present, and also the future. Even something like a potential divorce could throw everything off course.

Key questions the wealth manager asks their client:

- What is your investment history?
- Tell me about your experiences, both good and bad.
- Which asset classes do you prefer, and why?
- How are your assets allocated (by asset class and as a proportion of your wealth)?
- Are you happy with the services and results you're getting right now?
- What's your investment time frame?

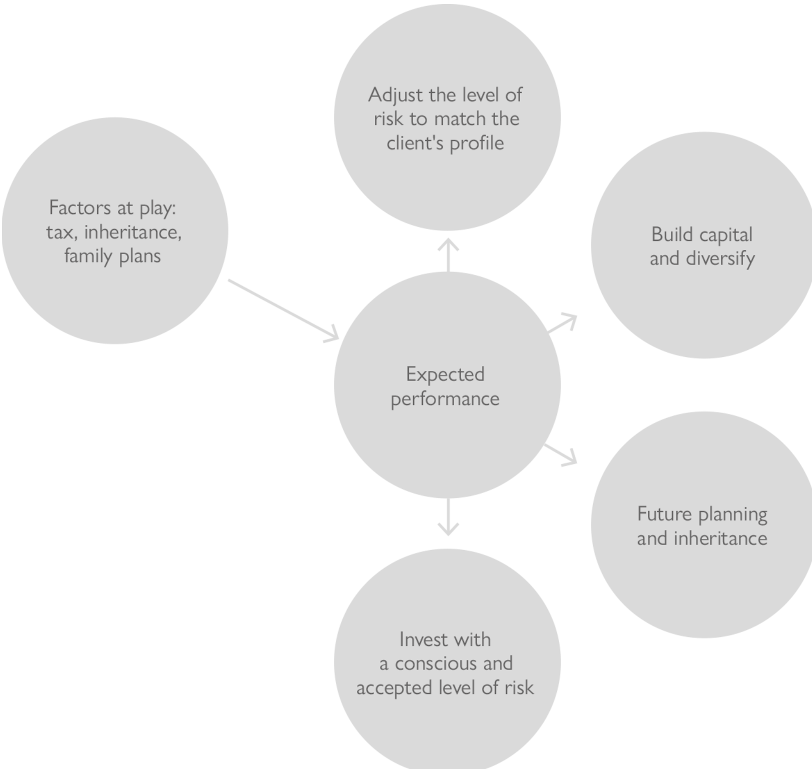
This stage will allow us to:

- Get to know our client well, as they transform into a partner.
- Conduct a financial evaluation.
- Assess the client's overall profile.
- Adjust our efforts based on the client's financial capacity.
- Start to develop a tailored investment strategy.

B. FINANCIAL ASSESSMENT

The three key purposes of the financial assessment:

- The recommended investments will be in line with the client's profile.
- It will allow us to assess what's at stake for the client.
- It will help us understand where the client stands in terms of risk.



Striving for balance

During the analysis, the wealth manager will strive to find a balance between:

- Investments and debts
- Income and expenses (which determine their savings capacity),
- Cash flow needs and income
- Wealth and future investment intentions.

How to assess a client's potential?

By considering four factors:

- Assets held with our bank
- Assets held with other banks

- The projected growth of their wealth over time, considering their professional capacities, potential inheritances, entrepreneurial profile, and personal ambitions
- Additional services the client may need from our bank in the future.

This step allows us to:

- Provide key figures to build the client's profile
- Decide whether commitments should be secured with linked investments
- Focus on what is emotionally important, the amounts at stake, and the projects that need funding
- Understand the client's financial boundaries.

At this stage, it's important for the manager to visualize this financial overview on a sheet, for example, divided into two columns, with financial investments, income, and assets on the left, and the list of commitments and expenses on the right. This will help the client realize what they need to do in relation to what they can do.

C. THE INVESTOR'S IDENTITY: DISCOVERING THEIR TRUE NATURE

What the wealth manager does

The manager will discover the "true" nature of their client when it comes to investing.

The central element for establishing an investor profile is determining their willingness or, conversely, their aversion to risk. Two key factors for assessing this risk profile are the client's capacity and willingness to take risks—what they want and what they can handle.

The ability to take risks is unpredictable and depends on events that have occurred in the client's life. It is important to explore and revisit these regularly (roots analysis).

What is the client's attitude toward taking risks, and their readiness to bear the consequences?

How would they react if they experienced losses?

The wealth manager will rely on the client's experience to gauge this capacity. What the client has revealed through past experiences: their expectations, interest in finances, understanding of what it means to lose money, and possible reactions (based on their previous ones).

There is a clear correlation between the client's knowledge and their willingness to take on risk:

- If they are knowledgeable about financial markets;
- If they are comfortable with equities;
- If they are aware of the risks involved and feel confident investing in high-risk products;
- If they can stay calm when their portfolio loses value.

A risk profile evolves in line with changes in a client's financial situation. It is therefore reviewed as and when these changes occur.

The wealth manager's questions:

- How do you react to a significant increase in your assets? And how about a major loss?
- How would you describe your risk profile using the table below?

RISK PROFILE	CLIENT'S COMMENTS	BEHAVIOR IN THE EVENT OF A (SIGNIFICANT) GAIN	BEHAVIOR IN THE EVENT OF A (SIGNIFICANT) LOSS
Conservative			
Balanced			
Growth-focused			
Aggressive			

D. AN INVESTMENT STRATEGY (ASSET ALLOCATION) THAT ALIGNS WITH THE RISK PROFILE

What the wealth manager does:

The investment strategy is determined by the client's risk profile. Each bank offers investment strategies through standard portfolios, specific products, or customized solutions that consider the client's profile, needs, and the results of prior analysis.

The strategies take into account what the client has said, what they are capable of doing, and what they need to do to achieve their goals.

It is the wealth manager's role to explain how the recommendation fits with the bank's management strategy, before reiterating the investment philosophy.

The management mandate (this will be explained in detail later) is the main framework in which a **client's risk profile** must be clearly defined:

- the profile,
- the client's investment objectives,
- their attitude toward risk,
- the bank's proposed investment solutions,
- the reference currency = the currency of residence, current and future spending, and the currency used to measure performance,
- the timeframe.

The management mandate is often one of the bank's flagship products, where it can showcase its expertise.

The wealth manager's questions:

What kind of open architecture do we offer, and with which partners?
Does our investment style make sense to you?
In your view, what are the main advantages of a management mandate?

E. IMPLEMENTATION, FOLLOW-UP, AND REVIEW

management, potential for new inflows, or specific needs), allowing for more effective tracking plans tailored to individual client profiles. This is when managers must ensure all relevant information is recorded in their CRM system to maintain valuable business records.

7. THE EXPERIENCE-BASED BUSINESS PRACTICES FRAMEWORK (IN ADDITION TO POINT 2.)

An investment doctrine is inspired by the bank's core principles, values, strategy, and work philosophy (see point 2.1). An investment doctrine is inspired by the bank's core principles, values, strategy, and work philosophy (refer to point 2.1). This doctrine sets out the principles that should be followed in the different areas the manager will discuss with the client:

– doctrine on the client's savings,

– doctrine on their financial security and funding,

– Investment principles followed by the client.

The framework is the way in which the doctrine will be applied.

How will the client go about applying their doctrine?

Example:

If the client's doctrine on savings is to reduce financial risks by maintaining the same level of reserves, then the model they would apply would be to save the equivalent of a set number of salaries, depending on their lifestyle.

What makes this topic so important?

Defining a doctrine and sharing it with the client provides a clear guiding framework for investment decisions—a backbone. It ensures coherence in the relationship between manager and client and is supported by solid principles that provide reassurance to clients.

In pursuit of coherence, the model draws on principles we've already outlined:

- Cultural alignment between the manager/salesperson and their bank.
- Understanding the client's investment philosophy and sharing their own.
- Place the client's life project at the heart of the business relationship.
- Present, suggest, and offer products and services that meet the client's needs.
- Treat objections as an opportunity.
- Conclude with grace and confidence.
- Establish a follow-up plan and never give up!

During my wealth management negotiation seminars, I used to invite highly experienced advisers to spark discussion with the younger generations[7].

SPEAKING FROM EXPERIENCE

The following 10 practical tips are based on the account of one of these experienced professionals:

1. You must have a deep understanding of who your client truly is.
2. Investment style depends on the origin of the funds. Someone who has built their savings over a lifetime will generally avoid taking excessive risks in the markets.
3. For older clients with descendants, the time frame takes on great significance, and the ease of accessing funds may strongly influence decisions.
4. It is not the manager's job to dissuade the client from investing, but to outline the associated risks; after all, the client is an adult.
5. The less experienced a client is (even if they have clear ideas), the more advisable it is to offer them a discretionary mandate.
6. As a rule of thumb, the older the client, the more they value income over performance.
7. It is essential that the client understands the risk/return trade-off.
8. Clients should ensure that at least half of their assets remain in their reference currency.
9. Diversifying assets is the cornerstone of sound investment management.
10. Follow the spirit of the times and the culture of your institution by adopting its investment philosophy.

7 Source : CAS. PB executive program 2007.

8. SALES AND ADVISORY PRACTICES IN RETAIL BANKING

Focused on advice and engagement, we felt it would be valuable to share.

The retail banking model

It seemed fitting to end this chapter on models and strategies with a final suggestion, centered around three concepts: Inform – Converse – Commit.

INFORM

1- PREPARATION – UNDERSTANDING THE CLIENT (Google, LinkedIn)

Draw on the information gathered during the initial meeting or previous discussions.

- Identify their stage in the life cycle
- Review the client's relationship with the bank
- Assess their assets and wealth
- Look into the real estate project further if known (using Google Maps)
- Prepare relevant questions to gather any missing information
- Consider how to open the conversation in a warm, positive way
- Establish my objectives and understand theirs.

2- ESTABLISH AN ATMOSPHERE FOCUSED ON GUIDANCE

Introduce the team to the client

- Pay close attention to the little things (such as making sure there's a warm welcome, being punctual, offering refreshments).
- Create a seamless flow from the greeting to the meeting.
- Set the tone with a clean, orderly meeting space.
- Offer a memorable welcome.
- Begin the meeting at a relaxed pace; avoid creating a sense of urgency.
- Exchange business cards.
- Build trust by letting the client get to know you and your organization.
- Structure the meeting by outlining the timings, how many meetings will be needed, how the analysis will unfold and what to expect from each meeting.

DISCUSSION

3- BE AN ACTIVE LISTENER

Ask questions to assess their needs

- Be eager and curious from the outset.
- Ask pre-prepared open-ended questions to pour gather information, then confirm accuracy before recording.
- Engage in discreet cross-selling initially but be sure to document future opportunities.
- Avoid offering products or solutions until you have fully explored the client's needs. Do not make a case before completing this learning phase.

4- INTENSIVE DIALOG

Ask questions – Listen – Affirm

- Recap the client's requirements and be sure to write down the key points.
- Acknowledge the client's perspective during the conversation; ask what stands out to them and what they agree with.
- Draw attention to the most crucial points for the client.
- Wrap up with a method designed to collects "yes" responses (more details in the concluding chapter).

5- IS THE CLIENT HAPPY WITH THE DISCUSSION?

Highlight the advantages of your proposals for the client.

- Explain your value proposition as clearly as possible, taking a teaching approach.
- Link the proposal directly to the identified needs.
- Present two options and back up your recommendation with figures (monthly payments, interest rates, savings…).
- Be confident when discussing the price and hold firm at first (I say no before I say yes, "I never offer something for nothing").
- Monitor both the buying signals and closing indicators closely.

COMMIT

6- DARE TO CLOSE – ENCOURAGE COMMITMENT

Help the client finalize the process:

- Invite feedback ("How does this all sound to you?")
- Prompt the next step with "action-focused" questions (see chapter 12).
- Don't shy away from guiding the client toward the best option.
- Be bold – it's in the client's best interest.
- Move seamlessly into signing the contract.
- Confirm the agreed timeline with the client.
- Confirm all key points in writing, such as commitments, deadlines, and next steps.

FOLLOW-UP: THE SECRET TO SUCCESS!

The quality of the relationship, trust, and professionalism is ultimately reflected in one key action: **the follow-up!**

Confirm legal timeframes clearly in the written summary.

- Establish the client's preferred communication channels for future contact.
- Test the contact methods—a mock phone call with colleagues in the office works best, or send a test message via WhatsApp.
- Introduce everyone who'll be involved in supporting the client, highlighting everyone's strengths.
- Give them a short guide outlining what to do before the next appointment.
- Ask if they'd be willing to act as an active referrer.
- End the meeting with care and personal attention; treat the client as if they were the bank's only one!
- Record all key deadlines with this client in your calendar.

An expert's perspective

In my 38 years of experience, I've known a few "communication gurus" – those masters of rhetoric who can turn the mundane into universal, almost sacred, truths. I've always found them quite fascinating, especially the one who trained me. More often than not, their talent lies not in the depth of their advice but in the theatrical way they deliver it. They're like showmen of the sales or wealth management worlds, reinventing the obvious reinventing the simplest concepts with a single gesture, captivating an audience eager to absorb the most basic truths in expensive seminars.

I've seen this amusing scene unfold a few times: the CEO of a major company being corrected, not on a complex strategic decision, but over a minor behavioral detail. The scene played out in the hushed, luxurious atmosphere of a seminar in Zermatt, Switzerland, reserved for the well-meaning European elite.

I was there, playing the modest role of the assistant, or rather, the supporting character. This memory reminds me how amusing it is to see a room full of seasoned decision-makers religiously embracing advice that could fit on a post-it note: "Adopt a positive inner attitude." Then, with a theatrical gesture, our guru raised his finger to the heavens, as if he had just revealed the secret to eternal life.

The magic happens, not through the message's substance, but simply because it comes with an exorbitant price tag. The sumptuous surroundings of the Mont-Cervin hotel seem to amplify their gullibility. Let's be honest, who would dare question such a revelation when it's delivered in such a setting, complete with all the trimmings of a five-star hotel?

The cost of critical silence seems directly proportional to the size of the hotel bill.

I've always had a rather critical view of the ever-thriving communication industry, largely ruled by gurus like Anthony Robbins and Éric Krauthamme. It's a world where the questions posed are those we should all be asking ourselves without needing an invitation: "What can I improve?", "Are my goals clear?" Questions so disarmingly simple, yet when wrapped in pseudo-spiritual jargon, they seem to take on a mystical dimension.

This "centrifugal management," focused more on the leader's image than on any lasting strategy, often leads to only surface-level problem-solving. A true leader, by contrast, would take a longer view, choosing long-term solutions over quick fixes and allowing everyone to learn from their mistakes.

These so-called gurus seem to live in a bubble of self-satisfaction, untouchable and immune to challenge or contradiction. There's no room for doubt, hesitation, or apology. Their arrogance is often disguised as self-confidence – a confidence that is rooted more in superciliousness than in genuine expertise.

In the end, perhaps the most valuable lesson in private wealth management is how easily we can be drawn in by appearances rather than substance. If these speakers achieve something close to mythical status, perhaps it's simply due to the play of light and shadow they cast upon minds searching for guidance. It's a dazzling performance, but the real mystery is this: How can anyone believe that something so deep could come from a show that is, in the end, nothing more than hot air?

I recently returned to studying, and I and now find myself among university professors who are also researchers (such as Durance, Rival, Ruano Borbalan and Chatelain Ponroy). What strikes me is the depth of their discourse; they embody an ethic of knowledge and learning. They may have other flaws, but arrogance is not one of them. Meeting them has reinforced the critical perspective I've always held. They also reassure me in my role as a trainer, having always tried to avoid empty showmanship and focused instead on encouraging critical thinking and personal autonomy.

Spring into action! **5 key takeaways and an exercise**

FIVE KEY TAKEAWAYS

- Have a commercial strategy guided by a clear philosophy and doctrine.
- Adopt a systemic approach to your discovery process, coupled with an integrated consulting model.
- Structure your commercial strategy based on customer life cycle stages.
- The five-step STAR model.
- Good advice starts with education, then dialog, and finally commitment.

EXERCISE

Chapter 1

Title: A guiding principle, a coherent approach

Aim of the exercise: Learning to make sure your sales philosophy matches your sales behavior.

Instructions:

- Write a few lines outlining your sales philosophy and doctrine.
- Provide two concrete examples that illustrate your definition of advisory work.
- How do you incorporate the concept of the life cycle when analyzing clients' needs?

2

Stay on the ball! !

Strategy, segmentation, and networking

Always have an idea, a vision,

and a strategy — stay one step ahead

TEACHING OBJECTIVES

After reading this chapter, you will be able to:

- Define a strategy and put it into action.
- Use segmentation as both a working principle and the key to efficiency.
- Build commercial momentum within your bank.

Contents table
chapter 2

THE STORY OF THE SHOE SALESMEN…

Two shoe salesmen from the same company were sent on a business trip to a developing country. After a week, the first one, disheartened, sent a message to his sales director: "I'm coming back tomorrow. There's no potential here; everyone walks barefoot."

At the same time, the second salesman also sent a message: "I'm staying longer. This market has huge potential: Everyone goes barefoot!"

Strategy involves thinking ahead of any sales activity.

Look around you, take stock of your resources and options before making a move. Keep one step ahead[1].

1. PUT PRAGMATISM AT THE HEART OF YOUR STRATEGY!

Wealth managers are often well-positioned, comfortable, and well-paid, so motivation isn't always at its peak. With generous salaries, there's little incentive to go the extra mile. Yet private banks have to stay profitable to keep things running, which means the pressure on bankers keeps increasing. The issue is clear!

Where does the energy to keep moving forward come from?

This slightly absurd conversation, pieced together from various sources and set out here nearly in its entirety, highlights just how far we still have to go.

A STORY OF COMPLACENCY

– "Do we really need to prospect?"
"Honestly? Not really. There's no objective reason not to just stick with what we already have. And we already have a lot!"
– "Why is there always this push for more?"
"I've got everything I need. Our salaries are more than generous, and I'd rather just take care of my clients, nothing more."
– "Expanding my portfolio? No thanks. It makes me uncomfortable and anyway, I was hired as a wealth manager, not a salesman! *It's the bank's job to do the canvassing. That's something for the juniors anyway. And to be honest, I don't even know who to contact anymore."*
– "As we say back home, 'we've got nothing to worry about'!"
"How far off retiring are you, anyway?"

1 Well-known 1980s SBS (Swiss Bank Society) commercial

Reading this (real) dialog highlights the reality of a profession that may be at risk of stagnation. The allegory of the frog is the perfect illustration of this.

A FROG IN HOT WATER

An experiment was carried out with a frog.

First, the frog was placed in a pot of cold water, which was then heated on a stove. The frog didn't feel anything. The water began to warm up and get hot, but the frog still felt nothing. The water became very hot and started to simmer, before finally boiling. The heat gradually dulled the frog's senses, and it was gradually overwhelmed, eventually dying without noticing.

In the second part of the experiment, the water was brought to a boil before the frog was dropped in. The frog's reaction was immediate: As soon as it touched the boiling water, it leapt out of the pot and survived. Just like the first frog, we too can fall into a comfort zone that lulls us into danger. Sometimes, chaos serves a purpose.

2. WHY IS IT IMPORTANT TO KEEP PROSPECTING ALL THE TIME?

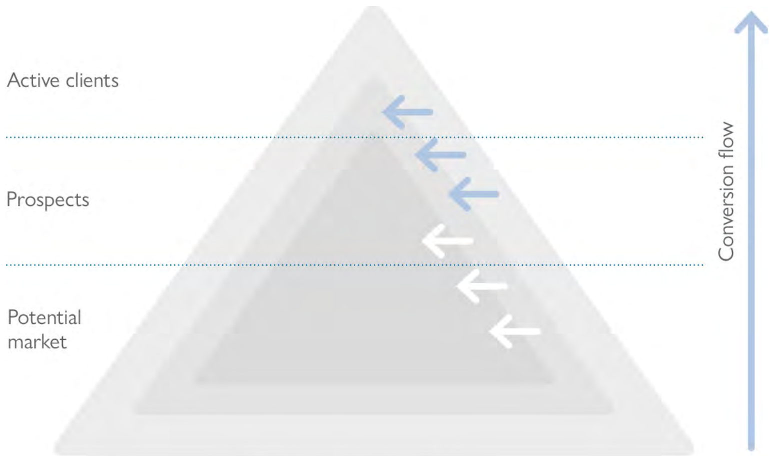
We must remain constantly alert, awake, and aware, both in terms of the market, our existing clients, and our prospects.

A commercial portfolio naturally erodes by 3 to 5% per year (excluding client inflows and departures), due to capital drawdowns and client inheritance. On top of this, banking clients are becoming increasingly volatile, and loyalty is no longer a given.

There is, therefore, a mathematical reality behind the need for ongoing prospecting.

Another argument – central to the very nature of commercial activity – is the importance of building contacts to maintain a steady stream of business income.

If you don't prospect your market,
your competitors will do it for you!



Changes in a sales portfolio

As the diagram shows, when a portfolio isn't actively managed, it naturally shrinks. To increase the number of active clients, the salesperson needs to engage their potential market and broaden their base to ensure an upward conversion flow.

The wait-and-see approach, sometimes laced with arrogance, once typical of "old school" private bankers, has thankfully faded away. You hardly ever hear things like "Here's my card, just in case" anymore—a typical Swiss expression. The days when private bankers only had to look out the window to see the length of the line outside their door are well and truly over.

3. THE FOUR CARDINAL POINTS OF COMMERCIAL THINKING

One attitude and three actions: The first direction (1) is a strategic attitude.

Only the "pitbull" wealth managers survive

A. STRATEGIC ATTITUDE OR STRATEGIC "INTUITION"

Strategy allows us to express what we want to do for our clients and helps to guide our decisions. This might be a case of "focusing on the needs of our most demanding clients" or "providing a service for external asset managers."

A strategy is always something you can explain; otherwise, it's not a strategy, it's simply an intention.

When a bank sets out a strategy, it is to meet specific needs or constraints, including:

- A change in situation
- Increasingly complex markets
- Tougher performance goals
- The need to reposition in the market to stay ahead of competitors.

At the root of any strategy lies the company's vision of its future, where it wants to go, and why. Next comes its mission – its purpose in the market – and finally, its (commercial) strategy, which outlines how it intends to achieve its goals.

Every strategy has a starting point, which is the bank's position in the market.

What market segment is it operating in today, and where does it intend to position itself in the future?

Market positioning is based on key values such as proximity, cutting-edge technology, CSR (Corporate Social Responsibility), and a human touch. These values underpin the future strategy and help make a stronger case when explaining it or justifying commercial choices.

Excuse the tautology, but putting a strategy in place allows the commercial leadership to make strategic decisions. These include identifying priority markets, targeting specific market segments, and outlining competitive tactics.

What is the point of having a strategy?[2]

One of the main purposes of a strategy is to establish a competitive position in the market. It is by no means necessary to be the market leader; what matters is showing how you stand out. The decisive advantage lies in a combination of human expertise and technology, in addition to price and product benefits.

Analyzing the competition is strategic tool to identify our own strengths in the market. Harvard expert Michael Porter (Porter's Five Forces) outlines four main areas to examine when looking at competitors. This approach involves asking clients directly about their other banking providers.

Porter's four components adapted for banking clients:

1. Identifying the **goals** of competing banks and evaluating their position with our mutual client.
2. **Assessing** the quality of these competitors' engagement with the client: are they comfortable in their relationship with our mutual client?
3. What are their short- and medium-term **strategies** with the same client?
4. An assessment of each competitor's strengths and weaknesses in fields that complement or overlap with the services we offer to our mutual client.

The interesting angle in this analysis adapted from Porter is to ask the client about our competitors. This is certainly easier said than done, and you'll need to pick the right moment and have a good reason for bringing it up.

The following risk matrix can help private banking leaders take stock of where their bank stands commercially.

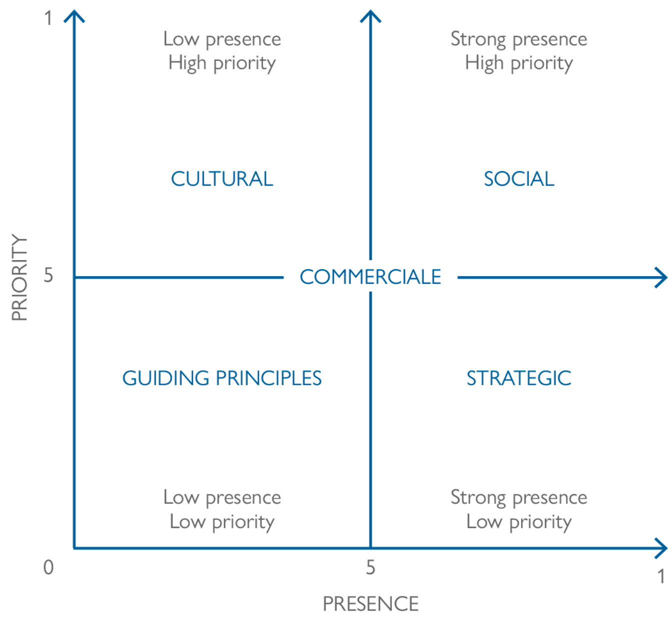
A bank can assess the risk to its commercial impact if any of the following dimensions are insufficiently integrated into its sales process.

Risk is measured by combining how much importance the bank attaches to a dimension with how present it actually is in practice across the following five areas:

2 Largely inspired by: *Waging Business Warfare – Lessons from the Military Masters in Achievig Competitive Superiority*, David Roger.

1. **Strategic:** Is there a clear sense of commercial direction?
2. **Guiding principles:** Are these declared and used by Relationship Managers?
3. **Social:** Does the bank value the human side of the business?
4. **Commercial:** Is the commercial focus clear to those in client-facing roles?
5. **Cultural:** Are values and group identity used in sales conversations?

Each dimension should be mapped onto this risk matrix.



B. THE DIFFERENT TYPES OF STRATEGY

They may pursue a leader, challenger, niche, expert, or follower strategy[3].

The goal is to stand out by using competitive advantages as talking points during client meetings. It's not about being obsessed with leading on a client or a portfolio. Sometimes, what Kotler[4] refers to as followers can be far more profitable than the leader in the same market.

The wealth manager may adopt a niche strategy with a client by focusing on a segment where they have more expertise than their competitors.

3 Cf. Kotler & Dubois, *Marketing Management*, Pearson, 2005.
4 *Ibidem*

The table below compares three strategies[5], and we consider the judo strategy to be the most appropriate.

CONFLICT STRATEGY	COOPERATIVE STRATEGY	JUDO STRATEGY
• Power is key • Focuses on immediate gain • Relationships are secondary • Tries to impose their solution • Pursues maximum gain • The end justifies the means • Zero-sum games • Willing to accept an unequal outcome • Risk of relationship breakdown	• Trust is key • Focuses on the long term • Relationships are as important as the stakes • Tries to understand problems • Seeks mutual gain • Willing to make concessions to build together • Win/Win • Something is better than nothing • Wants to maintain good relationships	• Mutual consultation • Positive compromises • Competitive spirit • No compromise on fundamentals, but mutual support • Seek common interests • Credibility lies in the technique • Power is in movement • Action is consistent and aligned

C. STRATEGIC OFFENSIVE MOVES: A LESSON FROM THE MILITARY

The military invented the concept of strategy, describing certain phases of conflict as high or low intensity. Here, we provide an analogy with five simple, short examples of military strategy:

FRONTAL ATTACK STRATEGY

It requires a "strength" advantage; the military refers to it as "3 to 1" to gain an advantage on the battlefield. In other words, three times more presence, budget, and personnel on the front lines.

FLANKING ATTACK STRATEGY

The advantage is geographical, involving both the location and segmentation.

ENCIRCLEMENT ATTACK STRATEGY

The wealth manager takes up positions on several fronts at once, including price, distribution, and quality.

BYPASS ATTACK STRATEGY

Offering unrelated products, targeting new geographical areas, or using new technologies.

5 Remarks from a participant at the 2007 CAS banking sales seminar.

GUERRILLA STRATEGY

Attack by all possible means, ignoring established rules and conventions.

CONVICTION STRATEGY, A DOUBLE-EDGED SWORD[6]

Conviction carries energy and helps persuade. However, it can also be tricky when a client uses their own conviction as a form of objection.

When a conviction is challenged, it tends to grow stronger. Conviction is rooted in each person's rational mind; it bubbles up from their past experiences, and how those experiences made them feel, whether good or bad.

Personality functions as a holistic system: Its elements are interconnected and influence one another. The system seeks its own balance and resists cognitive dissonance[7] when certain beliefs are challenged.

How can this dissonance be reduced? As with objections, the same options apply: avoid, reframe, isolate… but not direct confrontation through opposing argument. Sidestepping the issue is the most effective strategy.

1. The strategy of conviction involves identifying the shared beliefs between the two parties in a business relationship.
2. Once we've established what we have in common, we can move toward looking at the dissonances. These will serve as a starting point for exploring potential issues the client may face in managing their assets (with other banks). The goal is to highlight general dissatisfaction and, in particular, cognitive dissonances. In other words, a form of reversed conviction.
3. The third phase is where we really highlight the gap by asking about the negative effects of these dissatisfactions and dissonances.

The strategy ends at that point. Solutions should only come up once the client acknowledges the situation and comes to you in search of answers to their problems.

D. THE LEGACY OF SUN TZU[8]

The father of all strategists: Sun Tzu and The Art of War

Sun Tzu, an author from several millennia ago, wrote a book that still feels surprisingly relevant today. This section is inspired by Pierre Fayard's insightful and highly readable commentary[9]

6 The role of emotions in negotiation, Fanny Chollet, "Le comportement non-verbal en négoci ation." ("Non-Verbal Behavior in Negotiation.") Master's thesis in psychology. University of Geneva (2021).
7 Cognitive dissonance, a term coined in 1957 by Leon Festinger, refers to a state of mental tension experienced when there is a conflict between our thoughts, values, and actions.
Source: Lionel Bellenger, *Être stratège. Éduquer l'esprit de compétition* ("Being a Strategist: Educating the Spirit of Competition", untranslated) ESF.
Pierre Fayard, *Comprendre et appliquer Sun Tzu. La pensée stratégique chinoise : une pensée en action* ("Understanding and Applying Sun Tzu: Chinese Strategic Thought – Thinking in Action", untranslated), Dunod & Polia.

Strategy is the opposite of chance; it is determinism, the opposite of "it was meant to be," "that's how it is," or "come what may." Strategists are the opponents of fatality. According to Chinese thought, strategy praises flexibility and adaptability, the "soft and fluid," in contrast to the rigid and inevitable "hard and certain".

Keeping clients is more profitable than finding new ones.
Client loyalty is the key to long-term profitability.

This perspective on strategy as a series of opportunities (could anything be more contradictory than that?) is fiercely human. It strives to predict, yet remains humble because it recognizes the reality of things. *"It is easier to predict the past because we are never wrong."* The future is scarcely anticipated; it is glimpsed, perhaps even felt in times of change, but reason has its limits.

For Sun Tzu, strategy is about the relationship with the environment; it is conceived in a holistic, 360° manner. It considers all the possibilities of a situation, making connections with each parameter and creating harmony. The systemic approach from the previous chapter fits into this way of thinking.

The military strategist, in Sun Tzu's view, pays attention to the energies around him, especially those from nature, and draws inspiration from them.

The book is structured around 36 stratagems, which are tricks, tactics, and strategic ideas to address a problem. In the context of the book, the problem is often military or diplomatic. For instance, one battle pitted two forces against each other, with one being numerically superior and better armed. The weaker side had no choice but to resort to cunning and stratagems to win. The idea behind strategy is important—it's about survival. In business, the comparison ends there; strategies are choices, but no one's life is on the line.

According to Pierre Fayard, strategy is adaptive, just like a goldfish that only grows depending on the size of the bowl it lives in. The depth, reflection, and follow-up of strategy should be in harmony with the environment where it's applied (its implementation).

This concept merges with the subtle Chinese perception of time and duration.

- **The temporal dimension** must become a competitive advantage.
- Strong ties between an army and its leader are the key to success. A true strategist looks for sources of invincibility, rather than being swayed by appearances.
- **Better to be modest than to seem powerful** while lacking real strength – like a paper tiger. True power is best unveiled at the right moment, to win both physically and psychologically.
- For Sun Tzu, the strategist exploits the enemy's weaknesses and relies on internal unity to wait for the other side to slip up.

- Understanding that relationships are central to success, he deliberately **sows discord in the opposing camp,** wearing them down, and patiently waits for the client to turn to him. Though the terminology is aggressive, it aptly reflects negotiation tactics, such as when a wealth manager encourages a client to confront their competing banker with an awkward question.
- The creative analogy between business dynamics and Sun Tzu's strategy can also be illustrated by a Chinese martial art, **Tai-chi-chuan**. The movements are harmonious and fluid, with a graceful aesthetic expressed in both the body's motion and the synchronized rhythm of the breath. Unhindered in its flow, the movement expresses life itself, and the flow of energy is tangible.
- The philosophy **of Yin and Yang** – opposites that complement one another – forms the fabric of Chinese philosophy. Another insightful feature of Chinese thought : The wise and the thoughtful (those considered knowledgeable) have always been valued more highly than powerful, battle-driven warriors. As Sun Tzu wrote, *"weapons are inauspicious instruments, not the tools of the enlightened,"* as well as the need to *"attack the enemy's strategy… attack plans at their inception."*
- Another key angle of strategic thought is the **ability to adapt**. The image of water frequently appears as a metaphor for flexibility — it takes the shape of whatever it encounters. Another strategist, Clausewitz[10], echoes this idea when he states that "war is more than a true chameleon."
- An equally important idea in Chinese thinking is **the art of cunning**, which we'll refer to as creativity. It involves handling situations sensitively, never fearing to engage with opposites. The strong and the weak, the true and the false, the more and the less — these are not in conflict, but are interconnected. After all, *"If one side of the mountain is in shadow, the other is in sunlight."*
- Another hallmark of Chinese strategy is **the order of focus**: The big picture comes first, then the details. One must begin with a broad overview before narrowing in on specifics.

Sun Tzu's strategic thinking is expressed through stratagems, and we have selected seven that seem the most useful in negotiation.

1. **The secret cloaked in light.** As a judoka, this first stratagem spoke to me because it illustrates the fundamental principle of judo: Use your opponent's strength and add it to your own. You must pay attention to the tiniest details, even the seemingly insignificant, rather than the glaringly obvious. The idea is to blend into the opponent's polarity. When the opponent is strong and assertive, the strategist fades into the background and lowers their stance.
2. **The potential of others.** Use the strategies of others as leverage for your own. Have others carry out the riskiest tasks. Never lose sight of your objective. Any strategy, regardless of its origin, is a potential that can be appropriated. Do not reject others but use them to serve your purposes.

10 Carl von Clausewitz, *On War*, 1832.

3. **Concentration followed by dispersion.** At the peak of strength comes the beginning of weakness; it is from the zenith that the Sun starts to decline. It's like in Judo, where brute force must be met with flexibility and adaptability. In negotiation, the manager does not oppose, but rather cooperates and adds.
4. **Creating from nothing, when illusion shapes reality.** The strategist achieves their aim by exploiting existing tensions. Where imagination takes hold, the strategist makes their move. Opportunity arises when tension is released through false appearances.
5. **The pinch of praise, uncovering concealed motives before taking action.** This is an attacking stratagem. It involves leaking information to expose the intentions of others. Using deception to flush out hidden motives. The strategist's goal is not to reach a conclusion but to reveal the other's intentions in order to act with certainty.
6. **The fatal favor, surrendering what has already been lost.** This stratagem is based on the principle of the winning surrender or "serving the poison on a silver platter." Feigning defeat to induce a victory when there is none, taking advantage of the opponent's momentary lapse (or victory) to strike hard. *"By abandoning what is nearly lost, you soften the other. Do not insist on defending what is indefensible before focusing on what is possible."* (Fayard).
7. **The greatness in retreat.** The long march: salvaging what remains. Retreat is considered the ultimate stratagem, or the "stratagem of all stratagems." Whether real or feigned, there is dignity—and no shame—in turning back or letting go. Dying a hero often serves less purpose than a retreat that allows for reinvention. It's the price to pay to preserve one's freedom of thought and move forward again toward the future.

E. MORE ON SUN TZU

These three excerpts drawn from *The Art of War* offer useful parallels with negotiation.

- Sun Tzu's five rules for a general[11]:

1. Know when to fight and when to stop.
2. Know whether to deploy a few or many resources.
3. Appreciate ordinary soldiers as much as officers.
4. Know how to make the most of every situation.
5. Know that the ruler approves of anything done in his service and for his glory.

Sun Tzu emphasizes the importance of *initiative* and *surprise*, as well as choosing the right time and place to strike. Finally, he describes *deception* as the highest form of intelligence in conflict.

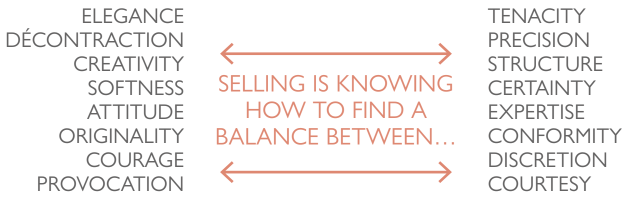
11 Pierre Fayard. Opus cité.

- The most often cited principles that deserve attention:
- – Allow the opponent to save face; give them a way out,
- – Create changes in the situation,
- – Attack when the opponent least expects it,
- – Sow division; exploit internal dissent,
- – Bait the enemy to lure them into a trap,
- – Simulate disorder and strike unexpectedly,
- – Feign incapacity,
- – Know the terrain thoroughly,
- – Know yourself well,
- – Prefer to capture the enemy intact rather than destroy them,
- – Use the enemy's own resources to achieve swift victory,
- – When danger looms, move quickly,
- – Ongoing use of intelligence.

How to exploit the five common weaknesses of leaders:

If they are reckless, they are easy to kill.
If they are cowardly, they are easy to capture.
If they are quick-tempered, they are easy to provoke.
If they are proud, they are easy to insult.
If they are emotional, they are easy to upset.

Balancing Yin and Yang in sales



4. COMMERCIAL STRATEGIES

A commercial strategy is the approach managers use to optimize their commercial efforts and manage their portfolio (including all current and potential clients or prospects).

The reasons for changing a strategy often stem from developments in the client's situation, usually because they didn't see those changes coming.

Strategies for staying one step ahead:

- Adapt to the situation, find your place, and make the most of it.
- Monitor competitors closely for slip-ups.
- Develop in every possible direction — in volume, in the range of products and services offered, through cross-selling and client referrals.
- Scale back offerings and home in on a more selective, focused approach to client support.
- Reinvent your client relationship by redefining your place within their overall portfolio.
- Change your communication style.
- Change the investment strategy you offer them.

In the coming years, wealth managers will need to demonstrate even greater agility in their business strategies. Private wealth clients are all connected, some extremely so, spending over five hours a day online.

Social media is shaping our view of the world, and the desire for discretion is fading. The rise of the Metaverse makes this even clearer. The behaviors of banking clients are changing just as rapidly, and so are their relationships with their banks. When they engage online, they become targets for marketing. Increasingly, clients see this as a form of recognition, often becoming visible without intending to.

But paradoxically, clients are increasingly averse to intrusions into their private lives (even though they do everything to invite them) and unwanted advertising. Sharing experiences on social media has become commonplace; my children and grandchildren snap photos of their meals and can't experience an emotion without capturing the moment and sharing it with their friends. Clients are more engaged with their consumption than ever.

If we add hyper-connectivity to this, we have a shared "hyper-connected customer experience."

With all the known drawbacks, the majority of content is shared by internet users, not brands. Social media networks are aging poorly; Facebook has been considered outdated for a few years now, and new alternatives are taking its place. I won't mention specific examples as they would be outdated in six months.

At every level, connectivity has become pervasive, with an all-knowing AI.

This prompts us to consider new ways of attracting our customers. They no longer have the same sense of loyalty as before, they speak their minds and are no longer afraid to switch banks (as they have endless options available). They have access to expertise 24/7 through tools like Google or ChatGPT and expect the same level of attention they experience while online.

In this context, the following behaviors are essential for the wealth manager[12]:

- Ensure as much personal contact as possible.
- Be creative and know how to think outside the box more than before.
- Work as a team, make your resources available, and use them to reassure clients.
- Make your clients' expectations the starting point for all thinking (give them a voice).
- Prepare to incorporate cutting-edge tools such as ChatGPT or augmented reality.
- Tailor every approach with your clients, like on the internet (dynamic content personalization).
- Follow up with the client; they no longer mind this.
- Don't be afraid to make comparisons.
- Be more addicted to social media than your clients – it's the new CRM (Customer Relationship Management)
- Nothing will ever be the same again!

BAD ADVICE, BEST UNDERSTOOD IN REVERSE13[13]

1. *Never approach a negotiation with enthusiasm.*
2. *Always respond negatively to the initial offer.*
3. *Always ask for the impossible. The worst that can happen... is that you get it.*
4. *Be smart: play dumb! Ask for explanations or say you don't understand. They might pity you and make concessions—or underestimate you and slip up.*
5. *Try to gain concessions without giving anything real in return. Always be ready to walk away, and say so. Then the pressure of potential failure shifts to them!*

12 Source: Inspired by a PowerPoint presentation delivered by a participant during a sales training session.
13 Source: «Train to RM» training, CS 2004.

THE TACTICAL APPROACH

1. Appliquez le principe de Pareto : dans une négociation, 80 % des concessions sont faites dans les dernières étapes (les derniers 20 % du temps de négociation), formulez vos demandes les plus importantes en fin de négociation !
2. Si vous êtes en difficulté… sachez changer de sujet… et oubliez ce qui vous pose un problème, si la partie adverse refuse, proposez un report à plus tard pour manque d'informations ou d'éléments.
3. Une négociation n'est jamais une partie de plaisir, aussi elle se prépare avec soin. Richard Nixon disait : « Il faut toujours être prêt à négocier mais ne jamais négocier sans être prêt. »

A. WHY COMMERCIAL STRATEGY MUST BE HOLISTIC

B. A STRATEGIC ASSESSMENT[14]

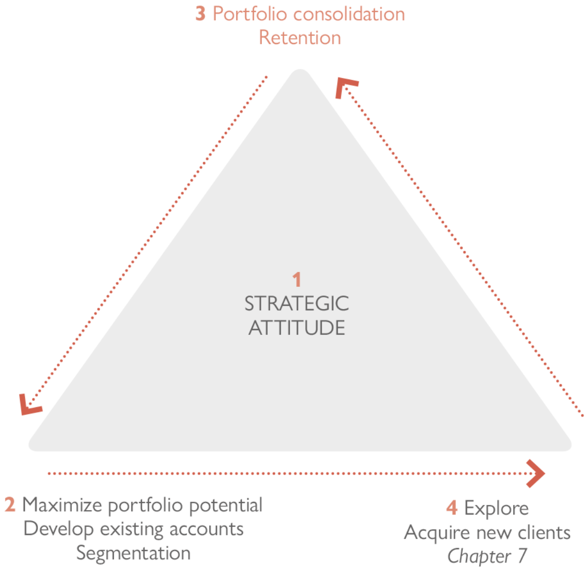
The principle is simple: we list resources, skills, and external factors available to the wealth manager. The next step is to assess whether these are positive or negative and how they could affect our client.

14 Based on Professor Raymond's course: "Strategic Diagnostic Framework" (2017).

RESOURCES	ADVANTAGES/ STRENGTHS DISADVANTAGES / WEAKNESSES	IMPACT ON THE PRIVATE BANKING CLIENT	WHAT THE RM CAN DO
Human	Sharing the workforce to cater to a client's needs in a bank is a strength	Expertise is given a human dimension	The RM should personally introduce the staff supporting the client
Material	The premises, branches, and lounges	Showing clients around the bank, commenting on the artwork, is crucial. Offer them the catalog	Make sure the client is familiar with the surroundings and feels at home
Financial	A bank needs to be profitable to build trust	Projected outcomes are bound to create impact	Regularly present the bank's figures
IT	Depends on how up to date it is	Mobile connectivity is now expected	IT systems should simplify the user experience
Marketing	It's a strength if marketing is aligned with RM behaviors	Market visibility and brand awareness have a positive impact	Access to senior leadership increases asset inflows
Bank structure	Streamlined information and processes give a competitive edge	Meeting senior managers helps clients feel valued and connected	The RM's reactions illustrate the managers' ability to motivate
Managerial skills	Motivation evident at all stages of the client journey	Clients notice the bank's ability to create motivation	Formal qualifications are now essential for private banking institutions.
Professional roles	The cornerstone of the bank	It depends heavily on the skill level of all contributing professionals	Toutes les certifications techniques deviennent vitales pour les banques de gestion privée.

RESOURCES	ADVANTAGES/ STRENGTHS DISADVANTAGES / WEAKNESSES	IMPACT ON THE PRIVATE BANKING CLIENT	WHAT THE RM CAN DO
Market analysis and strategy	Its strength is reflected in the investment proposals	The client understands the relevance of each recommendation	The RM must know how to highlight this part of the work
Research and development	The bank sells analytical	Explain how R&D operates, its budget, and its mission	If possible, introduce the R&D leads
External factors			
PESTEL (Political, Economic, Social, Technological, Environmental, Legal)	A broad environmental analysis is carried out.	Contextualizing the situation (particularly in Switzerland) helps build client confidence.	Reinforcing core values such as freedom of action, thought, and investment
Attitude toward the competition	Confident market awareness becomes a strategic asset in the RM's hands	A composed attitude, where the RM invites clients to check out competitors on specific points	The RM should remain calm and composed toward the competition
The bank's market positioning	The bank's core principles define its unique positioning	Every visit should give the client a clear sense of the bank's world.	Culture, history, values, strategy, and market stance must be part of the message.

The second cardinal point: Maximizing the value of a commercial portfolio



C. TWO CONDITIONS AND FOUR KEY PRINCIPLES in managing a client portfolio:

Condition 1: Knowing how to step back and anticipate market changes and client behavior.

Questions to ask in order to anticipate change:

- How is my market "moving" right now?
- How is it likely to evolve?
- Am I detecting the subtle signals my clients are currently sending?
- How can I interpret these subtle signals to identify business trends?
- Where should I focus my attention to spot subtle signals?
- What methods should I use to monitor these them?
- How will I respond to keep up with these developments?

By anticipating, I can make decisions today to help me be more effective tomorrow.

Condition 2: Segment my client portfolio (see point 5).

Organize my portfolio into separate segments to make it easier to decide how to allocate my resources (time and resources).

"I have a large number of clients but limited time available."

THE FOUR MAIN PRINCIPLES OF ACTION:

1. The principle of choice:

This principle involves prioritizing the highest commercial potential; in other words, focusing and dedicating your time first to clients who bring the greatest added value. Segmenting the commercial portfolio will help the manager apply this principle. Which clients will help me most easily reach my short- and medium-term objectives?

2. The principle of the highest potential segment:

This principle involves identifying the most profitable segment within my portfolio.

Questions to ask yourself:

- Which segments bring me closest to my personal objectives and commercial strategy, in line with the bank's?
- Which segments make the best use of my skills?
- Which segments represent the largest volume in terms of assets under management?
- In which segments do I have the greatest chance of obtaining client referrals?

3. The principle of portfolio balance:

This principle involves maintaining the right balance between existing clients (with potential to grow) and new clients (to be acquired).

Within a balanced portfolio, two strategies operate simultaneously:

- acquiring *"new name assets"*
- retaining *"old name assets"*

The Pareto principle – the 80/20 rule:

Using this principle, I can pinpoint my Top 40 clients.

Focusing on developing the "Top 40" segment requires less energy than constantly acquiring new clients.

The principle: 20% of our clients generate 80% of our revenue.

What really matters isn't just the obvious 20% that gets the most attention. These are the best clients.

Even more interesting is the remaining 80% of existing clients; this rich source of potential is often "underexploited."

These clients are the focus of renewed commercial efforts, with the objective of maximizing the potential of an already captive client base. This analysis is key, as it represents the most favorable strategic option when no additional human resources are available.

You may want to consider:

1. List the top 20% of your clients (who generate 80% of your revenue). Ensure they are contacted regularly and consistently invited to events.

What have I done today for my best clients?

2. Identify the remaining 80% of your clients (who generate only 20% of your revenue) and schedule follow-ups to explore their growth potential.

5. SEGMENTATION: A TOOL FOR COMMERCIAL INTELLIGENCE

Segmentation is a commercial tool that has become strategic. Its implementation is now essential due to the need for greater efficiency, the reduction in available resources, and the growing demand for productivity.

SEGMENTATION	
is...	is not...
A purely commercial logic	A rigid organizational requirement
An efficient way to classify clients	A way to control wealth managers
A way to focus on what matters most	A banking standard for sorting clients in a CRM

Segmentation is first and foremost about selling intelligently.

WHAT'S THE POINT OF SEGMENTING A CLIENT PORTFOLIO?	VALUE
It helps you draw a clear picture of your portfolio. *I know who is important to my business.*	****
To focus efforts on the biggest potential, which allows better allocation of my resources toward the right target. *The less time I have, the more I segment.*	***
Prioritizing business contacts and managing my energy more effectively. *If I had just one hour to prospect, who would I call first?*	***
Simpler and quicker targeting for the bank's marketing activities (events). *Who should I invite first?*	**
Cross-selling and pitching are easier. *I sell relevant products; what and to whom?*	**
Sharing and spreading positive customer experiences more effectively (within the same client group) *Birds of a feather flock together!*	**
You improve your up-selling strategies. *I see results more quickly.*	**

When managers must handle a large number of clients, it's easy to get lost in the volume. Segmenting means differentiating by characteristics that allow the portfolio to be organized into distinct and recognizable parts; it's about creating "homogeneous subsets." [15]

To be more efficient, managers tend to lump clients and their needs together; **even worse, they follow a *"first come, first served"* approach.**

A. SEGMENTATION HELP YOU STAND OUT FROM THE COMPETITION

Segmenting your portfolio means being able to quickly target and qualify each of your clients in order to:

- Identify several client groups and develop a specific approach and attention for each group.
- Offer each group opportunities suited to their profiles.
- Take concrete commercial steps within each segment.
- Exploit all the potential of each client.

15 Kotler & Dubois, *Marketing Management*, Pearson, 2005.

- Be as rational as possible by matching the necessary skills and resources to each segment (no over-servicing).
- Sell the right product to the right client.
- Distinguish the different levels of client knowledge.

Segments are effective when they are:

- Measurable,
- Appropriately sized,
- Relevant to expectations of the client group within the segment.

Segments are generally defined using criteria such as AUM[16] amounts or the potential for AUM growth.

Each segment can be broken down into sub-segments, often organized by life-cycle criteria. This approach is the most frequently used.

We rely on what can be recognized at first glance by the manager. The finer points of analysis fall to the CRMs, which are far more effective. This glance means reviewing their list or portfolio—an ongoing commercial action the manager performs whenever possible to decide what to do and with whom.

Segment-based client management helps the wealth manager to:

- Use their commercial time effectively and adopt a "differentiated marketing" approach[17].
- Quickly understand new clients, their needs, and their level of knowledge.
- Align the bank's offerings to new clients in a timely and relevant way.
- Target prospecting efforts, build convincing arguments, and select the right acquisition targets.
- Focus sales efforts and adapt their negotiation approach.

B. WHAT HAPPENS WHEN SEGMENTATION IS ABSENT OR POORLY EXECUTED?

- The offer doesn't match the client's profile, and the relationship feels impersonal.
- The manager's time and attention are spread too thin.
- Misdirected attention results in wasted time and energy.
- Ineffective commercial efforts lead to high marketing costs and unnecessary use of resources.

Relationship managers may design differentiated offerings for each segment of their portfolio. This implies, of course, that the manager has a thorough understanding of their clients (a self-evident truth). They can then develop a commercial action plan (CAP) tailored to the segments in their portfolio.

The following provides an initial outline of such a plan (refer to point 6).

16 Asset Under Management.
17 *Ibid*. Kotler & Dubois.

Stages of the Commercial Action Plan:

CLIENT SEGMENT	SUB- SEGMENT	SEGMENT ANALYSIS	SALES CHANNELS	SALES OBJECTIVES
AUM by segment	Lifecycle stage	Source of RA	LinkedIn and social media	Qualitative and quantitative
Development potential	Top 40	Development potential as a %	Direct contact	Event participation
Sector segment	Legal, medical professions, etc.	Close relationship	Direct prospecting	Qualitative and quantitative
Family cluster segment	Main client's inner circle, outer circle, etc.	Number of clients, initial contacts	Specific events for the cluster	Qualitative and quantitative

RECAP: WHY A CRM IS IMPORTANT

The CRM is your best friend!

You can't improve what you don't measure.

As the saying goes, a craftsman is only as good as his tools. A CRM is an essential tool to retain commercial knowledge—and therefore secure the future of your revenue.

C. TWO CASE STUDIES IN PORTFOLIO SEGMENTATION

Two easy-to-use, combinable segmentation techniques: **ABC & Top 40.**

ABC SEGMENTATION

This is the most widely used and recognized way to organize a portfolio[18]. It consists of splitting it into three categories: A, B, and C.

18 There's no point in reinventing the wheel.

Segmentation process

- Create the ABC segmentation and the resulting Top segment.
- Complete the ABC table, outlining the nature of contacts and their frequency.
- Define the commercial actions to be taken for each segment (A-B-C) and schedule them in your calendar.

Create an action plan where every client is visible in your calendar!

The ABC segmentation principle applies across the entire commercial portfolio.

CLIENT SEGMENT	ALLOCATION CRITERIA	AUM / PROFITABILITY PROPORTION	NUMBER OF MY CLIENTS IN THIS SEGMENT
A	Clients with the largest assets under management, OR clients with the biggest potential, OR those with potential for repeat business, OR clients with strong relationships OR small clients who are highly satisfied (potential client referral) who have extensive contacts.	20% of clients who generate 80% of your AUM	40
B	Clients with a smaller volume of assets under management and limited potential	50% of clients who generate 15% of your AUM	100
C	The “small” clients	30% of clients who generate 5% of your AUM	60

Exemple pour un portefeuille de 200 clients

Who is behind the 160 clients in segments B and C?
Segmenting is about organizing your sales efforts!

Keep things simple and follow them through.
Only pitbull managers survive.

Exercise: Perform an ABC segmentation based on your actual client list.

Column 1: Assign segment A, B, or C to at least 5 of your clients.

Column 2: Choose the kind of contact to be made with these clients.

Column 3: Determine how often to contact clients (the frequency can be applied to the entire segment).

Column 4: Identify specific sales actions for each client.

Column 5: Record the details from columns 3 and 4 in your diary (do this for at least 5 clients).

CLIENTS BY SEGMENT	TYPE OF CONTACT (IN-PERSON MEETING, PHONECALL, VIDEOCALL ETC.)	CONTACT FREQUENCY	SPECIFIC SALES ACTIONS, SPECIALIST INVOLVEMENT	TO SCHEDULE IN YOUR DIARY
Client Dupont **A** AUM 15 Million	In-person mee-ting	4 times a year Once yearly review	Private asset presentation on June 12 with the Portfolio Manager	Add to the calendar: June 12 and September 10 (follow-up)

The important thing is to leave no stone unturned!

D. THE TOP 40

The number 40 could just as well be 20 or 30.

These are the 40 clients or prospects you consider most important and therefore need close, if not constant, attention. The Top 40 often takes the form of a simple list and appears in your calendar based on your chosen meeting frequency.

See the following table: "Complete your commercial action plan."

The key to successful commercial segmentation is simplicity.
As soon as it gets complicated, it no longer works.

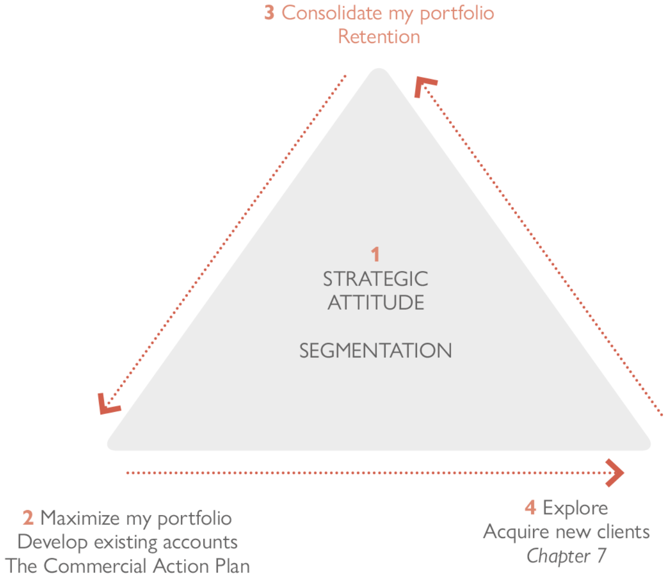
SEGMENT A OF MY PORTFOLIO
NUMBER OF CLIENTS: 40

COMPLETE YOUR COMMERCIAL ACTION PLAN			
	Clients	Actions to be completed (aims)	Planning
CAP			

SEVEN RULES OF SEGMENTATION

1. In an ABC segmentation, within each segment there are sub-segments and attributes:
– The segment is the first level of classification (e.g. by AUM);
– The sub-segment may reflect the client's stage in the lifecycle;
2. The attribute may describe the client type: a referrer, a prospect, or someone with a specific professional background or behavioral trait.
3. It is wise to create an age pyramid of your client portfolio to draw insights and conclusions.
4. Sometimes, doing nothing is the right thing to do.
5. Segmentation has an important corollary: time management takes over once clients are segmented.
6. If you only had one hour to meet someone, which client or prospect would you choose? If you had just one ticket to a major concert, who would you invite?
7. In my Top 40, I divide clients into emerging clients and returning clients.
8. Segmentation helps improve efficiency by making it easy to see the full client portfolio in the calendar and plan the next steps.

Up-sell	**=**	**Sell more to the same client**
Re-sell	**=**	**Sell again to the same client**
Cross-sell	**=**	**Sell complementary or related products to the client**
New-sell	**=**	**Sell a new product to the client**
Stop-sell	**=**	**Stop selling to the client**



6. THE COMMERCIAL ACTION PLAN (CAP)

The logical next step after segmentation is a commercial action plan. It helps us turn strategy into objectives, and objectives into measurable actions.

Here is a checklist to create or expand your Commercial Action.

All your existing clients (A, B, and C) must be organized in a dedicated place in your calendar.

The process:

1. Align yourself with the bank's commercial strategy.
2. Ensure that your sales objectives are SMART.
3. Allocate your sales targets by segment.
4. Distinguish between outcome goals and effort goals.*
5. Organize the tasks to be completed.
6. Systematically track the outcomes.

7. Regularly reassess the sales strategy by reviewing the full portfolio.

* **Examples of effort-based goals:**

Quantitative:

- Number of phone calls
- Number of meetings, both virtual and in-person
- Systematic contact with the families of my older clients
- Number of marketing follow-ups
- Number of commercial events.

Qualitative:

- Systematic assessment of each client's potential
- Evaluation of possible discretionary management mandates
- Evaluation of the client's overall wealth situation (descendants, family)
- Identification of product types by segment.

A. CRITICAL KEY QUESTIONS TO BUILD YOUR COMMERCIAL ACTION PLAN

What specific commercial objectives do I want to achieve?

Which client segments are the priority for development?

Which segments will be the focus of my commercial efforts?

How much commercial potential does each segment represent?

How balanced is my portfolio (New vs. Existing), and what objective indicators reflect this?

What strategies will I use to efficiently focus my effort and sales engagement?

What resources, supports, tools, and products do I have?

A vague goal leads to a specific mistake.

B. KEY COMPONENTS OF A COMMERCIAL ACTION PLAN

Prospecting:

- Set a target number of prospecting appointments and meetings with existing clients.
- Monitor my clients' desired frequency of visits.
- Analyze the 80/20 distribution of my clients.
- Map out all specialists available to me.
- Schedule joint visits.
- Meet with active referrers.
- Follow-up with clients who have left the bank.
- Set aside a specific day and time for "hard" prospecting.

Analyzing the results:

- Analyze current results.
- Appropriate training for new products and services.
- Follow-up with existing clients on new or specific products.
- Share experiences with colleagues.
- Interim assessment and adjustment measures.

Events:

- Leverage the bank's external marketing support.
- Compile a list of events for the months ahead.
- Prepare events and send invitations to clients and prospects.
- Follow-up on meetings after events.
- Using this list and an annual schedule, block recurring yearly tasks in your calendar.

Technically, that's all there is to know; the rest is just willpower or procrastination!

C. HOW TO CREATE A CAP

CAP STAGES	ACTIONS TO TAKE	HOW TO DO THEM
1. Sales targeting	Outline target client groups	Identify the client segment. Describe the client profile.Provide quantitative data.
2. Objectives	Define commercial objectives	Over a defined period, outline the objectives for each segment.
3. Commercial strategy	Set out the commercial activities for each segment	• Establish the number of direct contacts to be made over a given period. • Set specific commercial actions like assessing the potential of each segment and client (A, B, C). • Specific value proposition for each segment/client.
4. Preparing direct commercial activities	Creating a pipeline corresponding to the segment analysis	• Establish a clear order of commercial priorities. • Define the purpose of the sales campaign: how to spark prospects' interest? • Strategy for setting up face-to-face meetings.
5. Direct commercial activities	Planning activities	• Work closely with your calendar. • Take a long-range approach to planning commercial activities. • Plan all travel and business trips. • Schedule all events and their preparation.
6. Performance tracking	Initiate a one-to-one meeting with your manager	• Plan regular feedback opportunities. • Seek an outside perspective on your commercial activities.
7. Sale pitch	Develop a specific argument for each commercial action.	• Find the arguments that will convince the target customers. • The message should be KISS (Keep It Simple and Short) and clear. • Plan each meeting in writing. • Structure each meeting with your targets in mind. • Refine your pitches (both for the bank and products).

Frédéric Lamotte's 7 famous rules

They are well known by many managers. Originally, Frédéric Lamotte, a senior executive at a financial institution, came to give a presentation to young managers at the bank where I worked. He left a lasting impression.

FRÉDÉRIC LAMOTTE'S SEVEN RULES

1. Talk about what you know!
It's a matter of your credibility. Stay authentic and human in your relationships

2. Say when you don't know!
Show humility; clients understand. Dare to tell the truth, be genuine!

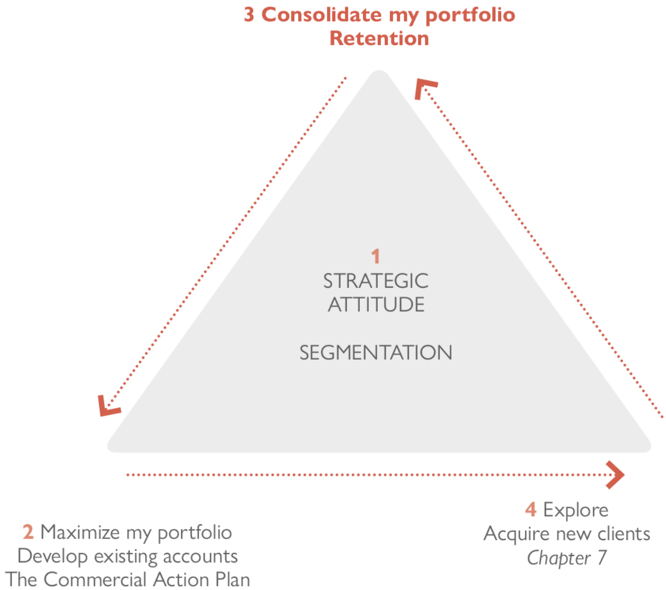
3. Sell and recommend what you believe in!
Offer and promote what you genuinely like and would buy for yourself. However, also be willing to give your opinion on a product, even if you wouldn't use it yourself.

4. Look ahead, not behind!
Let go of what the market's doing.
Don't get attached to one position; be ready to sell! Clean up your portfolio.
Stay confident about the future, change is constant.

5. Learn to do nothing!
Don't expose your clients unnecessarily. Sometimes, doing nothing is the right decision.

6. Communicate on a global scale!
Tell your clients what you're doing with your other clients. Share your ideas and success stories. Don't be afraid to give your opinion.

7. Call your clients when things go wrong!
Challenge yourself to pick up the phone quickly. Don't hide the truth.
Try to share a positive takeaway.
Don't change everything when things go wrong—take a step back first.



7. RETENTION = STAYING CLOSE

Definition: It's a combination of anticipation (a potential risk that hasn't materialized) and prevention (a risk that already has).

The first rule of prospecting is to retain your existing clients!

Why focus on retention?

1. To keep existing clients!
2. To build a trusting relationship.
3. To be more profitable by strengthening client loyalty.

Wealth managers often ask themselves a difficult question:

Will my most satisfied clients continue to be loyal in the long term?

It's hard to be certain, as trends are clear and do not point in that direction. Clients are:

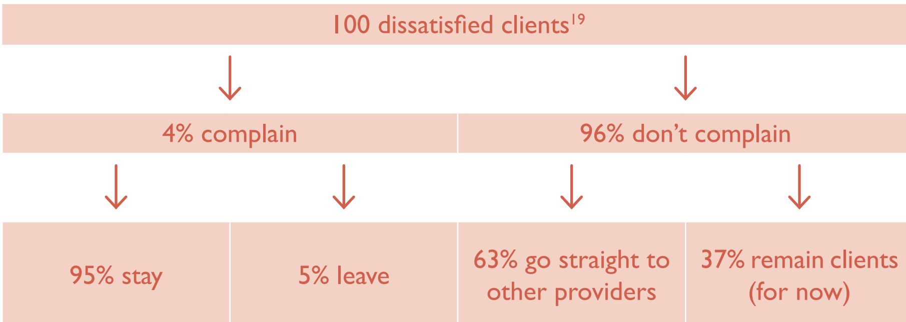
- Increasingly demanding
- Increasingly volatile
- Less and less loyal.

The retention process is illustrated in the following table. Its operating principle is based on two elements: Being vigilant to the slightest sign and reacting as quickly as possible.

8. A SATISFIED CLIENT IS WORTH DOUBLE

Retention strategies must take into account customer dissatisfaction, as it is the top reason for losing clients. Retaining dissatisfied customers is difficult.

What does this statistic tell us? That most dissatisfied clients won't bother to tell us. The salesperson needs to actively gather this information by regularly gauging the client's perception of their relationship and the services provided.



Client satisfaction depends not just on the quality of products and services, but also on the quality of the relationship. This makes the wealth manager's time management crucial. When poorly executed, it can lead to client dissatisfaction. It's essential to find a balance between the manager's four key time areas (see also Chapter 14).

19 Source: Marketing common sense, contributed by a PG Bank participant.

CAPTIVE CLIENT

Reinforce value through account reviews.
Maintaining close contact.
Proven client satisfaction.

EFFORTS TO RETAIN CLIENT

Assign the correct segment.
Continually update their needs.
Offer long-term products and services.
Stay in regular contact.

DETECT DANGER EARLY ON

Clues may include: price discussions, complaints, sudden or unusual requests.
Evaluate relationship closeness (10 key questions), involvement of a third party such as a consultant.

IMPLEMENT RETENTION STRATEGIES

Closeness.
Contact (again and again).
Events.
Joint specialist visit.
Meeting with management.

CAPTIVE CLIENT

Reinforce value through account reviews.
Maintaining close contact.
Proven client satisfaction.

WEALTH MANAGERS CHASING TIME	INTENSITY	WHY	MANAGER'S REACTION
Time dedicated to managing their commercial portfolio	Low	Lack of clarity, lack of perspective	Block reflection time in their calendar
Time dedicated to client relationship	Low	Stuck in a routine	Block commercial action time
Time dedicated to administration	Hi	It feels reassuring	Delegate if possible
Time dedicated to prospecting	Too low	Lack of courage	Block prospecting time: It's urgent!

9. THREE MORE WAYS TO BOOST RETENTION

A. SMALL GIFTS GO A LONG WAY…

Retaining a client means demonstrating that your actions are dedicated exclusively to their best interest. How?

- Create emotional added value in your business relationship.
- Express your commitment and even affection; the client must realize that the relationship goes beyond business and includes a human, emotional connection.

Thinking about clients this way means showing genuine consideration. The saying "it's the thought that counts" has never been truer than in a business relationship.

Two questions to ask yourself:

- To whom did you recently give a small gift that created a big impact?
- Who could you give a small gift to soon?

The method is so simple that it almost insults our intelligence: a small gesture, a little gift, something inexpensive—in short, a clear message from the heart addressed to our client.

Retention is about keeping them in mind!

Why do this?

- To create a "wow" effect
- To make them feel special and the center of attention.
- A small present that makes a big impression is a clear indication of knowing the client well and understanding their preferences (it shows you know exactly what they like).

B. TEAMWORK ALSO DRIVES RETENTION, SO PUT YOUR MANAGERS TO WORK!

Involve your management to contact your new or "at-risk" clients in order to:

show your clients they are valued.

- measure their satisfaction levels.
- create an additional social connection and strengthen the relationship with the bank.

Have all your clients had the chance to meet your management team?

C. WHAT TO DO WHEN A CLIENT SAYS THEY'RE LEAVING?

Sadly, sometimes a client decides to leave our institution. If their decision is final, it is best not to press too hard or appear desperate in trying to reverse it. Instead, focus on maintaining a positive relationship and parting on good terms, as there is always a chance the client may later be dissatisfied with their new provider.

The seven steps to take in this situation:

1. Develop a clear action plan with your team immediately upon learning of the client's departure: assign responsibilities and deadlines?
2. Arrange a meeting with the client, preferably involving your manager.
3. Conduct an exit interview to learn from the experience.
4. Invite the client to bank events, even after they leave.
5. Get back in touch six months later to ask if they need anything.
6. Reflect on how the relationship could have been improved.
7. Keep the client on mailing lists for ongoing bank communications.

Appendix 1

SAMPLE CAP FOR POLAND[20]

I. DEVELOP THE NETWORK	CONTACT WITH OUR REPRESENTATIVE IN WARSAW - GAIN RECOMMENDATIONS FROM EXISTING CLIENTS - BE INTRODUCED INTO THE LOCAL NETWORK BY INFLUENTIAL REFERRERS
Potential referrers: (who I can rely on)	Lawyers and notaries Business introducers and insurance providers Real estate agents, Third-party asset managers Luxury goods professionals High-end cultural events (e.g. art exhibitions, fashion shows) Professional organizations (consider joining) Twin Chambers of Commerce (Switzerland/Poland) Embassy – get in touch with the economic attaché
2.The main goal	Make at least 20 positive contacts. Conclude and open at least 5 accounts. Attend at least 5 events, be active, visible, and transparent.
3.The action plan	Plan quarterly trips for the entire next year. Organize 5 events with the marketing department for this year. Bring in banking experts for my next two trips. Carry out systematic debriefings after each event or trip.
4.Added value	Travel with top specialists. Engage my local partners. Highlight our business strength by making at least one visit with the department manager.
5.Segmentation	- Target clients (industrialists, lawyers, lawyers' clients, private investors, hoteliers) - Concentrate on a single segment (it's more efficient and addresses similar needs)

20 CAS RM training.

1. DEVELOP THE NETWORK	**CONTACT WITH OUR REPRESENTATIVE IN WARSAW - GAIN RECOMMENDATIONS FROM EXISTING CLIENTS - BE INTRODUCED INTO THE LOCAL NETWORK BY INFLUENTIAL REFERRERS**
6. Concentrate on a specific segment	What are the advantages? It's more efficient. Clients in the same segment have similar needs. To test my commercial approach and gauge reactions. Obtain comprehensive information about the sector, immerse myself in the culture and habits. Sharing relevant information, building credibility and trust What are the risks? Focusing too much on the segment and missing out on other opportunities. Forgetting to diversify risks.
7.Development	What timeframe do I have to develop this market? What is the typical profile of the investors (are they more conservative)? Take into account the initial strategy (the framework and strategic objectives), the local culture, and the market.

An expert's perspective

Never fight against your nature…

Quitterie manages a small bank in Geneva. She meets with a French tax lawyer. The bank asks her to give a presentation without mentioning any business agenda.

She takes a relaxed, natural approach and delivers a straightforward presentation with a smile, carrying no commercial pressure. The outcome is remarkable; the lawyer is won over by her authenticity and later brings over valuable clients.

This anecdote teaches us about how clients sense the sincerity and confidence of their RM.

Being natural and relaxed can be incredibly persuasive.

Spring into action!
5 key takeaways and an exercise

FIVE KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. Continuously prospect and develop a commercial strategy.
2. Take inspiration from the military and Sun Tzu.
3. Segment your client portfolio to operate more effectively.
4. Construct your CAP using ABC and Top 40 approaches.
5. Practice active client retention.

EXERCICE

Title: Know where you're going and prepare for it.

Aim of the exercise: Identify the resources needed to achieve your commercial objectives.

Instructions:

- Describe in no more than two lines the segmentation of your commercial portfolio and your commercial action plan.
- Write down your next five client contacts spontaneously and check they are in your calendar.

3

Field research and firsthand accounts

Wealth managers: the salespeople who must not be named . . .

TEACHING OBJECTIVES

After reading this chapter, you will be able to:

- Gain insight into the reality of a field we have explored for four years.
- Recognize the gap between what managers say and the theories outlined in this book.

Contents table
chapter 3

"There's what can be done,
what the bank asks you to do,
and what the client wants.
Finding your place in all that isn't easy."

Introduction

We conducted a study with a master's student, Malika Klaus, under the supervision of Fabien Smadja, who was then the Head of Human Resources at Banque Mirabaud (until June 2018). The study was based on 52 interviews carried out in seven different banks in French-speaking Switzerland. We chose to focus exclusively on senior relationship managers. The research spanned four years, from January 2018 to June 2022.

Most of the interviews were semi-structured, meaning they followed the same framework to allow for comparative analysis.

The analysis brought to light both professional dilemmas and key themes. In other words, it revealed the presence of challenges typical to the wealth management profession, which demands an ability to handle paradox and contradiction. Meanwhile, the themes offer a clear snapshot of a profession in the throes of transformation and adaptation to regulatory, tax, and technological developments in the financial world.

A key underlying issue for the financial industry right now is the role of sales and the commercial identity of wealth managers. Are we really salespeople?

At the end of this chapter, we share several real-world accounts gathered while preparing for a major training initiative.

You have to be happy to succeed,
not the other way around.

I. PROFESSIONAL DILEMMAS

A. WHO AM I WHEN I'M WITH THE CLIENT: MYSELF OR A VERSION OF THEM?

Here's a direct quote from a wealth manager I met:

> "Take elderly clients, for example. They love being looked after, it's their special moment. They come, and we take them out for lunch. On the flip side, you've got businesspeople who don't have much time, so with them you need to prepare the meeting in advance and be brief when they arrive. You get straight to the point. This job teaches you humility every day, but some people are better at dealing with several clients, and others just aren't."

Wealth managers try to be "in tune" with their clients, whether in terms of shared interests, personality, or – more practically– fees. But only a few managers in this study see this harmony as something that should start from the client's perspective when reflecting on their commercial approach. One manager, for example, kept repeating in different ways: "We must never forget the client is our main focus. They're the ones we talk to the most. We need to be in sync with them, otherwise, it falls apart."

However, is this "being in sync" something natural, or is it just a role we play?

For half of the wealth managers, this rapport develops naturally, and they believe it is essential to remain authentic in front of the client. The interviews reveal that:

- Even at the prospect stage, managers look for clients who fit their way of working and their view of the client relationship, especially to ensure agreement on practical matters like fees. They tend to go for clients who suit them personally.
- If a manager doesn't click with a prospect or client, there's no point forcing the relationship. A better option might be to suggest a colleague who's more in tune. However, this rarely happens as managers don't always want to admit there's no real connection.
- A small number of managers express more radical views, which represent the "be yourself with the client" side of the dilemma. One such wealth manager stressed the importance of sharing openly and showing one's true self with sincerity. He believes this is essential for the client to develop trust and view the relationship as a long-term one.

For the remaining half, adapting to the client is considered essential, provided it does not come at the expense of authenticity. We learn that while some clients naturally click with the manager's personality, others require a degree of adjustment. Another manager explained that adapting is simply part of any human relationship. A helpful strategy to be able to do this is to find a point of connection (such as a topic of conversation or a shared interest) that the manager can draw on during meetings. This point of connection must be genuine, not contrived.

Three managers see the client relationship more as a form of role-playing, with the manager adopting a chameleon-like approach to mirror each client. This idea sits at the far end of the spectrum and reflects a completely different take on client relationships.

Here, selling is seen as a form of acting. This raises questions about the sincerity of the behaviors adopted.

> "At some point, the chameleon either changes color or it doesn't. And if it doesn't, it will never work. A wealth manager must adapt to their client. They need to be completely flexible, and the client must feel that their manager is like them. You have to talk about what they enjoy. It's a roleplay where you're constantly shifting your attitude."

To wrap up, many managers – regardless of how they approach this dilemma – note that, over time, their client base naturally evolves to reflect who they are. This raises a fundamental question for the profession: in terms of adaptation and sales, who should be doing the adapting?

B. WHOSE SIDE AM I ON, THE BANK'S OR THE CLIENT'S?

For 70% of managers, it is essential to remain at the heart of this dilemma and strike a balance between the bank's interests and those of the client. They say it's about "being fair to both the bank and the client." They cannot imagine a client relationship that isn't win-win, which one wealth manager described as a situation where "the bank covers its costs, and the client receives suitable financial products." This win-win approach is seen as a foundation for long-term partnership.

> "I take a very long-term view, and everyone needs to benefit. When I say "everyone," I mean the firm, the client, and us. It might sound obvious—it's what you're taught in sales training—but it's the key to long-term success. Trust takes time to build but can be lost in an instant. If even a hint of suspicion creeps into the relationship, it's over. And that goes both ways."

One of the managers who falls into this 70% raised an interesting idea: working together with the client to find common ground and build this win-win relationship.

> "You've got to aim for consensus, not compromise—compromise just feels too negative, and in the end, the banker will pay for it. With consensus, you're helping the client understand and agree that the service or product you've offered is the right one, at the right price. They'll see you're being fair, doing your job properly, and that they've approved the fee. That kind of trust lets you build a strong, lasting relationship."

For the remaining 30%, their philosophy is to "put the client's interests before those of the bank." For them, In their view, the role of the wealth manager and the banks themselves depends on this. The client's needs take precedence over the bank's sales objectives. This the age-old question still persists: Who does the wealth manager truly represent – the client or the bank?

C. AM I A GENERALIST OR A SPECIALIST WEALTH MANAGER?

The interviews suggest that this dilemma might not be one at all, as 100% of the managers agree that today's wealth manager is a generalist.

In the past, wealth managers were much more well-rounded in terms of financial knowledge and technical skills. "Back then, we had to do more investing ourselves. Today, many top relationship managers spend their time going hunting with the client or attending concerts. They're fantastic brand ambassadors but they're not at all technical specialists."

This transformation of the role came about due to an increase in the scope of activities within banks, allowing them to respond to current regulatory and tax demands. "[…] In the past, one person could handle many tasks, but nowadays that's no longer feasible because of the rapid increase in the number of topics to master. You must rely on real experts. Either you pick a field you enjoy and specialize, or you stay a relationship manager, much like a general practitioner."

Four comments on the concept of the generalist wealth manager

> "I've never had too many problems because I've often relied on experts. I've never been afraid to say, 'I don't know' or 'I don't have the answer right now, but I'll get back to you with an answer'. Banking professions, to be frank, are not very technical. **There's a lot of psychology and human relations involved, so the keys to success really lie on that side of things."**
>
> "Our role, as wealth managers, is much more restricted in the sense that there are many specialists. We work within tight guidelines, so **I can't give investment advice without following what my advisors pass on to me and without respecting the bank's recommendations**. So really, I just press a button, look at all the securities recommended by the bank, and pick from those."

> "Nowadays, a portfolio manager doesn't need to be a product specialist—they need to be a salesperson. It's a generalist role: we're expected to have broad knowledge across many areas, but when deeper expertise is required, we defer to specialists. That makes sense since the role is really about 'advising' and 'selling'."

> "You have to **sell and stand by the bank's policy**: it has an investment committee, an investment strategy, and decisions made by competent people – rather than thinking, 'I'm the one making the decisions, and if I make a mistake, it reflects badly on me.'"

These remarks illustrate how the role of the portfolio manager has evolved – from an independent decision-maker in the 1990s to a relationship manager today. As markets and investments have become more complex, so too has the nature of client interaction. The rise of specialists across every branch of investment has made it clear that clients need a central coordinator, who acts as a guide through the maze of investment options.

One consequence of the profession's transformation is that there used to be a greater expectation and responsibility placed on managers. Today, the risk is that managers might feel less accountable, as they are overseen by other expert departments.

Somewhat contradicting the definition of the manager as a generalist, the interviews reveal that managers must constantly stay up to date on financial, legal, regulatory, and even political matters. Requirements such as a professional certification (CWMA in Switzerland) reflect this trend.

Various factors contribute to this need: fast-evolving regulatory and tax environments, information that is widely available and accessible, and a more sophisticated client base. Many managers agree that it is acceptable to admit when you don't have an immediate answer, but if it happens too often, it can hurt your credibility. Still, two managers confessed that clients really like to get a relevant answer straight away.

Clients value the professionalism and expertise of managers, which is largely based on multidisciplinary knowledge and technical competence. Although managers are increasingly supported by specialized teams within the bank, they still need a high level of expertise not only in finance and banking services but also in human behavior, politics, and social issues. The role is evolving towards greater technical sophistication, but more importantly, it's about building better social relationships.

> "In the past, the manager handled everything. Nowadays, due to strict regulations, there's a team managing discretionary accounts and another handling advisory services. There are fewer clients who are unmanaged, meaning those who call knowing precisely what they want to do. So, I'd say our role really involves a mix of routine tasks and more specialized ones. Personally, I like to stay well-informed on investments, often by attending internal conferences. I make it a point to know exactly what my clients hold in their portfolios because understanding the composition of specific funds or securities helps explain portfolio performance. I think this is important, even though we have strong support."

D. AM I AN EXPERT ON THE CLIENT'S NEEDS OR JUST AN ADVISOR?

Reflecting the dilemma expressed earlier, managers universally see themselves as advisors to client needs. None identified as experts – perhaps the term carries too much responsibility or conflicts with existing investment policies? One manager mentioned that "some individuals jump straight to selling a product without verifying if it fits because they are convinced it suits the client. That poses a significant risk compared to the client's desires and expectations." Could this indicate an impostor syndrome among managers? Not all fully accept the expert role, even though it is crucial in the complex nature of private wealth relationships.

Within the concept of "advising" on client needs, two perspectives already exist among wealth managers:

CREATE THE NEED	ACKNOWLEDGE THAT THERE IS NO NEED
"It's important to have a thorough understanding of everything the bank offers and try to meet the client's needs. Sometimes clients aren't aware they actually need something. For instance, they might not realize they can get a loan instead of taking money directly from their account. So, it's fair to say it's about meeting both the expressed and the hidden needs." This quote captures the sentiments expressed by several managers. The overall takeaway is the concept of anticipating needs and, at times, creating them.	Just one manager endorsed the view that it is crucial to assess needs objectively and, where applicable, recognize that the client has none. According to him, "creating the need" results in a breakdown of trust. Rather than anticipating or creating needs, the manager should sharpen the client's articulation of their needs through client insight and the full range of financial techniques.

This second viewpoint shows another paradox the manager faces: institutional demands come with commercial targets, plus economic and social pressure. They need to hit those targets to earn respect from colleagues. So where does the client's real need fit into this paradox, and how important is it really?

2. CHALLENGES

A. TRAINING BACKGROUND OF THE 52 MANAGERS INTERVIEWED:

BUSINESS APPRENTICESHIP IN A BANK: 12 MANAGERS

BUSINESS APPRENTICESHIP IN A FIDUCIARY FIRM: 5

BUSINESS SCHOOL: 6

HEC AND MBA GRADUATES: 3

HOSPITALITY MANAGEMENT: 4

BACKGROUND IN JOURNALISM AND ENGLISH LITERATURE: 1

DEGREE IN POLITICAL ECONOMY: 4

ECONOMICS DEGREE AND BANKING INTERNSHIP: 5

MASTER’S DEGREE IN LAW: 2

MASTER’S IN FINANCIAL MARKETS: 2

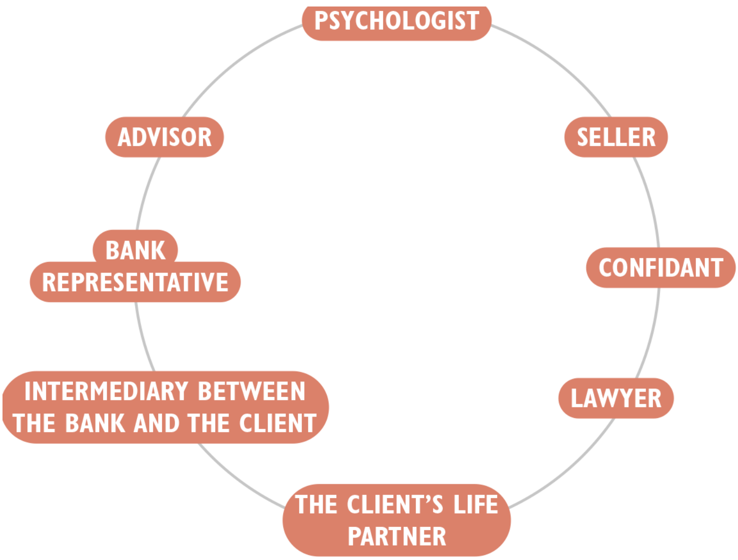
MASTER’S IN MANAGEMENT AND WEALTH MANAGEMENT: 2

BUSINESS DIPLOMA (SWISS COMMERCIAL SECONDARY SCHOOL QUALIFICATION): 4

NO SECONDARY SCHOOL EDUCATION: 2

B. THE WEALTH MANAGER'S IDENTITY

Multiple identities come through in the interviews:



C. WHAT EXACTLY IS SELLING?

HOW WEALTH MANAGERS VIEW SALES

The topic of selling was discussed at length in the interviews, and sparked a variety of reactions, sometimes strong ones.

The term "selling" didn't sit well with everyone, and several relationship managers tried to describe their work using terms that better aligned with their view of the profession. For them, selling was more about advising and supporting clients:

"I'm not there to sell products. I'm there to help my clients achieve their life goals. As part of this, we put forward an investment proposal and suggest a new product. I work alongside them." It is interesting to note that only three managers immediately accepted their identity as sellers without trying to renegotiate it, which is just under 5%. "Basically, we're just selling. We're the front line. So, do we sell here? Yes. I'm a salesperson and I don't see anything wrong with that."

Two aggressive, negative images of selling came to their minds and posed a problem when they reflected on their identity as sellers:

- Selling means imposing.
- Selling means offloading something onto someone else.

Several people mentioned that if a manager adopts the posture of a salesperson, they will not last. While a manager must sell, there's significant work to be done before and after the sale, which the negative view of selling tends to neglect. This bias against sales often blinds some managers to the dignity of the act and the thoughtful process it entails. That's why terms like advice or support resonated more with them.

Ultimately, selling seems secondary to managers. «I never walk into a room thinking, 'I'm going to sell this today.' [...] We need to hit targets, but how? I support clients and the sale happens naturally. I don't sell right away and I'm not just a product pusher." The issue is that this initial inhibition shows up again when it comes time to carry out the sales acts. It leads to obstructive behavior during the sales process (particularly in closing and actively seeking referrals).

There was unanimous agreement among the managers on one point: selling is about believing in the products you propose to clients; "I never sell investment products that I wouldn't buy for myself."

One interesting idea raised by one manager is that of value creation. According to him, this is a core concept in the profession today, and it comes down to questioning the added value the manager brings to the client. It is this added value that justifies the financial compensation –the price the client will agree to pay. This view reflects what all the managers said:

"Selling is a complex process. It goes beyond simply selling a product. It means selling a relationship, a way of working, an organization."

There is a notion of an "extended service," also known as a "concierge service," a nod to the luxury treatment found in top hotels. The wealth manager should be able to handle almost everything, from sourcing an engagement ring for a client's son to arranging holidays, purchasing property, sorting out card payment issues, or finding a lawyer.

> "You shouldn't think, 'I come from private banking, so I'll only deal with private banking.' You need to be open-minded, take an interest in what the client does and wants to do, and see if you can support them in their projects and connect them with other professionals."

> "Finance isn't secondary, but it's about finding solutions for the client. A client with money wants to save time. Selling means streamlining everything you can for them. You take away an emotional burden and as many concerns as possible by saying, 'I'll take care of it.'"

SELLING IS ABOUT "SELLING YOURSELF" AS A MANAGER, BUT ALSO SELLING THE BANK.

While the idea of being a salesperson for products or services was debated among managers, they all agreed that a manager's role involves "selling themselves" and promoting the bank to clients.

> «If the chemistry isn't there and the client doesn't take to you, they won't open an account—even if they find the bank interesting. That's how a form of indirect selling takes place because they'll ask you things like, 'What's your background? Where are you from?' To me, it's a very indirect kind of selling, where we're personally involved."
>
> "You represent your company. The way the bank is perceived, whether positively or negatively, depends on the manager. So, in effect, you're selling the company every moment of the day."

Sometimes, selling the bank is much easier because other factors come into play, such as recommendations:

> "So, sometimes you don't need to do anything to sell the bank. Other times, you have to do some prospecting work. You meet people, explain who the bank is, who you are, and why it's interesting. But after a while, things get easier. Like today—I'll probably open two accounts, but really, the work was already done by someone else. Other clients recommended the bank to colleagues or friends, and now those people are calling me. In these cases, it's usually a done deal because the referral comes from someone they're close to."

DO WEALTH MANAGERS SEE THEMSELVES AS SALESPEOPLE?

The notion of a sales identity sparked discussion during the interviews:

- 19% of managers accepted and acknowledged a salesperson identity without trying to reframe it.

> "Absolutely! I tend to agree that a relationship manager is a salesperson. What do they sell? They sell themselves as a manager, they sell the bank, and they sell the bank's products."
>
> "In the end, it's all about sales. We're on the front line. So, do we do sales here? Yes. I'm a salesperson, and I don't see that as particularly negative."

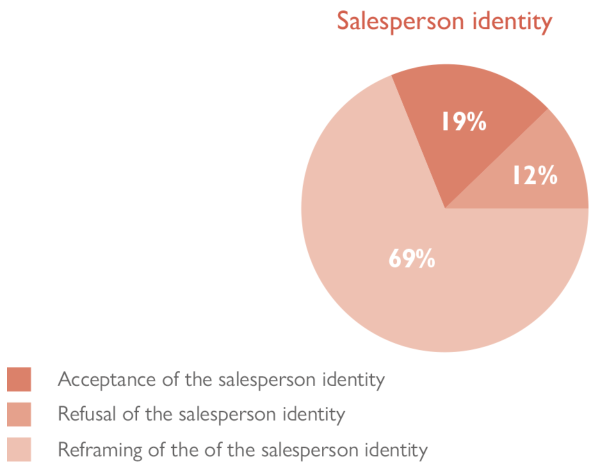
- 12% of managers did not identify as salespeople.

> "I don't think I'm a salesperson. I see myself as someone a client trusts with something incredibly valuable. Before wearing the hat of someone selling a product, I'm a person to whom a client entrusts their wealth, and who must meet expectations around that wealth. I find it hard to think of myself as a salesperson—but I don't really know what to call it instead… Just not a salesperson. The word feels too aggressive."

> "I don't feel like a salesperson because I'm not here to sell products. I'm here to help my clients achieve their life goals, and in that context, we might suggest an investment or offer a new product, etc. I support them, but I never walk into a meeting thinking, 'I'm going to sell this to them today.'"

- 69% of managers admitted to being salespeople but tried to redefine this identity to distance themselves from a negative perception of selling.

> "Being a salesperson is a matter of character. Often, it's something quite innate. However, I don't really like the term 'salesperson' because it sounds almost derogatory."
>
> "We need to hit targets, but how? I support clients and the sale happens naturally. I don't sell right away and I'm not just a product pusher."
>
> "We are sellers, but selling takes many forms, including deeply understanding the client's needs and including them in the process. The better we know the client, the more proactive we can be in offering them solutions. But we don't offer things randomly; we do it because we know it suits them."



SELLING TODAY MEANS REFLECTING ON PRICING

In the past, the cost aspect was rarely discussed, questioned, or negotiated by clients. Nowadays, pricing is more and more a subject of conversation. A manager pointed out that because of transparency, all accounts are now declared and taxable. When accounts were untaxed, clients had no qualms about paying their banker.

Nowadays, this is a problem that prompts banks to reconsider their pricing: what should clients be billed for, and what kind of service?

What emerges from the interviews is that clients are willing to pay for added value, for a tangible service. However, this added value is not the same for everyone, and it is the manager's role to understand what the client expects from them: a confidant, performance, security? This brings us back to the concept already discussed, that of *value creation*.

D. SALES METHODS

The interview analysis shows that managers use two sales methods:

- **The "needs creation" method**

With this approach, the manager's role goes beyond simply meeting an expressed client need; it also involves anticipating and occasionally generating that need. However, this does not mean offering just any product. Wealth managers stress that the client's interests must always be respected.

- **The "objective needs" method**

This method involves managers objectively identifying clients' needs, moving away from the idea of creating needs. The sale must therefore meet the exact need expressed by the client.

There seems to be a third method, though no manager admitted using it: a direct sales method. It is a **direct selling method.** "Some people go straight to the product to be sold without knowing if it suits the client, because they are convinced that this is the right product for them. Doing so is a major risk compared to what the client wants and expects. Doing so is a big risk in relation to what the client wants and expects. Moreover, it either risks an immediate refusal or, later on, backlash. Yes, we are sellers, but there are different ways to sell: to truly understand what the client wants and to involve them in the process. The better we know the client, the more proactive we can be and the more we can offer them. But we don't propose products randomly – we do it because we know it fits them. What sets apart a good salesperson with business ethics from a less scrupulous one is this ability to distinguish needs, and that is not always easy."

For the first two methods, all wealth managers (100%) mention that it is essential to believe in the products they offer. This conviction appears to guide the work of every manager interviewed, who argue that a long-term relationship with a client cannot be built by selling just anything. Two managers raised points that align with this view:

- Question the *suitability* of a product for a client.
- *Put yourself in the client's shoes without being too intrusive to offer the most suitable product.*

Only one manager, who had initially expressed the need to believe in what they offer, admitted that if they believe less in a product, but it is the most suitable for the client, then the client's best interests take precedence over their personal feelings.

From the interviews, seven separate ideas concerning selling practices were brought to light:

Innovation: The current competitive and transparent environment is driving managers to become increasingly innovative, particularly in how they respond to client needs.

> "Selling means going after the answer, dissecting it, analyzing it, and delivering insights the client has never heard before. You need to innovate."

Take an interest in the client: Wealth managers say that understanding a client's needs isn't all that difficult, but it's much easier when they know them well. Getting to know them means taking a genuine interest. One manager pointed out the importance of sharing—of open, two-way exchanges. For him, that's the foundation for making a sale.

> "I like talking about them because people enjoy it when you take an interest in them. Getting to know your client well is part of the job. I enjoy learning about them: how they succeeded, where they failed, how they treat their employees. And then, in turn, they start asking questions too."

Honesty: Being honest, genuine, and sincere is seen as essential in client relationships. This reflects the wealth managers' long-term vision, which requires open and truthful communication. A truthful message is also a persuasive one. You can't mislead a client, which is why the manager must believe in what they say, as well as in their bank, and in the products they offer. As one wealth manager pointed out, you also have to be willing to say no to clients, because saying yes to everything can be dangerous.

The concept of service: "To go back to the idea of being a seller, a manager should answer the phone immediately when it rings. That's what defines good service. We constantly have to go the extra mile for the client and be truly at their service. Selling isn't about sweet-talking them; it's about showing our availability and empathy."

Collaboration: For the majority of managers (94%), collaboration serves as a key support in the sales process. Only 6% reported not recognizing the benefit of collaboration in their role. However, collaboration can take different forms and vary in intensity: collaboration within the team or between teams, familiarity with colleagues' clients or only a vague understanding of their cases, and so on.

> "There's a lot of teamwork. Clients know the names of the assistants, and the manager tries to introduce them to the team members when they visit the bank. It's reassuring for the client to know that there's a team working together."
>
> "You have to introduce your colleagues, the assistants, and so on. That way, the client feels well supported because there's always someone available to respond. And not just someone—they know this person, who also knows their file and their expectations."

Negotiations: Selling also means knowing how to convey the value of your work, for example by not lowering prices straightaway. One manager remarked that some colleagues "punish themselves" by consistently undervaluing what they offer.

Professionalism: For many wealth managers, professionalism is particularly important today because they are judged on their expertise. This means arriving at client meetings very well-prepared, which, in their view, was not always essential before.

E. KEY SKILLS

What skills and qualities do the wealth managers talk about?

- Listening skills: referred to by all managers
- Empathy: referred to by all managers
- Humility
- Sincerity
- Organizational skills
- Sense of responsibility
- Persistence
- Service-oriented
- Technical skills
- Ability to explain clearly
- Curiosity
- Team spirit
- Adapting language: The ability to tailor communication according to the client's level of understanding. The most difficult task is explaining things to clients with no financial background.
- Persuasion: Especially at the start of a client relationship, it is important to be persuasive about both the advantages and the risks of a product, always considering its suitability for the client. Over time, once trust has been established, persuasion becomes less necessary as the client relies on the manager's judgment.

F. CLIENT ACQUISITION AND RETENTION

For most managers, acquiring clients is a key part of the job. They must always be on the lookout for potential clients, whether they are *"farmers"* or *"hunters":*

> *"It all comes down to contracts. There are different types. When you hire a wealth manager, you may hire them as a hunter — meaning that if you don't provide them with a client portfolio, they are expected to go out and find their own clients. In that case, they become like entrepreneurs within the bank, earning a percentage based on the assets they bring in. A farmer, on the other hand, is someone who is handed a client book and has every incentive to grow it. We're really trying to motivate our farmers more these days — we don't want them to just sit back and manage what they've been handed. Why? Because we realized it's easier to develop business with existing clients than to go find new ones outside. Often, the best marketing happens through clients who already know us, like us, and might have other accounts somewhere else — but sometimes we just don't think about that."*

All managers are clear that referrals are the most common way prospects become clients.

Looking for new clients is one thing but getting them to change banks is another. Interviews reveal that nowadays it's not easy for a client to move to another bank because, as mentioned in one interview, they have to "bare all" again. They must disclose everything, and few people are eager to do that or to do it again.

Another manager admitted, "If a client isn't too upset with their current bank and everything is going well, there's virtually no chance of convincing them to switch." This implicitly means that clients might only follow a manager who leaves the bank. So, the client needs a solid reason to change banks. Managers must deal with both the pros and cons of their bank honestly, without lying or stretching the truth:

"We need to persuade them. There's always sales pressure and competition. Every bank and every wealth manager has strengths and weaknesses. So, it's about finding the middle ground. You can't overstate traditional arguments such as the bank's history. You have to sell what you actually do. If you oversell and then can't deliver when the client opens an account, you're in big trouble."

Somewhat contradicting the views of the previously mentioned managers, others highlight the difficulty in acquiring new clients. Additionally, they stress the importance of targeting prospects who align with their "client philosophy" (for example, agreement on fees). Another interesting idea is that managers need to be brave enough to admit when things won't work with a client and to steer them toward another manager. Saying no is a fundamental part of a manager's role, as it prevents disappointment. A dissatisfied client can generate significant negative publicity.

Building client loyalty is a long process. Yet, a manager noted that this loyalty doesn't develop in the first few meetings but rather after many years. Why does it take so long?

Client retention is described as "the result of positive persuasion experienced as a positive journey." It stems from every interaction with clients, every conversation, and every meeting. It's important to stay in regular contact to keep the relationship steady: "Trust comes from clear results and transparency in service. Even when results fall short, you've reached out to the client to keep them informed, thoroughly explained the situation, made investments in their portfolio with their approval, and set up a joint responsibility — that's what really makes a difference to the client."

Loyalty can also develop more quickly, particularly when it stems from a client's sense of indebtedness towards the manager: "It's a long-term process. Loyalty builds over time or because you've helped them with an important project. For instance, I have some clients where we had to solve a lot of complicated problems. I won't go into details, but the client clearly told me and made it clear that they felt deeply indebted."

Wealth managers talked about two kinds of loyalty — some clients stick with the bank itself, while others stay because of their relationship with a specific manager. Both types matter a lot to them.

The ultimate goal of client loyalty, according to several managers, is to reach a state of «blind trust» on both sides.

G. WHERE IS THE PROFESSION HEADING?

ADAPTATION D'ORDRE FISCALE ET RÉGLEMENTAIRE

ADAPTING TO FISCAL AND REGULATORY CHANGES

In response to the question, "What do you find most frustrating in your work today?", every manager (100%) cited the increasing weight of regulation, which they feel is constraining their ability to do their job. Since it takes up more and more time, they now have less time to spend with clients. Many agreed that the job will continue to demand major adjustments to tax and regulatory requirements in the future.

> "I'd say it's more about adaptation now, particularly in terms of taxation, because tax laws are changing in the countries we work with."

TRANSPARENCY

Perhaps due to their history, wealth management services are increasingly moving toward transparency. Most managers view this shift positively, though one mentioned feeling that it represents a profound transformation in the spirit of private banking. The allure of the forbidden gave a special kind of intimacy to the days of banking secrecy.

TRANSFORMATION OF CLIENT RELATIONSHIPS

What emerges from the interviews is that the relational aspect has tended to erode in recent years, giving way to a more formal and regulated approach. Yet, client relationship management is fundamentally based on human interaction. This loss of the human element is perceived as a risk to the profession. Interestingly, they also speak of a growing trend toward a more 'scientific' client approach, reflected in the growing number of courses focused on psychology-based sales training and NLP coaching.

RETHINKING PRICING

As outlined in section 2.3, the question of pricing, once largely ignored, must now be reconsidered. Already today, and even more so in the future, clients will have access to free tools and platforms to manage their finances. Anyone who chooses to pay will therefore expect real added value: a concrete, high-quality service.

> "Who are the clients who will still be willing to walk into a private bank and pay for services that are available online for free? What will they be looking for?"

DIGITALIZATION

Wealth managers unanimously anticipate significant developments in new technologies. However, it seems we are currently in a phase of intensified digitalization. Not everything can yet be standardized (such as client profiles or fully aligned investments). Managers are aware that their work is moving in that direction, and "that robo-advisors will strengthen client advisory services, that our thinking will soon be replaced by robots." However, we're not there just yet.

> Some managers feel a bit pessimistic, whereas others talk about adapting and say, «You have to go with the times."
>
> "Digital technology will somewhat kill the profession: clients will place orders online and attend fewer meetings."

According to Deloitte's 2017 survey, 64% of those questioned think that automation will, conversely, generate new employment opportunities.

The new generation of clients is much more connected and comfortable with virtual interactions with their managers.

UNCERTAINTIES SURROUNDING THE YOUNGER GENERATION

A major question for managers concerns the younger generation: how will they perceive banks, and what will they expect from them?

Young clients will have different expectations, ones that may be unfamiliar to the older generation of wealth managers. Many mentioned the importance of bringing in young professionals who will be more relevant in the years to come, as they will combine the experience of their seniors with a clearer understanding of younger clientele.

The 2017 Deloitte "Millennial Survey" confirms what the managers we interviewed said: Banking is going digital, and managers will need to adapt to this new, more hybrid style of client relationship.

OBSERVATION

It is interesting to note that wealth managers maintain a strong emphasis on the relational dimension of sales, even when discussing technical matters such as product adaptability. In the interviews, no one mentioned the growing range of bespoke products designed to meet clients' specific needs. This raises questions about managers' professional identity and their relationship with technical and financial knowledge.

The topics covered in this study:

BIOGRAPHICAL BACKGROUND

Training background
Professional background
Professional development

PROFESSIONAL CONTEXT

Bank culture
Clientele

WORK

Activities
Challenges, difficulties, frustrations
Key experiences

PROFESSIONAL IDENTITY

Sales identity
Selling skills
Client relationship

COLLABORATIVE WORK

A tool to support sales and client relationships?
Cross-department and advisor collaboration

CHANGES TO THE JOB

Recent and future developments
Future skills

QUESTIONS PUT TO THE 52 MANAGERS WE MET:

TOPIC 1: **BIOGRAPHICAL BACKGROUND**

Educational and professional background:

- Could you briefly describe your education and professional background?
- How long have you been working as a wealth manager?

Professional development:

- Have you completed any professional development courses?
- Do you plan to take any in the near future?

Learning from experience and colleagues:

- What is your opinion on learning through experience and peer interaction in your professional development?

TOPIC 2: **PROFESSIONAL CONTEXT**

- How would you describe the bank you work for? (For example, family-oriented, community-focused, or other characteristics) and how does this influence your own practice?
- Do clients choose a bank based on its culture? Do their expectations vary accordingly?

TOPIC 3: **WORK**

- How would you explain your job? What are the main tasks it entails?
- What are the most important aspects of your work (the most difficult, frustrating, rewarding, interesting, etc.)?
- What are the biggest problems you face in your job, and how do you usually deal with them?
- What kind of experiences do you think are important to have in order to do this job well and build the right skills?
- What motivates you in your work?
- What meaning do you attach to your work?
- After discussing these important aspects and challenges, do you feel you would benefit from any further training to perform your job better?

TOPIC 4: **PROFESSIONAL IDENTITY**

Sales identity:

- How do you view your role in relation to sales?
- Do you consider yourself a salesperson?
- What does the term “client” mean to you?
- What do you think are the must-have skills for someone to be a good salesperson?
- How did you pick up and improve these skills over time?
- What are the main challenges you face in sales?

Client relationship:
- In your opinion, what makes someone go from being a prospect to becoming a client?
- What are the essential psychological skills and interpersonal qualities in a client relationship?
- How do you go about building client loyalty?
- How do you make sure you fully understand a client's needs?

Training:
- Following on from these questions, are there any other areas of training you feel you need?

TOPIC 5: **COLLABORATIVE WORK**
- Would you say that collaboration plays an important role in supporting sales and ensuring strong client relationships?
- If so, which departments or teams are most helpful to you?
- Do you feel responsible not just for the service you personally deliver, but also for the service provided by other departments that interact with your clients?

TOPIC 6: **CHANGES TO THE JOB**
- How do you envision your work changing over the next few years, particularly in terms of delivering service and building client relationships?
- Do you think today's sales skills will still be adequate in the years to come?

Firsthand accounts from wealth managers

As part of designing a sales training program for wealth managers at a private bank in Switzerland, my teaching team and I gathered a group of experienced managers to collect their testimonials and training needs. The workshop lasted a full day, during which the managers shared their experiences from various regions around the world.

This contribution completes the investigation, corroborating the occasionally more theoretical recommendations elsewhere in the book. The workshop was structured around a few questions highlighted in bold. The wording has been transcribed exactly as spoken, reflecting conversational language.

At times, the parallel with the investigation at the start of the chapter is remarkable. The same expressions are used time and time again, confirming the professional reality. This testimony was gathered before the survey.

1. What methods do you use to find new clients?

- The first thing is to be commercially proactive. This means keeping your network alive and working with recommendations from your own clients. Yet, referrals are sometimes difficult to secure as clients often want to stay discreet.
- With my Turkish clients, most are proud to introduce their banker to their friends. But in other Middle Eastern countries, that's totally off the table as there's often a fear of reprisals. It's quite rare in Italy too.
- You have to be persistent when prospecting. I work with business introducers like local agents, notaries, lawyers, accountants, former bankers turned financial promoters, and even industrialists.
- I'm always on the lookout for ways to fit into the local social life.
- The bank plays an important role and helps us by organizing cultural and social events. You must be careful with this part of the relationship because showing up too often can backfire.
- Another method I've used is passing client files around internally. Sometimes I just can't build a good relationship with a new client; maybe my personality doesn't click with theirs. It bruises my ego, but I'd rather that than lose the client to a competitor bank.

2. How do you get ready for an interview, particularly overseas?

- I begin by looking at the client's geographic, cultural, and religious roots. It's important to understand both their culture and the culture of where they live. I have to get a sense of their cultural identity before building a relationship.

"If you want to do business in a country, it needs to be somewhere you love."

- I'm careful to observe the proper customs; you need to really adapt culturally. With my Asian clients, I'm very careful to meet them on their level with a very humble approach.
- How much should a manager emphasize their differences versus mirroring the client?
- There are other details in the client's background I consider: their gender, social origin, the size of their wealth and how they built it. What do they do professionally? Are they just living off investments, running a business, or perhaps they're a trader?
- It's also important to figure out what stage they're at with their wealth: Are they still building their assets, an entrepreneur, or someone who's enjoying their fortune?
- Are they part of a first or second generation of clients?
- The first tends to develop lasting relationships, whereas the second relies more on results to maintain theirs. (One manager joked that the third generation simply spent the wealth accumulated before them!)
- I focus on what he needs in managing their wealth, their level of banking and financial know-how, how savvy they are, and above all, how comfortable they are with risk – whether they avoid it or seek it out.
- Depending on the culture, fortune is either flaunted or kept low-key; understanding how my client views wealth is really important to me.
- Another aspect is the client's national identity, which depends on the political and economic context of their home region. Sometimes they want to play a part in their nation's development.
- I consider the basis of our relationship. What truly motivates my client? Is it fear, the desire to protect their fortune, tradition, how they see the bank, or the need for strong returns?
- I always ask myself whether documentation is absolutely necessary and what its purpose really is.
- It's not always looked at, but it offers peace of mind and leaves an impression on the client. At my bank, the documents are very elegant, which is a real plus.
- It can be used as a discussion aid as well. The marketing team at my bank put together what they call the "manager's marketing kit", which has variety of documents, materials for opening accounts, and product information sheets. Having a checklist makes things easier. The documents are simple, clear, practical, and all written in the client's language.

3. What objectives do you have in mind before a client meeting?

- Before meeting clients abroad, I always ask myself: What results do I want to achieve?
- The most obvious result is that the client opens an account!
- I know clients never sign straightaway, so my main goal in the first meeting is to secure a second appointment. After that, I'll have plenty of time to close the deal in the second or even third meeting. I give myself time to woo the client, win them over, and see if my bank's products truly meet their needs.

4. How do you maintain your business relationships?

- I build relationships to last and let the time and shared experiences strengthen them.
- I keep in touch constantly, so my client never forgets me.
- I pay close attention to their needs and tailor my approach accordingly. I also work on the relationship by sparking their curiosity, trying each time to break the routine, introduce a new product, service, or simply share a creative idea related to their wealth or otherwise.
- In the first meetings with a new prospect, relationship matters more than skill; my approach always adapts to where we are in the relationship.
- I pay attention to every detail and treat all my contacts equally because I know that small things build something bigger.

5. What difficulties might you encounter during the negotiation process?

- The first is the client's lack of financial knowledge. They don't always understand the products or the stakes. Others don't know what they really want; they're cautious but still expect high returns. The whole risk-return balance is a tricky concept to fully take on board — and I mean really take on board, not just understand.
- The client sometimes doesn't know what they don't know. It's really important to establish an equal footing here and not let knowledge gaps get in the way. I focus on keeping that balance throughout; the client brings the funds, while the manager brings the expertise and the team.
- When it comes to negotiating fees, I've learned that clients who haggle over prices from the start often turn out to be difficult. Sometimes I prefer to walk away early. But I can tell the difference when someone negotiates because it's part of their culture and complicated banking fees don't help with this.

6. What strategic factors shape a client visit?

- The choice of location. Sometimes, clients prefer discreet settings like a hotel or office rather than their home or business, even long after banking secrecy was phased out.
- Meeting clients at their home or office often makes it easier to carry out due diligence. Many are proud of their home or business and enjoy showing us round.
- Cultural norms in places like Asia often mean you meet clients in a hotel or a formal office, not at their home.

- Visiting clients at their home in the Middle East helps with sticking to the timings; you arrive on time and leave on time.

7. How do you manage your client-facing time?

- Perception of time is one of the fundamentals. It's less about punctuality and more about how clients view time and long-term thinking; this shapes how I structure investment proposals.
- Before planning any business trip, I take time to understand how time is viewed locally, including religious holidays, school breaks, and other key calendar dates.
- Depending on the culture, appointments are either scheduled in advance or arranged locally. When I travel in Asia, I can plan my schedule ahead of time; conversely, in Middle Eastern countries, I only set things up once I'm there and confirm any meetings I was able to arrange in advance.
- I always keep a day free during my trip to plan for unforeseen events, cancelations, or unscheduled appointments.
- The average meeting lasts an hour in the Middle East, but it can be much longer.
- In some countries, such as the Far East, the length of the interview is determined in advance.
- Punctuality is a very flexible notion, depending on the culture, so I'm careful to be disciplined on this point.
- When customers open an account, they would like the relationship to begin immediately. Some customers find it difficult to envisage a long-term investment; they want a quick return.

8. How do you approach a first meeting?

- I look for a topic to break the ice; my aim is to create an atmosphere that's conducive to communication.
- The main quality of a wealth manager during an initial meeting is adaptability.
- First, I introduce myself in just a few words to spark curiosity, then I present my bank.
- In the Middle East, it's important to make it clear that you know the environment and the culture; the private and professional spheres often mix.
- I don't bring up financial matters directly when meeting clients in Asia.
- I begin by showing my awareness of current financial trends. This helps establish credibility early on. This naturally leads into a discussion about opportunities for growth and wealth protection in the current context.
- I then explain how our private banking department operates; everyone who's involved, the people in charge, and so on.

9. How do you build trust and find out about your clients' needs?

- Have empathy, enjoy communicating, respect your commitments and, above all, be highly disciplined.
- Customers value reliability and thoroughness, with a structured approach.
- I'll admit, when I run out of arguments, I sometimes let the client dream a little.

- Eastern clients tend to approach discussions more indirectly, while Western clients are generally more straightforward.
- I try to uncover areas where clients may be dissatisfied with their current financial providers. There's often a gap to exploit.
- I look for a thread I can pull – a reason to stay in touch and gradually build the relationship.
- I simply follow my intuition!

10. How do you build your arguments and deal with objection?

- I always ask myself whether I'm being too direct; in any case, I remain discreet.
- Genuine objections are rare. Often, they're just a way to prolong the conversation and test my persistence.
- The most common objections are about fees, competition from local banks, performance, and track record.
- The best way to address objections is to explain everything – fees, commissions, and why things are the way they are.
- I try to meet the client halfway, to avoid any long-term friction.

11. What are your closing techniques?

- I can clearly tell when a client is ready to move to the closing phase; their questions become more specific, they start talking price, and their body language speaks volumes.
- I also recognize when a client isn't convinced; they become distant, switch to more general topics, and strangely, become overly polite and thankful. They become vague about timings.
- If needed, I suggest pushing back the decision to give the client more space.
- When there's an introducer involved, it's typically about sealing the deal!
- Never walk away entirely; keep a line of communication open.
- I also know when it's time to stop believing and let go – that's my strength.

12. How do you maintain your client relationships?

- A client feels valued when they are regularly visited and kept informed.
- Maintaining a client relationship consists primarily in showing an interest in them.
- It's all about having a continuous intelligent presence.
- I nurture my clients intellectually.
- I keep my clients well informed. That way, if something goes wrong, there are no nasty surprises.

An expert's perspective

I can't resist sharing this anecdote with you again[1].

He was in his fifties and had made his fortune importing luxury goods in South America. He was meeting his wealth manager – we'll call her Bérangère – from a major Swiss bank for the third time.

He was chatting about various investment opportunities and the pleasures of life in Switzerland. But he couldn't quite bring himself to become a client of this bank or to switch partners. Just two months earlier, he had reminisced with her about his student days at EPFL in Lausanne. Those were youthful, joyful years, though not without hardship. His scholarship barely covered his expenses, yet he persevered and graduated with honors as an engineer.

Three days earlier:

Bérangère was shopping in a Geneva supermarket; she often bought chocolates for her South American clients. It was second nature to her, as she didn't like to arrive empty-handed. As she walked past the grocery aisle, she reached for two tubes of Cenovis, the iconic Swiss yeast-based spread, barely thinking about it. She popped them into her basket, thinking of her last meeting with a Brazilian client. Why did she do it? Most likely due to some unconscious link from the conversation they'd had. A few days later, in a São Paulo hotel room, she got ready to meet her client, grabbing her papers along with the tubes of Cenovis.

She arrived at her client's home, and the conversation began with how the investment funds she had recommended during their previous meeting were performing. She returned to emphasizing the benefits of working with her bank. Mid-sentence, she leaned down to pull two tubes of Cenovis from her bag and said to her client, "I thought of you and brought you a typically Swiss specialty."

Her client's gaze suddenly fixed on the two tubes. A silence fell over the room. He picked them up slowly, as if they were of great value.

He turned them over, opened one, and carefully held it to his nose. Bérangère watched and immediately realized that her client was becoming emotional. He squeezed out some of the paste, took a bit with his finger, and tasted it. A tear slid down his face. He smiled and apologized to Bérangère. He explained that during his student days, he sometimes didn't have enough money to eat at the end of the month and would get by on Cenovis and bread. The emotion had resurfaced instantly, and the conversation shifted, as though this surge of feeling had brought a new closeness to their relationship. He went on to become one of Bérangère's top clients, opening a $10-million account.

1 I've already shared this story in my previous book, "*Successfully Selling*", chapter 5.

Spring into action! **5 key takeaways and an exercise**

FIVE KEY TAKEAWAYS

13. I can recognize where I stand, between the bank and the client.
14. I can embrace my identity and role, whether generalist or specialist.
15. I know that selling starts with selling a relationship.
16. I understand how the wealth manager's role is evolving.
17. Empathy is the common thread running through all the accounts.

EXERCICE

Title: What did you learn from this investigation?

Aim of the exercise: Draw lessons from this field study.

Instructions:

- What are the three key takeaways you retain after reading this chapter?
- What two personal lessons can you apply to your own professional development?

4

Wealth manager skill sets

Corporate culture

and commercial dynamics

Business momentum relies on commercial energy and expertise; develop and nurture your sales fighting spirit!

TEACHING OBJECTIVES

After reading this chapter, you will be able to:

- Understand the social skills essential for the role of a wealth manager.
- Drive your bank's culture to invigorate its commercial momentum.

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1. THE WEALTH MANAGER'S MANY FACES

In few other roles are the differences in approach so pronounced.

A future that is both certain and uncertain

The wealth manager, like a service salesperson, acts as a guide. It is difficult for them to sell and convince clients about products that do not have a certain future.

To put this in perspective, consider the future of a product such as a car.

We know how to operate it and roughly how long it will function before showing signs of wear. As such, its future is relatively certain.

In the case of a banking product that represents an investment, the future is uncertain. The bank and the manager sell something uncertain in exchange for something concrete: the fees and commissions, expressed in monetary terms, charged to clients.

From this perspective, is the wealth manager just selling hot air? No; they are simply a seller of uncertainty, and that's beyond their control. They become a guide to uphold ethical standards and remain firmly on the client's side. They reassure clients to ensure a calm, objective analysis of investment options, not to charm them or hide the difficult aspects of the relationship.

For the wealth manager, this side represents the struggle against the fear of losing the fruits of their labor. The manager guides the client along the road to Damascus, taking them by the hand and pointing out the wrong turns to avoid.

2. WHAT ARE THE DIFFERENT ROLES OF A WEALTH MANAGER?

- The roles assumed by the wealth manager unfold naturally. They start as a financial advisor, then as trust builds, they evolve into a kind of pilot before eventually becoming a trusted confidant.

As far as possible, the wealth manager tries to avoid becoming the client's sole champion. Sometimes, they may experience a sort of identity conflict, since they must simultaneously serve the interests of their clients and the bank that employs them.

They need to be able to wear multiple hats, each with its own limits.

What are the five roles of an account manager? [1]

1 Source: *CS Competency Model*, 2009..

The advisor
They give advice as they would for themselves, building a long-term relationship

The pilot
Once the manager fully understands the client's rational and emotional needs, they navigate the relationship between the bank, its services, and the client

The conductor
They take control to relieve their clients of as much mental strain as possible

The advocate
The wealth manager always defends their client's interests. The client knows and feels this.

The confidant
The manager listens, speaks uncomfortable truths, and isn't afraid to ask difficult and personal questions.

The wealth manager may find themselves questioning their true role, grappling with the ambiguity (as previously mentioned) of whether their loyalty lies with the client or the bank.

Don't bite the hand that feeds you!
But what if there are two?

The stances they adopt in turn:

1. **Creativity:** They work on the "enchantment effect," a refined version of the wow factor.
2. **Commitment:** They base promises on facts, never on assumptions.
3. **Agility:** They move seamlessly between roles, each requiring a different approach: first as the client's advocate, then as a portfolio manager, and finally as a trusted confidant.
4. **Humility:** In a long-term relationship, beware of the sin of pride. Approach each meeting with the same anticipation as the first; sales is a school of humility. Match the effort your clients put in. Every follow-up should feel like a fresh start, approached with renewed energy and commitment.
5. **Depth of the relationship:** They talk about contributing to the client's happiness and aren't afraid to ask the fundamental question: What is the meaning of your life? It's a way of approaching sales as a way of understanding the world, and it offers a more philosophical kind of competitive edge.
6. **Closeness:** I make sure that every presentation only focuses only on what's relevant to the client! I connect my own experience with theirs. I work like an architect, offering solutions to build something meaningful, without pushing for a sale.

7. **Social connection:** The deeper it is, the quicker trust can be established. Some clients don't want this kind of closeness. Trust is built more easily when the wealth manager is constantly active and engaged, demonstrating how they are working hard for the client. They clearly enjoy building a relationship and often find common ground with the client.

3. THE CHALLENGES FACING WEALTH MANAGERS

The manager must deal with numerous challenges in their role, reflecting the wide range of skills they need to master. The diagram[2] below shows some of the key areas where they need to demonstrate relevance and effectiveness. It is not an exhaustive list.

4. PUTTING THE ROLE INTO CONTEXT

A. "PROTECT OR PERISH"

Each bank will aim to maintain a strong position and clear identity in the market and with its private clients.

Every bank vies to highlight the excellence of its services with carefully chosen adjectives. The comparison to the luxury sector is the most common, and it makes sense since both industries serve the same customers: the very wealthy looking for exclusive, high-end services.

The manager represents the tip of the iceberg.

Below the surface are the bank's full range of products and services, the implementation of tailored solutions, and, of course, the expertise of all the bank's specialists.

2 Source: CAS training, 2007.

The wealth manager's central role is to build a "special" relationship so that the client feels completely at home. They should have the same sense of security they experience when comfortably settled at home, cozy and protected from harm.

They know that their assets are safe here, their private sphere is well protected, and they are fully taken care of.

After all these considerations, somewhat worthy of a firefighter's motto, the role also includes meeting all the professional commitments that come with being an employee of a company.

B. BE COMMITTED!

The role therefore also includes:

- Acquiring new clients,
- Maximizing existing clients' potential (by optimizing their portfolio),
- Expanding their catchment area within the limits of the bank's geographic strategy,
- Providing a service that offers an outstanding customer experience.

If all you have is a hammer,
everything looks like a nail.

5. ASSESSING YOUR COMMERCIAL SKILLS

Inspired by a questionnaire co-developed with Yvan Constantin, a Geneva-based trainer[3], during a training for junior managers at a private Geneva bank, this tool helps evaluate your current commercial skills (know-how in action) in wealth management.

This questionnaire, which assesses your commercial skills, will help you to:

- track the progress of your commercial abilities,
- support your development by identifying training areas to focus on.

Instructions:

1. For each question, place a cross in the box matching your estimated level.
2. Complete the results table at the end of the questionnaire.
3. Identify the areas where you need to improve.

3 Source: CAS training "Commercial Proactivity," 2003. www.hypso.ch

CHOOSE ONE ANSWER FOR EACH QUESTION	1	2	3	4
I do not possess this skill (1)	X			
I have a basic understanding of this skill (2)		X		
I use this skill but need to improve it (3)			X	
I have mastered this skill (4)				X

COMMERCIAL STRATEGY	1	2	3	4
I know how to maintain and regularly grow my commercial network and referrals.				
I know how to build and strengthen trust with my client.				
I can identify key levers for future business opportunities and turn them into referrals.				
I understand and make a concerted effort to embrace my client's local culture.				
My sales approach respects and conforms to the behavioral standards of the client's local culture.				
I know how to retain clients to ensure the long-term success of the business relationship.				
I plan my visits and set the framework for each meeting whenever possible.				
I prepare and tailor my marketing kit to the specific needs of the clients I am going to meet.				
I can measure the key issues involved in organizing a meeting, like where and when it will take place.				
I can conduct a preliminary analysis of the negotiation's stakes. I can carry out a cultural analysis. I can conduct a biographical analysis of my client.				
I understand and have full command of my bank's commercial orientations.				
I understand the potential impact of economic, political, or cultural news on my clients and know how to take appropriate actions.				
I set and formalize my sales objectives specific to each business meeting.				
I know how to secure appointments over the phone (following initial contact via LinkedIn) with new clients.				

MEETING PREPARATION	1	2	3	4
I am fully familiar with the content of all client-related documents from my bank, including sales presentations and product pitches.				
I know how to prepare my client file.				
I prepare a tailored sales pitch for each client's profile before the meeting.				

GETTING TO KNOW THE CLIENT	1	2	3	4
I am able to take charge of the first meeting and build trust from that moment.				
I am able to adjust my way of communicating to match the client's style.				
I know how to manage the transition from a social relationship to a business one.				
I can distinguish between implicit and explicit needs.				
I know how to apply effective questioning techniques to understand the client.				
I am comfortable discussing the client's personal, private, and professional situation.				
I can pinpoint aspects of the client's profile, such as their background, risk tolerance, outlook, and wealth management goals.				
I use my surroundings, my bank's reputation, and its private wealth management approach to support my sales pitch.				
I know my bank's USPs (Unique Selling Propositions) and how to use them.				
I am aware of all the benefits of working with my bank.				
I am skilled in managing communication within client relationships, including aspects like appreciation, safety, and belonging.				
I am proficient in managing objections, from theory to practical techniques and responses.				
Je maîtrise la négociation tarifaire.				
I confidently manage pricing negotiations.				
I am comfortable closing deals.				
I can leverage compliance as a competitive advantage.				

COMMERCIAL FOLLOW-UP	1	2	3	4
I have a systematic approach to planning client follow-up.				
I can manage the follow-up process for my client portfolio.				
I regularly inform my clients about new products.				
I am comfortable handling difficult relationships with certain clients.				

RESULTS TABLE

Calculate the total number of marks awarded in each section.

	1	2	3	4
COMMERCIAL STRATEGY				
MEETING PREPARATION				
GETTING TO KNOW THE CLIENT				
COMMERCIAL FOLLOW-UP				

Questionnaire Debrief If most of your marks are in columns 3 and 4 in each section, your proficiency is strong, and reading this book will help refresh your skills.

If your marks fall mainly in columns 1 and 2, we aim to support you in improving your skills in these sections.

A. KEY SKILLS EVERY WEALTH MANAGER NEEDS TO MASTER

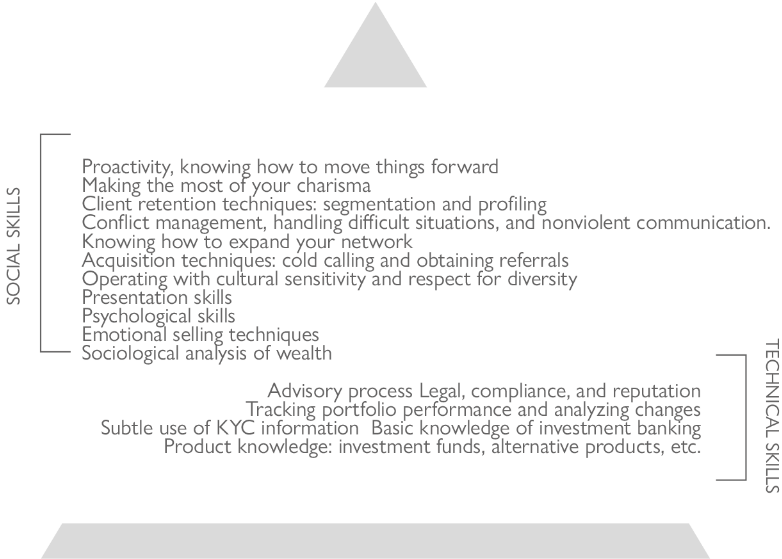
The table on the previous page helped us establish an initial assessment of the different skill sets.

The quest for excellence within a bank encourages setting out the expected skills. Afterwards, the competency levels of every manager need to be evaluated. The CWMA certification in Switzerland does this very effectively for wealth managers[4].

This type of certification sets out the competency requirements and standards. It includes two competency frameworks:

- Une pyramide des compétences
- Un court référentiel et son échelle de mesure[5]

4 CWMA = Certified Wealth Management Advisor.
5 Source: Based on the research conducted by Patrick Balzli for his master's thesis in finance, supervised by the author in December 2023 at ISFB.



Skills pyramid

Technical competencies form the base of the pyramid and are considered the top priority. Given the complexity of sales in banking, a wider range of social competencies is required.

The first table outlines the required competencies, and the second provides a scale for measuring them.

You can use it to develop a customized competency framework within your institution.

For the role: Banking advisor

COMMERCIAL BEHAVIORAL SKILLS	DEFINITIONS
Emotional Intelligence	Ability to perceive, understand, manage, and express one's own emotions, while recognizing and interpreting the emotions of others.
Sense of efficiency	Ability to take the right actions to achieve expected outcomes.
Questioning mindset	Ability to proactively seek information to gain deeper understanding and avoid reaching hasty conclusions.
Adaptability	Ability to adjust to new needs and adapt to future changes in the environment.

Seeking alternatives	Ability to offer clients multiple solutions, giving them a range of options.
Effective communication and storytelling	Ability to communicate and receive information clearly, using various channels to foster understanding and build strong client relationships. Ability to structure persuasive arguments tailored to the client's needs.
Proactivity	Ability to identify opportunities and act on them at the right time.

Rating scale for assessing each skill:

NEEDS DEVELOPMENT	• Is unaware of how their work affects other teams or services. • Fails to follow the given guidelines when performing tasks. • Is not engaged in their work. • Spends time and effort on activities that add no value.
PROFICIENT	• Meets established deadlines and manages time efficiently. • Makes good use of available tools including new technologies. • Plans and organizes assigned work according to predetermined standards or procedures. • Pursues and achieves set objectives. • Demonstrates an ability to set priorities and plan tasks with the results in mind.
HIGHLY PROFICIENT	• Knows how to let go of outdated methods, processes, behaviors, and habits. • Makes the most of opportunities to surpass expectations. • Undertakes training on their own initiative. • Engages proactively with a focus on achieving goals. • Improves processes and skills to perform their role effectively and efficiently.

B. MEASURING SKILLS

It is essential for banks to carefully measure skills, as this will help raise the standard of customer service and, in turn, their performance.

A skill helps to clarify and define:

- The behavioral expectations the bank considers important for all wealth managers.
- Each wealth manager's strengths (whether they possess the expected skill or not) in order to identify their development needs.

Test: What is your commercial potential?

INDICATORS OF MY COMMERCIAL POTENTIAL	EVALUATION OF MY POTENTIAL 1 TO 10	MEASURES FOR IMPROVEMENT
I take time to develop my expertise (credibility).		
I have blocked out time slots in my schedule for focused prospecting.		
I allocate sufficient and structured time for my clients' development.		
Based on my results, I am an effective and profitable seller.		
I work on building client loyalty.		
I maintain good relationships with all my referrers (active referrals).		
I pay special attention to my most "vulnerable" clients (loyal and friendly).		
I have organized all appointments with potential clients.		
I have planned sales visits with my market manager.		
I have followed up with all clients who have left.		
I share my commercial experiences, both good and bad, with my colleagues.		
I have regular meetings with my management to review my commercial development and retention of more vulnerable clients.		
Total:		

If your total score is between 60 and 120, you have no reason to worry about your commercial future.

If your total is below 60, you'll find plenty of helpful advice in this book.

Improving good habits requires first identifying your weak sales habits.

C. SKILLS NOT ASSESSED IN THE CWMA CERTIFICATION

Knowing how to work effectively with different departments.

Managing conflicts

Managing client relationships with a human touch.

Promoting diversity.

Managing reputational risks.

Creativity and problem-solving (crucial in client relations)

Collaborating with specialists in law, tax, investment, credit, and analysis to build solutions.

6. THE SIMULTANEOUS EVOLUTION OF BEHAVIORS

We highlight the connection between the evolution of private clients' behaviors and the future skill sets that managers will need to develop.

A. THE CHANGING PERSONALITY TRAITS OF CLIENTS 3.0[6]

Clients are often a reflection of their times. Private banking clients are no exception – they live in their time and are influenced by the defining traits of their generation.

Today, they are caught up in a technological whirlwind. Given their wealth, they generally manage quite well. They often have substantial financial resources and can allocate a budget to acquire up-to-date technical tools.

From a demographic perspective, lifespans have extended alongside increasingly advanced healthcare, resulting in longer and more productive lives.

Lifestyles today are more health-conscious and balanced, and wealthy individuals place high value on both.

Families are undergoing multiple changes over the course of a lifetime, which adds complexity to all matters related to inheritance.

Gender equality is now the norm, not a discussion point, and it goes hand in hand with a natural openness to diversity in all its forms.

6 Gratton, Lynda. *The Shift: The Future of Work Is Already Here*, London: William Collins.

On a societal level, consumption has become a way of life, and an insatiable one at that.

People are acutely aware of environmental concerns, which are no longer just theoretical but part of daily life.

Rising fuel prices, climate fluctuations, and seasonal extremes: everyone sees them, and everyone feels them!

Attitudes of the wealthy are changing. As the inequalities between rich and poor grow and the spectacle unfolds before their eyes, they can no longer – and no longer wish to – remain indifferent to the tragedies taking place. They want to know everything, and this type of information is not sugar-coated.

It is hard not to be affected by the suffering in the world, which is now truly at our doorstep in all its forms; the migrants' tragedy is real and no longer just virtual on a television screen. Clients of the 3.0 generation want to "do something," to promote greater equality and to support a culture of sustainability.

The client's behavior frequently often a range of consumption theories in practice.

For the wealth manager, it's about finding the client's most important focus and respecting their beliefs and what drives their needs.

B. HOW THE NEEDS OF PRIVATE WEALTH CLIENTS CREATE NEW BEHAVIORS IN WEALTH MANAGERS[7]

The consumer generally acts rationally, without being influenced by their environment. There is one exception: the **Veblen** effect (named after sociologist Thorstein Veblen) on conspicuous consumption; the higher the prices, the more the consumer will buy, provided others know about it. Except for this anomaly, clients aim to find solutions to their problems. Their motivation is fueled by rationality, and their consumption follows suit.

Bank loyalty depends on how well investment proposals match the client's stated needs and expectations. Rationality and consistency in buying behavior go hand in hand. Price remains a differentiating factor.

Clients who are extremely satisfied with their bank never discuss the price.

This is a stimulating behavior that impacts client actions, similar to Pavlov's conditioning experiments. Stimuli, which can be words, trigger emotional responses that firmly root themselves in the client's personal experiences. The way we react to words is connected to each person's past experiences (see the filter concept in chapter 8).

7 Inspired by the excellent consumer behavior course taught by Joaquin Fernandez at HEG in 2011.

Another way to refer to argumentation is the method of applying positive (adding) or negative (taking away) reinforcements.

Providing a free analysis for a portfolio held at another bank is an example of positive reinforcement (like small wins on slot machines that keep the player hooked).

Consistent positive behaviors in a business setting cause the client to associate the meeting with a positive experience, highlighting the need to maintain steady positive relations with clients. The risks clients perceive are managed by foreseeing the potential drawbacks of their decisions.

In this situation, the client considers the negative consequences and will choose the least risky alternative – one that accounts for potential losses, primarily financial but also time-related.

Psychological risk should be viewed on the same level (frustration, misunderstanding, loss of self-esteem). Clients reduce risk perception by relying on the adviser's expertise and simultaneously digging deeper into what the bank offers.

To lower the client's sense of risk, the bank will:

- Let the client benefit from its years of experience.
- Demonstrate the manager's ability to understand and solve client problems.
- Give the client risk-free trials by offering complimentary services up front.

C. CHANGES IN WEALTH BANAGER BEHAVIOR (MIRRORING THEUR CLIENTS)

Will the wealth manager turn into a therapist in the future?

I'm sure of it!

Twenty years ago, in negotiation seminars (we weren't allowed to use the word "sales") for wealth managers, I would gently stress the importance of psychology in client relationships.

I got quite the backlash from the private banking heads of the time who considered such topics taboo and frivolous in the highly structured world of wealth management. Back then, with minimal global competition and clients lining up at Swiss banks, this attitude made sense. But times have changed.

Emotion is a vehicle for memory; everyone remembers exactly where

they were during key events of their time (for me, September 11, 2001).

Memories are clearer when emotions run high. Based on this fact, each manager can consider: how can we ensure our client interactions are emotionally powerful?

The idea is to leave "emotional markers" in the minds of our contacts.

For a long time, reason has prevailed over emotion.

"Emotions are an obstacle to rational thought." (Plato)

Our culture encourages us to hide our emotions. Managers find themselves caught between different cultures — those of their clients and that of their bank.

One of the most relevant skills for a manager is emotional intelligence.

7. EMOTIONAL INTELLIGENCE AND VALUES ARE TWO CORNERSTONES OF COMMERCIAL PERSUASION

Definition of emotional intelligence

One of the key skills in commercial relationships within wealth management is emotional intelligence — the ability to understand our clients' emotions. While IQ stabilizes during adolescence, emotional quotient is constantly improving, provided we work on it by enhancing our ability to express our own emotions and to decipher those of others.

Emotional intelligence is the capacity for recognizing our own feelings and those of others (Daniel Goleman).

Values

It all starts with the fact that emotions are based on values. Emotions are behind most buying signals.

The values the company stands for, plus the personal values of the manager and the client, anchor the emotions that come up during commercial exchanges.

Wealth managers need to reflect on the values they live by and represent to their clients. They are showing who they truly are.

It is when these values are deeply challenged or shaken that the individual reacts emotionally, experiencing a "values shock."

The way they manage their emotions is strongly influenced by their personal ethics.

Sometimes, real "ethical pain" causes strong negative emotions that harm the relationship, like when a sale feels forced or manipulative (for example, when a bank pushes its products on customers).

This parallel with Maslow's pyramid can help to understand the different stages of one's emotions.

Wealth Manager's Motivation Pyramid (Inspired by Maslow's Pyramid)

A. SKILL AS THE DRIVING FORCE BEHIND STRATEGIC ALIGNMENT (LIKE A PITCH)

The following table[8] is an exercise you can carry out. It puts the fundamentals of banking to the test of commercial persuasion. How can these elements be used as sales arguments? How can values be used, for example, to convince a reluctant customer?

Alignment exercise, an example from the banking sector

BANK BASIC PRINCIPLES	DO YOU USE THIS BASIC PRINCIPLE AS PART OF YOUR PITCH?	GIVE A SPECIFIC EXAMPLE FROM YOUR COMMERCIAL EXPERIENCE (HOW DO YOU USE IT?)
My company's values Integrity –Value creation - Teamwork - Commitment		
The bank's cultural identity – its DNA		
The mission and positioning of my bank		

8 Table created for a training session at a private wealth management bank in Geneva (2022)..

My bank's commitment toward its clients: Security, quality, closeness, trust and reliability		
My bank's USP: Helping you achieve your life projects.		
Human characteristics of my bank, the owners, the leaders, and their charisma		
The bank's history		
Perspectives we offer: Art and culture Sustainable development		
The bank's commercial approach: Life cycles: family, retirement, place of residence, business, wealth		
Financing solutions: Mortgage, Lombard loan		
Wealth management solutions: Wealth assessment, financial planning		
Investment solutions: Discretionary and advisory mandates, thematic funds, and certificates		

B. UNE LIGNE DE COHÉRENCE

The table below[9] illustrates the importance of maintaining a line of consistency between the bank's values and the relationship manager's concrete commercial actions. It is the manager's skills that will enable them to align each of their actions with their origins (at the top of the table: values, mission, strategy, etc.). This skill supports the manager throughout their journey, from value to action.

Alignment is the consistency the manager must emphasize. They show congruence and trustworthiness when working with their client, representing the balance between their words and environment, promises and actions, and how they want to appear versus who they really are.

9 This table is inspired by a course given by the author at the ISFB (Institut Supérieur de Formation Bancaire) on banking management (2022).

BANK'S VISION

"Things I'll never give up"	"What I'm paid for"	"What methods will we use?"	"What's our usual way of doing things?"
Declared values →	Objectives →	Bank's strategy → for my segment	Commercial → policy
"New Growth Markets" Develop new strategic markets	↑ Develop live chat with private banking clients	Roll-out of the Vision 2027 strategy	Increase direct and personal contact with clients
	↑		
	↑		
	↑		

VALUE — **LINE OF CONSISTENCY**

Skills will serve as the link between all the elements in the roadmap above.

Aligned messaging, meaning consistent with the bank's core principles, to:

- Be able to justify (explain) all my actions with clients.
- Establish a clear connection between the bank's positioning and my commercial proposals.
- Be perceived by clients as a confident and authentic partner.

8. REVISITING THE QUESTION OF IDENTITY: ARE YOU A *HUNTER* OR A *FARMER*?

This is a trick question; this notion is largely outdated and obsolete today in 2024, both in concept and in reality.

Why?

1. Competitive pressure drives the optimization of all resources in contact with clients.
2. Commercial necessity: any actions that can expand the portfolio base are welcome.
3. Organizational necessity: productivity is increasing, meaning resources remain stable but expectations for results are rising.

	Operational phase		
Results and effort objectives →	Who's responsible? →	Operational follow-up →	
		Interim period	Final deadline
To have contacted my 243 customers by the end of December 202_ and converted at least 25% of my customers to remote relationships.	Me!	30.06.202_.	31.12.202_

COMMERCIAL ACTION

Farmers must now go beyond mere management to also focus on growth. What was once handled on an ad hoc basis is now approached systematically.

This does not imply a radical shift in the profile of traditional farmers. They have always enjoyed nurturing, developing, and pampering existing clients, but they must now adopt a more proactive commercial mindset.

The *hunter*, who enjoys pursuing and acquiring new clients, is still (unfortunately) a rare breed in the banking sector.

FARMER* OR *HUNTER?							
The resources I can access at the bank			My portfolio		My clients		
Tracking my commercial time	My network of internal experts	Assessment of my technical and social skills	Action plan	Risk evaluation	Organizing my commercial time	Active referrals	Cross-selling = multiple needs

Table highlighting the shared concerns of *farmers* and *hunters*

A. THE "KILLER" SALESPERSON?

Does a wealth manager need to become a "killer" salesperson? Certainly not – that would be completely at odds with the culture of private banking. Client relationships in this field are emotional, filled with subtlety and nuance. Still, they're not without a fighting spirit or the will to close a deal.

Amid these apparent contradictions, the wealth manager must shape their own identity as a salesperson. They need to find their way and overcome internal barriers.

The biggest hurdle is often how they see selling – and salespeople. We explored this in depth in our book on sales basics[10].

B. THE IDENTITY OF THE SALESPERSON – AGAIN

Conviction is the fuel of effective selling. To gain it, the salesperson must shake off the taboos, preconceptions, and biases that drag down their engagement. Like a weight on their shoulders, it's like carrying a burden that holds them back from closing the deal.

The first of these taboos is the perception that selling is vulgar. This negative view of commercial exchange often leads to negative behaviors—most commonly among poor salespeople…

Identity is directly linked to social perceptions – in other words, how we see things. If our social perceptions are clear and strong (and fully embraced), then our identity will in turn be clearly defined.

That's why the first step for any wealth manager is to reflect on their commercial role, to accept it, and to own it, in order not to be held back by the taboos we mentioned earlier.

There is a historical and sociological background to this observation. To make sense of it, one must delve into our mythological heritage.

Hermes was the god of merchants, the messenger of the gods, but he was also the god of another group: thieves. For thousands of years, we have therefore associated sellers with thieves. We still carry the legacy of this story today.

I've been asking the same question in my sales seminars for 35 years, almost like a mantra: **How do you perceive selling?** The response rate has remained fairly constant, reflecting the biases we've discussed – 70% of participants expressed discomfort with identifying as a salesperson. The survey in Chapter 2 says the same thing: In this profession, selling still carries a certain stigma.

Why is this a problem? In principle, everyone is entitled to their own inhibitions. But this perception creates obstacles during sensitive stages of the sales relationship – for example, when closing a deal, or when questioning the client, especially when asking for an active referral.

10 Fabien Smadja, *Successfully Selling*, 2021.

We've explored how these barriers arise from individual beliefs, but they can just as easily be embedded in the very culture of the bank.

9. HOW TO DEVELOP COMMERCIAL MOMENTUM

This section aims to provide some key insights for developing commercial momentum within a banking institution.

Culture and sales behavior

The Swiss cultural dimension can be an obstacle

Swiss people are naturally discreet and modest — a moral quality that, while admirable, can hold back commercial activity. In banking, this creates a paradox: while clients expect and value confidentiality, relationship managers are also expected to be proactive — a quality that can push against this cultural discretion. Wealth managers must learn to move beyond it.

AI is about to change everything

Administrative and transactional tasks currently handled by relationship managers (RMs) will soon be automated thanks to artificial intelligence. The time this frees up will allow for more client interaction. The quality of the relationship will depend on human contact, reliability, keeping promises, and the warmth of the interaction.

The relationship itself will come under increasing scrutiny, with even the smallest details (such as the emotions felt or cultural differences) being carefully considered. While artificial intelligence will ensure the information shared is accurate, authentic, and relevant, it is the human connection that will guarantee the quality of the interaction and the ability to respond to the emotions expressed by the client.

A. BUILDING A COMMERCIAL CULTURE

Culture develops through a systemic process. This process shapes a living environment, one in constant motion. That environment needs a name, an identity—a culture that the organization can rally around. The broader business project it supports should be easy to grasp, visualize, communicate, and implement.

But what defines a bank's culture?

- Clear, recognizable behaviors that influence the way the bank operates.
- A set of symbols and shared beliefs (passed down from the top of the organization to the bottom).

A culture trickles down – it might even be said to cascade. The behaviors modeled by those at the top of the hierarchy strongly influence all employees, particularly the client-facing managers, through the power of example.

The bank's culture acts as a driving force shaping sales behaviors.

When leadership emphasizes only the results and overlooks the commercial behaviors that support them, it sends out the wrong message.

It's better to promote a cultural message focused on active listening, understanding the client's emotional needs, and so on, before drawing attention to sales performance. The purpose of sending out the "right message" is to develop RMs' relationship-building skills. These are the skills that will deliver long-term results.

Referring to the bank's values as a foundation for influencing client relationships is another key lever for driving commercial momentum. Commercial behaviors and company culture work in tandem, reinforcing each other to sustain business development.

One benefit is that such behaviors naturally embrace innovation, new technologies, generational change, and are consistently adaptable to evolving legal regulations.

B. THE DIFFERENT LEVERS OF COMMERCIAL MOMENTUM

THE BANK'S DNA

The bank's deeply distinctive elements are found in its DNA. The term DNA—short for deoxyribonucleic acid—is a molecule that stores all the genetic information of a human being. When applied to a private bank, it refers to a unique and coherent identity that shapes its culture and drives its actions. Defining this DNA helps distinguish the bank from other institutions.

What are the key elements that define a company's DNA?

DNA COMPONENT (GENOME)	PURPOSE	PRACTICAL VALUE
Definition and explanation of the bank's core values and strategic orientation	Why does the bank uphold these values? Why is it heading in this direction?	Why are these values important, and in what contexts do they matter?
Unique client experience	All the bank's resources are mobilized to create this unique experience (technology, organization).	Create a lasting impression on the client by focusing on the smallest details throughout their experience.
Communication and visual identity	Consistency with the logo, color scheme, and materials.	All communication elements should convey the same message.
CSR (Corporate Social Responsibility)	Demonstrate this component through actions aligned with CSR principles.	Strengthens the bank's reputation.
Innovation and creativity	Rolling out new or exclusive products.	Creates a dynamic and proactive brand image.
Employee training and development	Show that the bank fosters professional expertise.	Enhance expertise and overall skill levels.
Brand identity	Create a clear "look and feel" with a strong signature.	The client can easily identify the bank.

From all these elements, the bank can establish its DNA while respecting the consistency between the component, its purpose, and its practical value.

THE BANK'S "BRAND"

The bank emphasizes the main distinguishing features of its brand that will enhance its competitive edge.

What are the brand's key distinguishing features?

1. The wealth managers are proud to work for this bank's brand and express this to their clients.
2. The bank has identified common behaviors specific to its culture. Common does not mean identical or cloned; cloning is not beneficial in sales.
3. Examples:

Energy	Commitment	Kindness
A friendly smile and positive manner	Close connection to action, reliability	Human connection and active listening

At this bank, the commercial relationship is a pleasant experience; it's a social connection.

4. At this bank, the banking strategies and key arguments are fully aligned.
5. This bank has a playbook that answers the question: "What unified messages do we convey to clients?"
6. Cross-selling is used to reinforce the brand and unify the bank's related service offerings.
7. At this bank, the messaging is well structured, commercial, and leverages the bank's strengths and competitive edge.
8. This bank offers training programs that help managers overcome their reluctance to sell.

C. COMMERCIAL BEHAVIORS AND MANAGEMENT

Commercial skills require a nurturing managerial "environment" to thrive and grow. This balanced management style (the environment) should be participative, as it best fosters creativity and allows everyone room to flourish.

The wealth manager needs this positive internal hierarchical relationship to build strong external relationships.

"Fear management" only leads to inhibiting behaviors. The relationship manager is afraid of making any mistake that might be blamed on them. They will hold back in all their interactions if they work in a stressful environment. In a negative management context, the commercial relationship is constantly blocked by new barriers and cannot thrive. The foundation of the commercial relationship is its intimate and authentic character. Only when these are present will the client open up and share.

A positive client experience is supported by a managerial style that allows freedom in the relationship.

Success begins with analyzing the twists and turns of all our failures.
We need to explain why a sale failed in order to understand how to succeed.

10. WHO ARE THE KEY PLAYERS IN DRIVING COMMERCIAL MOMENTUM?

First and foremost, we must mention the executive management and the bank's owners. Without their active support, there is no point in moving forward.

The goal of this cultural transformation project is to inspire new behaviors, starting with those involved in the commercial value chain and extending to all employees. Everyone needs to focus on the client, each in their own way and at their own pace.

The bank triggers the cultural turnaround by establishing:

- A clear strategic intent,
- A framework of client-facing behaviors,
- The image of an energetic, forward-moving bank,
- Best practices that create a shared language.

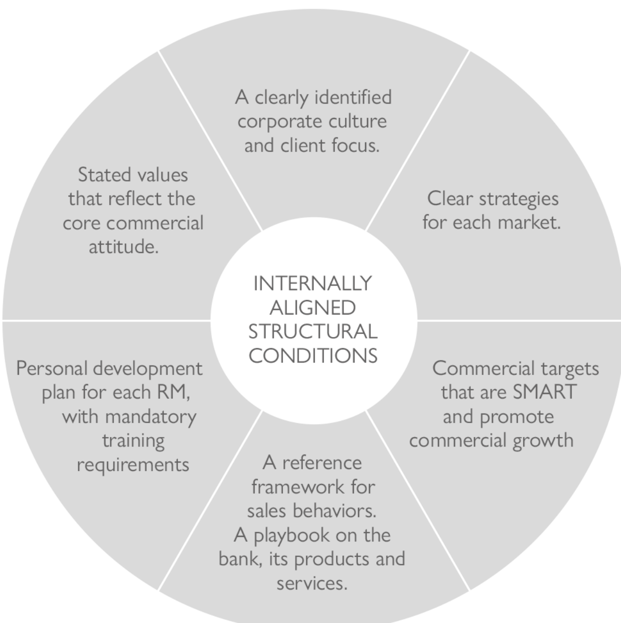
Who is this project aimed at, and why:

WHO IS IT FOR?	WHY IS THIS NECESSARY?	WHAT ACTIONS SHOULD BE TAKEN?
All wealth managers	To immerse them in the new commercial dynamic. To develop reflexive sales behaviors. To break down cultural barriers. To unlock the potential of existing portfolios.	A short training course delivered over a long period. This program would alternate between sales training and product or technical training.
Market / team managers	To ensure consistent operational support for team leaders as they drive sales initiatives.	Workshop on sales management, focusing on three key areas: setting and tracking sales targets over time; conducting sales meetings; coaching relationship managers.
Administrative assistants	They also play a role in client relations. They should speak the same language as Relationship Managers (RMs) and adopt the same mindset.	Training aligned with the managers' program. A short course that complements the "pincer effect" (between RMs and team leaders).

All staff who interact with clients (as part of the client journey).	To understand the mindset and adopt the appropriate behaviors. To ensure consistent behavior when interacting with clients.	A short workshop designed to engage everyone in the client value chain, using a tailored version of the sales training themes for targeted awareness.
All stakeholders involved in the client journey without direct client contact.	To foster a shared sense of ownership and align efforts with the commercial drive.	Short training sessions to instill shared values across the entire client value chain.
Recruiters in the HR department.	Their role is to ensure the commercial mindset is embedded during hiring and onboarding.	Clear job descriptions aligned with this philosophy, plus role-specific onboarding training.

A. KEY PHASES IN ESTABLISHING COMMERCIAL MOMENTUM IN BANKING

The commercial momentum begins with an assessment of the bank's business status. Each institution must first align its structural conditions internally.



Afterwards, establish the steps to be completed.

STEP 1	STEP OBJECTIVES	Report on the findings.
	STEP CONTENT	Share the results with all employees.
	ACTION TO BE TAKEN	Delivering the results. Keeping a realistic perspective.
	COMMENTS	Revisit the basics of strategic management.
STEP 2	STEP OBJECTIVES	Rally the entire frontline team.
	STEP CONTENT	Design a cohesive tool, for example a charter, plus a monitoring dashboard.
	ACTION TO BE TAKEN	Develop the charter and evaluate the performance of sales staff.
	COMMENTS	Train sales managers first and set commercial targets.
STEP 3	STEP OBJECTIVES	Bring together the existing commercial teams.
	STEP CONTENT	Develop a slogan like "all hands on deck" and list everyone with direct or indirect client contact.
	ACTION TO BE TAKEN	Hold regular town hall meetings.
	COMMENTS	Declare a state of urgency to spark awareness.
STEP 4	STEP OBJECTIVES	Get moving, initiate the attack!
	STEP CONTENT	Everyone to develop a Commercial Action Plan (CAP).
	ACTION TO BE TAKEN	Sales training to support commercial efforts.
	COMMENTS	Develop a three-year training plan to ensure long-term perspective.
STEP 5	STEP OBJECTIVES	Assessing the relevance of actions and their outcomes.
	STEP CONTENT	Reporting on business progress.
	ACTION TO BE TAKEN	Hold review meetings several months post-training.
	COMMENTS	Share the findings of the assessments.

B. THE 4 PILLARS OF THE "COMMERCIAL MOMENTUM" PROJECT AND THEIR RELATED COMPETENCIES

Strategic dimension
Developing a commercial culture
↑
Human dimension
Cultivating the instincts of a premium customer relationship
← COMMERCIAL MOMENTUM PROJECT →
Organizational dimension
Building a method and a CAP (Commercial Action Plan)
↓
Operational dimension
Learning sales techniques and boosting the value of each interaction

C. THE ROLE OF COMMUNICATION IN THE "COMMERCIAL MOMENTUM" PROJECT

Private bank clients are becoming increasingly well connected. This has three consequences: one is rational, and the other two are behavioral.

RATIONAL

Clients gain quicker and more precise access to information related to their portfolios.

BEHAVIORAL

- They expect a steady and abundant stream of information to satisfy their demands.
- They are increasingly uninhibited when it comes to discussing prices and switching banking providers.

The smooth flow of information strengthens the call for transparency; both clients and managers are habitual users of social media. Facebook has pushed transparency to the limit, revealing our private lives, the meals we choose at restaurants, and the scenes we witness and share extensively. Wealth profiles are shifting alongside the mobility of individuals,becoming transnational and more complex.

Let's return to the first obvious point that goes hand in hand with the digital revolution we're experiencing. Images and videos, combined with the demand for immediacy, have made social media the primary platform for communication today. Paper is almost a thing of the past. A decade ago, our training company used over 500,000 printed pages annually for client materials. Today, that number is close to zero.

COMMUNICATION PLAYS A CENTRAL ROLE IN DRIVING COMMERCIAL MOMENTUM

- It supports the bank by:
- Strengthening the brand,
- Increasing the project's internal and external visibility,
- Using the project to raise the bank's profile,
- Reinforcing and sharing the bank's values (as a commercial asset).

Its main objectives are to:

- Showcase expertise,
- Grow AUMs (Asset Under Management) and profitability,
- Enhance overall performance,
- Remain an attractive employer in the marketplace.
- A project that drives commercial momentum needs a strong foundation to take root both internally and externally. It will gain visibility through several key areas of focus:
- The bank's market positioning,
- Its reputation, shaped by its history, values, and shareholders,
- Its business expertise and competencies, which should be shared with the market through platforms like YouTube and LinkedIn.

The role of communication is to bridge the gap between the bank's public image and what employees experience inside the organization. Be wary of inconsistencies: a local bank may promote a bold, forward-thinking image, yet still require paper files and numerous handwritten signatures to open an account. Meanwhile, other banks have streamlined the process with iPads and digital interfaces. Ensuring consistency between external messaging and internal practices is critical.

A bank's public image is shaped by what it does – and what it does must carry meaning, so that the manager on the front line can use it to support their messaging. Sponsorship is a good example of this, with one caveat: it represents the brand, just like the way sales teams behave reflects the bank's values.

It's helpful to give the commercial momentum concept a visual form to make it more identifiable. Communication plays a key role in moving the project forward by relaying its intent, style, and the voice of leadership.

The following steps help to align brand communication (visibility and reputation) with the commercial momentum project:

- Deliver specialized, high-value services;
- Ensure appropriate visual identity across all publications – both static (such as brochures on the bank and its services) and dynamic (financial proposals, reports, product offerings);
- Strengthen the brand to support client-facing managers
- Showcase internal expertise
- Sharpen core professional skills

- Reinforce entrepreneurial spirit through strong governance
- Demonstrate the bank's strengths and attributes to the market
- Highlight the quality of human resources and training
- Commit to CSR initiatives
- Clarify key principles such as stated and shared values
- Build an event framework for relationship managers
- Use events strategically to drive commercial momentum.

Communication efforts often focus on external audiences, but internal communication is equally vital. For the momentum of the project to build, front-line teams must feel a growing sense of belonging.

One example comes from a small bank that chose to strengthen its internal communication by publishing an internal newsletter (along with a brand book, webinars, and a dedicated intranet page, etc.) to support the project.

D. CREATING THE RIGHT CONDITIONS: SYSTEMS, ENVIRONMENT, AND SPECIFICS

What makes a successful commercial environment for RMs?

Commercial objectives and instructions are clearly communicated.

The necessary tools are available.

Recognition and reward principles are in place and clearly understood.

Technical skills are assessed.

Motivation initiatives are regularly implemented.

Clients are drawn to salespeople who are truly passionate; their energy is infectious.

They also value those who are generous with their time and advice, putting the client's interests first.

Ultimately, the RM's ethical compass must center on aligning client needs with tailored solutions.

7 PRACTICAL WAYS TO ENCOURAGE COMMERCIAL BEHAVIOR

1. Maintain a commercial database with clear segmentation.
2. Ensure that all salespeople are aware of their sales targets.
3. Both results-based and effort-based objectives.
4. Hold sales sessions that include performance checks and pipeline reviews.
5. Organize joint client visits.
6. Run events to "energize" the client portfolio.
7. Develop a marketing plan and a training roadmap for the sales team.

Kindness is like a boomerang;
it has a way of coming back to you.

An expert's perspective[11]

The battle over emotional intelligence!

We all know the joke about an American banker who claimed, "I'd rather hire golfers and teach them banking than the other way around," underscoring the relationship aspect of the profession. I find it quite provocative to reduce the essence of banking to something like golf. Imagine if doctors were judged solely on emotional intelligence rather than their technical diagnostic skills? In my view, three essential elements must come together: first, a very high level of technical knowledge that's constantly updated; second, a broad general culture inspired by the humanities; and third, true emotional intelligence enabling teamwork and an understanding of the client. Only with this demanding stance can you be a specialist (*deep* knowledge), enlightened (*broad* outlook), and client-centered (*horizontal* approach). EI is necessary, but not enough on its own.

Long live general culture!

Is calling for a revival of the humanities old-fashioned? In wealth management, clients often benefit from substantial social and cultural capital. How can you connect with them without the humanities — without having read a few books, without some exposure to the arts, basic knowledge of geopolitics, insight into human behavior, an economic perspective on the world, and, above all, a critical mind?

Being a banker means embodying an ideal of knowledge that transcends the technicalities of the profession. It means embracing a demanding ethos—one that goes far beyond emotional intelligence. It is a way of life where curiosity, raised to the level of a guiding force, fuels lifelong learning.

This way of life is what allows bankers to build genuine rapport with their clients, whether during informal conversations or business meals. I've always wished I could be a fly on the wall during those dull, lifeless exchanges between clients and overly technical bankers at obligatory dinners.

Is this an outdated idea?

In other words, are younger bankers and clients immune to the influence of the humanities? Absolutely not. No one is. And let's not forget that "young people" don't actually exist as a distinct sociological group.

The hype around Millennials and Gen Z, peddled by consultants looking for work, is problematic. After conducting 150 interviews, I came to suspect that Millennials don't actually exist—not as a coherent group, at least—but are

11 **Testimony from Stéphane Haefliger, psychosociologist, Deputy CEO at Vicario Consulting (www.vicario.ch) and university lecturer.** He is the author of the book *DRH et Manager, levez-vous ! Vie et mort des organisations* ("HR Directors and Managers, Rise Up! The Life and Death of Organizations" untranslated), EMS Editions, 2018.

instead a myth manufactured by postmodern management theory. Since then, numerous academic studies have confirmed this hypothesis. Here's a quick summary of what we've learned:

In short, here's what we can say:

1. Yes, young people clearly exist – and they probably have higher expectations than previous generations. After all, Millennials haven't experienced major economic crises, war, high unemployment, or deflation. Raised by affectionate, open-minded parents (which has shaped their relaxed relationship with authority), they've traveled 10 times more than their elders, courtesy of EasyJet, the Bank of Mum and Dad, and the internet.
2. Caution: millennials are not a homogeneous group, and social classes still exist; Marx is still relevant. For example, the son of immigrant workers who settled in Switzerland at six doesn't have the same odds of getting a higher education degree as a typical Swiss kid, whose parents come from the local middle class. So, millennials are really a media construct, not a true sociological category.
3. This "millennial" generation indeed seeks a new work organization, more freedom, the end of petty bosses, clearly defined autonomy, meaningful work, and the elimination of "bullshit jobs," to borrow the title of David Graeber's book. Millennials express these desires, especially during job interviews. Actually, all generations – baby boomers, Gen X, and millennials – want this change in how we work. But since baby boomers and Gen X are running most organizations today, they're not really the ones best suited to push these reforms. This is why generational discourse can be misleading: it obscures the essential truth that all generations today want to establish a new social contract. We're on the cusp of a major, deep change in our relationship with work.

Spring into action!
5 key takeaways and an exercise

FIVE KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. The diverse roles and challenges faced by the relationship manager: acting as advisor, pilot, confidant, among others.
2. Taking active steps toward commercial proactivity.
3. Assessing your sales skills: knowing your strengths and weaknesses and how to measure them.
4. How have our clients changed in the last decade?
5. Relationship managers, armed with emotional intelligence, will become the bank's new therapists!

EXERCICE

Title: Your skills are your strengths!

Aim of the exercise: To become aware of your strengths and areas for improvement.

Instructions:

- List three of your commercial strengths and describe how you will apply them in your next client meeting.
- Identify three areas for improvement in your sales approach.

5

Philosophy

and psychotherapy

for dummies

Navigating two worlds: the rational and the emotional — between philosophy and feeling, psychology and the realities on the ground.

TEACHING OBJECTIVES

After reading this chapter, you will be able to:

- Bring a touch of philosophy to this dog-eat-dog world.
- See the psychotherapist in the private banker (seriously).

Contents table
chapter 5

1 This section is inspired by the excellent course I took with Marius Moutet on the psychology of money.

1. A TOUCH OF PHILOSOPHY[2] IN THIS DOG-EAT-DOG WORLD

But what does philosophy have to do with any of this?

Probably more than you think. In fact, philosophy and negotiating in a banking context have more in common than meets the eye. Each of the five main branches of philosophy[3] has something to say about sales:

1. **Epistemology** looks at how we know something is true.
2. **Metaphysics** explores the nature of "reality."
3. **Ethics** deals with how we value our actions, choices, and relationships.
4. **Logic** studies sound reasoning.
5. **Aesthetics** explores art and beauty.

Philosophy (in the broadest sense of the term) helps us reflect on the world. It shapes how we relate to others. The unique kind of commercial relationship we're talking about needs that kind of perspective – it needs philosophy. Strong, mature human relationships are grounded in thoughtful reflection. When a relationship manager steps back and thinks about the meaning of their commercial actions, they're engaging in philosophy without even realizing it!

He'll find himself entering very personal territory, wanting to understand the reasoning and deeper roots behind his client's decisions.

He'll be able to anticipate not only their "*capacity for reasoning and analysis in pursuit of truth*"[4] but also what is likely to appeal to the client – and what they'll almost certainly reject. This kind of relationship opens the door to **both down-to-earth** conversations and philosophical debates.

A client's profile has two dimensions:

- The first is biographical: the life stages they've been through, their current financial situation, family, and professional status.
- The second is psychological, including risk tolerance, attitude toward money, stress response in relation to investments, and their overall philosophy on life.
- Profiling is strategic; getting it wrong can change the nature of the advice provided. Continuous review is key to avoid misinterpretation, either by the adviser or the client.

We all come from our childhood.[5]

2 Larousse definition: "A set of conceptions concerning the principles of beings and things, and the role of Man in the universe."
3 Theresa Lukose, M.S. in Psychology and Philosophy, Columbia University, 2020.
4 Socrates' definition of philosophy.
5 Louis Shorderet

Creating a profile means putting a face to someone you don't really know.

It's a serious responsibility that requires a meaningful relational process.

The manager will hold up a mirror to the client, but it won't be the one from Snow White.

A. WHY IS THE PHILOSOPHICAL ARGUMENT SO COMPELLING?

Philosophy, as we approach it in this chapter, is a guiding principle – a "way of life" – that can underpin commercial interactions. Shared references provide a reassuring basis for evaluating the quality of what's being offered.

Many banks express their investment philosophy through their investment strategy. It answers the question: what conceptual foundations will guide our work?

Does having an investment philosophy help you sell more intelligently?

Yes, in a way. There's nothing cynical about this approach – quite the opposite, it's grounded in psychological reality. A client may think: If my adviser operates according to standards and values I share, that's a reason to see them as trustworthy.

B. WHAT DOES AN INVESTMENT PHILOSOPHY LOOK LIKE IN PRACTICE?

This refers to a clearly defined position on the financial practices the bank relies on to provide advice to its clients.

Examples of such positions include:

- A critique of mainstream financial thinking (see BCGE's investment philosophy document on www.bcge.ch).
- A doctrinal standpoint offering principles presented as fundamental truths.
- Basic assumptions for investment decisions, like "broad diversification increases return and reduces risk." Choosing a philosophy thus establishes a strategic framework for the bank. If the client understands this philosophy, they are more likely to accept the bank's advice.

In principle, all decisions and subsequent proposals should be based on the theoretical foundation provided by the investment philosophy.

AN EXAMPLE OF AN INVESTMENT PHILOSOPHY
(BASED ON AND ADAPTED FROM A SWISS FINANCIAL INSTITUTION)

Here are the four pillars of our investment philosophy, all designed to serve our clients:

1. The bank's mission is to preserve our clients' wealth while helping it grow.
2. We carefully select products that align with the client's intentions.
3. Our asset allocation reflects rational, well-founded convictions.
4. Our investments are never left to chance; they are both manageable and deliberately managed.

C. HOW CAN YOUR BANK ESTABLISH AN INVESTMENT PHILOSOPHY?

A bank's investment philosophy can be presented to clients as a set of clear positions on the following points:

1. The bank's approach to its clients when it comes to investing their money.
2. Its vision of the financial world.
3. How investments relate to the real world, including the economy and ESG (Environmental, Social, and Governance)
4. Its guiding principles and preferred investment strategies.
5. The bank's basic assumptions and key selection criteria – what it chooses to do and what it avoids.
6. The bank's view of performance.
7. How it selects the tools and strategies to achieve that performance.
8. The ethical guidelines and codes of conduct governing all private client interactions. (With reference to FINMA's Code: "Employees of FINMA are expected to act with integrity, preserving its reputation and credibility, and avoiding any behavior that may damage it." Article 2 of the FINMA Code of Conduct, Swiss Financial Market Supervisory Authority).

If it is written down and shared (for example, on a website), it will carry even more weight. Wealth managers can then use it as a sales resource in their opening meetings with clients.

D. HOW CAN IT BE USED IN PRIVATE BANKING CLIENT RELATIONSHIPS?

The investment philosophy serves as a sales pitch.

The client receives and understands the message in various ways:

- We have given thoughtful consideration to our work.
- We clearly state that we act with the client's best interests as our priority.
- We take a clear position and stand by our convictions.
- We provide genuine value by sharing our considered views.
- We ensure adherence to ethical codes, such as confidentiality and avoiding conflicts of interest.

However, there can be pitfalls.

The wealth manager holds a position involving various roles that might lead to ambiguities:

- He has commercial responsibilities, such as attracting new clients and increasing managed funds.
- He acts as an advisor and must maintain closeness with his client.
- He has duties toward his employer.
- His goals might be overly ambitious, risking undue commercial influence.
- He needs to strike a balance between technical skills and
- likability.

INSIGHTS

These five excerpts from a recent client satisfaction survey, conducted ahead of a seminar on proactive sales for a Geneva bank, highlight discrepancies between client experiences and the bank's stated philosophy[6]:

1. When I asked a question, the teller merely directed me to the brochures on display.
2. A consultant met with me for an hour and a half, and then I never heard from them again.
3. The relationship manager couldn't answer my question right away. He promised to call back within two hours; I'm still waiting.
4. When I signed my investment contract, it felt special to me, but my advisor just went through the motions and didn't notice a thing.
5. I need people who are positive, who take an interest in me, who explain things…

6 The Principled Negotiation Model (Harvard Negotiation Project)

E. THE CONCEPT OF A COMMERCIAL PHILOSOPHY

Philosophy refers to professional ethics.

A bank can establish principles of conduct within its investment philosophy. How does it develop its advice, and how is that advice delivered?

This applies equally to its commercial philosophy, which defines the ethical boundaries and standards of conduct for sales interactions. The relationship manager communicates and upholds these values, openly sharing the moral foundations that shape their approach:

"This is how I work — does that work for you too?"

The seven core «philosophical» principles put forward by R. Fisher and W. Ury[7]:

1. **A cooperative solution is better than an authoritarian one.**
2. A solution is built on the trust capital generated by both parties.
3. A strong agreement is a source of mutual benefit.
4. Work together to find and create a solution acceptable to both sides.
5. Ensure both parties take part in the decision-making process while protecting mutual interests as best as possible.
6. Reject one-sided agreements that may lead to poor relations in the future.
7. Aim for a sustainable, win–win agreement.

The concept of a commercial philosophy encompasses a structured process (a kind of model) outlining the steps a relationship manager follows to assess client needs and present appropriate proposals.

Strategic questioning is a key part of this process.

IS NEGOTIATION ABOUT COOPERATION OR COMPETITION?

During a *competition*, two sides fight to win. On the other hand, *cooperation* involves both parties working together, aiming to succeed and achieve shared goals.

If negotiators fail to understand that cooperation is the best approach, one party may adopt a combative stance while the other attempts to cooperate and this mismatch won't work.
Cooperation allows for two winners and helps build a foundation of trust.

Gain more together, rather than gain more than the other.

7 The Principled Negotiation Model, Harvard Negotiation Project).

THE COOPERATIVE VERSUS THE HOSTILE APPROACH

HOSTILE	COOPERATIVE
The seller pursues their own goals	Shared interest is the priority
Distrust is the norm	Compromise is the norm
Short term	Long term
Aggressive style	Cooperative style
The seller is pushy	The seller asks questions and explores
No information sharing	Transparency and information sharing

Are there other options other than win-win?

I win You lose	**I win You win**
I lose You lose	I lose You win

The answer is NO!

The buying intent is matched by another force: the manager's drive to sell. Ideally, the client's need to buy and the manager's desire to sell should be in equal balance – one party wants to close a deal, the other to solve a problem.

In a negotiation, this is a false balance. There is an inherent power dynamic in any negotiation: the client can always choose to say, "no deal."

The cost of doing so is lower for the client than for the manager. Only the client can say:

"I need to compare the offers and conditions from another bank with yours..." At this point, the stakes of the negotiation change.

How can you become the client's only real option? This is where the concept of a USP (*Unique Selling Proposition*) comes into play, which forms the essential foundation of your sales pitch.

F. THE PHILOSOPHY OF RELATIONSHIP-BUILDING, OR THE MANAGER'S POSITIVE MINDSET

What positive mindset should a relationship manager adopt?

We chose to answer this question using a method known as "Appreciative Inquiry"[8]. This approach helps individuals reach their goals by focusing on what generates positivity.

In companies, it usually involves interviews and research. We'll focus here on the types of behavior that reflect this mindset.

Appreciative Inquiry is based on three core principles:

- Life is a continuous act of creation, not merely a struggle for survival.
- Our purpose leans more toward creating than protecting.
- Every step we take helps create the world around us.

Appreciative Inquiry encourages the practitioner to value every relationship and to recognize what is best around us. It is about affirming strengths and celebrating successes in order to unlock their full potential. It naturally gravitates toward what energizes a relationship – its vitality, well-being, and the quality of its interactions.

Inquiry means exploring, staying curious, asking the right questions, and staying open to potential.

"We cannot solve our problems with the same thinking we used when we created them." (Albert Einstein)

Appreciative Inquiry is based on five principles, which serve as a counterpart to more traditional commercial exploration.[9]

1. Constructionist Principle: The future of the relationship depends on mutual understanding.
2. Anticipatory Principle: The way we envision the future shapes present behavior.
3. Positive Principle: The more positive the questions, the greater the impact. Simply asking a question influences the outcome.
4. Congruence Principle: "Be the change you wish to see in the world." (Gandhi)
5. Free Choice Principle: People are more committed to decisions they make for themselves.

Appreciative Inquiry is grounded in a positive philosophy. It assumes that in any relationship, something is always working well – and this is what should be highlighted first.

8 David Cooper Rider and Suresh Srivastva, 1987.
9 Inspired by the presentation and course on Appreciative Inquiry by Pascal Godivier (2004)..

The other is seen as a mystery to be uncovered,
It offers a vision of what could be,
It opens a dialog about what should be,
It leads to the creation of what will be.

2. WHAT IS AN EMOTION?

If you're going to talk about selling, you've got to talk about emotions. Selling is all about connection, and emotions are what drive that connection.

Emotion is a response to stimulation. It affects the body, with the ability to cause mental distress, joy, excitement; it brings the whole body to life.

The word "emotion" comes from the Latin *ex-movere*, meaning "to move outward," the same root as "motivation" (also a form of movement).

Emotion carries with it an element of spontaneity that is often beyond our control.

In a bank, the client inevitably experiences emotions. These emotional responses can serve as valuable indicators for those who know how to read them.

Clients may feel fear when faced with an unfamiliar environment, anxiety over decisions whose consequences are unclear, or feel confused by the volume of figures and data shared by their wealth manager.

Emotions give rise to mental states the wealth manager must learn to recognize. It is part of their role to prioritize the client's emotional state, much like a psychotherapist would. To exploit these emotions for sales purposes, without stepping back or reflecting, would be ethically questionable.

PRIMARY EMOTIONS	VARIANTS AND RELATED EMOTIONS	CLIENT'S EMOTIONAL STATE	CLIENT'S NEED	WEALTH MANAGER'S RESPONSE
Fear	Worry, suspicion.	Anxiety, nervousness, sweating, anguish, panic.	Needs reassurance and clarity. Feels a strong need to retain autonomy in decision-making and to avoid pressure.	Is there a danger, a threat, or any concern for my client? Fear should not be used as a springboard.
Anger	Annoyance, irritation, unhappiness, dissatisfaction.	Aggression, raised voice.	Need to feel respected and heard, to experience fairness.	Understand the source of the anger. Always keep your promises.
Sadness	Disappointment, failure, frustration, loss, grief.	Withdrawal, silence, emotional shock.	Need for compassion. Help them to bounce back and start again.	Support the client in moving beyond fear toward acceptance.
Joy	Achievement, satisfaction, happiness, receptiveness.	Shows initiative and self-confidence.	Desires acknowledgment and the opportunity to celebrate success.	Reinforce the client's choices and congratulate them on their achievements.

The manager must train themselves to instinctively detect the client's emotions. Existing techniques tend to rely on the feeling one develops in a sales setting: observing, perceiving, and probing. Observations can be structured around the three Vs:

- **Visual:** What are they showing me?

Their gestures, reactions, facial expressions, and body posture.

- **Verbal:** What are they telling me?

The words they use, how they respond verbally to my proposals, and how they express doubts or concerns.

- **Vocal:** How are they speaking?

Their tone of voice, volume, pace, and breathing.

Emotional slots

We need to actively look for them. A "slot" is a time slot in aviation (one the pilot must not miss). In this context, a slot is the moment the client offers me the chance to engage with them emotionally – the crucial moment. When a slot appears, I must not miss it.

Clients tend to fill the space the wealth manager sets aside for them. If the salesperson leads them into technical territory, that's where they'll stay.

But if they gently move together into emotional territory, the client will follow. That's where trust is created.

In a negotiation, **the emotions experienced**[10] (either by the client or by the wealth manager), can lead to indecision regarding the purchase. These emotions can sometimes complicate the needs analysis stage.

How can the wealth manager control their own emotions? How can they support their client's emotions?

The author of this article asks four questions.

1. HOW DO YOU WANT TO FEEL WHEN BEGINNING A NEGOTIATION?

Emotions can be mixed, but it's important to be calm and composed to pass that on to the people you're negotiating with.

At the same time, you need to stay sharp and ready to spot any chance, keeping your senses alert to avoid errors; a calm and creative mindset paired with being proactive and patient.

Can you have both at the same time?

Absolutely! That's what commercial emotional intelligence is all about—finding and keeping that balance.

2. WHAT CAN YOU DO BEFOREHAND TO GET INTO THE RIGHT FRAME OF MIND?

If you've ever competed in sports, you'll know that getting mentally ready is what helps you switch into the emotional state you need.

How?

By starting with simple things, like breathing deeply and focusing on positive memories. Each person has their own way of relaxing and getting into a positive mindset before starting a sale.

Whatever works for you, treat it as your personal mantra for success in building strong client relationships.

10 Harvard Business Review, January-February 2013. Kimberlyn Leary, associate professor of psychology.

3. WHAT MIGHT THROW YOU OFF BALANCE YOU DURING A NEGOTIATION?

The same situation can trigger wildly different reactions. Some people show great patience, while others quickly become frustrated. Reflecting on this question is another form of mental preparation.

We're always trying to reduce the inconsistencies between our actions and our attitudes.

4. HOW CAN YOU REGAIN YOUR COMPOSURE MIDWAY THROUGH A NEGOTIATION?

To steer the negotiation back on track and create a more constructive dynamic, consider interrupting the flow. How can you reset a conversation that's taken a wrong turn?

- Pause the conversation.
- Step away from the negotiating table with a (positive) pretext.
- Change the subject.
- Step back from a specific detail and raise the conversation to a broader principle or process.

If your behavior is becoming reactive, controlled breathing is a reliable method to regain composure.

Amy Cuddy[11] *showed that standing tall, with feet wide apart and arms extended, increases testosterone—the hormone linked to confidence and risk-taking—in both men and women. Equally important, this posture lowers cortisol, the hormone associated with anxiety. This is known as adopting a "power pose."*

11 American psychosociologist specializing in postures and body language (TED Talk).

A. COMMON EMOTIONAL STATES IN INVESTOR CLIENTS AND HOW TO RESPOND[12] :

TYPE OF CLIENT	EMOTIONAL STATE	POSSIBLE REASONS FOR THEIR EMOTIONAL STATE	POSSIBLE CLIENT REACTIONS	WEALTH MANAGER RESPONSES
Dissatisfied	Disappointed, feels betrayed or let down.	The client has suffered significant financial losses or unprofitable investments.	Threatens to leave.	Provide explanations, put things into context, and remind them of initial decisions.
Cautious planner	Worried and anxious, fearful about the future.	A client nearing retirement, anticipating reduced income.	Hesitates, doesn't sign, procrastinates.	Avoid applying pressure; make sure the client feels in full control of their decisions.
Intimidated, inexperienced	Lacks experience, feels overwhelmed by an unfamiliar field.	A client who has inherited wealth and is not used to managing large sums.	May react impulsively or withdraw and become very reserved.	Be educational, clearly explain the investment process. Take twice as much time if needed.
Prudent	The "responsible family man" type – does not want to take risks.	Seeks solid solutions and a trusting relationship.	Moves slowly, gathers full info on bank and wealth manager.	Take time to explain thoroughly and compare all options.
Knowledgeable	Confident, sees himself as an expert.	Knows exactly what he wants.	Makes decisions quickly.	Questions the rationale behind client decisions.
Loyal	Calm, composed, and confident in the relationship.	Thinks ahead, with a very positive history with their banker.	Says: "Do as you would for yourself."	Show appreciation. Take every precaution; nothing is guaranteed.
Anxious	Hesitates over short-term decisions.	Fears making the wrong choice for their needs.	Persists but won't commit; puts of making decisions.	Clarify all options, provide written summaries, reassure them. Help them decide.

12 Largely inspired by the commercial proactivity training materials from a bank in Lausanne, 2004. Facilitated by Fabien Smadja and JJ Schnegg.

B. DES CAS PRATIQUES POUR VOUS EXERCER. COMMENT RÉAGIRIEZ-VOUS ?

Case Study #1: Misunderstanding the risk/return trade-off

Your client is a highly skilled entrepreneur but has limited knowledge of banking. He says it's time to be aggressive ("buy when there's blood in the streets"). He demands higher returns but is unwilling to accept any increase in risk. He doesn't fully understand the risk/return relationship.

Case Study #2: A difficult family situation (divorce)

Your client is feeling very low as he is going through a difficult divorce. He has two young children and two older children from a previous marriage. His wife knows about his relationship with your bank but has no financial information. He wants to maintain a good relationship with his soon-to-be ex-wife for the sake of their young children. He is already actively involved as a father to his older children.

Case Study #3: Positioning and competitor offer

Your client, passing through Geneva, was approached in his home country by a manager from a competing bank. This manager made an excellent impression. Because he travels extensively for work, he is attracted by the competitor's global reach and trading operations. He wants to know what sets your bank apart.

How would you prepare for each of these cases?

- Outline the client's emotional profile.
- Identify the client's notable behaviors.
- Determine the appropriate communication style.
- List the questions to ask.
- List the information to provide.
- Take note of cues from body language.

Becoming "emotionally intelligent"[13] means not only staying rational during interactions but also recognizing and accepting your own emotions in order to manage them effectively.

Acceptance must be without value judgment – a clear-eyed, uncompromising acknowledgment of what is felt. The wealth manager must find the right balance between intelligence and emotion, and between reflection and action.

13 Daniel Goleman.

This table outlines the pros and cons of the wealth manager expressing their emotions in the sales relationship:

ROOT EMOTION	ADVANTAGES	DISADVANTAGES
Fear	Avoid taking excessive risks; know when to let go or stop.	Avoid asking intrusive questions; may unsettle the client or lead to reluctance closing the deal.
Joy	Infectious enthusiasm; builds trust; drives action and results.	Loss of control and discernment; risks losing credibility if overly enthusiastic.
Sadness	Compassion, empathy.	Emotional distancing; risk of over-identification.
Anger	Expressing disagreements; clearing the air.	Inaction, standstill.

C. THE THREE EMOTIONAL MANAGEMENT REFLEXES TO USE IN MEETINGS

1. Be aware of your emotions and those of your client

- What am I feeling right now?
- What might my client be feeling at this moment, and why?
- What emotions could the information I just shared or the question I just asked trigger?

2. Investigate your client's emotional state

- How do you feel hearing this information?
- Does this question bother you? (And why)
- I noticed you reacted to my question – can you tell me why?

3. Build on your client's emotions

- Which emotions motivate them to take action?
- Which emotions could be harmful to my client?

Identifying Your Own Emotions

We all have emotions that shape what we do.

Emotions influence or control decisions in commercial relationships, particularly in wealth management. Recognizing and identifying your own emotions at every moment during an interaction is the cornerstone of emotional intelligence.

If the wealth manager is unaware of the emotions they feel or evoke, they're left at the mercy of their deeper feelings.

Channeling one's emotions enables focus on the client and motivates the relationship as well as self-motivation.

Canaliser ses émotions permet de se concentrer sur son client et motiver la relation autant que de s'automotiver.

A new door opens

Managing one's own emotions and understanding those of others are key elements in private wealth management relationships. This, too, requires practice. Business and negotiation relationships based on a genuine desire to understand the other's world and meet their needs tend to be productive and lasting. Emotions hold only the power we allow them during an exchang.

The risk is that a client might become overwhelmed by their own emotions and fail to grasp the rationality of our arguments.

Another strategy for managing client emotions is to prevent them from surfacing too abruptly. How? By structuring the discussion framework – setting objectives, timing, methods, and so on – rather than letting the conversation run freely.

D. WHICH EMOTIONS ARE AT PLAY DURING A CLIENT INTERACTION

They fall into two categories:

The client's emotions: These may be openly expressed or lie beneath the surface. When a client expresses or reveals an emotion, that moment becomes a lasting memory in their relationship with the adviser. The adviser must support the client in bringing that emotion to the surface by offering space for it to emerge.

The wealth manager's emotions: These are used to demonstrate sincerity and openness, with the potential to act as a catalyst and even deepen the relationship.

If the client brings up the competition, the adviser doesn't take it personally.

They discuss it openly, asking honest questions and showing emotional control. Their emotions are a tool for deepening the relationship.

If I open up, the client will too!

Trust is built through the wealth manager's ability to identify and respond to the client's underlying emotions. This includes any emotional tension they may be carrying.

The real difference between two banks lies in their people and their social skills.

From a technical standpoint, most offers are similar.

When you stay on technical ground, you're competing on level terms with everyone else.

OBSERVATION

Entering the realm of emotional management is what sets you apart. It is the wealth manager's unique emotional territory. What's more, it's one that competitors cannot access!

The product (the technical aspect) is not the client's goal (it is ours); it is merely a means to achieve their goal, their dream, or project.

It's better to understand the bigger picture than to get lost in the details.

Example of a difficult emotional moment

An adviser wins back funds from a client previously held at another bank. The client explains his decision.

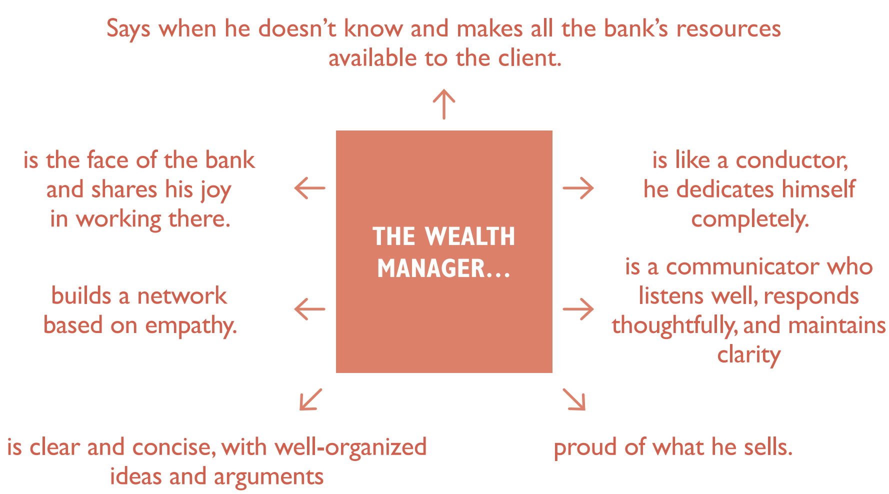
"It's because in our last meeting, you told me I had a nice Longines watch." The wealth manager was surprised that such a small detail had influenced the client's decision. He asked for an explanation, and the client replied,

"It was given to me by my late wife."

This true story may seem trivial, yet it perfectly illustrates emotional intelligence – the world of detail and subtlety.

"Power by its nature expands until it reaches its limits" (Montesquieu)

Emotional dimensions that build trust



Which behaviors lead to distrust?

- Preaching, not keeping promises, and irritability.
- A lack of knowledge of the bank's products.
- Incompetence, dishonesty, pushy sales tactics, evasiveness, arrogance, sarcasm, and treating clients condescendingly.

3. THE WEALTH MANAGER AND SELF-AWARENESS

Why should we be so transparent with our clients?
True intelligence means being self-aware – aware of one's emotions and reactions in order to respond with balance. A manager who recognizes and shares what genuinely moves him can create a deeper, more sincere connection with clients. It is through a personality grounded in self-awareness that the manager will earn the client's trust.

"Know thyself and you shall know the universe and the Gods" (Socrates).

A. IDENTIFYING CRUCIAL MOMENTS IN CLIENT INTERACTIONS

It's the point in the client relationship when a strong emotion is felt. This key moment matters because, depending on its intensity, the client will remember it vividly.

Recognizing key moments – through experience or training – is essential for a wealth manager. They must learn to identify them easily. A positive emotional moment often precedes a decision to invest; a negative one may result in the client walking away.

How can you create a key moment in a sales discussion?

- Give the client a sense of being recognized in who they are and what they need.
- Show that you truly understand them.
- Keep linking back to their personal history.
- Take every chance to make proactive suggestions.

These key moments often arise from emotional strain, such as when:

- A client faces heavy financial losses.
- The client inherits a large amount of money and feels overwhelmed.
- They are dealing with a sensitive financial transition, such as selling a business, going through a divorce, or entering retirement.
- The client overestimates their technical knowledge.

The power of visualization and the selfless gesture

A STORY IS WORTH A THOUSAND WORDS…

A driver was on the motorway between Geneva and Lausanne, driving at a steady 120 km/h. Near the Morges exit, a thick bank of fog appeared. The driver slowed down cautiously; he could barely see a thing. If the fog had been any thicker, he might have had to stop altogether.

That's how human behavior works too: when we lose visibility, we instinctively slow down.

Clients are more motivated when they have visibility:

- Clearly outline the next steps.
- Keep the client regularly informed, even if they don't ask; information provides reassurance and keeps them engaged.

A human-centered or utilitarian approach?

Acts of generosity in client relationships carry a virtuous quality and practical benefit – they are long-term investments.

Good relationship managers are generous by nature and avoid being overly transactional.

If you invite a client to an event, don't necessarily expect anything in return.

Being proactive means acting in full view of the client.

B. THE EMOTIONAL ROLLERCOASTER IN CLIENT RELATIONSHIPS

A rollercoaster moves through highs and lows – that's its nature. This metaphor illustrates a warning in the sales relationship: it descends into negative emotions before climbing back to positive ones.

Two examples:

1. When fear grips a client, they show it by postponing decisions, evading conversations, or leaving matters hanging. The way to address this fear is through closeness. Just as parents soothe their children by holding them tight, eliminating all distance, closeness is a human act of reassurance.
2. Certain financial products bring clients into an emotional space: for example, succession planning, family-involved products, and those that enhance the bond within the relationship.

It's during the rollercoaster's downward plunge that clients feel the strain. Here are some of the dips they may experience:

- Fear of losing their capital and its ripple effect on their standard of living.
- The uncertainty of a financial world they don't fully understand.
- Feeling powerless when markets fall.
- Being thrown out of their comfort zone.
- Having their financial beliefs shaken when confronted with hard truths and their expectations turn out to be wrong.
- Contexts beyond our control, such as the stock market, legal changes, geopolitical events, or economic fluctuations.
- Regret and remorse for not following the wealth manager's recommendations, disappointment at a missed goal, and a sense of betrayal by a business partner.
- A lack of reliability.

To offset the ups and downs of the emotional rollercoaster, it's essential to put everything in writing, especially when future tensions are foreseeable. Structured protocols and written reports should record all commitments, along with clear timelines and deadlines.

4. REVERSE PSYCHOLOGY… BUT GENTLY DOES IT

Doing the opposite can spark creativity, whether you're asking the opposite question, making a bold counterstatement, or flipping a demonstration on its head. These a contrario tactics go against the grain and help free up thinking.

- What do you absolutely NOT want?
- What don't you like?
- What did you feel was missing?
- What mistakes would you definitely want to avoid repeating?

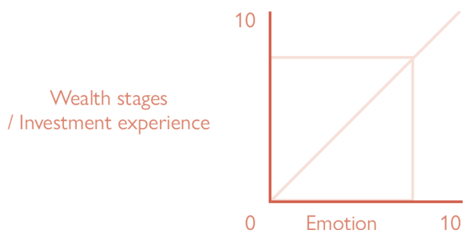
Reverse psychology can be seen as a subtle form of manipulation, as it seeks to influence someone's behavior through an indirect and often misleading approach. It works by playing on expectations and emotional responses, deliberately suggesting the opposite of what is actually desired.

A concrete example: offering a conclusion at the very start of the conversation is one way to apply reverse psychology. The conversation might go something like this: "*Feel free to say no if you feel I'm missing the mark — I'd rather we didn't end with a vague 'I'll think about it'.*" It's a bold move, but one worth trying.

Why is reverse psychology sometimes considered manipulative? Here are a few reasons:

1. **Deliberate subterfuge:** It often involves deliberately ambiguous language or suggestions designed to provoke a specific response.
2. **Psychological games:** It plays on human tendencies like defiance or resistance to authority.
3. **It's indirect:** Instead of clearly stating a desire, it takes a roundabout approach to reach the intended goal.
4. **Concealed intention:** The person using reverse psychology appears to say the opposite of what they actually want, hiding their true intent.
5. **Potential for misuse:** While it can be harmless in some contexts, reverse psychology can also be used to mislead or manipulate, undermining the other person's freedom of choice.

There is a link between the stages of wealth management and a client's emotional sensitivity. In other words, the more investment experience a client has, the more attuned they become to the human side of the relationship.



Sensory pathways to emotion

What we feel in a relationship is closely tied to our sensory perception of it. A strong first impression lays the foundation for trust.

Perception is shaped by the information we gather through our senses: sight, hearing, touch, and taste. A relationship manager who greets a client warmly with a smile (sight), a few kind words (hearing), a handshake with a light touch on the forearm (touch), and a coffee accompanied by a small chocolate (taste), increases the likelihood of creating a positive emotional response.

Attitude reflects an individual's intent. It can be described as a general disposition or a specific behavior. When intent and action align, we experience consonance. When they are misaligned, dissonance can occur, and this creates discomfort.

We recommend including descriptions of positive client attitudes in a sort of commercial behavior glossary (consonance).

5. THE DELICATE ART OF DISCUSSING MONEY[14]

Everyone agrees, although it's sometimes a taboo subject, yet it's exactly what a relationship manager must address with their clients.

What tone should you adopt? What stance should you take?

Money is part of our life stories. It's a social marker and one of the ways we measure our professional progress.

1. Money has an emotional dimension.

While for banks money is a product, for clients, it's something else entirely.

Its emotional weight is ever-present. Each person attaches their own meaning to the money they hold.

For some, it enables their dreams; for others, it's a source of stress.

Historically, money has been a strategic driver—fueling wars, trade, and growth.

As the saying goes:

"Money is the lifeblood of war."

2. Reflecting on money brings us back to our needs, life story, and worldview. When a client talks about their money, they reveal their relationship with possessions and the material world. What people say about their finances often reveals their attitudes, especially their fears about losing what they have or not having enough.

A client's ability to tolerate fluctuations in their capital gives us valuable insight into the level of risk they are willing to take.

This is why it's important to ask private banking clients about their relationship with money.

3. Many wealth managers have observed that once the money taboo is out of the way, real, open conversations with the client can finally happen.

Conversely, if this topic is still perceived as uncomfortable, then other subjects also become difficult to address openly – and therefore professionally – such as:

- inheritance,
- complex family situations,
- funds invested outside your bank,
- how the client's wealth was built,
- detailed aspects of the client's lifestyle (expenses, spending, various sources of income).

14 This section is inspired by Marius Moutet's excellent course on the psychology of money.

How can we free ourselves from feeling awkward about these conversations?

By reading this chapter twice…

By thinking about your own relationship with money and take a moment to reflect.

By anticipating a negative reaction from the client.

By looking at how money is managed day-to-day in your family; it's a helpful benchmark.

Money often acts as a way to exert control in personal relationships. If you sit down with your partner to review finances, you'll find plenty of disagreements. Try making spending plans together, and the same issues arise.

Discussions about money tend to amplify power struggles in a relationship and reveal the stance of those involved. They also highlight each person's autonomy.

In private wealth management, these issues come to the fore when topics like inheritance and wealth transfer are discussed.

By investigating the client's family history, the manager can learn about money stories spanning generations, from which they can infer transmitted frustrations, differing perceptions of heirs' fortunes, resentments, and grudges.

The wealth manager's role is first to act as an outside advisor, keeping a respectful distance while upholding ethical principles. Sometimes, clients in distress may cast the manager in roles such as therapist, father figure, or notary – roles that can be tough to step away from later.

It's important for the wealth manager to quickly recognize relational games, especially power struggles within the family. Paying attention to behavior, body language, and signs of resistance can reveal challenges ahead. Right from the beginning, the manager should make it clear that sensitive matters like money, family, and inheritance need to be addressed to foster a healthy, lasting relationship.

At the casino: place your bets!

As part of a psychosociology experiment[15] , we worked with young relationship managers from a private bank in Geneva. During a sales seminar near a casino, we invited them to observe how gamblers interacted with the game. They were told not to bet more than 20 CHF, so they could personally experience the feelings involved. We asked two simple questions:

15 At a seminar co-hosted with Yvan Constantin.

What behaviors and emotions did they experience?

They spent part of their evening at the casino. The experience was eye-opening for their work.

Below are some thoughts shared during the feedback meeting the following morning:

- *We sensed an atmosphere that felt unhealthy. As bankers, it was almost shocking. The behaviors all seemed distorted, tainted by greed, lacking any elegance.*
- *There is a close connection between actions and the hope for very short-term gain.*
- *Some players even play at two tables at once; their behavior seems unusual. Recognizing the facial expression typical of this extreme conduct was a useful lesson.*
- *What motivates the player? What are their ambitions? The environment seems to push them along while clouding their judgment.*
- *One thing is certain after this observation: playing at a casino is not capital investment. All managers should face this experience.*
- *There's a stark difference between games of chance and strategic games (like chess or Go). Strategic games involve thoughtful human intervention, which is absent in games of chance.*
- *We felt a lot of tension related to money.*
- *The timing is so different between the short-term nature of the casino, which is nothing more than the gratification of a vice, and the long-term relationship of wealth management at a bank.*

What lessons were learned from the experience?

- *A wealth manager should focus on one project at a time for their client.*
- *The manager must be present and available, so the client never feels alone in managing their wealth.*
- *It's essential to know what really drives your client when it comes to money.*
- *Always distinguish between gambling and investing— only investing is a deliberate, serious act.*
- *Take the time to explain both the risk-return ratio and the time horizon involved in investment decisions.*
- *Discuss the differences in timeframes between the client and the bank.*

We'll close this chapter with two powerful emotional accounts from two female wealth managers.

***How much importance do you place on emotions in your negotiations?*[16]**

Whether we like it or not, emotions are part of life and are always present; they are triggered by our thoughts, and during a negotiation, both parties inevitably experience emotions. Learning to manage them is, of course, essential. Emotional regulation is something we begin learning in childhood, but as adults, not everyone reaches the same level of emotional maturity. Managing our emotions begins with knowing how to name them.

For a long time, I found it very difficult to identify a particularly unpleasant emotion I felt after a meeting that didn't result in a signed agreement: the fear of rejection.

As a relationship manager in a private bank, my first negotiation with a prospective client is to open an account. This always involves a meeting, and usually, the prospect decides at the end whether or not to move forward. What's being negotiated or sold isn't just the bank, its fees, and its products – it's also the "privileged" relationship with the relationship manager, in other words, with me. There are, of course, objective and measurable elements involved, but also a deeply subjective dimension. The prospect needs to feel a genuine desire to enter into what may be a long-term relationship with their adviser. In the end, whether they choose to sign or not, the decision always stirs strong emotions in me, both positive and negative, because I inevitably take it personally.

I'd say this is the most difficult emotional aspect to manage, and it lingers despite years of experience – even though one gains perspective over time.

I often meet prospects at times of stress, both positive or negative. The decision to open an account with a new bank usually follows a major life event: an inheritance, the sale of a business, an expatriation, a divorce, or the launch of a new venture. In these emotionally charged moments, clients may make impulsive or extreme decisions. Or, conversely, they may feel paralyzed and stuck in a state of indecision.

Cultural factors also play a key role. Many of my clients are local businesspeople and often quite sensitive and emotionally reactive, especially when they're out of their comfort zone or feeling out of their depth.

When they come to the bank, these emotions can lead them to make decisions that aren't in their best interest.

At the start of a meeting, it's best to set things straight, calming any tensions, provide clear guidance, and rebuild the client's trust with full transparency. By remaining calm myself, I was able to refocus the discussion, and through empathy, help find the best solution.

To sum up, I think experience has helped me to better recognize, grasp, and control a key emotion I often feel (fear of rejection) as well as that of my clients (a kind of macho sensitivity).

16 Text by Juliette, a wealth manager and student in my negotiation course, EMBA, 2021.

What's your ideal behavioral approach to negotiation?

When everything clicks into place, when the arguments come naturally, and you sense real progress, the feeling is one of intellectual satisfaction. Ideally, you want to bring the client into that same positive energy. However, in reality, things don't always go that way, and energy levels aren't always high.

In my view, achieving this begins with laying the groundwork: preparing thoroughly, treating the other party with full respect, and knowing how to use every tool that can help steer and support the negotiation process.

I would also add that knowing yourself well can be a powerful behavioral strategy — it allows you to stay in control of the situation by managing the agenda effectively.

I've noticed that I'm much more motivated to call clients and sell products on Monday mornings than on Friday afternoons. It makes sense to plan the week around recurring energy levels.

We keep the time slots with low energy levels for administrative tasks and reserve the times when we have the most positive energy for important customer interactions. Save your lower-energy periods for administrative work, and dedicate your most energetic, positive moments to meaningful client engagement.

There's no way I could have organized things like this early in my career. And nowadays, it's even harder, given that we're constantly connected to clients – thanks to, or because of, instant messaging.

An expert's perspective

Learning to be rich

Marc stands to inherit a considerable fortune. For the last five years, he's been in charge of managing his father's wealth. While his father built his fortune through intelligence and hard work, he raised his children with a sense of restraint, treating money almost as a taboo and spending only what was strictly necessary. The family had significant wealth, yet they lived modestly. Now, as Marc navigates his new role, he is struck by the scale of what he's managing. Old patterns from his upbringing resurface, influencing his judgment and sometimes leading to irrational choices. It might sound strange, but being wealthy is something you have to learn.

Today, Marc's lack of financial learning is evident in his behavior as an investor. He exhibits several well-known behavioral biases recognized in the financial world. These observations also serve as valuable advice for individuals who come into wealth. Let's take a closer look at a few of Marc's habits:

- Marc lacked a basic financial education; he was never introduced to core concepts such as saving, investing, or debt management.
- He was not taught how to invest in financial markets, real estate, or businesses—assets that can potentially outperform inflation and support long-term capital growth.
- His father didn't pass on an investor's mindset, or the discipline needed to manage wealth, such as income diversification or prudent financial planning.
- He holds a high opinion of his own intellect, yet lacks the humility to listen to financial experts, making constructive dialog more difficult.
- He may fall victim to the Dunning-Kruger effect, where people overrate their financial know-how and make choices without fully understanding their gaps. He could also be overconfident, trusting his decisions too much despite little hands-on investing experience, which leads to underestimating risks.
- He frequently takes a short-term approach, looking for quick wins rather than focusing on long-term gains. Financial decisions tend to be driven by the desire for instant gratification instead of sustainable growth strategies.
- Confirmation bias. His overconfidence and lack of complete financial education lead him to confirm his existing beliefs, even if they're incorrect.

Many wealthy clients I have met understand how important it is to teach their children about wealth and its responsibilities, including respect for work and people. The best wealth managers I know always focus on educating the next generation. Some bankers I worked with even gave their children money to help them learn by doing.

Being wealthy is something you learn.

Spring into action!
5 key takeaways and an exercise

FIVE KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. Reflecting philosophically on selling offers a rich source of ideas and motivation.
2. Consider negotiation as cooperation, not a competition.
3. We need to be sensitive to our customers' emotional states, as this is an opportunity to consolidate the relationship.
4. Use key emotional triggers to steer the rollercoaster of emotions towards a positive outcome.
5. Speak openly and confidently about money, with both grace and resolve. Reflect on your personal relationship with it, and don't shy away from meaningful conversations.

EXERCICE

Title: Put yourself in the shoes of a psychotherapist.

Aim of the exercise: To develop sensitivity and subtlety.

Instructions:

- Which emotion do you most frequently notice in your clients?
- How do you handle it?
- Can you name three important moments in your relationships with clients, as well as how you deal with each one?

6

Drivers of Influence

(Motivation or manipulation?)

The need for creativity

We can influence others!
See situations differently, offer alternative solutions,
break out of the mold!

TEACHING OBJECTIVES

After reading this chapter, you will be able to:

- Understand and apply all the influence techniques used in sales strategies.
- Highlight the need for wealth managers to think creatively.

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I. DRIVERS OF INFLUENCE IN THE CLIENT RELATIONSHIP[1]

One question continues to haunt critical thinkers in the sales world is this: where is the line between a salesperson's sincerity and the manipulation used to persuade clients to buy? Here are two things to keep in mind:

- It is the initial intent that defines the degree of manipulation between individuals.
- If the goal is to serve the client's best interests, influence becomes a tool for helping, not exploiting. A sincere desire to support the client makes all the difference.

After all, we all encounter situations where we're influenced by others.

MAIS QU'EST-CE QUE L'INFLUENCE ?

Influence is the ability to shape someone's behavior, mindset, or choices using emotional, social, or psychological tools. It often relies on persuasion or subtle manipulation to achieve a desired outcome. [1].

For relationship managers, using influence techniques after the fact is part of the sales process. These techniques serve to persuade, but only once the client's needs have been clearly matched with appropriate financial products.

Here are two everyday examples of the influence we may be subjected to:

- **Authority bias:** When experts recommend a product. This type of influence relies on trust, or the so-called **"white coat effect"**, demonstrated by Milgram's experiments[3].
- **Commitment:** By encouraging clients to take a small step, the relationship between the client and the bank is reinforced. Signing up for a newsletter is one example of such a minimal commitment.

1 Robert Cialdini, *Influence: The Psychology of Persuasion*, Harper Business, 2006. We drew a great deal of inspiration from this book.
2 ChatGPT's definition.
3 Stanley Milgram's 1960s experiments exposed how willing people are to follow authority, even when doing so inflicts suffering on another person.

2. DIFFERENT INFLUENCE TECHNIQUES

A. CONTRASTING PERCEPTIONS

The goal is to highlight value by contrasting it with something less attractive. When selling a service, comparing it to a less desirable option makes it stand out.

It's the same tactic used in car sales: buyers haggle over the price of the car itself, but not the add-ons, and those are precisely where the profit margins are highest.

B. RECIPROCITY

The basic principle is that we return what we have received as a favour from others.

Receiving something creates a sense of debt. In many languages, the word «obliged» carries a double meaning — both as a form of constraint and as a polite expression of gratitude. In French, for instance, a gentleman might say, "Monsieur, je suis votre obligé." In English, too, the expression "much obliged" conveys a sense of both duty and gratitude.

The rule of reciprocity, as a tool of influence, relies on an initial gesture or gift from one party to create a sense of obligation in the other.

Clients want to hear certain "magic words":

"I'll take care of it."
"I'll do my best to get you the best deal."
"Leave it to me — I'll sort it out."
"Don't worry — the bank will handle the situation…"

CREATING A SENSE OF RECIPROCITY

What can you do for your client to encourage them to return the favor?

Reciprocity starts with giving. A small gift at the beginning of a relationship can go a long way.

A product sample creates the same reaction and serves a dual purpose: it introduces the prospect to the product and acts as a gift. This is what triggers reciprocity. The American company Amway, for example, uses this technique by leaving a free sample case of products with prospects for a few days before returning to take their order. After trying the products, prospects feel compelled to reciprocate.

For the rule of reciprocity to work effectively, the service must be unsolicited but freely offered, in order to create a social relationship that naturally includes an obligation to return the favor.

An unwanted gift can still create a sense of obligation.

C. MAKING CONCESSIONS

Concession is a form of reciprocity. You offer a premium service which the prospect might decline. In response, you "make a concession" by offering a second, lower-priced but still high-quality service. This concession often prompts the prospect to make one in return, by accepting the second offer. Using this technique can also serve as a gateway to a longer-term relationship.

The rule of reciprocity governs how compromises are made: you start with a large request to eventually settle on a smaller one. Rejecting a request can create an opportunity to ask for something else, such as an active referral, provided this second request is framed as a concession from the prospect.

Hone your influencing skills!
Where might you make a concession?
What request could you follow up with?

D. THE DESIRE FOR CONSISTENCY

The desire for consistency is a powerful motivation; coherence forms the basis of logic, reason, and stability.

There is automatic consistency, where the logical sequence of facts is taken to the extreme.

Consider the well-known syllogism: Socrates is a Cretan, all Cretans are liars, therefore Socrates is a liar.

Commitment is the corollary of consistency and leads to the purchase decision.

Commitment begins with making a small request to "get the ball rolling"[4] with the interlocutor; following that, the salesperson presents a larger request. When the prospect agrees to the small request initially, the relationship manager no longer faces a prospect but a client!

This change in status is meaningful, even if the effort put in does not match the initial outcome.

Exercise:

Among the following "engagement hooks," which do you consider the most effective?

- *Inviting the client to join a pilot program*
- *Offering a demonstration*
- *Organizing a joint activity, sports-related or otherwise*
- *Booking a session with an expert*
- *Providing free training on an investment tool*
- *Running a simulation*

4 Draw the interlocutor into a cycle.

- *Providing a free test*
- *Assigning a task or project*
- *Performing a feasibility study*
- *Lending a book to the client*

E. THE IMPORTANCE OF PUTTING THINGS IN WRITING

This technique is known as the "foot-in-the-door"[5] approach. Signing a petition is a form of commitment that makes it easier to agree to larger requests later on.

A signature strongly symbolizes engagement in the business relationship.

One way to reinforce commitment is to put in writing what you want, turning intention into action.

The more effort an engagement requires, the more likely it is to be followed by action.

How can you get your client to write things down? Perhaps by taking notes yourself.

F. SOCIAL PROOF

This refers to the herd mentality effect, which works by assuring the client that many others have already made the same choice.

The TV equivalent is canned laughter, which helps set a humorous tone even during parts that aren't actually all that funny.

It's just a technician pressing a button. Everyone hates it, but it works.

A behavior seems more acceptable when others have already adopted it.

This is social proof in action.

When people see that other customers are happy, they tend to believe the product must be good. In sales, simply having clients share their testimonials in front of prospects—say, during a lunch—can trigger a bandwagon effect.

Exercise: Create a sales pitch based on social proof.

PANURGE'S SHEEP EFFECT AS A FORM OF SOCIAL PROOF

When we don't know what to do, we often look to others and copy their behavior—particularly if they're people who seem just like us.

We're more likely to follow the example of someone similar than someone who is very different. This is known as the Werther effect (David Phillips, University of San Diego), which shows that after a widely publicized suicide, there is often a noticeable increase in suicides in the same region.

5 Freedman and Fraser, 1960.

The likelihood increases when the initial case closely resembles the person exposed to the story.

Mimicry is a form of influence that can be activated by referring to similar people who acted in the same way when facing similar problems.

The example may be sad, but it's a serious one.

3. TUPPERWARE MEETINGS, A SOURCE OF INSPIRATION FOR WEALTH MANAGERS

I've been to Tupperware parties where I was the only man there. These are sales events for storage containers made of a plastic-like material. Tupperware boxes are very well-known—my wife still uses a few that are nearly 50 years old! Their sales method is simple: direct selling through home parties. A regional host arranges a gathering at someone's house, gives a demonstration, and then it's time to place orders.

Why use this example, which seems far removed from banking?

Because Tupperware parties are a textbook case of influence theory:

- **Reciprocity:** each participant receives a welcome gift.
- **Commitment:** Everyone is asked to explain how they use the product.
- **Social proof:** each participant who makes a purchase helps show that if many people endorse the product, it must be good.
- **The active referral chain:** friends recommend friends. This is the marketing idea of actively referring others. At the end of every party, they decide who will organize the next one and who to invite.
- **The liking principle (see later in the chapter) and kindness:** everyone has a friendly connection with someone else in the meeting. This positive bond helps create another positive connection, enhanced by the warm, personal setting of someone's home. Participants buy from a friend, not a salesperson.
- **The sense of group belonging:** everyone realizes they are part of a group brought together by a common social interest.
- **The recognition principle:** every sale that's made is celebrated by the group, usually with applause. The biggest sales get rewarded by the Tupperware company with presents. There's a clear system of both personal and social recognition (and hosts are trained on this).

Use the table below to put all these principles into practice with your clients:

TUPPERWARE'S INFLUENCE TECHNIQUES	APPLIED TO PRIVATE WEALTH MANAGEMENT CLIENTS
Reciprocity	
Commitment	
La preuve sociale	
Active referral chain principle	
Liking principle	
Sense of belonging principle	
Recognition principle	

4. WHAT MAKES US LIKABLE?

It goes without saying that a likable person attracts more of our sympathy and that we are more likely to agree to their requests.

Here, I present an approach I have promoted since the beginning of my training career—a theory about kindness and its strong influence in commercial relationships.

A. KEY FACTORS THAT INFLUENCE LIKABILITY[6]

- **Physical appearance** acts like a halo effect. It overshadows other aspects of the person in front of you. This beauty halo is useful in any situation where influence is to be exerted. Aren't scammers often handsome gentlemen or beautiful ladies?

When you're badly dressed, the clothes get noticed;
when you're well dressed, they notice you!

- **Similarity = we like what resembles us.** It can occur naturally or be created, affecting opinions, personality traits, preferences, origin, and lifestyle. Clothing is among the most obvious signs of similarity and is a factor that can be easily acted upon.

The most classic sales tactic (especially among car salespeople) is to claim they have something in common with the customer. This similarity effect was made famous by the French comedy trio *Les Inconnus* in the 1990s, with their hilarious catchphrase, "I've got the same one at home".

6 Nicholas Boothman, *Convince Them in 90 Seconds or Less*, Workman Adult, 2010.

- **Flattery and compliments.** When the salesperson immediately offers a positive statement of intent[7] by telling the client they find them likable, it's a compliment that is likely to be returned.
- **Le sourire.**
- **Declaring "you are a friend"** was the signature move of the so-called world's best salesman[8], who would send cards to all his clients several times a year with that very message. A positive declaration like this borders on flattery when it's entirely fabricated. The key to making it effective is sincerity and spontaneity: the compliment must be based on something concrete and objective.
- **Familiarity and cooperation.** People are more receptive to what they know. Repeated exposure to an object, concept, or person can positively influence our attitude. On the flip side, if that contact occurs in a negative environment—conflict, hostility, or discomfort—it can breed dislike.

Cooperation creates likability when it is seen as an alternative to unnecessary competition between two people or groups. A salesperson who demonstrates cooperative intentions naturally becomes more likable.

- **Conditioning and association**

Blaming the weather presenter for bad weather is a classic example of how we associate people with the messages they deliver. When someone brings good news, our affection for them tends to increase.

Which kinds of positive updates could make us more likable in the eyes of our clients?

- It's all about associating our products and services with things the client already likes—that's what makes them appealing. Another approach is to associate ourselves with celebrities (a tactic used by all politicians), when the opportunity arises.
- **Pavlov's experiments on conditioned behavior** (associating a sound with something pleasant) show us that clients can come to associate meeting their salesperson with something enjoyable—such as receiving a small gift, a piece of chocolate, or a regular lunch invitation to a nice restaurant. A pleasant lunch can create a feeling of well-being for the prospect, who may then link that positive experience to the sales interaction. To be liked, associate yourself with good news—and avoid being connected to bad news.
- **The winner takes it all!** Associating with well-known or highly successful individuals makes the salesperson or product more likable—through both association and the desire to bask in the reflected glory of others.

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7 *Positive Statement of Intent.*

8 Joe Girard in the *Guinness Book of Records, Chevrolet car salesman* in Détroit, Illinois, USA.

- **Deference to authority:** Milgram's experiments[9] demonstrated how individuals may blindly follow the instructions of someone in a white coat, shifting responsibility from the person performing the action to the one giving the orders. People tend to comply with legitimate authorities and often default to automatic obedience in their presence.

How can we make prospects and clients like us?

We have just 4 seconds to make a good first impression.

According to the second law of the Iceberg Theory, a positive first point leads to other positives (and the same goes for negative ones). Always start with a positive posture and refer to tangible, positive facts

This attitude is reinforced by another behavioral effect: mirroring.

It involves mirroring the other person's behavior and posture to achieve synchrony. This is how children naturally learn from adults, by copying their manners, social habits, and so on.

When the salesperson mirrors their prospect, the client feels comfortable, even thinking, *"We're alike."*

It feels as if the wealth manager is treating them like an old friend.

THINKING IN REVERSE

If a salesperson is too kind, they may come across as weak. Unfortunately, while this boosts their likability, it significantly reduces their ability to be firm. It opens the door to concessions. Perceived weakness creates openings; it's a deeply ingrained human instinct. By trying to be too nice in the moment, you may end up having to be harsh later on.

5. THE POWER OF SYMBOLS AND AUTHORITY

- **Titles**

The Cambridge[10] experiment illustrates this clearly. One individual was presented to five separate classes—first as a student, then a lecturer, then an assistant professor, and ultimately as a full professor. When asked to estimate the person's height, each group gave progressively higher estimates as the title became more prestigious.

9 Refer to the start of this chapter

10 Nicholas Boothman, *Convince Them in 90 Seconds or Less,* Workman Adult, 2010.

- **Clothing:** Research by Leonard Bickman demonstrates that what someone wears can convey authority and lead to automatic compliance. Requests made by a man in uniform are almost always followed.
- **Accessoires:** From the car to the pen I write with, the glasses case, or even my smartphone case – individually, these items may seem insignificant, but collectively they convey a refined aesthetic that is inevitably appealing. We could call this an eye for detail, which is a valuable asset in sales.

6. SCARCITY, OR THE POWER OF RARE

The wealth manager's job is closely connected to information. Information becomes most compelling when it's reserved for a select few.

Opportunities feel more valuable when they are rare, and even more so when they are off-limits to others.

- **The rarity of something makes it valuable**

The fear of missing out (FOMO) influences decisions more than the potential for gain. The scarcity principle is reinforced by limited availability; when a product is no longer available (even artificially), it increases in appeal.

- **What others desire becomes (more) desirable to me**

Psychological reactance is a defense mechanism studied by Jack Brehm.

We place greater importance and value on our freedom of choice when it is under threat. How can this freedom be endangered?

It happens when someone else desires the same object or service, so we work harder to get it.

How can you "work with" the driver of influence that is scarcity? Beware of being too obvious, as these techniques are easily noticed and can then become counterproductive.

7. OTHER DRIVERS OF INFLUENCE

Presented in a less structured way, these are other levers that can contribute to influencing those we engage with.

A. GETTING TO YES[11]

Problem-solving lies at the heart of this method, with everyone aiming to reach a mutually beneficial agreement.

The underlying concept is that emotional impulses during negotiation can be largely offset by rational evaluation of the situation alongside a shared desire to resolve issues: the mindset before negotiation tactics.

The method involved:

1. Separating the person and their emotions from the problem or negotiation.
2. Separating the negotiators' positions and the negotiation's object, concentrating on the interests at stake, the reason behind the demand.
3. Prioritizing so-called win-win cooperation.
4. Reaching agreement on shared criteria to analyze the situation and seek solutions.

B. USING VOICE AND EMPATHY EFFECTIVELY

Emotional intelligence lies at the heart of effective negotiation; it is not seen as an obstacle to overcome[12]12.

Tactical empathy means turning active listening into a purposeful act during a conversation. It consists of verbalizing active listening to amplify its effect. Listening and clearly showing that we are actively listening will motivate our counterpart twice as much.

The role of the voice and its pitch varies depending on the situation. The tone of voice conveys specific messages; for example, a low pitch (like Macha Béranger's voice in the 1980s) conveys a sense of confidence).

We fear what is different and are drawn to what is similar; it is a basic biological principle («birds of a feather flock together»).

11 Roger Fisher and William Ury, *"Getting to Yes: Negotiating Agreement Without Giving In."* (1981) Nicolas Boothman, previously cited.

12 Nicolas Boothman, previously cited.

Mirroring (isopraxy) is a natural, involuntary imitation behavior common to animals and humans alike.

This concept extends to echoing the words and pronunciation of your conversation partner — for example, when your client says a phrase and you repeat the last few words. This technique serves as a form of acknowledgment and an influence strategy that demonstrates your willingness to connect with and understand your clients better.

How to get in tune?

1. By adjusting the pitch of your voice.
2. Using mirroring techniques.
3. Leaving breathing room for them to process.
4. Experimenting with the natural quality of your voice.
5. Using a slow, calm, descending tone with good enunciation to encourage trust.
6. Adopting a positive but measured tone that reflects your commitment.
7. Using a direct, incisive tone might be off-putting.
8. It's not only the voice that allows synchronization; the rest of our body can sync at the same time with our attitude (our intention).

The voice shapes the message, and it travels wherever the eyes are directed.

The role of empathy

Negotiation is not a battle; it's a process of discovery: the goal is to uncover as much information as possible to act wisely.

In praise of slowness

In negotiation, it's best to take things slowly, as haste can cause misunderstandings: lack of active listening, reduced trust, and feelings of being manipulated.

Building a positive mindset during exchanges means smiling and saying positive things. A Positive Inner Attitude (PIA) fosters mental agility for all parties involved.

Empathy comes into play as a communication technique that involves grasping both the feelings and the nature of the person you are speaking with.

Empathy creates a physical response; when we feel empathy, we resonate with the other person, which allows us to understand what they feel and think. This phenomenon was demonstrated (Stephens, Silbert, Hasson, Princeton University, 2010) using brain scans through functional magnetic resonance imaging.

The resonance vanished when people communicated badly. They showed that those who practiced empathy and active listening could predict what their conversation partners would say.

Another technique is referred to by the author[13] as labeling.

This technique consists of achieving a deep level of empathy, enabling the emotions that clients are experiencing to be recognized. Once identified, the emotion is "put into words," or verbalized. Labeling is a shortcut to intimacy.

C. SPARKING THE CLIENT'S IMAGINATION to awaken their emotions, helping them to imagine future scenarios that could also spark an emotional response in them. The role of creativity in sales will be covered further on in this chapter.

There are two kinds of projection:

- **Logical projection:** This is a sequence of "why" and "because" questions to help the client understand our explanation as logical and clear.
- **Emotional projection** is similar: it involves helping the prospect envision an ideal future by explaining how to get there.

The decision to buy is driven by both kinds of projections. Customers often give priority to the emotional side first, and then justify it with logical, rational arguments afterwards.

What counts as an objection and what doesn't.

A salesperson can't magically turn a NO into a YES (even though traditionally, NO isn't considered a final answer).

However, they can act to turn the following attitudes into a YES:

- I'll think about it / I'll call you back later / I need to discuss it with my wife / Now's not the right time / I don't have the budget for this investment…

Another method to spark imagination is to **assume the role of the expert** (like a doctor), and the wealth manager has every right to do this. They can confidently state, if they believe it, that this is the best option for the prospect/client.

D. TRUST, ALWAYS AND FOREVER

This is an ongoing theme that resurfaces in every chapter. There's certainly a reason for its constant presence. Trust is the foundation of the sales relationship.

13 Nicolas Boothman, previously cited.

How do you inspire trust?

- By creating a positive atmosphere as soon as you arrive.
- Convey your energy by appearing healthy, smiling, with controlled posture, and maintaining good eye contact.
- Demonstrate self-confidence while also being friendly; this balance leads to success in relationships.
- Align your communication focus (your "heart's axis") toward your client.
- Keep your hands visible and open—this instinctively reduces suspicion.
- Be clear about why you're asking tough questions.
- Be considerate of your client's financial knowledge.
- Reframe any biases into positive views that benefit the relationship.
- Respect your client's personal space and comfort zone.
- Match your body language with what your message.
- Make sure your gestures and speech are in harmony.

"What you are stands over you the while, and thunders so that I cannot hear what you say to the contrary."[14]

- Maintain "useful" attitudes, meaning positive both in content and in their expression. Eliminate all attitudes that do not contribute to the quality of exchanges: anger, impatience, arrogance, criticism, etc.
- Provide acknowledgments (confirmation of receipt, reformulation) and feedback to improve the quality of your exchanges by valuing your interlocutors.

When you meet someone for the first time, how do you know you can trust them?

E. SALES LANGUAGE BEGINS IN THE BRAIN

The brain handles positive messages much better than negative ones.

When we use negative wording, it often leads to negative responses.

For example, when you respond to a client with "no problem," the underlying message suggests that problems could occur.

It's better to use positive language when acknowledging something, such as:

"It was a pleasure," which is a positive expression.

14 Ralph Waldo Emerson, a 19th-century American essayist, poet, and philosopher.

Negative language prevents us from sending positive impressions to our clients.

The motivation behind a request, and the way it is explained, are powerful tools of influence.

Explaining, clarifying, stating why, and using “because” make your message clearer and strengthen your argument.

Testimonial

Guillaume Berney, a conductor and a student in my EMBA negotiation course at HEG Geneva, 2022.

A brief reflection on the boundary between negotiation and manipulation.

In the often-misunderstood world of orchestral conducting, beyond its image of absolute authority, the conductor is tasked with overseeing the success of a performance with both benevolence and responsibility. Tasked with steering the course of a performance, the conductor must foster excellence while rallying seasoned musicians around a shared artistic vision.

This is especially true when the repertoire includes collaboration with an instrumental or vocal soloist.

Unlike purely orchestral pieces, accompanying a soloist requires the conductor to place themselves at the service of the soloist, to understand their interpretation of the piece, and ideally to share it.

Take, for example, a world-class violinist who gives two to three concerts a week with orchestras around the world. Every few days, they play with a new orchestra, under a new conductor, each with a different artistic approach.

Between flights and trains, jet lag, lack of sleep, and a packed schedule, the time they have available to rehearse together is extremely limited.

It’s crucial, then, to work efficiently. When the two share the same artistic vision, things fall into place quickly and the process runs smoothly.

But when their interpretations differ, complications arise.

Each one feels justified in their stance — the soloist, as the star of the performance, and the conductor, as the one overseeing the entire production.

What follows is a subtle and complex negotiation.

For this exercise, let us place ourselves in the shoes of the conductor — a role the author knows all too well.

As for the piece, we’ll choose Tchaikovsky’s majestic Violin Concerto.

The soloist, both inspired and diligent, has been working on this emblematic piece for several years.

Over time, their interpretation will naturally evolve, with their phrasing and mastery of the notes becoming more dynamic and fluid.

A soloist's performance is, of course, informed by the original score and the composer's markings — but perhaps even more so by their own playing style.

It may happen, for example, that the conductor envisions a tempo completely different from the one the soloist is used to.

So, what happens when the conductor and soloist don't see eye to eye?

At the start of the first rehearsal, the orchestra, conductor, and soloist are all gathered on stage.

After a few seconds, the soloist stops and signals to the conductor that the tempo does not suit him.

The conductor then asks the soloist to demonstrate the tempo he has in mind.

But this version doesn't sit well with the conductor either — for minor stylistic reasons. Still, the conductor's job is to support the soloist and should make a genuine effort to be persuaded.

The soloist, who is less flexible due to physical limitations, will try to sway the conductor, like a kind of evangelist.

A good conductor's skill lies in one thing: listening to the soloist's arguments, taking on board their version, grasping their artistic vision and needs, and negotiating the sticking points.

At times, however, even with the best intentions, the two visions are completely at odds, and common ground is hard to find.

That's when the truly great conductors show their strength, by making the soloist believe they're going along with them, while in truth, using skilled gestures, shared glances and subtle smiles, the conductor gently leads and shapes the soloist's choices without them ever noticing.

But this can only happen during the performance itself.

This is the realm of the unspoken; the realm of feeling, of instinct, listening and a great deal of self-confidence.

The line between manipulation and negotiation is very blurred here. But in the end, the soloist will be satisfied, convinced they have persuaded the conductor, while the conductor has stroked the soloist's ego and achieved the desired outcome. A win-win?

Who were you?

This is an exercise in self-reflection on our personality.

Take an old photo of yourself and try to analyze as objectively as possible the personality that the young man or young woman you were back then expressed. Play mentalist and create your psychological profile, specifying your communication skills at the time.

After completing this portrait of your past self, reflect on what you communicate today and the impact you have on your current relationships.

A chart outlining potential manipulations in negotiation and ways to counter them[15].

THE MANIPULATOR	THE COUNTERMOVE
Puts themselves on a pedestal by saying "We are serious and responsible." They want to make you feel ashamed: you are a victim of your own principles!	State that "Everyone here is serious and responsible." Assert yourself. Say: "My principles are my own." Don't let yourself be defined by the other person or threaten to do the same to them.
Accuses you of being selfish.	Assert yourself: "I decide how I help others."
The manipulator lies.	Verify, fact-check, and call them out.
Rephrases what was said, changing the meaning.	Restore the truth: "I didn't say that!" Expose the tactic. Call out the interpretation and ask: "Why are you doing this?"
Negotiates point by point to gain small concessions.	Expose with irony: "Are you trying to nibble away at us, bit by bit?"
Uses flattery and compliments.	Laugh and accept the compliments.
Gives gifts.	Refuse anything that would overly bind you.
Tries to impress with a prestigious or luxurious setting.	A lavish setting doesn't mean you owe anything.
Uses the other person's fatigue or worries as an excuse to ask for immediate agreement (can also cite lack of time).	Uses the other person's fatigue or worries as an excuse to ask for immediate agreement (can also cite lack of time).
Puts you in the position of a supplicant, and therefore weakness.	Asking doesn't mean weakness—adults have needs and express them.

15 Inspired by the negotiation and conflict management technical course by Tjosvold, D. & Hodgson, J., pages 52 to 56.

Alternates between threats and kindness.	Call out the pattern: "Is this hot-and-cold treatment?"
Alternates between aggression and negotiation, presents you with a *fait accompli*.	Set boundaries and state what action will be taken if they are crossed (deterrence principle).
Holds firm on initial positions, then gives way on points they care least about.	Stay focused on your own goals, not on the other party's concessions or pushbacks.
Threatens a withdrawal from negotiations under the pretext of seeking approval from their superiors.	Negotiate the rules of the negotiation itself—e.g. mutual right to pause sessions. Threaten to do the same.
Provokes you, trying to make you lose your temper.	Call out the provocation: "Are you trying to make us lose our cool?"
Addresses each person separately.	Highlight the tactic to the group during a break in the session.
Flatters one member of the opposing group to stir up jealousy among others.	Expose the manipulation: "Are you trying to divide us?" (to have more authority).
Tries to impress by referring to higher authorities.	Refer to that authority if it is one you both share.

8. RARELY HAS A BOOK INFLUENCED ME SO DEEPLY[16]

There are certain patterns in human behavior known as *consistent behaviors*.

A wealth manager can begin to detect these consistencies in a client's behavior by closely observing their personality, life story, and attitudes during successive meetings.

These are what we call "behavioral signatures", principles that tend to emerge in specific situations. Let's examine some of these through examples drawn from wealth management negotiations.

16 R.V. Joule, J.L. Beauvois, *Petit traité de manipulation à l'usage des honnêtes gens*, ("A Small Treatise on Manipulation for the Use of Honest People,") Presses Universitaires de Grenoble, 1987.

UNDERSTANDING HOW CLIENTS MAKE DECISIONS

Negotiation takes place within the framework of both social and interpersonal relationships. Social dynamics are shaped by the broader environment and the cultural backgrounds of the participants, while interpersonal dynamics are influenced by the quality and intent the manager brings to the relationship.

A. WHY IT'S USEFUL TO PROMPT YOUR CLIENT TO MAKE EVEN SMALL DECISIONS

Every time a client makes a decision, however small, their attention shifts to behaviors aligned with that choice. This is what's called the "freezing effect" (Kurt Lewin, 1947): once a decision is made, people tend to act in a way that reinforces it.

Applying this to a banking setting

The wealth manager should nudge their prospective client to make a decision, such as monitoring the performance of an investment product or completing a task.

The resulting sense of responsibility becomes a commitment, driven more by the action itself than by reason.

When it comes to decision-making, the manager needs to exercise great caution because of the risk of an "escalation of commitment." This refers to the human tendency to cling to a decision even when all the evidence suggests it should be reconsidered. The wealth manager should slow things down if a client wants to make decisions too hastily, as they may then be inclined to persist with that decision.

This persistence can lead the client into a "no-way-back trap" because their initial decision has pushed them to follow a course of action from which they no longer want to deviate. This phenomenon illustrates the saying "gone too far to turn back."

This no-way-back trap often arises in investment situations, where the client insists on going through with a decision, even when all the signals point to pulling out — despite the wealth manager's repeated warnings.

He digs himself in deeper just to avoid admitting he was wrong.

B. CREATING A FALSE SENSE OF FREEDOM CAN BE A FORM OF ENTRAPMENT

Making a decision without pressure is the ideal way to secure true conviction and commitment.In a well-balanced client–banker relationship, there is no power struggle. When clients feel entirely free to choose, they are more likely to commit.

Thoughts, opinions, and feelings can show intent—but only actions truly commit us, especially when formalized, such as by signing a contract.

Wealth managers can encourage this sense of autonomy by regularly reaffirming things like:

"Only you can make this decision,"

"This is a personal and private decision,"

"You're free to walk away."

Commitment through a "teaser" offer or by "baiting"

The idea is to "bait" the client by first offering a very attractive product or service, then subsequently proposing additional items. Once the client has made an initial purchase decision, their behavior is likely to align with that first commitment going forward.

Sales promotions are the best example of this bait technique; it involves a loss-leader product offered at an exceptionally low price ("slashed") to attract customers.

Applying this to a banking setting

Providing a wealth assessment is a classic example of a baiting technique — it encourages the prospect to behave like a client before any formal agreement. The adviser can build on this dynamic by sharing privileged insights or materials usually reserved for actual clients. I knew a manager who would offer a bank-branded pen during the very first meeting. While the outcome wasn't guaranteed, the "gift" helped put prospects in a positive frame of mind. There's a positive cause-and-effect relationship at play.

C. FOOT IN THE DOOR

This is known as a preparatory behavior, involving an initial request that is explicit, low-cost, and unproblematic, followed by a second, more substantial request. The aim is to trigger a gradual commitment. The second request becomes implicit and more binding. It should not be made at the same time as the first, to avoid making the strategy feel too heavy-handed. The wealth manager should reinforce the client's choices by offering encouragement or praise for each decision made.

Applying this to a banking setting

A financial adviser might suggest that the potential client go ahead and open an account while they continue to think things over. This small, low-pressure step often strengthens the client's initial inclination and makes it more likely they'll follow through.

The role of physical contact in purchase decisions. The "touch effect" is real (as demonstrated by studies from Smith, Gier, and Willis in 1982). These studies showed that physical contact increases the likelihood of creating a sense of intimacy. It is processed unconsciously and can influence purchase decisions.

Although one must exercise great caution in this area, I will still offer this advice: wealth managers, make (appropriate) physical contact with your clients!

Bien qu'il faille être extrêmement prudent sur ce sujet, j'oserai quand même le conseil : gestionnaires, touchez vos clients !

D. SLAM! THE DOOR-IN-THE-FACE TECHNIQUE

In contrast to the "foot-in-the-door" approach, the "door-in-the-face" technique works in nearly the opposite way. It involves making an initial, excessive request (almost guaranteed to be refused), followed by the actual request—the one you really want accepted. The contrast increases the chances of a "yes." To be effective, this strategy requires careful phrasing: the second request should appear "reasonable," and the gap between the two should be kept short.

Applying this to a banking setting

The technique involves making an initial large request, such as asking the client to transfer all of their assets to your bank and make it their sole banking institution. Based on the client's response, the wealth manager can scale back the request and instead ask to become the client's main bank. The second request is less demanding but still meets the essential criteria of the door-in-the-face technique: it must appear reasonable, normal, and appropriate. In this case, the adviser can gently insist, explaining that they are not asking to become the client's only bank— "just" the primary one.

E. THE COMMITMENT EFFECT

The time and energy a wealth manager devotes to a client create an added psychological impact. The effort each party invests in a negotiation reflects how much they value the process – and how willing they are to move forward. Any experienced negotiator recognizes this dynamic.

The client's initial engagement helps you gauge their readiness to go forward with your offer.

You can check their commitment and even boost it by looking at these five things:

1. How much time have they invested in the sales process? Keep the calculation simple.
2. What have they done on their own? Filling in forms, gathering paperwork, getting ready for meetings.
3. Did they ask any outside experts for advice, such as a lawyer or financial advisor?
4. Have they had meetings with your team? How many, and how for long?
5. Can you estimate the cost of preliminary work (before account opening) dedicated to this prospective client?

It may be entirely appropriate to present a kind of summary to a client who is hesitating but hasn't yet signed. The aim is to help them grasp the tangible extent of both their own investment and yours:

- How much time have you invested?
- What resources have you mobilized?
- How much money has already been spent?

F. THE CONCEPT OF KEY MOMENTS

A client's decision to say yes almost always happens during a key moment – one that is emotionally charged and memorable for them.

The wealth manager's clarity of mind

An adviser should know when to take a mental step back and assess the dynamic with the client. This "freeze frame" moment allows for a clear-sighted analysis of the interaction.

During this moment, the wealth manager should be able to:

- Tune into the client's emotional responses, whether verbal or non-verbal.
- Adjust their own reactions to align with the client's behavior.

During the meeting, the wealth manager can demonstrate commercial empathy by recognizing the client's emotional state and supporting them through it.

He uses his empathy to provide reassurance and clarify what will happen next in the meeting.

It's important not to dive straight into technical explanations the client may not understand or care about. The emotional side must be addressed first. Only then should concrete matters like investment choices, timescales, or income projections be discussed.

Always put things in perspective

Clients might take portfolio performance at face value.

To avoid difficult conversations, always explain results in the context of market conditions and recent economic events.

Taking time to look at things in context is essential; a basic portfolio review is only appropriate when the results are significantly out of the ordinary.

The three foundations of a successful client relationship in private banking: follow-up, follow-up, and follow-up.

9. CREATIVITY IS THE MOTHER OF ALL SKILLS

Why is creativity essential for the wealth manager? For countless reasons—and one more…

Because it's the ability to come up with surprising and inventive solutions that truly

makes a difference.

Banks all face a challenge: their products are too similar. None truly stands out with something entirely new.

But creativity has a broad scope—from suggesting a good night out in Zurich or arranging a private jet for the weekend, to proposing a unique financial structure for a complex case.

It may even be about helping resolve a family conflict between siblings.

Creativity, then, is needed at every stage of the client relationship.

A. IS CREATIVITY JUST A SET OF TECHNIQUES? OR IS IT A STATE OF MIND?

The answer lies in the question: above all, it's a state of mind. It's the mindset that keeps us alert to great ideas and commercial opportunities.

To adopt a creative mindset, you need to set aside taboos and inhibitions—let your mind roam freely (or, as transactional analysis might say, let your "free child" speak).

This mindset is a necessary foundation for using any creativity technique. Research shows that two key conditions support a creative state: a calm environment and a positive attitude.

After all, it's hard to think creatively in a tense or stressful atmosphere.

The mind is like a parachute; it only works when it's open!

How can we get into the right mindset for creativity, that 'flow' state where ideas come effortlessly?

One of the first steps is to reflect on when and where our best ideas tend to appear?

- In the shower?
- While out hiking?
- In the bathroom?
- During the night?

And when those ideas do come, how do we capture them? Write them down, memorize them, dictate them? Everyone has their own method, but the key is to record them before they fade.

B. WHAT DOES IT TAKE TO THINK DIFFERENTLY?

An artist sees the same things as everyone else, but from a unique perspective. Their power to imagine an alternative world defines their difference, and when they show us what they see, it becomes art.

The most important trait is the ability to think outside the box, as famously demonstrated by the nine-dot challenge[17] (which I'll leave out here).

There are personality traits common to creative people—traits we can consciously adopt to enter a creative phase, to set the right conditions.

The "free child" we referred to earlier resurfaces here!

Behavioral traits to encourage a creative mindset:

- Fearlessness and absence of worry.
- Embracing originality.
- Being a bit crazy but maintaining caution.
- Having a slight cheekiness, breaking the rules just enough to see things differently.
- Constantly combining ideas, mixing concepts, and flipping conventional practices.
- Having cognitive flexibility and the ability to adapt to new ideas or situations.
- Combining opposites to explore new possibilities.
- Feeding curiosity and maintaining an open mind.
- Persisting despite setbacks and learning from failures.

Thinking differently and lateral thinking

In our opinion, this passage captures the essence of lateral thinking: a form of creative thought full of subtlety[18].

17 Created by the artist Georges Perec as part of the Oulipo movement.
18 The young girl from London, inspired by Edward de Bono, cf. *Lateral Thinking*, 1970.

THE YOUNG GIRL FROM LONDON

In 17th-century England, it was customary to imprison debtors unable to repay their creditors.

A poor grocer found himself owing a considerable debt to a predatory moneylender — a surly old man who had set his sights on the grocer's daughter. One day, the creditor made a proposition: "Give me your daughter, and I will absolve your debts," he declared. Such a bargain was utterly unacceptable to both father and daughter.

So the old man proposed leaving their fate to chance. Into an empty pouch, he placed one white stone and one black stone. The daughter, blindfolded, was to draw a stone. If she pulled the black stone, she would become his wife and the debts would be forgiven. If she drew the white stone, she could remain with her father and the debts would still be cleared.

But if she refused to play, her father would go to prison.

The scene took place in the creditor's park. The old man bent down, picked up two stones, and dropped them into the pouch. However, the girl noticed he had actually picked two black stones. The old man then ordered her to draw a stone from the pouch — the stone that would decide both her fate and her father's.

What do you think the young girl did to get out of this trap?

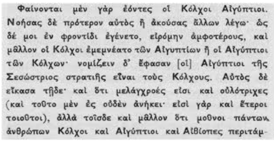
The answer's on the next page…

C. WHAT ARE THE BARRIERS TO CREATIVITY?

Often, the toughest barriers are the ones we put up ourselves, a kind of self-imposed restriction. Such obstacles come more from our beliefs and habits than from external pressures. They generally represent personal limitations.

Here are several examples:

THE HUMAN TENDENCY TO SEE ONLY WHAT THEY KNOW


Φαίνονται μὲν γὰρ ἐόντες οἱ Κόλχοι Αἰγύπτιοι. Νοήσας δὲ πρότερον αὐτὸς ἢ ἀκούσας ἄλλων λέγω· ὡς δέ μοι ἐν φροντίδι ἐγένετο, εἰρόμην ἀμφοτέρους, καὶ μᾶλλον οἱ Κόλχοι ἐμεμνέατο τῶν Αἰγυπτίων ἢ οἱ Αἰγύπτιοι τῶν Κόλχων· νομίζειν δ' ἔφασαν [οἱ] Αἰγύπτιοι τῆς Σεσώστριος στρατιῆς εἶναι τοὺς Κόλχους. Αὐτὸς δὲ εἴκασα τῇδε· καὶ ὅτι μελάγχροές εἰσι καὶ οὐλότριχες (καὶ τοῦτο μὲν ἐς οὐδὲν ἀνήκει· εἰσὶ γὰρ καὶ ἕτεροι τοιοῦτοι), ἀλλὰ τοῖσδε καὶ μᾶλλον ὅτι μοῦνοι πάντων ἀνθρώπων Κόλχοι καὶ Αἰγύπτιοι καὶ Αἰθίοπες περιτάμ-

2+2=...

Given a choice between this Greek script, this Japanese character, or this basic math operation, if I ask: "What do you see?", almost all people will say the arithmetic operation.

L'HOMME NE VOIT QUE CE QU'IL VEUT BIEN VOIR

During the Japanese air raid on Pearl Harbor[19], the massive fleet flew right over an observation post. The American lookouts glanced up and grumbled, "They're carrying out maneuvers and haven't even warned us…"

It it has all gone pear-shaped!

If I ask you to look at the image of the pear above and tell me what it says, most of you won't immediately notice that the word "it" is deliberately repeated…

The young girl from London's response:

The young girl understood the old man's trick. She picked up a pebble, held it in her hand, then dropped it on the ground among thousands of others. She claimed she had chosen the white one and proved it by pointing to the black pebble left in the bag.

It's the creative state of mind that counts more than the tools or techniques. We've selected two to focus on.

---

19 December 7, 1941.

10. TWO CREATIVE TECHNIQUES

BISOCIATION[20]

This technique has led to many inventions. Creators simply observed two separate elements and combined them to create a third – the invention itself.

Bisociation is a key concept in lateral thinking. It refers to a connection made between ideas or concepts that are usually unrelated or different.

Bisociation differs from association, which links similar ideas.

One example is the Bic disposable lighter. We can imagine that the inventor simply combined a regular lighter and a rubbish bin, and from that came the idea of a disposable lighter.

Try the exercise yourself. Look around you or, during your next client meeting, see if you can come up with an investment idea or a persuasive argument by combining unrelated elements.

Another example is Gutenberg's invention of the printing press. He combined a wine press and stamp seals to create movable type. It was this bisociation of completely different elements that led to the printing press.

The famous brainstorming technique

The simpler it is to use, the more effective it becomes. Here's a quick guide:

- Idea generation:

An organizer presents a clearly defined problem to a group of participants.

Precision in the question leads to precision in the responses.

- Free and spontaneous expression:

At this stage, all ideas are equally valid:

– There are no taboos and no criticism.
– All ideas are written down where everyone can see them. This creates a cascade of ideas.

- Sorting through the ideas:

– Remove irrelevant suggestions.
– Group similar ideas by theme.
– Select the most relevant ideas.

- Implementation

20 Edward De Bono, *Lateral Thinking*, previously cited.

10 PHRASES THAT KILL IDEAS

1. We've already tried everything. It's impossible.»
2. «We're not big enough for that kind of change.»
3. «That's not our problem.»
4. «Why change? Everything's fine as it is.»
5. «You can't teach an old dog new tricks.»
6. «Let's set up a committee first.»
7. «We've managed just fine without it.»
8. «That would never work here.»
9. «Be realistic.»
10. «Let's not dream too big.»

An expert's perspective

Ali Altinsoy, Chief of Staff Private Banking

Personally, I'm struck by how often the topic of influence comes up in conversations with client advisers. I believe influence is too often confused with manipulation—a way of coercing clients into a specific direction. In my view, there is a fundamental difference: influence aims to expand the number of viable, realistic options, whereas manipulation tends to eliminate them, typically to serve the manipulator's interests.

The goal is not to overcomplicate decisions that may already be difficult. Often, when someone shares a problem, they've already been grappling with it internally, weighing scenarios and risks repeatedly. Still, it's essential to lay out all the relevant options clearly to ensure we understand the client's objectives and needs – and that they, in turn, understand the available solutions, along with their implications.

It is at this point that we can *influence*. First, it's about ensuring that the client has understood all available options, even those we might not recommend based on our specialist expertise. Then, it's about offering a concrete recommendation and taking a clear position to support their decision-making.

Paradoxically, it is often this second step that is missing, even when there's a perception that the client was manipulated or negatively influenced. There's a big difference between saying, *«Here's what I recommend and why,»* and simply saying, *«I definitely wouldn't do that,»* without offering any clear reasoning or alternatives.

One of the key challenges, of course, is ensuring that the recommendations we make are sound. What happens if the client follows our advice, but things don't go as planned? Or if, in hindsight, another option would have been better?

That's why surrounding yourself with specialists—whether internal or external—is essential. In any case, giving advice always involves responsibility, but the final decision must always lie with the client.

Conclusion:

I'm convinced that influencing a client is not only possible but is in fact at the very heart of our profession. Clients turn to us for guidance and expert opinions as they face decisions and projects in a complex world. It is therefore our duty to shed light on areas of uncertainty and provide clear recommendations.

Spring into action!
5 key takeaways and an exercise

FIVE KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. Influence techniques work. Think about reciprocity, commitment, and social proof!
2. Make yourself likable and show empathy.
3. Encourage your clients to make decisions while giving them the freedom to choose.
4. Be creative, it's the mother of all skills.
5. Think differently – don't be afraid to step outside the box!

EXERCICE

Title: Knowing how to influence others.

Aim of the exercise: Understand and act on influence strategies.

Instructions:

- Think of at least two things you do on purpose to influence someone.
- What do you do to come across as likable to your prospects and clients? Name at least three techniques you use.

7

Prospecting

(Or the art of survival)

Behind every client lies a universe of life stories,
of hard work, victories, and pain.
Approach prospecting with passio!

TEACHING OBJECTIVES

After reading this chapter, you will be able to:

- Implement your prospecting plan.
- Make direct phone calls to potential clients.
- Make asking for referrals a natural part of your marketing routine.

Contents table
chapter 7

Back to basics!

When you approach prospecting with discipline, the rest tends to fall into place.

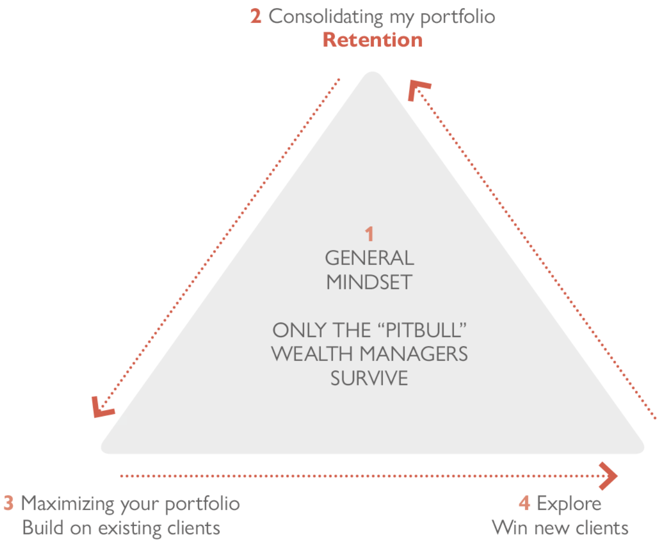
Want a formula? Here's the best one:

Take your list of prospects or clients. Start with the first name, do what needs to be done for them, and once that's complete, move to the next one. When you've reached the end of the list, go back to the beginning and start again.

You know the myth of Sisyphus? That's pretty much it.

1. PROSPECTING, OR HOW TO BUILD YOUR COMMERCIAL SUCCESS

We're now entering the fourth phase of portfolio development. To recap: managing a portfolio means first adopting a commercial mindset (Step 1), then consolidating it (Step 2), maximizing its potential (Step 3), and finally exploring and winning new clients (Step 4 – the focus of this chapter).



Behind every one of your clients, a competitor is lying in wait.

Setting out on a prospecting mission is like traveling to an unfamiliar country: you need to leave your assumptions behind and keep your mind open to new and unknown opportunities.

Five key principles of client acquisition in private wealth management:

1. Acquiring new clients takes more time and energy than developing existing ones through upselling or active referrals.
2. Traditional prospecting methods are often at odds with the culture of discretion that defines private banking.
3. Leave no stone unturned in your portfolio; your hidden gems are already there. (Think Pareto's 80/20 rule[1]).
4. Maintain a constant awareness of "when." Every prospect should appear in your calendar.
5. Active referrals remain the most effective way to grow your client base.

Three key conditions for effective prospecting:

1. Prioritize contact goals over performance targets.

Contact means *relationship*, and that's the essence of the job. Focus on expanding the base of your client network as broadly as possible.

2. Meeting in person always carries more weight.

While digital marketing is highly effective, it should only be seen as a back-up to in-person relationship building.

3. Understand that prospecting never really ends.

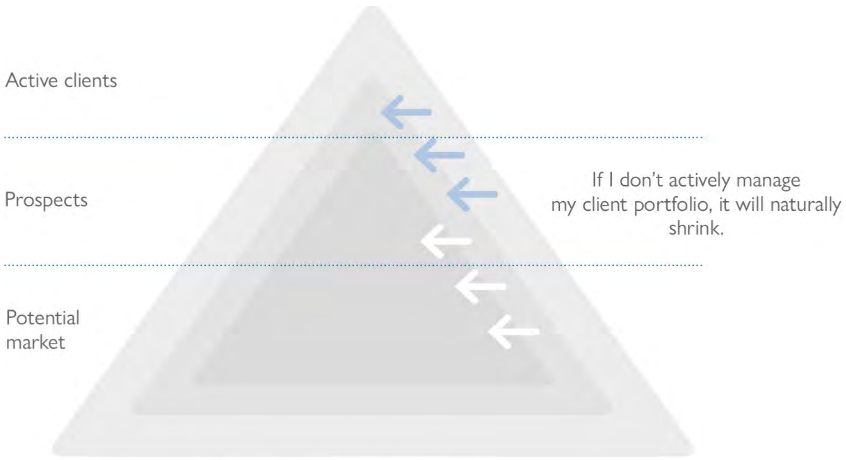
You need the mindset of a diligent worker ant: consistent, steady effort. Keep at it constantly and always make sure no client feels neglected.

"It's more cost-effective to retain clients than to acquire new ones—customer loyalty is the key to long-term profitability."

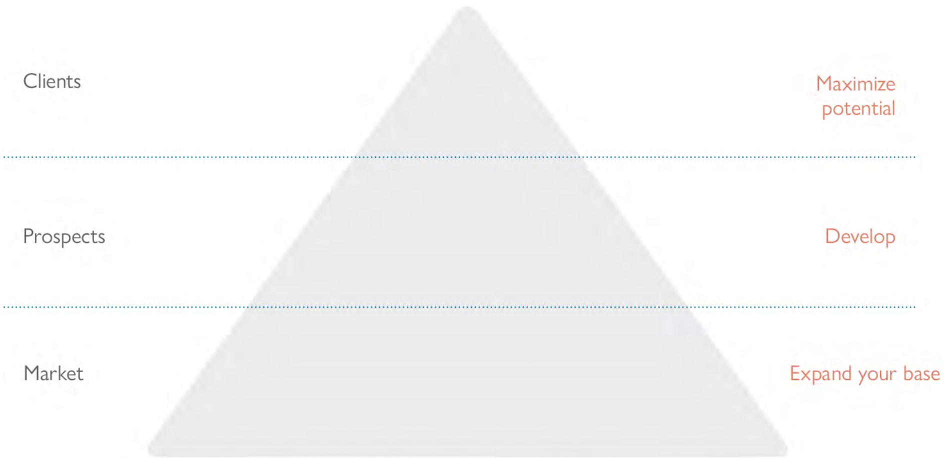
Prospecting is a preventive measure against portfolio erosion. The following diagram illustrates the natural shrinkage of a client portfolio.

A portfolio typically suffers natural erosion of 3 to 5% per year (not counting client inflow and outflow), due to capital drawdown, inheritance transfers, and evolving social trends among banking clients[2].

1 See chapter 2.
2 Increased volatility and an evolving concept of customer loyalty.



The evolution of a client portfolio



Avoid portfolio erosion by working across all three **dimensions**

2. THE REASONS BEHIND PROSPECTING

There are many misconceptions about prospecting. It is often seen as degrading, creating an uncomfortable feeling of begging for something.

In fact, it's quite the opposite: prospecting is a vital act. It gives real meaning to sales in private banking; through it, we discover the extraordinary worlds hidden behind each of our clients.

By contrast: what are the five reasons people don't prospect, or don't prospect enough?[3]

3 CS Training 2007, «Train to RM".

I don't have time
It's fine for beginners, but not for experienced RMs like me.
I don't like prospecting and wouldn't even know how to do it…
I don't know who to reach out to from my prospect and client list.
It's not the RM's role to act as a recruiter.
It's not the RM's role to act as a recruiter.

3. THE BASIC PRINICPLES OF PROSPECTING

1. The manager shouldn't delegate direct prospecting; it's their primary responsibility.
2. Prospecting means smart targeting: meeting the right decision-maker and understanding the client's decision process.
3. Personal contact and in-person meetings remain the most effective way to prospect, though not the only one.
4. Being in sync with the right rhythm and using time strategically can boost prospecting results.
5. Prospecting means putting all your skills into play.

Prospecting is a consistent sales activity.

A portfolio should be uniform, eventually reflecting ourselves, just as our prospects resemble our existing clients.

There is an osmosis effect between the manager's style and their market, clients, and prospects. The "useful" prospects will appreciate what current clients already value. Naturally, clients and prospects share similar traits within the same portfolio.

Prospecting requires strict organization and must follow the segmentation each manager has established in their sales portfolio.

The following questions are crucial in establishing a time budget for prospecting:

- What are the geographical focus areas?
- What are the goals regarding the number of prospects (industry, size) and new clients to acquire?
- How many contacts will I need to make to reach my objectives?

A. AN EFFECTIVE TECHNIQUE

- It's better to invest significant time on a few prospects rather than spreading yourself too thin. ·
- How many prospecting plans fail simply due to lack of follow-up, because the manager targeted too many prospects at once?
- Concentrate all your efforts on one target group, collectively and during a specific period.

- It's better to make a large investment in one segment than to spread your budget across many prospects.

You need to do two things at once…

- Maximize the potential of existing clients in your portfolio to make them profitable, while also acquiring new clients. The "New Name/Old Name" concept isn't new, but it allows for easy and ongoing portfolio balancing, almost instinctively.
- Prioritize the largest commercial potential, but don't neglect the vital 80% of the 80/20 rule.

B. APPLY THE RULE OF CONCENTRIC CIRCLES

Throwing a pebble into water causes a central splash and radiates out in concentric circles. The analogy with prospecting is straightforward: prospects closest to your current clients (in terms of sector, profile, region, interests, volume) are nearest the central impact. After exploring the first circle, you can proceed to the second, and continue outward.

Talk to your prospects about what you're doing with your best clients.

C. PROSPECTING REQUIRES DISCIPLINE AND ORGANIZATION

Time management:

How do you balance the time allocated to prospecting versus looking after current clients?

Ideally, the split should be about 40/50%, always keeping an advantage for new prospects to expand your network.

Preparation:

Preparation makes improvisation easier and more effective.

Clients should clearly see the RM's preparation through:

- Written documents brought to meetings
- An agenda shared in advance
- Specific, personalized proposals
- Clear notes and questions highlighted by the RM.

4. PROSPECTING IS BUSINESS DEVELOPMENT

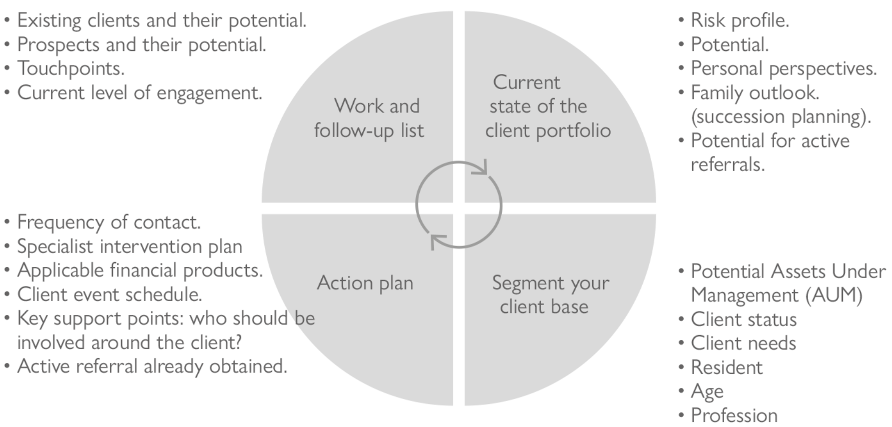
D. THE GENERAL CONCEPT

Let's revisit the general concept and take a step back to better understand the prospecting process. The following diagram outlines the possible stages of a prospecting approach, including the criteria and content for each step. It shows what needs to be done to prospect effectively.

There are five prerequisites before applying this framework:

1. Set goals and deadlines for your prospecting efforts to track success.
2. Identify the specific value you intend to offer each client.
3. Organize visits and determine how often they should occur.
4. Have a clear view of the bank's network of specialists and experts you can call on.
5. Rely on your most important prospecting tool: a list of prospects!

General concept



Each of our prospects is
currently a customer of another bank.

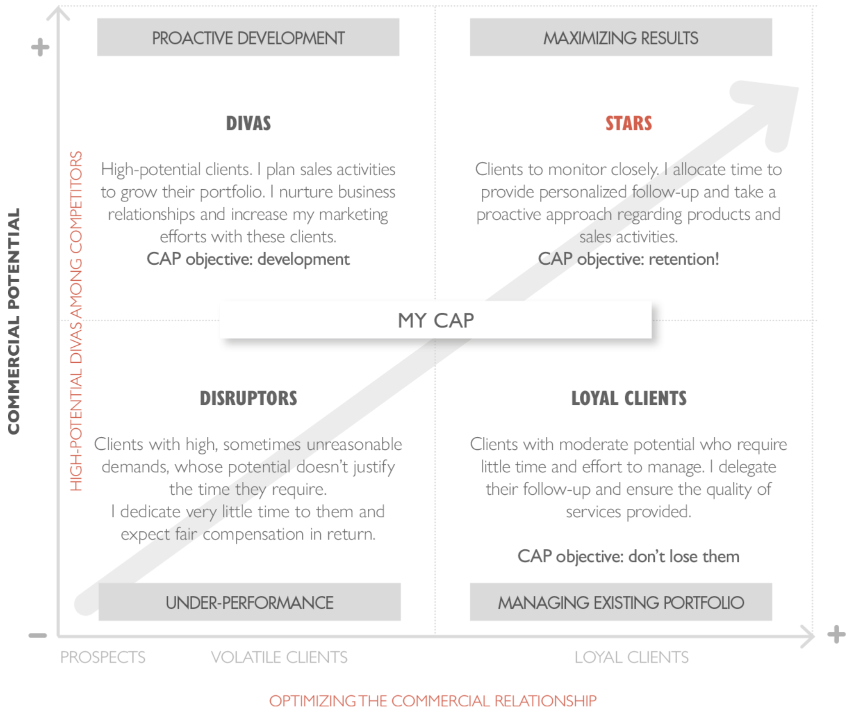
E. THE ALL-IMPORTANT LIST

The tool is so simple it almost insults our intelligence. It's about keeping a close eye on your top 40 list and constantly asking yourself:

Who should I be engaging with, and what should I do?

This theme will come up repeatedly throughout this book. Having a list to hand is both a concrete act and a symbolic one. It's simply about maintaining disciplined relationships with all your contacts.

A variation of the list, and its natural extension, is the Commercial Action Plan (CAP).



Here is a brief reminder (see also Chapter 2) in three steps:

1. **Create a list of the 50 most promising clients and prospects**, first defining what "potential" means.

This list should be detailed with each contact's information.

Prospect sources may include:

- Potential referrers;
- Classic referral targets such as trustees, lawyers, and notaries;
- Networks related to schools, universities, or former colleagues;
- Sports networks;
- Connections on LinkedIn;
- Personal and family networks.

CLIENTS AND PROSPECTS	DETAILS	PRIORITY LEVEL (1–10)	SPECIFIC HOOK
			Business introducer
			Request for appointment
			Share the bank's latest developments
			Overview of services
			See them again

2. Define value propositions tailored to each profile.
3. Reserve time slots for phone prospecting to arrange meetings.

F. METHODS FOR ACQUIRING CLIENTS

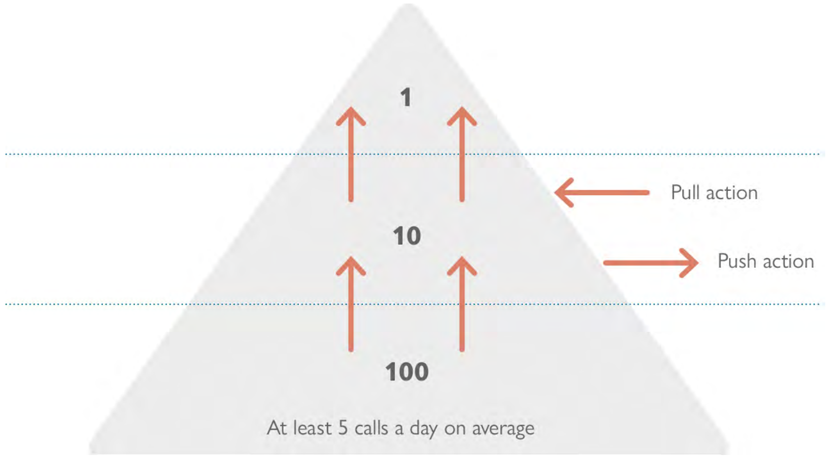
The following table addresses this question.

It also outlines the manager's personal potential. At the centre, we indicate the various sources of capital contributions from potential clients.

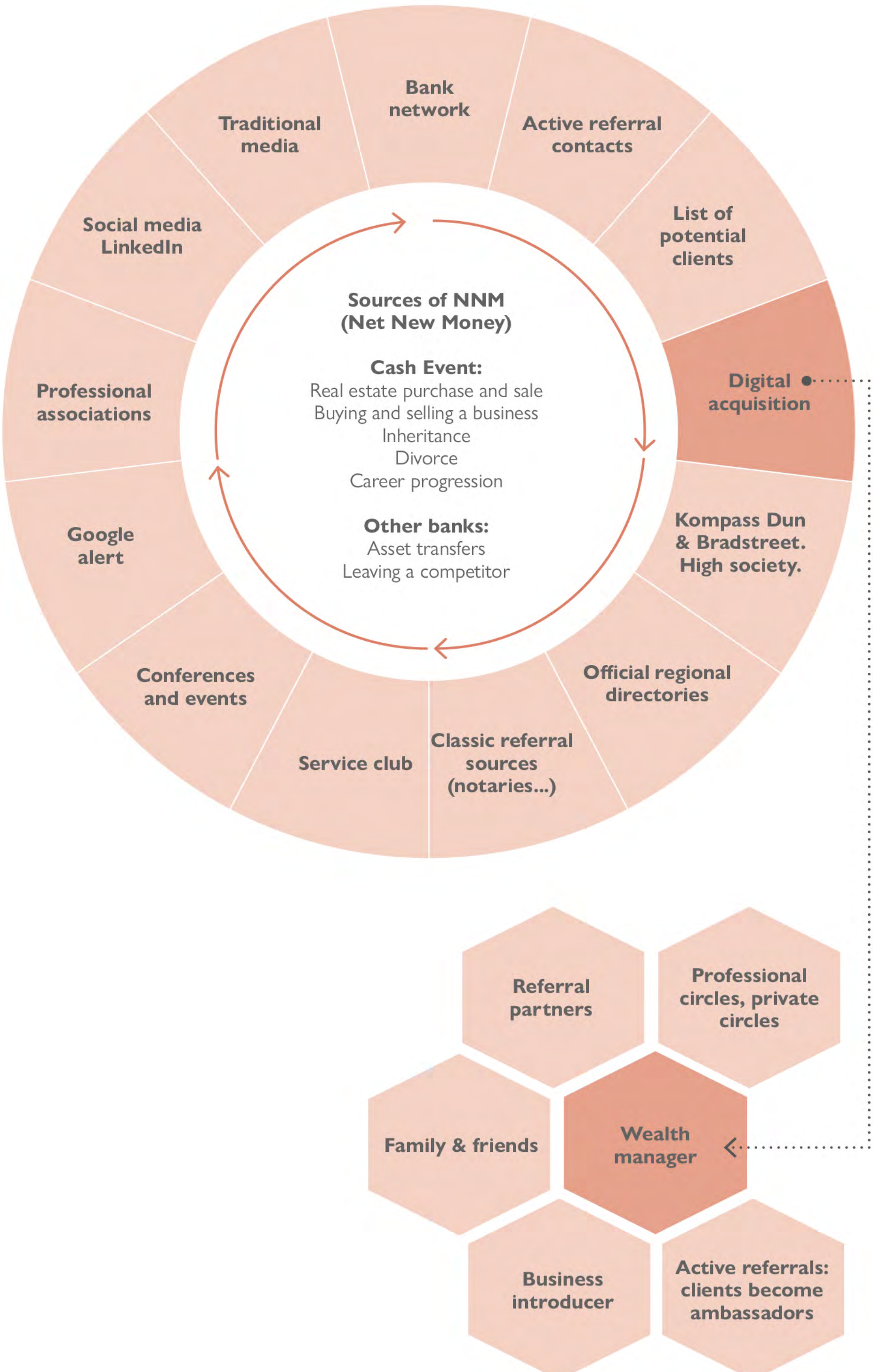
IT'S THE LUMBERJACK WHO SUCCEEDS IN SALES!

What matters is the steady continuation of effort, not how much you do at once. Regardless of the routine you pick (whether daily or every other day), it's the regularity of your efforts that drives results and prevents you from being caught off guard. By adopting the lumberjack's mindset, you won't be relying on mere opportunity (the strategy of those who have none!).

Just be sure to manage your ability to keep up with your prospecting targets without getting overwhelmed.



The pyramid illustrates the effort required to secure an additional client. Our experience shows that if you reasonably make five prospecting, contact, or follow-up calls per day, your schedule will soon be filled with valuable business appointments.



Bank network
Active referral contacts
List of potential clients
Digital acquisition
Kompass Dun & Bradstreet. High society.
Official regional directories
Classic referral sources (notaries...)
Service club
Conferences and events
Google alert
Professional associations
Social media LinkedIn
Traditional media
Sources of NNM (Net New Money)
Cash Event:
Real estate purchase and sale
Buying and selling a business
Inheritance
Divorce
Career progression
Other banks:
Asset transfers
Leaving a competitor
Referral partners
Professional circles, private circles
Family & friends
Wealth manager
Business introducer
Active referrals: clients become ambassadors

G. EVENTS: A RICH SOURCE OF CONTACTS

Banks regularly host events for clients and prospects alike. The event serves as a pretext to strengthen business relationships.

This is the art of public relations, demanding both expertise and interpersonal skills that a manager must master. If you attend, the way you conduct yourself can help make the event a success.

How? By being pleasant, sociable, well-mannered, and by making everyone you speak to feel valued. That's the best way to stand out. An event is always a long-term investment.

The objective of an event is simple: to invite people who might become clients in the future. The themes can be very diverse – everything from sports and music to art and charity galas.

The aim of this section is to outline the behaviors to adopt during these events.

At an event, patience and subtlety are essential. It would be inappropriate to try to sell your services overtly – this is not just about politeness but about sales tactics.

Prospecting must be done discreetly. Everyone appreciates positive, cheerful behavior that respects social norms. This is especially true during social events where communities come together.

Here are four things to do before going to an event:

1. Mentally prepare yourself to feel comfortable.
2. Focus on projecting positive energy.
3. Try to get the guest list – it's really helpful but not always available.
4. Have fun! Play the "profiler"[4] game by guessing people's professions, sports, hobbies, etc. Then see if you were right by talking to them. You'll be surprised by your instincts!

There are two key challenges at an event: making initial contact and saying goodbye.

Here are 10 tips to help you make the most of the events your organization hosts.

Two prerequisites:

- **Set a clear, specific goal for attending the event.** Know exactly what you want to achieve — this will shape your behavior. Ask yourself: What do I want to get out of this evening?
- **Adopt an attitude** that aligns with your objective. Assert yourself through eye contact, a confident smile, and positive energy.

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4 Inspired by Nicholas Boothman, *How to Make People Like You in 90 Seconds or Less*, Workman Adult, 2008.

1. Respect the dress code:

If no dress code is specified, opt for classic and understated.

2. Know how to introduce yourself:

"The tone sets the mood": Introduce yourself clearly and calmly, then pause to allow your interlocutor to introduce themselves. Always introduce yourself when shaking hands for the first time. Repeat the person's name when they introduce themselves. This not only shows respect but it also helps you remember it. If they don't say their name, feel free to ask.

3. Welcoming guests:

If you're hosting, the welcome is key, so plan it well. Don't hold back on your smile. Follow the usual etiquette (ladies first, then rank).

4. Guest introductions:

Acting as the intermediary during introductions is a strategic advantage – it often leads to future reciprocation. When introducing someone, highlight one of their strengths, whether it's a professional skill, personal quality, or specific expertise).

Focus and good manners:

Give the person you've just been introduced to 150% of your attention. For a few moments, act as though they're the most important person in the world. Looking around in search of someone 'more important' can border on a diplomatic faux pas. If you really must move on, excuse yourself politely ("May I excuse myself for a moment?") before approaching the person you had your eye on. Be warned: this move carries some risk.

5. Joining a group or conversation:

If you want to join a group, step into the circle and listen carefully. Wait for someone to acknowledge you – this happens in 90% of cases. If no one does, wait for a pause in the conversation, say something relevant, and then introduce yourself.

It usually starts with eye contact. Be mindful of social distances and stand where the group can clearly see you. When leaving, do so gracefully: offer a handshake or business card, and perhaps express an intention to follow up (or not).

6. Starting and maintaining a conversation

People remember good listeners far more than talkers – especially those who are pleasant, smiling, and well-mannered.

What do humans think about? Above all, themselves. A smile and some synchronization go a long way; empathy helps everything flow naturally. Prepare in advance by learning about the speaker or artist. Choose topics linked to the event, ask thoughtful questions, and keep the conversation going in a way that highlights your conversation partners.

7. Take the initiative:

Walk over to someone you haven't met yet, especially if they're on their own. Your introduction should have a clear reason behind it. Kick things off with a comment or question linked to the event.

8. A must: the business card

At some point, it's time to offer your business card. It's both a gesture of goodwill and an essential networking tool. When someone gives you theirs, they're sharing a part of themselves. The Asian style of exchanging cards – with both hands and care – is especially appropriate. It's an elegant, respectful, and attentive gesture. Take a moment to receive the card properly, look at it, and avoid tucking it away too casually. Giving your own card can naturally lead to requesting theirs. You might even jot down a detail on the back to remember them by after the event.

Don't expect immediate results; focus on making the connection. The relationship can develop later, for example via LinkedIn.

9. Five key behaviors to adopt:

- You're being observed, so stay alert, discreet, and attentive.
- Go easy on the food and drink. Networking and canapés don't mix – save the snacks for later. (And free hands are essential for handshakes).
- Respect personal space. Don't dominate the conversation and steer clear of potentially controversial topics (in this context).
- Never try to sell your bank at an event – it's not the time or place.

If attending with colleagues from the same bank, give instructions to split up and avoid clustering. Prepare a relevant question to ask the speaker; this can help you stand out and spark new conversations afterwards, both with the speakers themselves and other conference participants. In any case, it's a good way of building contacts[5].

10. What do I do next, with all the people I've shaken hands with?

Follow through and do what was promised. Send a quick thank-you note for the invitation. Connect on LinkedIn the next day with everyone you met. And if you talked about setting up a meeting, follow up by phone to make it happen.

5 A technique inspired by Vanessa Neil from P.G. Bank.

FIVE KEY FORMALITIES FOR EVENTS

1. **Eye contact –** It's a powerful communication tool! (What color are their eyes?)
2. **Smile –** It's the most positive and universal form of nonverbal language.
3. **Introduce yourself confidently**, as if you've known them forever.
4. **Quickly find common ground.**
5. Mirror their tone, gestures, and posture to build rapport.

H. PROSPECTING THROUGH SOCIAL MEDIA (SOCIAL SELLING)

Social selling is a strategy for initiating contact and building relationships with prospects through social media.

It has largely replaced traditional sales tactics in both B2B and B2C markets.

What are the benefits of social selling?

1. It helps reach the right decision-makers, at the right time, with the right message (you'll be knocking on the right doors).
2. It introduces a personal dimension that is absent from cold calling. This is ideal for nurturing authentic relationships.
3. It makes prospecting easier.
4. It enhances the synergy between the human and the digital.
5. Prospects are naturally more engaged thanks to the principles of social buying.

FIVE PRINCIPLES TO BETTER UNDERSTAND SOCIAL SELLING

1. By being on a social platform, your prospects have effectively qualified themselves.
2. For banking prospecting, LinkedIn is simply a tool to speed up connections, nothing more!
3. Think *social* **before** *selling*.
4. It's about supporting – and definitely not selling.
5. Your top competitors are already using social selling.

If you're still on the fence – and some people are – here's a quick test to run it through:

Is it compatible with the banking sector?	**OUI**
Is it acceptable for our private clients?	**OUI**
Is it ethically sound?	**OUI**

What makes LinkedIn particularly useful – and it's the platform we'll focus on – is that it gives insight into members' activity. You can gauge how engaged a prospect is by looking at how much information they share on the platform.

As we will see in the sales funnel, approach tactics must be smooth, with light, subtle but persistent touches[6].

1. The initial contact should be smooth; the follow-up more assertive, tailored to the responses of our contacts.
2. Establish yourself in your niche patiently and gently.
3. Pay attention to your prospect's *psychological reaction*[7]*!*
4. Keep things simple but follow them through to the end.
5. Only the pitbull managers survive in the long run.

Traditional selling *versus* social selling[8]

TRADITIONAL SELLING	SOCIAL SELLING
Search	**Search**
Buying prospect lists Limited personal contacts Blocked by intermediaries	Using professional networks Making contact on social media Direct access to key decision-makers
Understand	**Understand**
Random or outdated contacts Limited data Irrelevant information	Focus on genuine "opt-in" relationships Gathering online intelligence Discovering social insights
Interact	**Interact**
Cold calling Scripted sales pitches One-size-fits-all process	Leveraging proactive information shared by prospects Having relevant, focused conversations Supporting the buyer's journey

6 According to research by German psychologist Hermann Ebbinghaus on memory (the forgetting curve), we forget 90% of what we've learned after just three days.
7 Psychological reactance refers to our instinctive resistance to having our freedom of choice restricted.
8 Online course on LinkedIn.

How does it work?

1. **On LinkedIn, focus on building relationships with the right people – and don't try to sell!**
2. Rely on your bank's brand.
3. A strong professional brand will naturally enhance your credibility.
4. Don't expect immediate results. Social selling takes time!
5. Build smart relationships: nurture your prospects with valuable content. They'll remember you when the time comes.
6. Join groups and forums where your prospects are already active to create natural points of connection.
7. Share your expertise and add value to your community. How? By posting relevant, useful content and insights that address your prospects' concerns. It builds credibility.
8. Social selling isn't about increasing your number of contacts, but about developing the right relationships for your brand.
9. If you reach out to prospects who are mismatched, you'll come across as insincere.

I. TIPS FOR USING LINKEDIN

For your profile:

- Use a recent, high-resolution profile photo (it makes your profile up to 14 times more likely to be viewed).
- Use a banner that clearly highlights your strengths.
- Include a headline (under your photo) that sums up in two lines what you offer: your areas of expertise and unique selling points.
- Write the headline with the reader in mind, not about yourself.
- Make sure your contact details are complete – prospects should be able to get in touch with minimal effort.

Your profile should answer three key questions:

- What is our profession and what service do we provide?
- What sets us apart from the competition?
- What problems can we help solve? (*Pain points*)

What wins people over are your skills and how well you respond to common banking concerns. There must be no discrimination when people request to open an account – legal rules must be followed. It's fine to respond to people who get in touch.

Every message should be personalized.

Actions to take:

- Share posts written by others.
- Create your own posts and comments.

- Share bank content and repost from the bank to increase visibility.
- Offer something of value (insight, content) – avoid promoting a product!

Best practices:

- Always send connection requests to:
- – People you've met in person at events or meetings;
- – People you've had a scheduled meeting with;
- – People who have liked your posts;
- – Connections of your existing contacts.
- Take inspiration from your top clients' networks – there's no need to hurry, you're building relationships, not collecting names.

Even if prospecting doesn't always lead to immediate sales, it allows you to observe how prospects respond to your outreach and identify behavioral trends. By taking the time to build strong relationships, prospects will remember you when they're ready to take the next step.

Join the most relevant LinkedIn groups and forums.

Which groups do your prospects and clients belong to?

Once you've identified them by looking at their profiles, join the same groups and introduce yourself with a relevant message.

Build and grow your network:

- **Be clear and to the point.**

Avoid sending too many connection requests or generic messages. Social selling is about forming genuine relationships.

- **When targeting specific individuals:**
- – Like or share their posts before reaching out
- – Send congratulations on milestones
- – Give feedback on specific points
- – Message them to check in
- – Acknowledge work anniversaries or birthdays.

An example of a sales funnel

This funnel can also be applied to other channels beyond LinkedIn, such as prospect lists, text messages, emails, and video emails.

DAY 1

This is the day you meet in real life

DAY 2

Send an invitation on LinkedIn with a simple message

DAY 4

Remerciement pour avoir accepté l'invitation
Message personnalisé

Follow up on a key point from the initial meeting.
Send an article or document directly related to the discussion on the day.

DAY 10

Like or comment on one of the contact's posts.

Repost a bank publication.
Share an article they might find interesting.

DAY 20

Message them directly to suggest a meet-up

Examples of touchpoints
- Recommend they connect with an internal expert at the bank
- Congratulate them on an anniversary
- Go on their profile (they will see)
- Share a tip from the bank
- **Invite them to a professional or cultural event**

5. RECRUITING BUSINESS REFERRERS

Prospecting doesn't have to be done alone; both internal and external resources are available and should be used. One such resource is business introducers. Almost all financial institutions offer formal introducer agreements. The terms of remuneration may vary, but having a contract is essential to ensure transparency. Legal departments are well-versed in handling such arrangements with external parties.

Who can act as a business introducer?

1. The manager must be discerning in their selection. Introducers should be trusted individuals already known to both the bank and the relationship manager.
2. The manager should clearly outline their role, the bank's technical resources, the platforms they use, and the full range of products and services. Since the introducer will act as an external representative, it's vital they understand the bank's offering in depth.
3. Tell your future introducer about how we work using the active referral technique. Their role is very similar to this method.
4. Explain that this is also a way for a bank to acquire new clients through a chain of trust; relationships between people who trust one another. The relationship manager trusts the business referrer, who in turn trusts the people they recommend.
5. Provide a detailed explanation of the methodology and operational framework tied to the business introducer agreement, including the terms relating to commercial contacts and payment terms.

With this framework in place, ask yourself: who in your professional network could be a potential referrer?

Draw up a list of 10 contacts and plan specific meetings with each of them.

Take stock of your acquisition strategy.

NEGOTIATION STATUS / ACQUISITION STRATEGY	ACQUISITION	DEVELOPMENT	RETENTION WIN-BACK
Business introducers			
Development of existing clients			
Private and family networks			
Identified prospects			
Active referrals			
Share of wallet (the share of a client's assets in our bank)			
Cross-selling			
Second generation			

6. WHY YOU SHOULD DEVELOP TWO-PERSON VISITS AND JOINT NEGOTIATIONS IN PROSPECTING

What's the advantage of a two-person visit?

If such an approach is clearly beneficial when visiting existing clients, its value increases significantly during the prospecting phase. In our field research, we observed that this practice is still relatively uncommon. It is certainly not established as a formal sales technique. When it does occur, it tends to be opportunistic, with "partners" brought in solely for their expertise, which is already a strong point.

Who is involved?

- A specialist or colleague with a clearly defined role;
- A line manager or director, provided the visit is carefully prepared and presented as a special event.

A joint visit enhances the client's perception of value. Colleagues within our organization are a key asset; they bring knowledge we may not have. Two-person visits offer nothing but advantages: they elevate the client, offer reassurance, project a strong internal team spirit, convey a broader range of solutions, and highlight individual expertise.

Individualism is the death of the bank…

Five key benefits

1. Numerical presence creates impact: clients are often impressed by the attention of two professionals.
2. Further proof that a true team is working for the client.
3. Two heads are better than one.
4. Highlight the roles of everyone present, including specialists.
5. The follow-up, analysis, and proposals will be sharper thanks to combined active listening.

A. GUIDELINES FOR CONDUCTING JOINT VISITS

Code of conduct

Begin by introducing everyone present to reinforce the idea that each person is there to serve the client, bringing their own area of expertise.

Set out the meeting's agenda, which should be more structured than a one-to-one conversation.

Organizational guidelines

Plan who speaks and when – make sure responsibilities are clear. Appoint one person to lead the conversation.

Criteria for preparing a two-person visit:

1. Clearly define the purpose of the visit and understand the context and environment (client's activities, situation, and history). For joint visits, it is best to inform the client in advance.
2. Anticipate the client's possible needs.
3. Review any proposals the relationship manager may have already made (e.g. product suggestions), but only if the client's needs are known and the visit is part of an exploratory phase.
4. Assess what success looks like from the client's perspective.
5. Set out a clear plan for post-visit follow-up.
6. Prepare using a structured checklist.
7. One person should be responsible for notetaking (take more notes than usual).

Map out the flow of the meeting and decide in advance who will say what.

Watch out:

There shouldn't be a power struggle between the relationship managers; neither should dominate the other. Each must play their part!

Respect each other's areas of expertise and use collaborative language ("we") rather than arrogant "I" statements.

A. DEBRIEF IMMEDIATELY AFTER THE MEETING

- It helps maximize "cross-fertilization" between team members.
- Encourage a culture of kind, constructive feedback within the team.

- Two-person visits are a rare and valuable learning experience for honing negotiation skills – they provide real, first-hand exposure.
- It's a chance to reflect, reassess, and adjust course quickly.

What mindset should you adopt for the debrief?

Only constructive points should be raised:

- Feedback in the form of criticism brings cooperation to an end.
- Highlight strengths first, then areas for improvement.
- Focus only on concrete outcomes – be SMART, keep it KISS.[9]
- Practice active listening and respect each other's speaking time.
- Prepare notes in writing if needed.

Three key questions for mutual debriefing:

- What did I like about how you handled the meeting?
- What would I have personally done differently?
- What are my two recommendations?

1 + 1 = 3

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11 questions to evaluate a two-person client visit:

1. *What did we learn about the client and the meeting?*
2. *What did we do well?*
3. *Which objectives did we actually meet?*
4. *Were we wrong about anything? If so, what?*
5. *Did we forget anything?*
6. *5. Did we lack confidence at any point?*
7. *Did we talk too much and listen too little?*
8. *Did we focus too much on ourselves and not enough on the client?*
9. *Were we too nervous? If so, why?*
10. *What should we do differently or better next time?*
11. *What should we do immediately following the meeting?*

Exercise for tomorrow:

Define within your group potential opportunities for an upcoming two-person meeting:

Who will be in your pair?

What type of client will you meet?

With what objectives?

When could you schedule the next two-person meeting?

9 KISS: Keep It Simple Short.

7. THE TELEPHONE AS A PROSPECTING TOOL

Two current observations:

1. The telephone is making a comeback as way to reach prospects again. Social media has significantly reduced competition compared to before.

2. Speaking directly with your prospect remains superior to all other current forms of communication (digital or otherwise).

Clients we reach by phone don't mind us calling them; what they dislike is being called without anything meaningful to say.
(Nicolas Caron)

A. HOW TO SECURE APPOINTMENTS

Here's an appointment-setting dialog that we'll use as a guide throughout this section.

Relationship manager: *Hello, is this Jean Meyer?*

Client: *Yes, speaking. Who's calling?*

RM: *My name is [first name + surname], I'm a [job title] at XX Bank. We're indirectly in touch through your subsidiary, which we're financing as part of the Léman project in Martigny.*

Client: *Right, yes, we did run into a few issues with that.*

RM: *True. That's the nature of big projects—there are always a few snags. But we sorted them quickly; our Neuchâtel team made sure of that. Sorry about the inconvenience. I'm actually calling now about something else—I'd like to meet in the next few weeks to talk through your investments. We've got a new set of financial products that I think would really suit your needs.*

Client: *Ah, you want to sell me something… but I already have everything I need in terms of banking partners. I don't want to waste your time.*

RM: *Meeting you would be no waste of time at all—it would be a real pleasure. Don't worry, I'm not here to sell you anything. Just give me 45 minutes next week to introduce ourselves and our range of financial products. What day would suit you best?*

Client: *I'm not sure there's any point…*

RM: *At the very least, we'll get to know each other, and you'll have some extra information to compare with what your usual partners offer. How about Thursday afternoon? Is there a time that works best for you?*

Client: *Alright, if you insist. Let's say 5:30 p.m..*

RM: *Thank you so much. I look forward to meeting you—Thursday at 5:30, in your Lausanne office. Have a great day, Mr Meyer.*

Three criteria for effective preparation:

1. **Atmosphere – It's something people *feel*.**
2. **Attitude – It's something people *pick up on*.**
3. **Delivery – It's something people *hear*.**

Atmosphere is felt:

- Keep your environment distraction-free.
- Avoid making unnecessary noise.
- No fidgeting or excessive movement.
- Speak in the present tense and avoid negative expressions.
- Don't adopt a submissive stance (in the NLP sense).

Tip: Use noise-canceling headphones or AirPods.

Attitude is picked up on:

- Relax and explain what you're doing (e.g. "I'm just checking my calendar").
- Be comfortable and spread good energy.
- Focus on what you're going to say.
- Pay attention to the smallest details.
- Enunciate clearly, use pauses, and maintain a good rhythm.

Tip: Force yourself to smile!

Delivery is heard:

- Use a pleasant tone.
- Never shout.
- Avoid distracting sounds.
- Don't interrupt.
- Respect pauses and silences.

Tip: Speak more slowly!

Preparation: the only real key to success:

- What is my goal?
- What information do I need before picking up the phone?
- Have the relevant documents to hand.
- What objections might the client raise, and how can I handle them?
- Have something to take notes with.

B. GETTING PAST THE GATEKEEPER

The assistant gatekeeper is becoming increasingly rare. There are now leaner administrative teams than in the past, and clients with responsibilities are more autonomous. By way of comparison, there used to be one management assistant per manager; today, the ratio has shifted to one assistant for every three to five managers.

Nonetheless, this gatekeeper still exists.

Here's a suggested approach for successfully getting past this gatekeeper:

STAGES OF SECURING AN APPOINTMENT	BEHAVIORS TO ADOPT	SALES PRINCIPLES
Ask to speak to your target contact.	Smile, it's reassuring.	*Use positive social cues.*
Be clear, distinct, and precise in your greeting. Introduction: first name, surname, company… your role, your area of expertise.	Pause and let them react. Say something positive ("I'm glad to be speaking with you…») and remember their name – this person is very important to you.	*Show the same respect as you would to their manager. Check availability.*
Specific opening line for the assistant: The purpose of my call is to meet with Mr XX.	Follow up with a concise pitch. Explain things as you would to their manager. Use an active referral if possible.	*Answer the obvious question: "What is this regarding?"*
Propose a suitable alternative or ask an open-ended question.	"When would be a good time to reach your manager?" Follow your intuition.	*Be proactive and take the initiative.*
Handling their objections – perhaps the assistant manages the diary?	Acknowledge and value their role. Elevate the conversation: this is a strategic, personal, and confidential proposal.	*If the interaction feels right: shift to a more emotional tone – "Could you help me?"*
Respond to objections, bounce back, and steer the conversation back to the meeting request.	Stay relaxed – the stronger the objection, the wider your smile! It's an opportunity to clarify your message.	*Stand your ground, with poise and diplomacy.*
Wrap up and rephrase.	If the answer is no, ask if you may call again later.	*The second attempt is often more effective.*
Record the outcome and thank them, whatever the result.	Secure the client's commitment to a meeting or a follow-up call.	*Who should hang up last? Me!*

A phone call brings us into a world we cannot see and to which we weren't invited!

C. THE PHONE PITCH / OPENING LINE

Definition:

The opening line is a pitch designed to capture your interlocutor's attention. In appointment setting, it comes immediately after your introduction.

Formulating the opening line is the most important part of setting an appointment by phone.

What are the objectives of the pitch/opening line?

To make the prospect want to meet you.

We have a lot to say but only a limited amount of time.

What should the opening line include?

Your line should be unique and personalized, focusing on the client. It must be useful and centered on your contact's business.

"We (my bank and I) would like to meet with you to present a range of financial products that we reserve exclusively for our privileged clients.

You are a well-known professional in our region, and this will give you the opportunity to compare our offers with those of your current banking partners. I suggest we meet in the coming weeks…"

The explanatory sentence comes after the opening line.

It answers the client's question: Why do you want to meet me?"

The explanation should be brief; you need to keep returning to the appointment request like a broken record.

1. Don't go into details; pique their curiosity and they'll agree to the meeting to find out more.
2. Be enthusiastic and confident (if you believe in it, you'll be convincing); don't downplay your request (not just a quick chat…).
3. Only speak about them, emphasizing the benefits for their business in meeting your bank.

STEPS FOR MAKING AN APPOINTMENT (MUCH OF THIS REPEATS THE PREVIOUS TABLE)
Identify the person you're speaking with
Clear, precise greetings including first name, last name, XX bank
Opening sentence: the reason for my call is to… [get straight to the point]
Explanatory sentence (only when necessary) + suggest appointments (with a preferred alternative)
Address objections, redirect, and continue to ask for the appointment
Wrap up and rephrase
Note the outcome and express thanks

D. EFFECTIVE STRATEGIES FOR SECURING APPOINTMENTS BY PHONE

Basic phone behavior: listening

How to listen well:

- Do not interrupt; wait for their second sentence.
- Jot down notes.
- Respond to what your interlocutor says.
- Use acknowledgments to "smooth" the conversation and give listening signals ("Yes, indeed, I see, I understand…").
- Regularly summarize (by paraphrasing) to show you're on the same wavelength.

You have to listen properly to be properly heard!

A lot of wealth managers still think there is something slightly degrading about prospecting over the phone. This is a false and outdated perception; phone prospecting is an integral part of prospecting techniques and is generally accepted by clients as a normal way to make contact.

Managers mainly fear they might harass clients too much.

How do we define harassment and its boundaries?

It's when the client says no, and I call them anyway.

It's when I call them 10 times in a row.

It's when they give me a timeframe and it's not respected.

To distinguish persistence from harassment on the phone, set yourself limits; personally, I never insist beyond a second refusal.

Five practical tips:

1. Have a script in front of you: write down your hook and opening lines.
2. Make calls from a quiet, distraction-free environment.
3. Call mobiles rather than landlines (more personal, though potentially more disruptive).
4. Establish a phone rhythm or "samba" – the first calls are challenging, but it becomes easier as you go.
5. Keep Google and your contact's LinkedIn profile handy.

What should the relationship be like?

- The relationship should be warm and full of empathy.
- The relationship should be personalized (I use their name).
- The relationship should be professional; you have prepared their file.

What do our contacts expect?

- To be listened to and taken care of by a banking professional.
- To be reassured; clients only buy what they understand.
- Not to have to decipher obscure language.
- To have a sincere, transparent, committed, and reliable contact.

How can you be tenacious yet graceful at the same time?

It means having a clear goal (the face-to-face meeting) during your call and not letting go of it, while also understanding when to ease off.

It's also:

- Expressing the goals of the meeting.
- Daring to "battle" to secure a meeting.
- Being enthusiastic and full of empathy!

How should you do it?

- Restate and refocus on the appointment request.
- Stay firm but with a smile and grace.
- Employ the bounce-back technique as a follow-up: "That's exactly why I want to meet with you [+ favorable alternative]."
- Use polite and appreciative phrases.

CHARACTERISTICS OF YOUR SPEECH	HOW TO EXPRESS IT
Specific and to the point	Short, direct phrases
Kiss = Keep It Simple and Short	No jargon; simple language
Useful and effective	Every word adds value + no value judgments
Measurable and verifiable	Concrete facts + use present tense

E. HOW TO HANDLE OBJECTIONS OVER THE PHONE

This is how it works:

Acknowledgement of the objection.
+
Response + bounce back & advantages of meeting us!
+
Appointment proposal + alternative favorable date/time.

Table of objections with suggested responses:

OBJECTIONS	HOW TO RESPOND
He's in a meeting.	*I understand, I don't want to disturb him now. When would be a good time to speak with him?*
I know he's not interested.	*That's understandable at this point, yet I'm confident he might find value in our bank's solutions. It's important that we meet.*
I'm not going to transfer the call. What is it about?	*The purpose of my call is to outline our bank's services, which you probably know. I'm from XXX bank, that's why I want to meet with Mr… Are you the one managing his schedule??*
We already have a banking partner.	*Of course, that's completely understandable… A comparative offer can only be of interest to your manager. I suggest we arrange a meeting.*
We know you already, it's not the right time.	*That's good to hear! It's important, but not urgent. When would be a good time for me to call back?* *Do you happen to manage their schedule? If so, I suggest… (or favorable alternative)*
Send me some documentation that I can pass on.	*You know what usually happens to documentation; that's why I'd rather meet in person.*
Contact us again in six months.	*Of course, but does Mr. XX have any availability before that date? The meeting will last a maximum of 40 minutes with our bank and one of our specialists in…*

The following exercise helps you train yourself in using positive language:

POSITIVE / NEGATIVE EXPRESSIONS	RESPOND YES / NO?
Yes, of course, absolutely, perfectly, I, we	
"I will take care of that immediately, personally"	
Advise, offer	
Problems, worries, never, impossible	
Maybe, possibly, no doubt	
"I'll process your request as soon as possible..."	
Fast, immediate, right away	
No, absolutely not, definitely not	
"You can count on me"	
I can't, I don't know, I don't want to	

Disruptions on the telephone:

Phone calls cause us to lose 40% of the interactions we would have in face-to-face meetings. Why?

- Distractions and background noise.
- The quality of phones and headsets.
- Misinterpretation due to distortion.
- Interruptions in the conversation.

Telephone prospecting performance evaluation form:

EVALUATION / CRITERIA	+ POSITIVE POINTS	IMPROVEMENT POINTS
Making contact: Energy and enthusiasm		
Clear, brief, and engaging personal introduction		
Active listening with notetaking		
Open questions		
Wrapping up and appropriate reformulation		
Spontaneous smiling, warm attitude		
Intonation		
Clear articulation		
Speech rate		
Dynamic behavior without being intrusive		
Use of a CTA (call to action)		

8. THE HOLY GRAIL OF PROSPECTING: ACTIVE REFERRALS

Active Referrals can be a contentious issue, often caught between marketing logic and many preconceived notions. Even today, during our sales seminars for wealth managers, active referrals don't always receive unanimous support despite their proven effectiveness. This tool has now become part of standard commercial practice – all our clients know about it. There's no longer any risk of offending or surprising anyone. The goal of this section is to cover all the fundamentals of active referrals and help you overcome any remaining barriers.

A. WHAT IS AN ACTIVE REFERRAL?

This marketing prospecting technique is both effective and free, helping us to grow our network.

Active referrals are the cornerstone of commercial prospecting in the banking world.

It is the most subtle form of direct marketing we know, allowing us to expand our client portfolio and strengthen social ties with our customers.

The client becomes the driving force behind the commercial development of a client portfolio. This is a direct application of the cascade principle. Network marketing is about the deliberate creation of a social relationship network. Without this personal commitment, the network loses its meaning and becomes a weaker source of both volume and depth in relationships.

Active referrals require a sharp and responsive mindset. The manager needs to spot any sign of openness from the client and stay ready to seize opportunities.

It's a form of co-optation, much like in a private members' club.

Sales is a social relationship before a commercial one.

Beyond being a prospecting technique, active referral is also a valuable tool for expanding your personal network.

Building a network through active referral carries a threefold responsibility:

- to your employer, whose commercial success is linked to yours.
- to your client, who supports you in return for your commitment.
- to yourself, through your social influence and visibility.

This sales reflex helps increase commercial potential. Relationships stay alive through ongoing effort.

The dual nature of active referral

Active referral is both a sales method and a mark of appreciation. It strengthens the commercial relationship while honoring the client's trust.

There are often comparisons between this approach and the idea of the client becoming a brand ambassador. It reflects a shared community of values.

B. ACTIVE REFERRAL IS SIMPLE

The technique is simple: ask a client if they know someone who might be interested in hearing about our services.

When a client provides an active referral, they're **implicitly confirming** their satisfaction. Psychologically, it's a way for them to reinforce their own decision.

How can we spark this snowball effect without explicitly asking?

- Ensure our services are impeccable.
- Maintain close contact with the client.
- Meet with clients in person as often as possible.

- Clearly explain what we do and make sure the client fully understands what we're offering.
- Remain pragmatic and focus on the specifics of the client's request.
- Support the client both psychologically (by offering reassurance) and practically. The thing clients appreciate most is when they are told, *"I'll take care of it."*

It's important to write out your active referral wording so that it becomes second nature – a reflex, not something improvised in the heat of the moment when emotions can get in the way.

Asking for referrals is also a commercial mindset. Here are some key principles to maintain that mindset:

- Be alert to signs of openness from the client.
- Seize the right opportunities to ask for a referral.
- Stay natural and spontaneous.
- Master the timing of your approach.
- Manage the potential "what's in it for me?" expectations.
- Avoid sounding like you're in crisis mode.

C. HOW TO EXPLAIN AND ENCOURAGE ACTIVE REFERRALS WITH CLIENTS?

Client recognition:
Be our ambassador…
We're looking to work only with clients who share our values… We believe in choosing our clients just as carefully as they choose us…

Sharing your experience:
Let those around you benefit from your positive experience with us…

Proactive approach:
This is our approach to growth: quietly and with trust.

Proven method:
Our clients appreciate this approach and it works very well.
Trust is vital and it's why we go for this method.

Emotional appeal:
I'm asking you on a personal level.
Could I count on you?
Iwould be grateful for your support…

Unspoken logic:
An active referral implicitly means that the client is happy.

Psychological basis:
By referring us, you're reaffirming the choice you made when you chose to work with us.

By emphasizing its proven effectiveness:

- *It's a common method of business development within our organization because…*
- *We prefer referrals and personal recommendations…*

Two examples of the motivation behind this approach:

- *"The portfolio we are building is developed within a close-knit circle. I want all my clients to have the same quality as you. Our way of growing is through clients recommending other clients… "*
- *"We don't advertise, and we don't take just anyone on — all our clients come by referral." It's the principle of exclusive sponsorship.*

D. THE COMMERCIAL RATIONALE BEHIND ACTIVE REFERRALS

- *To stand out from the crowd.*
- *You're in the process of building your client base.*
- *You've acquired a portfolio and need to grow it.*
- *You're keen to build or expand your professional network.*

This means:

- *Initiating contacts with business clusters, families, and across generations.*
- *Setting clear, measurable targets for obtaining active referrals.*
- *Joining as many umbrella organizations as possible.*
- *Getting involved in the companies you work with — for example, by attending AGMs.*

E. THE CONDITIONS FOR REQUESTING AN ACTIVE REFERRAL

Who should I ask for a referral?
Internal referral (from a colleague)
Classic referral
External referral (a recommendation)
Network of contacts

When to ask for active referrals?
Is the initial meeting the right time? It depends on the client's positive signals!

- At each commercial meeting in direct prospecting.
- When delivering management or analysis feedback.
- When the client talks about their business and stakeholders.
- At bank-organized events, lunches, or commercial meetings.
- When presenting a product offer, particularly if benefits are involved.
- By offering free introductory services to encourage reciprocity: full financial reviews, estate evaluations.
- Gain active referrals by giving group presentations to trusted professionals who refer clients.

A few questions to ask yourself before requesting an active referral:

What is the psychological profile of the client I am considering asking?

Are they likely to be shocked by my request?

During our meetings, have they often spoken about their personal or professional circle? How can I phrase my request to build maximum trust?

What are the right conditions for asking for an active referral?

- The client is clearly satisfied and says so. There's a good rapport, and they're giving you an opening.
- Everything is going smoothly, results are positive — you're in a kind of "honeymoon" phase with the client.
- The relationship manager gently tests the waters, and the client responds positively.
- The client spontaneously mentions people in their network.
- You invite the client and some of their friends or contacts to a lunch — subtly encouraging referrals without directly asking.
- You give a small gift on a special occasion, such as the end of the year.
- You've known the client for a long time.
- There's a clear relationship of trust.
- The client themselves directly suggests someone.

Closed questions to lead into an active referral request:

Paradoxically, it can be useful to ask closed questions before moving on to an open-ended question about referrals:

- Have my proposals met your expectations?
- Do you, like me, value the quality of our relationship?
- Are you satisfied with the services provided by our bank?
- Can I ask you a very direct question?
- Is there anything missing for you to be completely satisfied?

What's the best way to formulate a referral request?

Three examples:

Precise:

"Given your business ties, would Mr. Dupont be someone who might value a short meeting with us?"

Elegant:

"Is there someone you hold in high regard to whom we could present our services on your recommendation?"

Classic:

"Who in your network might I contact? All of our clients are referred."

"Can you think of someone in your circle who might be interested in our services?"

Other open-ended questions to ask:

- Who could you recommend our services to?
- Who can I contact on your behalf?

- Who would you recommend my management services to (or my bank)?
- I'd love to meet customers of your profile (caliber), who would you have in mind?
- Who could I invite to join you for lunch at the bank?

It all starts with the list!

There's no better technique than the list.

Make a list of people who can give you an active referral in the following categories:

- *Clients (current and former)*
- *Potential clients*
- *Personal contacts*
- *Professional contacts (including work colleagues)*
- *Close friends*
- *Your family*
- *People you know through others*
- *Referral contacts of all kinds: financial advisers, solicitors, and top-level executives*

Who should be on my list?

- *Only include people who can help you open doors.*
- *Start with individuals who hold sway or influence; you're more likely to reach them.*
- *Include close, trusted contacts on your list: family members and genuine friends.*
- *Add former colleagues you still have a good relationship with.*
- *Include people you wouldn't expect to help you.*

It's important to be aggressive!

Don't hesitate to call people on your list directly to ask for a referral.

Set yourself a SMART target; it's an excellent booster.

F. THE THREE COMMON PITFALLS OF ACTIVE REFERRALS

1. There's the risk of being sent a **weak lead** that doesn't result in any business.
2. The client may ask for **something in return:** "If the person I refer becomes a client, what's in it for me?"
3. They may request **privileges** we simply can't offer.

You have to have the discipline to ask the question.

What if a client promises a referral but never follows through? **What should you do?**

The only real issue with active referrals is having the courage to ask. **If I don't ask, nothing happens.**

Objections to a referral request:

1. I place great importance on confidentiality, so I'm reluctant to give you a name.

Response:

I completely understand and respect your concern. Please be assured that we are bound by strict confidentiality obligations. A referral is too valuable to us for it not to be handled with the utmost discretion.

2. I don't think my friends would appreciate me sharing their names.

Response:

I completely understand. It's important to be transparent, so I suggest you mention it to them first. The goal is to offer your contacts a chance to benefit from our services.

3. I don't know if my friends really need your banking services.

Response:

The best way to find out is to allow me to contact your acquaintance and present the bank's services.

4. This is something that requires some thought; please give me a little time.

Response:

Of course, take your time. We'll discuss it at our next meeting.

The responses to these objections should follow a few principles:

- Try not to be too pushy the client and respect their position.
- Depending on how you feel, you can delay your request until later.
- Check if this approach bothers them.
- Remind them why this method is used: it's the only one you have, and it's discreet and exclusive.

G. PASSIVE REFERRALS AND INDIRECT ACTIVE REFERRALS

A Passive Referral involves no explicit ask, such as when the manager hands over a card to the person "just in case." It's common for the wealth manager to begin with a passive referral request before proceeding to an active referral.

The sequence can be as follows:

First meeting: Ask for a passive referral under the same contextual conditions as for an active referral.

Second meeting: Ask the client about the effects of the passive referral; have they spoken about it to people around them? (This is its intended effect).

If they say no: The relationship manager should repeat the request for a passive referral, perhaps with an extra incentive like inviting them to an event.

If they say yes: the relationship manager can ask who they spoke to – and that's the moment the passive referral turns into an active one.

Indirect referrals are yet another source:

This is where the wealth manager draws on their client's network as a way to spot potential prospects, often by asking a few well-chosen questions.

These might be: Who are your competitors? Who are the main players in your field? Who are your best customers? How is your business doing?

H. COMPLEMENTARY ALTERNATIVES TO ACTIVE REFERRALS

There are several external ways to generate new leads:

- Bank-hosted events and marketing efforts.
- Inbound leads from individuals who've made enquiries.
- Proactive contact through LinkedIn, which helps build relationships and a sense of connection. Many active banks now generate most of their leads this way.
- Messaging apps like WhatsApp can also facilitate communication. Many managers use these extra channels to strengthen ties with their clients.

Other useful avenues for uncovering potential prospect links include:

- Professional directories such as *Kompass*, which provide prospecting tools and list operational decision-makers.
- Networking events hosted by Chambers of Commerce.
- Industry-specific trade organizations, which can provide access to events and member lists.
- Club services can also lead to active referrals, though they dislike being used purely for prospecting. It's therefore a long-term approach.
- The family network often serves as the initial resource for young wealth managers.

Influencers and referrers represent another avenue:

- Opinion leaders who have a strong presence locally among potential customers.
- Business introducers, whether bank clients or not, may or may not have agreements and may be compensated for their services.

These two categories can be recruited from the following professions: notaries, lawyers, trustees, real estate brokers, business leaders, presidents of umbrella associations, artists, sportsmen and women, teachers. All have access to social categories likely to be interested in the services of a private bank.

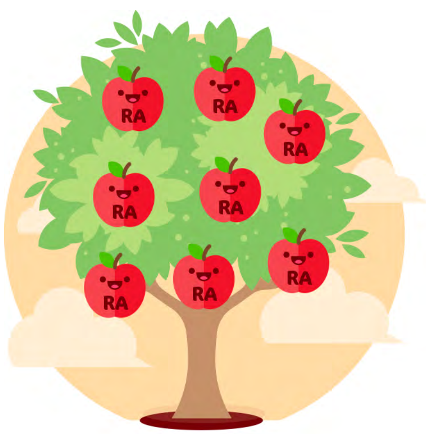
The wealth manager needs to build a strong rapport with these influencers and referrers, either on their own or through a bank partnership.

The foundation of these relationships is the overlapping of contacts.

9. THE NETWORK EFFECT OF ACTIVE REFERRALS

Active referrals are directly linked to the concept of a network, their very framework. A network is the sum total of the social connections found in an individual's environment. The well-known "six degrees of separation" theory suggests that anyone, anywhere in the world, might be connected to you[10].

Like the diagram below of a fruit tree, an active referral acts as a graft that helps the tree grow and multiply.



Bank
Fruit tree

The network is the foundation of all my commercial activities. I can develop my network through the **strength of my relationships with its members.**

We can influence others by increasing this strength—that is, by maintaining constant contact and presence with our connections. We can also broaden our network by "nurturing" it.

10 **Theory of Six Degrees of Separation:** Any person on Earth can be connected to any other through a chain of six links. The concept was introduced by the Hungarian writer Frigyes Karinthy (1929) and later popularized in 1967 by Stanley Milgram through the "small-world experiment".

"I don't need to know many people;
what matters most is that many people know me."

The components of a network:
Density Frequency
Events
Accessibility
Connectors (or people who act as "bridges")

A. NETWORK DENSITY refers to the quality of the relationships among members of a network.

It is defined by the number of mutual or overlapping connections between those individuals. The higher the density, the stronger the trust and cohesion within the network, much like a close circle of friends.

The denser your network, the more trust and collaboration you can expect.

Density measures the closeness between members of the same network and is reflected not only in the connection itself but also in shared interests, common professional fields, and similar investment aspirations.

How can I improve the density of my network?

It starts with truly knowing the members of your network.

What do you know about them?

The more information you have about your contacts, the easier it is to strengthen those connections and create a denser network[11].

Relationship managers can act in various ways to engage more effectively with members of their professional network:

- Offer enjoyable experiences to network members — for example, inviting them to a round of golf.
- Maintain regular contact and create opportunities to connect and stay visible.
- Nurture the **relationship** to continually expand your network's base and thus generate more prospects!
- Constantly ask yourself: **who have I left out** of my portfolio?
- Every wealth manager should be able to read all the names of their prospects in their diary[12].
- Keep a record of "**WHEN**" for each prospect.
- Don't leave anything out, scrutinize everything.

11 See the concept of degree of closeness with the client, discussed in Chapter 9.
12 This concept is intentionally repeated multiple times throughout the book.

B. HOW OFTEN SHOULD YOU ENGAGE WITH YOUR NETWORK?

This time, it's about the intensity of the network, which increases with the frequency of the interactions you establish.

NETWORK CHARACTERISTICS	DEFINITION	WHAT YOU CAN DO	OBJECTIVES
Strong or weak density?	Quality of my relationship with network members. Depth of the relationship. Interconnection among members.	Identify what would truly delight your top client. How well do you know them personally?	Create an emotional connection with this client.
Frequency	Number of times I engage with people in my network.	What events can I create to build and maintain my network?	Know the right frequency of contact.
Accessibility	There are 7 degrees or fewer between any two people, even if they don't know each other.	Identify the fastest and most effective way to connect with your target contacts.	Show that no one is truly out of reach.
Connectors (people who act as bridges)	People in your network who help make introductions and guide you to the right contact.	Identify their area of expertise so you can support them—and wait for the favor to be returned.	What matters most isn't knowing many people but being known by many.
Network segmentation	Division into groups of people with varying interests. Maintaining a uniform network	Identify the abundant sources of active referrals in your network.	Understand who in my network could act as a conduit for me.

Think of your top client.
What would truly delight them?

A network is built on allies.

This military term suggests people who are willing to stand by you and provide support.

Can they assist you in expanding your portfolio? How long can they be expected to last?

If these allies work in your favor, the network will become more robust.

This exercise helps you identify your network's allies:

1. List your best-known allies, those you are sure will support you.
2. Opposite each name, write down the reasons they might assist you.
3. Develop a plan of action to reach out and request an active referral from them.
4. Make sure you "nurture" these relationships, as they are the essence and foundation of your network.

Organize your ongoing relationships with your allies. Segmentation helps you categorize your allies by:

- How well you know them (your relationship history).
- The amount of information you have about them.
- Places where you can meet them (sports clubs, restaurants, etc.).

ALLIES	REASONS THEY SUPPORT ME	NEXT CONTACT	ACTIVE REFERRAL GOAL	HOW TO MAINTAIN THEIR ENGAGEMENT?

An expert's perspective

Philippe L. was a journalist with Télévision Suisse Romande (TSR) for over 30 years. In this capacity, he developed a keen sense of human relations. Here's what he has to say about his banking relationships.

A few years ago, I inherited money from my mother. For me, it was a large amount – more than three times my annual salary. The bank's initial reaction was to block the arrival of the funds without informing me or giving any explanation. This first contact was quite a shock. A young woman, whom I found somewhat arrogant – she acted as if she had already won me over – called me and said she had "plenty of suggestions" to offer, requesting a meeting. The meeting reflected my first impression: she did not listen to my needs and instead suggested banking products that were not related to what I wanted. It was a disaster. In the end, I left the bank; their approach and strategies did not fit with my needs.

First, I got to know my client profile. I think I'm the profile that managers hate! I'm a very demanding and rational customer, I'm very results-oriented without too much sensitivity to the "niceties of salespeople". I have no qualms about changing managers and banks if the results aren't good enough, or if I'm not happy with the way they're achieved. I set profitability targets in agreement with my manager and compare results with my various partner banks.

My investments are handled through an advisory mandate, and I make a clear distinction between the technical experts I talk to and the managers who keep the business relationship going. I really value commitment in the relationship. Wealth management is all about people, and I can tell right away if they get me or not. Their engagement and availability are easy to measure, and that matters a lot to me. If it's hard to get hold of them, or if they don't reply – for example, if a relationship manager doesn't respond in the evenings or on WhatsApp – that's a problem. A manager who only answers during office hours isn't truly dedicated. If they don't bring ideas and seem to be stepping back, I know the relationship won't be interesting or positive.

I have accounts with several banks, so I can compare bankers and how they behave. I can tell who goes the extra mile in my best interests and who just rigidly follows their bank's guidelines. As a client, I take note of what the relationship manager says – I listen, remember the details, and then refer back to them at the appropriate time to assess whether what was said was relevant, useful, and actually served my interests.

I can tell from their attitude whether they're just a yes-man blindly following the bank's directives, or whether their bonus is actually tied to the bank's performance. I ask questions, and if they respond with something like "it's not me, it's the market," without offering a proper explanation (even if everyone lost money in 2022), that refusal to take responsibility is really off-putting. It makes me question how committed they really are to acting in my best interest.

I expect my relationship manager to own up to their mistakes and apologize if they've got something wrong. They should demonstrate good manners and not just shrug things off.

Some RMs have even stood up to their own management to defend me.

They're committed, and they're willing to put our relationship ahead of the bank's agenda, at least within legal limits). That's the kind of partnership I expect when someone is responsible for my capital.

Spring into action!
5 key takeaways and an exercise

FIVE KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. Prospect relentlessly – it's the future of your business success.
2. Constantly renew your customer base to avoid erosion.
3. You need to have your top 40 close at hand at all times – use a list!
4. The one who succeeds in sales is the lumberjack – minimum effort with consistent rhythm.
5. Be as prepared as possible for every event your bank organizes.

PROSPECTING SUMMARY:

#1. Create your qualified contact base – it's your passport.
Start by listing everyone you've come into contact with – literally. That includes people you've connected with through a business card exchange, LinkedIn, Facebook, or any other interaction.

#2. Choose the right channels to approach your identified targets. All methods are valid (phone calls, letters, in-person visits) but increasingly, digital sales tools are key.

Connections made following a digital introduction are much more likely to succeed.

#3. Prepare your sales pitch and arguments.
Preparation is 100% of your success. Sharpen your tools, meaning every aspect of your argument, including how you'll handle objections. This stage is about fully understanding your client's needs, down to the smallest detail.

#4. Use all your energy to close.
Trust your instincts when closing signals appear. Set aside your hesitations and move forward. Closing means helping the client.

#5. Three keys to sales success: follow-up, follow-up, follow-up.
Long-term client follow-up is a challenge, but it's the cornerstone of success, along with tenacity, perseverance, and determination.

EXERCICE

Title: Prospecting = Survival

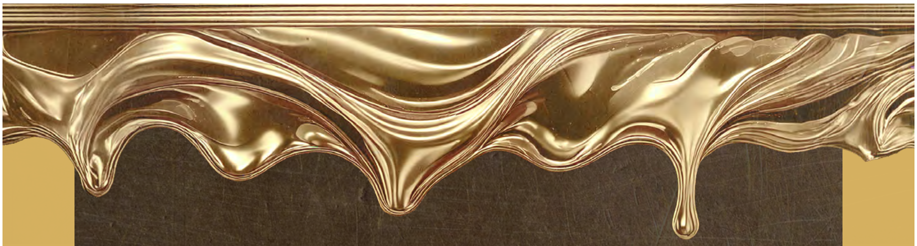
Aim of the exercise: Build your prospecting efforts consistently and intensively.

Instructions:

- List the three most recent prospecting activities you have carried out.
- When was the last time you reviewed your client list?
- Which clients will you ask for your next two active referrals?
- Using the table below, define the status and determine the next steps for two of your prospects:

STAGES OF NEGOTIATION	IDENTIFY	CONTACT	DEVELOP	SUPPORT	OFFER	CONSOLIDATE	FOLLOW UP AND RETAIN
Prospect 1							
Prospect 2							

Golden nuggets of wisdom



The 10 Basic Tips

Negotiating means seeking the best possible deal for both parties.

1. Focus on the object of negotiation. How do you do this?
- Define the topic clearly, then confirm it with the other party.

2. How do I ensure the objectivity needed for a successful negotiation?
- By avoiding a self-centered approach.
- By setting clear goals and limits before entering into negotiations.

3. Have I written down my goals—or at least my requests or expectations?
- The client's objectives are more important than my own.
- Only concrete objectives are worth achieving.

4. Real preparation is written preparation.
- Analyze the forces at play (K. Lewin).
- Define your BATNA – Best Alternative to a Negotiated Agreement (Ury & Fisher, 1983).

5. Negotiation is, above all, communication.
- And communication starts with silence.
- Your body speaks before your words do.

6. Meeting the client's requests is the only true goal in sales.
- Accept, qualify, and validate their request.

7. Arguing your case is like moving your pieces on a chessboard.
- Add rather than subtract.
- Focus only on the benefits for your client; they will do the same.

8. Selling is all about creativity.
- Look at the same thing from a different perspective.
- Creativity is the opposite of fatalism; a "no" is a beginning, not an end.

9. Close the deal—whatever it takes!
- Dare to close: you're helping the client make a decision.

10. The three keys to selling: follow-up, follow-up, follow-up.
- Selling is about leaving NO stone unturned.

7 Banking Negotiation Principles to Reflect On

1. Service quality in banking? Everything must work seamlessly!
2. The first interaction is a honeymoon — it only happens once.
3. At the first meeting, the top priority is securing a second one.
4. Nothing replaces face-to-face.
5. Replace misplaced shyness with conviction and calm energy.
6. A bank manager's role is like a doctor's: prescribing without diagnosing is a mistake.
7. Ask questions to which neither you nor your clients know the answers.

Assessing the quality of your customer interviews

For each stage of the meeting described below, where do you currently stand: stage 1, 2 or 3? You can indicate your position on a scale from 0 to 5 between each stage (e.g. 1.3 or 2.4). How will you improve the situation—or maintain it, if you're at stage 1)?

WELCOME / INITIAL CONTACT / FIRST IMPACT / CREATING THE RIGHT ATMOSPHERE

1. The wealth manager is confident and smiles. Their warm welcome puts the client at ease and makes them feel valued. They invite the client to sit in the "right" place. The opening conversation is pleasant and positive; the atmosphere is very pleasant. The wealth manager carefully hands over their business card and kicks off the meeting with style and clarity by outlining the objectives.
2. The welcome is courteous, though not particularly warm. The manager directs the client to the appropriate seat and sets a relaxed tone with light conversation (e.g. the weather, parking). Their business card is placed on the table. While the client feels comfortable and under no pressure, the exchange could be warmer.
3. The welcome is cold, perhaps even unpleasant. There is no real greeting, and the business card is either forgotten altogether or handed over without enthusiasm. The client feels uncomfortable. The adviser begins the meeting abruptly with a very direct question.

STRUCTURING THE INTERVIEW / OBJECTIVES / TAKING THE CLIENT'S AGENDA INTO ACCOUNT

1. The structure of the meeting and its agenda were already suggested in the appointment confirmation. They are now confirmed with the client, and the adviser asks about the client's own objectives. Each objective is clearly explained, and short pitches are used to spark the client's interest. The client feels like he is being taken seriously.
2. The agenda and objectives are discussed, but more quickly. The manager seeks the client's confirmation and pushes for attention by asking closed questions.
3. The start is somewhat chaotic and unstructured. The meeting's agenda and objectives are mixed together. The manager begins with a monologue about their personal background and the bank. Nothing is confirmed, and the client feels uncomfortable.

NEEDS ANALYSIS / QUESTIONING / QUESTIONING STRATEGY

1. The manager masters questioning techniques and strategy. They advance the analysis with an ideal distribution of speaking time (70% client, 30% manager). They know how to encourage difficult questions. The client feels comfortable sharing information.
2. The manager asks many open-ended questions, as well as some closed control questions. They handle the exchanges more superficially. The speaking time is well balanced (50/50). The client appears satisfied.
3. The manager talks too much and focuses on themselves. They ask almost only closed questions and ignore the client's buying signals. The client feels like they are being interrogated.

DISCOVERING THE CLIENT'S MOTIVATIONS

1. The manager pays attention to all the client's reactions. They explore the emotional dimension of the exchanges and delve deeply into each topic. They paraphrase every motivation and need, validating them. They understand what the client wants as well as the reasons why.
2. The manager identifies the client's needs but does not explore their psychological motivations. While aware of what the client wants, they remain unsure because not all needs have been validated.
3. The manager asks few questions and extrapolates from the answers. They quickly suggest investments before fully analyzing the client's situation.

MAKING YOUR CASE / DISTINGUISHING FEATURES FROM BENEFITS

1. The manager has understood, articulated, and validated all the client's needs. They present offers aligned with those needs, speaking in terms of benefits for the client. The client approves all proposals.
2. The manager has grasped the client's needs. Benefits are highlighted, but not everything is explicitly linked to those needs. The client's reactions are positive but not always spontaneous.
3. The manager explains the product technically, without discussing the benefits and without considering the client's needs.

HANDLING OBJECTIONS

1. The manager accepts the objection and seeks to fully understand it before addressing it. They respond honestly, which the client appreciates. The objection is resolved to the client's satisfaction.
2. The manager handles the objection with a technical and considerate approach, which apparently satisfies the client.

3. The manager dismisses the objection, hurries through, and thinks that just saying sorry is sufficient. They seem detached and fail to learn from the experience. The client remains unhappy.

CONCLUSION / FOLLOW-UP

1. The manager recognizes buying and closing signals and moves smoothly to close. The conclusion is fluid and accepted by the client. Specific dates for follow-up are set.
2. The manager actively works to close, revisiting the benefits of the products. The next steps are planned in consultation with the client.
3. The manager hesitates to close and does not follow any known techniques. After securing a decision, no follow-up is planned.

ACTIVE REFERRAL

1. The manager raises the topic of active referrals naturally, explaining the concept of marketing through recommendations. He collaborates with the client to identify referrals.
2. He follows up with a request for an active referral and asks questions to check satisfaction. He obtains a referral despite difficulties.
3. After a forced conclusion, he doesn't even ask for the referral. When he does, it's too direct and lacks finesse.

8

First contact,
lasting impact

The first moments are crucial to making an impact in a relationship. Communication is the lifeblood of business relationships. Communicate!

TEACHING OBJECTIVES

After reading this chapter, you will be able to:

- Understand all the forces at work during your first contact.
- Master your initial interactions and impressions.
- Use every communication tool available to better promote your services.
- Get ready for negotiation.

Contents table
chapter 8

1. THE FIRST IMPRESSION IS ALWAYS THE RIGHT ONE — ESPECIALLY WHEN IT'S BAD!

There is a lot of truth in this. Every little detail matters and leaves an impression, whether consciously or unconsciously. Wealthy clients spend their lives sharpening their senses. They visit places where every detail is carefully designed to captivate them. Why would they let go of these expectations when they enter a private banking environment? This alone is a strong enough argument to raise awareness. Making an impression means communicating information about yourself.

Our strong first impression helps the client imagine how well we will take care of them.

A. WHAT CAN INFLUENCE FIRST IMPRESSIONS?

This chapter begins with some practical advice (sections 1.1 and 1.2). Here is a checklist you might use before meeting a client, as well as every subsequent meeting. These points are ordered by what your client will notice most.

Physical appearance:

- Dress smartly, matching the client's style.
- Make sure you have a positive, smiling facial expression.
- Stand tall and project energy through your posture.

Personal hygiene:

- Clean nails.
- Pleasant breath.
- Keep your hair clean and tidy (the author is bald!).

Non-verbal communication:

- Direct eye contact, where culturally appropriate.
- Controlled, non-aggressive body language.
- Smooth, calm body movements.

Verbal language:

- Appropriate tone of voice.
- Careful use of financial industry jargon.

Respect for personal space:

- Avoid being too physically intrusive.
- Maintain culturally appropriate distance.

Empathy and attention:

- Active, whole-body listening.

Self-confidence:

- Be sure of yourself, without being arrogant.

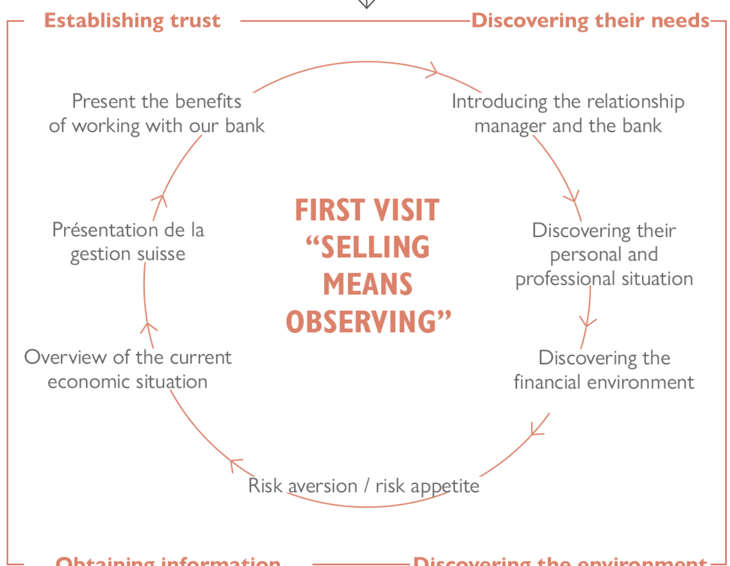
COMMERCIAL PRACTICES IN ASSET MANAGEMENT: MODELING THE SALES PROCESS

THE FIRST CLIENT VISIT

OBJECTIVES
Break the ice

- In France or Spain, the negotiator meets with clients to discuss money matters – there is no issue with employing a **direct approach** to explore their **needs**.
- They earn the client's **trust** by showing empathy and adapting to the client's communication style.

Direct negotiation



- The preparation phase helps strengthen the relationship manager's image and professionalism in the eyes of the client
- The RM comes to the meeting well-equipped with current brochures and product materials.

Discreet negotiation

- In China, the negotiator must **discreetly** explore the client's sphere.
- Asking about the client's **personal life** is considered inappropriate.
- It's essential to highlight the bank's strengths, as **competition** is fierce.
- The client must understand the difference between local management and the benefits of placing funds in **Switzerland**.
- The client's business card is an important source of information.

RESULTS: Add up the positive points + summary = Secure a second appointment
The variables of the model are adapted to each cultural context

Also important are the tools and accessories we use, such as a high-quality pen, a stylish notepad, and a discreet, high-end briefcase. Completing this list of subtle influencing factors is behind the 3 x 20 concept:

- the first 20 seconds of the encounter,
- the first 20 words that are spoken,
- the first 20 centimeters of our body (our smiling face).

B. 10 WAYS TO LEAVE A LASTING IMPACT DURING THE FIRST CONTACT

1. This is a **special moment**, a mutual discovery full of emotions. It's a great opportunity to start or strengthen a relationship, much like meeting an old friend again, with emotions running high and heart strings pulled as you talk. It all comes down to the empathy we build, share, and receive.
2. The **primary goal of the first contact** is at least to secure a second meeting to build and sustain the commercial relationship. The buying decision begins at this very moment. Every person prefers to purchase what feels familiar, understandable, or visualizable. The challenge lies in creating the motivation to buy, which precedes the purchase decision. At first, the client is wary of illusions and anything overly emphatic.
3. **Basic behaviors** for the first contact:

- Speak in the present tense at the start of the meeting, then switch to the future tense during the proposal phase.
- Take notes as soon as possible; this indirectly shows the prospect you value them. Regularly paraphrase and confirm important information, such as the names of your interlocutor's partner banks.
- Point out to your interlocutor what you appreciate about them, highlighting their positive qualities; sincere and immediate praise is a strong motivator.
- Explore all points of convergence with your client, including hobbies and mutual acquaintances.
- Maintain a positive attitude both verbally and non-verbally: smile, show good humor, and make positive remarks.

4. **Dare to ask probing questions.** You must gather in-depth information to influence your prospect's decision. The answers you obtain will be strategic. Your interlocutor will sense your seriousness depending on the nature of your questions. Examples of probing questions include:
   - What are your life goals?
   - What meaning do you give to your life?
   - Who are your current banking partners?
   - What capital are we discussing? What is the size of your fortune?
   - What are you looking for with us?
   - Admittedly, these questions can sometimes seem abrupt. It is important not to confuse probing questions with exploratory questions (see the questioning strategies discussed later in this chapter).

5. **Don't be afraid** to connect on an emotional level to make the conversation flow more easily. Light topics and searching for shared interests will help "soften" your counterpart. Empathy is something you prepare in advance – it's like a "radiator" warming the relationship.
6. In a first meeting, some product or service topics act like "**openers**" that pave the way forward. Choose your discussion topics carefully and prepare your pitches with great care to make them catchy and engaging.
7. **Be a teacher** right from the start. The whole process should be transparent. A clear, well-structured approach is predictable and thus reassuring to your prospect, who will never feel caught off guard.
8. **Be transparent and open about your objectives** as soon as the moment is right. This means sharing the aims of the meeting, as well as those related to the bank and your role as their manager.
9. **Answering your implicit questions:**

   How can I be helpful to you?
   What can we achieve together that you couldn't do alone?
   What benchmarks should I establish to keep us on track?
   - Boundaries: what we will not be able to do
   - Scopes: who are our decision-making contacts?
   - Objective frameworks
   - Limits to our actions
   - Timeframes.
10. **Set principles** that you would like respected in your business relationship. Only accept intelligent interlocutors; others will cause you problems in the long run. Setting principles has a corollary: it means respecting your commitments.
    - Provide a summary report after each meeting to avoid misunderstandings.
    - Your client must then accept your proposals by email.

There are many studies in psychology, communication, and advertising that show that the introduction and conclusion phases of an event are crucial in consumers' overall opinion of it. Many practitioners even consider that the first and last impressions made by an advisor during a sales meeting are the moments that most influence client assessments. However, few researchers have studied this phenomenon in the marketing literature. We conducted a survey with over 500 clients. Based on our analyses, the results indicate that perceived quality and trust are influenced by the initial impression, whereas satisfaction is influenced by the final impression[1].

C. WHAT IS THE CLIENT LOOKING FOR DURING THE FIRST CONTACT?

During the first contact, clients are more perceptive than usual. They pay close attention to details that would typically be overlooked. They are alert to any behavior that could raise suspicion, even the smallest "pause' they feel is inappropriate. The manager must be at the peak of their vigilance and preparation.

How the client expects the wealth manager to behave:

- **To be taken seriously** in everything that is said, without exception, and down to even the smallest detail; what might seem trivial can sometimes conceal a trauma. At this stage of the relationship, wealth managers still do not know the life stories of their future clients.
- They value being **treated with respect**. Wealthy individuals are used to such courteous treatment but dislike overly flattering behavior, which only creates distrust. When they enter a bank, they expect nothing less.
- They **appreciate decisive action** and are influenced, as we all are, by immediacy. Since everything nowadays is instant, why shouldn't banking services be the same? Wealth managers must respond promptly when possible and set deadlines whenever they can.
- **They want to be heard;** active listening is a key motivator. The manager should speak no more than 30% of the time during the first hour of each meeting. It's more effective to prepare questions rather than statements. Listening means staying attentive and giving the speaker room to express themselves.
- Be **straightforward and to the point**. Investors might view a manager's long-windedness as a sign of manipulative intent.

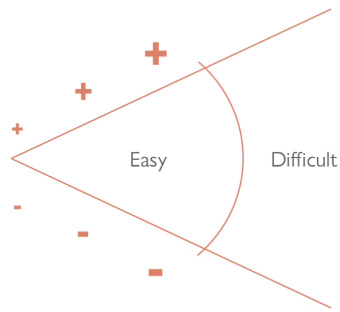
1 Jasmin Bergeron, Jean-Mathieu Fallu et Jasmin Roy, "Une comparaison des effets de la première et de la dernière impression dans une rencontre de vente" ("A comparison of the effects of first and last impressions in a sales meeting), *Recherche et Applications en Marketing*, Sage Journal, 2008.

- The manager needs to keep improving constantly in the client's presence. A single mistake can be forgiven, but if it happens again, it becomes a problem.

Never say anything that is more beautiful than silence.

The first contact is an exceptional moment, when a lot of information is exchanged. It's like a honeymoon that will never happen again. It is the perfect opportunity to increase your level of empathy and deploy all your energy to discover a story, a life, the world hidden behind the person.

The challenge of the first contact lies in the first impression. Our brain is deeply affected by all the signals communicated during that initial meeting. As shown in the diagram below, every sign (positive or negative) perceived tends to amplify; afterward, the gap becomes much harder to bridge.



If I send positive signals first, the client will focus on other positives as well. This is whyit's so crucial to excel in every aspect of the first contact.

D. BUILDING TRUST FROM THE FIRST CONTACT

Trust forms the perfect basis for the relationship between a manager and their client.

However, trust remains merely a concept if it is not supported by tangible actions. Elements that foster trust evoke a sense of reassurance.

Rational factors:

- Positive declaration of intent (PDI): the manager communicates a positive signal to the other party.
- Establishing the framework prior to starting the meeting shows where the discussion is headed.
- Objectives clarify the framework and include both the client's and manager's aims.
- Structuring the discussion allows the client to grasp the approach.
- The client should have the majority of the speaking time.
- Guarantees serve as assurances of trustworthiness, essential to a strong relationship, and carry binding (legal) obligations.

Emotional factors:

- Empathy: by grasping the emotions and behaviors of the other, the manager can align themselves on the same emotional wavelength.
- The manager conveys reassurance with non-verbal communication. The manager demonstrates respect for the story being told, showing regard for the ideas and opinions expressed. The information about the source of funds goes beyond legal requirements; it provides a chance to connect with the client's personal history.

An international scientific study on smiling (conducted by Nicolas A. Cole and David S. Mars with 3,700 participants across 19 countries in October 2022) demonstrated that smiling induces a state of happiness, while frowning induces a state of sadness. These two emotional states are mimicked in interpersonal relationships.

How objectives affect the sense of trust:

- Structuring the negotiation around sales objectives provides visibility.
- When the salesperson communicates these objectives, they demonstrate:

- confidence and self-assurance,
- a professional image,
- a respect for the client's intelligence,
- positive messaging,
- the ability to measure the gap between the client's wishes and what is feasible,
- they are SMART.

E. TRUST: THE CORNERSTONE OF NEGOTIATION

What shapes the client experience and helps build trust? It's the passion for working with people, along with conviction, strong ethics, and curiosity. That's what truly sets us apart[2].

How is trust built?

Trust is inspired and developed through the relationship itself. The relationship manager creates a consistent environment – a kind of ecosystem – around the prospective client. When the prospect observes the different factors that make up this ecosystem, they begin to feel a sense of trust. It is this fertile ground that each relationship manager cultivates to win the client over.

To move from mistrust to genuine trust, the manager needs to shed any assumptions or reservations that could slow down or derail the relationship.

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2 Source: Christian Barbaray, *Satisfaction, fidélité et expérience client* ("Satisfaction, Loyalty and Customer Experience," untranslated), Dunod, 2016, p. 52.

How do you practice **Human-To-Human (H2H) relationship marketing?**

- Segment client profiles so that you can deliver the right commercial actions.
- Find a form of personalization that hits the mark!
- A simple and well-known example is the way Starbucks notes down the customer's first name on each cup.
- Add an emotional dimension whenever possible.
- Consider the full multichannel experience.
- The multichannel relationship integrates all the channels (and products) made available to clients, allowing them to move easily from one to another – just like in the world Apple has created.
- Strengthen the sources of our clients' loyalty: through trust, by making the client's world unique, and by personalizing each response. Through preparation and personal commitment. By valuing human contact, the client becomes a confidant.

F. PLACING TRUST IN YOUR CLIENT

The first task of any manager is to inspire trust, and in turn, to place trust in their client.

Ways to demonstrate this include:

- Showing consistency.
- Being reliable.
- Following the client's lead.
- Being predictable.
- Taking actions with no expectation of return.
- Happy wealth managers stay in their roles, they don't leave.
- Stating it openly.

A self-assured manager will naturally inspire trust. The challenge lies in striking a balance between authentic self-confidence and overconfidence, which can, depending on the situation, come across either as excessive humility bordering on invisibility or as arrogance.

Trust grows when the manager listens carefully and picks up on underlying messages – when they internalize the client's sensitivity. Proximity between individuals and the longevity of the relationship are two key drivers in building trust.

G. HOW ONGOING RELATIONSHIP MANAGEMENT BUILDS TRUST

Follow-up is the main shortcoming I've observed in the managers I've worked with. Follow-up is as much a demonstration of interest as it is a basic commercial act.

What form might a follow-up take?

- Follow-up with your list of prospects and customers to maintain the relationship, offer services or simply check in to see how they are.
- Invitations to events organized by the bank.
- Sending information.

H. DEVELOPING SOCIAL SKILLS TO BUILD TRUST

Soft skills[3] have a secure future ahead. With the rise of automation and AI handling more administrative tasks, professionals will have more time to connect with clients. That makes social skills (such as listening, empathy, teamwork, and problem-solving) more important than ever.

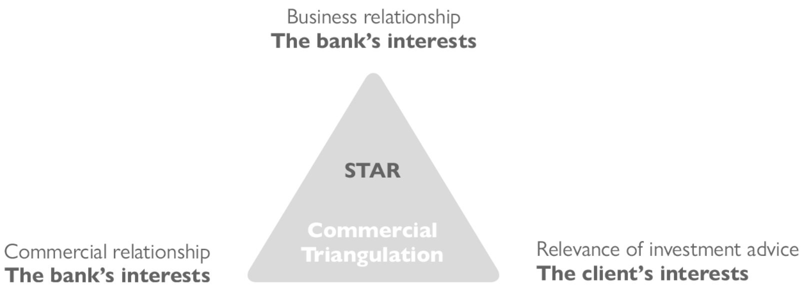
Automation will take over transactional duties, but humans will still own the relationship side of things. After all, buying decisions are made by people, not machines, and people respond to human connection. As far back as 2011, a Harvard study *The Soft Skills Disconnect*) showed that 85% of professional success depends on soft skills, with just 15% down to technical expertise.

There is no such thing as trust — only evidence of it.

Trust is built through the right mix of expertise and client relationship.

When a client meets with their wealth manager, they expect reliable answers to their questions about managing their assets. The level of expertise they encounter is a key motivator.

The bank must demonstrate its know-how through its in-house specialists. Presenting the technical face of the bank both reassures and inspires. Commercial triangulation helps foster a sense of belonging to a new group.



I. BARRIERS AND RESISTANCE

Mistrust comes more naturally than trust – in fact, it is instinctive. We have inherited it from our ancestors, who had to survive in a hostile environment. This legacy takes many forms: our reptilian brains remain on high alert, interpreting first impressions that may trigger fear– and with it, the instinct to flee. The limbic brain, the emotional brain, will analyze the situation and all its minute components, to help us decide whether or not to enter into the relationship.

3 "Future of Jobs Report 2023," published on 30 April 2023 by the World Economic Forum.

Why might a client be reluctant to place their trust in us?

- They may still be influenced by a past negative experience; the RM must work to clear away any lingering doubts.
- They don't understand the process or the product and feel isolated; the RM hasn't validated their proposals.
- The RM isn't confident in the technical aspects and doesn't call in expert support.
- The client feels pressured by overly aggressive sales tactics.
- Conversations are unbalanced; the RM dominates the discussion, makes excessive demands, and offers nothing in return.
- When demands are disproportionate and go unchecked.

Trust is earned through concrete actions:
- Acting proactively on the client's behalf.
- Being concrete and specific, never vague.
- Strengthening and identifying common ground between the client's plans, the bank's interests, and the RM's goals.
- Refraining from judging the client's views or decisions.

2. COMMUNICATING TO SELL EFFECTIVELY

Longitudinal research, drawn from long-term experience, offers insight into how sales behaviors evolve. It highlights trends and shifts in context – particularly technological ones. One of these trends is the ability to communicate effectively, which is a key factor in selling banking services.

The particularities of communication/sales in the banking world:

This type of communication seeks to align the interests of both parties. It may be straightforward – when the terms of the exchange are clearly expressed – or complex, when interests differ or remain implicit.

Negotiation begins when disagreements arise, and communication becomes vital. Negotiation is ever-present in interpersonal dynamics, economic transactions, social exchanges, and political or diplomatic relations.

Key principles at the outset:

- A cooperative solution is preferable to an authoritarian one.[4]
- A solution depends on the level of trust built by both parties.
- A good agreement benefits both sides, whereas a one-sided deal often leads to poor future relations.
- In negotiation, communication becomes both a social norm and a legitimate way to engage with the client.

4 Course by Emmanuel Josserand on Negotiation, MBA, HEC Geneva, 2008.

How communication works

Upon meeting a person, you experience either a positive or negative impression. How is this impression formed, and what behavior results from it?

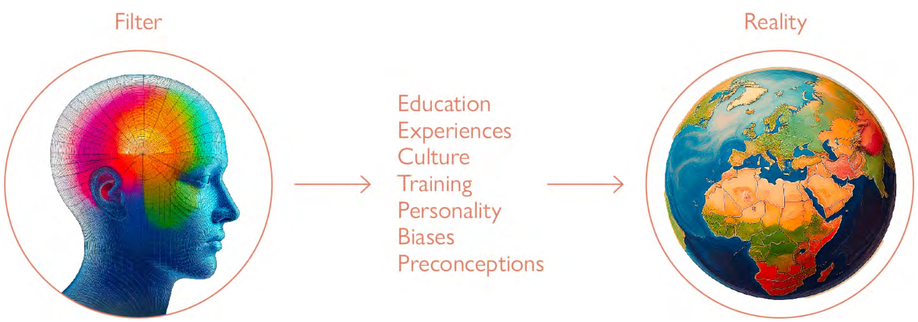
Every human being has a frame of reference – a kind of communication DNA, a filter through which they perceive reality, or their own version of it. This mechanism is called perception. This filter has been shaped since birth. We first inherit genes, then layer on acquired factors such as education, culture, training, physical characteristics, and accumulated experiences. All these elements influence our behavior. We perceive commercial situations through this filter and decide how to respond. Everyone has their own image of reality[5]. It is our perception that drives how we behave. Wealth management clients operate using the same mechanism.

A simple application of this filter principle is to ask two questions to a high-net-worth client (commonly found in KYC forms):

- What does €10 million mean to you?
- What's your reaction when your portfolio suffers a major loss?

The answers can be very revealing, providing insight into the client's personal filter.

The value of this approach lies in anticipating client behavior.



There is an initial problem: their preconceptions. If an individual immediately has a negative perception of the situation, their filter will be negative, and their reactions and behaviors will follow suit.

In commercial prospecting, the wealth manager "travels" through the client's filter to understand and anticipate their responses.

This is the purpose of biographical analysis, which involves examining a client's life history. We cannot change an individual or a situation; we can only change how we perceive them. Subtle persuasion specifically targets the contents of the filter. Our filters are often full – sometimes overflowing! – with prejudices.

5 Krauthammer International Course, 1992 — but nothing has changed!

It is easier to smash an atom than a prejudice!
(Albert Einstein)

A. WORKING ON YOURSELF TO TAKE CONTROL OF SALES INTERACTIONS

There are times, blessed by positive emotions, when our intellectual capacities come into play and enable us to excel. On the other hand, negative emotions often hold us back from performing well. At the root of these emotional states lie mental frameworks that affect our energy.

We have the power to form mental images and prepare ourselves mentally for specific situations. This is what athletes do before a competition: they visualize success to access their full potential. Salespeople, too, would benefit from creating positive mental imagery as part of their preparation.

Here's a training exercise to help you to produce positive mental images:

NEGATIVE STARTING SITUATIONS	POSITIVE MENTAL IMAGE
This client is difficult.	Thanks to their high standards, I'll learn a lot from them.
I lost this deal; my product must not be good enough.	This experience will help me avoid making the same mistake twice.
My bank's compliance team won't accept this client.	I'll go speak to them, so I can improve how I present future cases.
The bank is cutting part of my travel expenses.	This is a good opportunity to test remote client engagement…
Describe a negative situation and practice reframing it in a positive light.	

B. WE FILTER EVERYTHING!

The filter is the source of our behavior. It contains our reference system, which influences our actions. This is the same process we use for biographical analysis. Knowing and understanding our customers' backgrounds, education and training helps us to anticipate their decisions.

The filter is also influenced by sensory channels known by the acronym VAKOG (see table below). Each of these channels has a function and a possible influence in the sales relationship.

QUOI	COMMENT	APPLICATION À LA RELATION DE VENTE
Visual	Pay attention to the visual appeal of what is seen.	From personal presentation to the documents provided.
Auditory	Tone, pitch, and volume of what is heard matter.	Voice alignment depends on the person and the context. Being on the same wavelength in every sense of the word.
Kinesthetic	Physical contact is positive when culturally appropriate.	Physical contact enhances closeness between people (Beauvois et Joule).
Olfactory	Includes ambient smells as well as personal scent.	Avoid overpowering perfumes; subtlety and discretion are key.
Gustatory	If sharing a meal, ensure excellent quality – or don't do it at all.	Mealtime sharing fosters connection and can strengthen the commercial relationship.

C. THREE WAYS OUR FILTERS CAN DISTORT BEHAVIOR[6]

Projection: An individual projects their own frame of reference onto the other person. It involves assuming that the client necessarily uses the same filter as oneself.

Example: A salesperson says to a client, *"I think this product is very expensive,"* without knowing the client's financial means. They have projected their own purchasing power onto the client, without having any relevant information about them.

How to overcome projection?

Ask deeper questions and make sure the client's needs are clearly confirmed.

6 Based on Krauthammer training by Daniel Kluger (1995)

Introversion: This is when someone regards their own frame of reference as the only valid one. Their image of reality is equated with reality itself. Here, introversion is seen as a negative trait. An introverted salesperson might say to a client,"*We've always done it this way; there's no reason to change.*" In sales, introversion can be harmful because it blocks creative possibilities.

How to overcome introversion?

By systematically offering alternatives and second options, and opening the discussion with the client to explore all possible investment avenues. Consider what is opposite or different. Do not confuse introversion with discretion.

Identification: This is a variation of the mental filter in which the problem itself (reality) is confused with our perception of the problem (our image of reality). This confusion can trigger emotional tension (such as anger and frustration) and cause the person to become the problem.

Example: The client makes a harsh remark to their relationship manager, who takes it personally and gets offended. The manager fails to take a step back to assess the situation and find a constructive response.

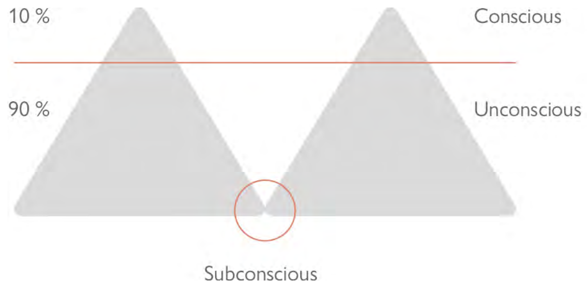
How to overcome identification?

By creating distance and remembering: "I am not the problem." Ask clarifying questions to better understand the issue at hand.

D. THE ICEBERG THEORY: A KEY TO UNDERSTANDING BEHAVIOR

The iceberg theory is often attributed to Sigmund Freud[7], the founder of psychoanalysis. He used it to illustrate the conscious and unconscious levels of the human mind: the visible tip of the iceberg represents conscious thoughts, while the submerged part symbolizes the unconscious.

His key observation was that two icebergs always meet at the level of their base — their unconscious. It's a useful analogy. During a first contact, people often say things like, "*I really click with this person,*" or, "*I don't know why, but I'm not feeling it…*"



7 S. Freud, neurologist and psychiatrist (1856–1939).

This theory is based on three principles.

First principle: We are always communicating!

We can avoid speaking but we cannot *not* communicate! How am I perceived?

Every action we take, every word spoken – or left unsaid – has an impact on the prospect. We have the power to either trigger or reduce their sense of mistrust.

Second principle: 100% Positive or 100% Negative

We are constantly sending verbal and non-verbal signals – either positive or negative – to those around us.

When our subconscious picks up on a message, it immediately starts looking for confirming signs. A positive signal triggers a search for more positives; a negative one prompts the opposite.

At any moment, a small detail – a drop of oil or a grain of sand – can tip the balanc. Which aspects of my behavior deserve special attention?

Third principle: We can consciously influence others to trigger unconscious reactions.

Through our gestures, words, and behaviors, we are able to affect those we interact with.

A skilled salesperson understands that everything they do, say, or suggest will have an impact on the client – often below the level of awareness. This awareness is where thoughtful, intentional selling begins.

3. THE ART OF COMMUNICATION

Three essential arts come together:

The art of listening

The art of asking questions

The art of acknowledging

A. WHY LISTENING IS AN ART

It is called an art because it draws on many skills: concentration, understanding, empathy, and the ability to grasp nuance and things left unsaid. When we really listen, we begin to pick up on the other person's feelings, needs, and thoughts. That's how we build deeper conversations, stronger relationships, and resolve conflicts better. This art goes far beyond hearing; it requires a deep receptiveness to what is being said. And like any art, it takes practice, awareness, and a feel for the finer points of human connection.

Human beings have two ears and one mouth,
so they listen twice as much as they talk!

Listening is described as "active" because it requires three complementary elements:

1. **Preparation:** The wealth manager must pose the right open and relevant questions, enabling the client to open up and share what matters most. Too often, advisers prepare what they wish to say rather than focusing on the information they need to receive.
2. **Physical engagement**: Listening involves more than ears; it includes body language such as nodding, facial expressions, encouraging smiles, and brief verbal cues that invite the client to elaborate. Taking notes is a concrete way to show attentiveness.
3. **Follow-up and action:** Listening becomes truly active when followed by concrete actions. Regular summaries and their confirmation are key parts of effective listening.

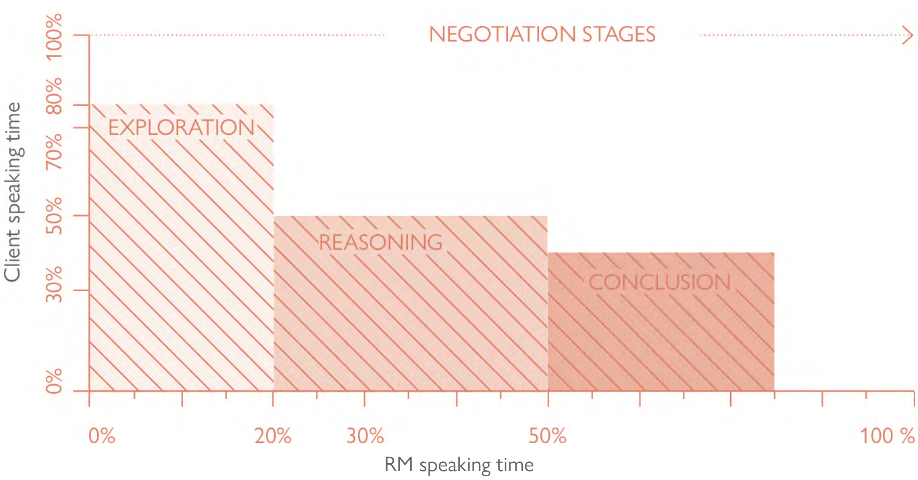
ALLOWING SPACE FOR SILENCE ENABLES…:

… my client to absorb the information.
… me to prepare the next question.
… intimacy to be established through a sense of restraint and modesty.
… time to commit the discussion to memory.
… the words spoken to carry more weight.

Selling is about learning from others; you must temporarily disconnect from your own opinions to truly listen to what they have to say.

Why is it so important to listen?

1. It ensures balanced communication between participants; this sense of balance encourages ongoing dialog and openness.



2. It ensures clear understanding among all parties involved.
3. It allows the message to be understood, problems to be identified, and a solution to be found.

Sadly, listening isn't a subject taught at university, even though it's the cornerstone of any good client relationship in wealth management.

Active listening is challenging and requires real concentration and alignment with the client.

Some key principles:

- Listening through to the second sentence.
- Listening starts with silence.
- Listening is about having empathy with others.
- Listening calls for kindness and an absence of judgment.

A good salesperson is recognized first and foremost by the questions the ask, not by the answers they provide.

B. THE ART OF QUESTIONING

It's an essential part of the art of selling. No questions, no commercial behavior!

In the next chapter, we'll look at questioning strategies.

Here's a table with different types of questions to help you assess your level of knowledge.

EXAMPLES OF QUESTIONS	TYPE OF QUESTION	PURPOSE OF THE QUESTION
Are you convinced by our services? Do you work with a single banking partner? Are you listed with other banks? Would you like to make a decision in the very short term?	**Closed**	These questions prompt the client to take a position.
Does the proposed diversification suit you?	**Closed, but more precise**	Depending on the answer, the RM can move toward the conclusion.
What do you think of our various management mandates? How many banking partners do you have? Which banks do you work with? What is your main selection criterion?	**Open**	These questions encourage dialog and invite the client to share their opinion.
What factors would lead you to choose us as your partner?	**Positively framed**	The way a question is framed shapes the answer it elicits

What don't you like about this management mandate?	**Negatively oriented**	The guided question directs the client's thinking in a specific direction.
What are the three main factors in your decision when choosing a bank?? What types of mandates do you hold with your current banking partner? What's preventing you from signing the investment mandate right now? What exactly are you interested in?	**Grounding questions**	An overly conceptual client needs to be grounded in practical terms.
How are you feeling? How important are your banking partner's values to you? What quality criteria did you use to choose your main bank? What's at stake for you with this decision?	**Elevating questions**	A client who is too focused on concrete details needs to be guided toward more a bstract ideas.
I imagine you already work with several banking partners. I'm sure you already have accounts with several banks. Let's move forward with opening the account — does that sound good to you?	**Implicit**	An implicit question is based on an assumption that subtly nudges the client toward a decision.

Why use leading questions?

Depending on how a question is phrased, I can influence or steer the nature of the response. A question can be positively, negatively, or neutrally framed.

Neutral: What do you think?

Positive: What interests you about this product? What did you like? What benefits can the bank offer you?

Negative: What did this manager fail to provide? What are you dissatisfied with?

WE'RE NO LONGER CURIOUS ENOUGH

Curiosity has actually been seen as a flaw since childhood ("curiosity killed the cat…"). We ask closed questions because we lack genuine interest, and are often self-centered and egotistical.

C. THE ART OF ACKNOWLEDGING

It's the art of truly understanding one another; it links the art of questioning with that of active listening. It is the foundation of communication. The most classic form of confirmation is paraphrasing, whose simple function is to ensure that my client and I are on the same wavelength.

Example:

Client: I would like my investment to comply with ESG principles. Is that possible?

Wealth manager: I understand your concern; you want your investments to align with your ethical principles; is that correct? In this example, the manager paraphrases with different words to confirm they have properly understood the client's request.

There are several types of acknowledgments:

- **Qualification:** The well-known "That's a good question!"; this type of acknowledgment helps to soften a response or even to flatter the interlocutor.
- **Reformulation:** As in the example above, this is an echoing repetition of what has just been said.
- **Verbalization:** a subtler form of acknowledgment that involves expressing a feeling or putting a sentiment into words.

Whatever its form, the purpose of acknowledgment is to ensure quality communication. Checking what is asked and what is said guarantees the right pace. Confirming all or part of a conversation brings clarity to the relationship.

Acknowledgment also serves an additional intermediate function: conveying perceived emotions, such as "What you're saying right now really resonates with me."

In French, acknowledgment is called an "accusé de reception" and can be **non-verbal** – a nod, a positive gesture, a posture during negotiation, a smile, or eye contact – all of which send a message of receipt or understanding.

Functions of Acknowledgment

Reformulations: The RM rephrases the message in the same sense but using different words.

"So you're saying that…"

Expressing compassion: The RM shows empathy and echoes the client's emotions.

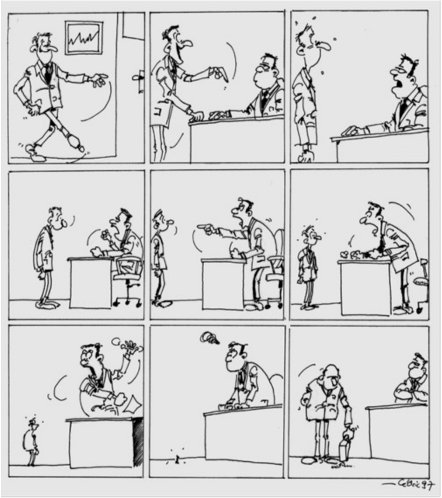
"I understand how you feel..."

"You and I share the same feeling about this topic…

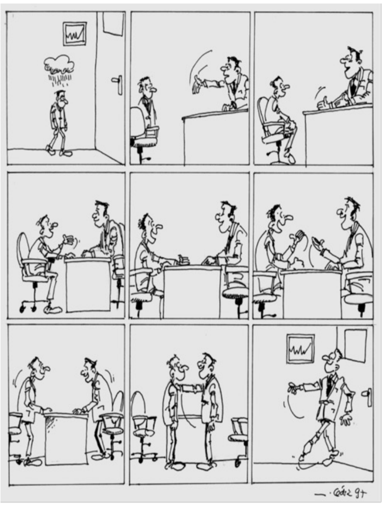
Prompts: The RM uses verbal or non-verbal prompts to encourage further dialog.

"Yes, of course... please go on, tell me more, keep going…"

Emotional angle: The RM takes an emotional perspective in their reformulation.
"What you're telling me pleases me, moves me, or worries me."
Check-in: The RM ensures they are on the same wavelength as the client.
"Let me summarize our conversation and please tell me if you agree."



NEGATIVE



POSITIVE

4. PREPARATION

Preparation is a key part of the first contact and has an impact in several ways.

- **A psychological impact:** A well-prepared manager will be more engaging and able to inspire confidence when they prepare visibly in writing (the client can see that they are well prepared).
- **A commercial impact:** Knowing which questions to ask, what information to collect, and which investments to discuss.

Preparation leads to significant time savings. How many oversights, delays, repetitions, or unnecessary trips could be avoided?

In the long term, preparation makes the salesperson more flexible and more creative:

- greater confidence and adaptability during the negotiation process.
- calmer mind that allows creativity to flow.

Wealth management clients are moving targets. Each meeting requires specific preparation, such as figures to share and investment opportunities to present. The meeting takes place on two levels: the exchange of technical information and its psychological impact.

A sale can't begin until all objectives are clearly identified – both yours and your client's. They must be stated, clarified, and confirmed.

A. THE ESSENTIAL REFLEXES OF PREPARATION

Questions a relationship manager should ask themselves before meeting a client:

- What are my client's goals?
- What are my sales objectives?
- What kind of needs does he/she have (both explicit and implicit)?
- What is his/her investor profile?
- What objections might there be?
- What materials should I prepare?
- How long is the interview likely to last?

Information to gather before the meeting:

- History of the business relationship.
- Is the client already listed, and if so, in what way?
- How well do I know the client's industry sector?
- What is their potential Assets Under Management (AUM)?
- Tangible outcomes from my previous visits (if relevant).
- The most positive point I plan to build on.
- Any referrals I might be able to obtain.

Mental preparation!

How do athletes prepare mentally?

They cultivate a positive image of victory and standing on the podium. They set clear, specific goals.

They reinforce positive beliefs to produce constructive energy when facing an opponent.

They look for common ground – with clients, socially or culturally.

He who fails to prepare is preparing to fail.

B. THREE ADDITIONAL REFLEXES

1. Sending the client an agenda ahead of the meeting, including three simple questions:
   – What is the purpose of our meeting?
   – What can I prepare in advance?
   – How long will our meeting last? Or: How much of your time should I allow for?

2. Sending a summary **after** the meeting:
   Thank them for the meeting, recap key discussion points,
   outline next steps, follow-up over time, and schedule the next meeting.
3. The 5 Whens and 7 Whos
   These questions help the manager focus on what matters most. The "Whens" relate closely to action, while the "Whos" relate to decision-making.

The 5 Whens:
- When will you decide to work with our bank?
- When can we meet again?
- When would you like to sign the management contract?
- When would you like the mandate to begin?
- When do you plan to make the transfer?

In every purchasing decision, seven "Whos" come into play (complementing the sociogram):
- Who expresses the need?
- Who analyzes the need?
- Who provides the funding?
- Who makes the recommendation?
- Who makes the final decision?
- Who handles the purchase?
- Who uses the product or service?

The negotiator cannot control the entire web of influences, but by identifying the "7 Whos," they can pinpoint allies and take steps to neutralize potential opponents.

Create a sociogram.

Definition: A sociogram maps out the existence and nature of relationships within any human group, independently of the formal structure defined by the organizational chart.

Eleven questions to ask when when mapping influence through a sociogram:

Who do you need to meet, and in what order?
Who is the actual decision-maker?
Can they be influenced, and by whom?
What's the best approach for arranging a meeting with them?
What are their responsibilities and constraints?
How does your proposal concern them directly?
What does the bank represent to them?
What is their role and influence in the decision-making chain? How can you bypass someone blocking the decision?
Which arguments are likely to resonate with them?
What specific outcome are you seeking with this individual?

C. ANALYZING POWER DYNAMICS

This analysis helps us understand that both sides have the power to influence the negotiation. The manager holds the power of the solution, while the client holds the power to decide.

What powers are at play among the various stakeholders?[8]
Each person has certain levers they can use. The manager may bring expertise, but others have power too.

- The power of volume and numbers
- The power of choice. The strongest negotiator is the one with the best BATNA (Best Alternative to a Negotiated Agreement); in other words, the ability to fall back on a satisfactory plan B if talks fail.
- The power to influence decisions. The client typically holds this power, while the manager holds the power of service quality and scope.
- The power to take one's time. Time can be a powerful ally; it strengthens those who are in no rush to decide or act.
- The power to disrupt. The potential to cause disruption if talks deteriorate.
- The power of charisma. In general, personality, confidence in communication, and charisma carry great influence.
- The power of social status. This includes the power of one's name, education, or network of connections.

The power that counts most is not real power,
but perceived power.

Choosing the meeting place

The manager will agree with the client on where the meeting should take place and may influence this choice. Since information is now exchanged automatically, the client has no real reason to remain hidden. Discretion is still associated with money, and bank clients often see it as a kind of trademark. If the client is seeking a high level of confidentiality, they won't come to the bank. They'll prefer a neutral location, such as their home, office, or a hotel.

For due diligence purposes, the manager is better off meeting the client at their workplace or home, as this offers a clearer picture of the client's activities and adds a different dimension to the relationship. It also gives the client an opportunity to take pride in showing their home or factory. Traditions vary greatly between regions: in Southern Europe, clients may receive you in their business premises, whereas in Asia, a neutral location like a hotel is more common.

8 R. Fisher et W. Ury, *Getting to Yes*, Penguin, 2011.

D. INTEGRATING DIGITAL TOOLS INTO SALES PREPARATION[9]

1. The first step in your digital preparation is to refer to your CRM. It serves as the bank's commercial memory – and it should be yours too. It manages all commercial tasks, making it not only useful but strategic. Part of your commercial success depends on the quality of your CRM.
2. The most basic reflex is to Google your future contact.
3. To go further in personalized follow-up, Google Alerts is a powerful tool that lets you stay informed about people you are tracking. As soon as any new information about them appears online, you'll receive an email notification.
4. Social media and LinkedIn: Most of our clients are on LinkedIn or other platforms (X, YouTube, Facebook, Instagram, TikTok). Subscription and follow features allow us to maintain a direct stream of information about the people we want to follow.
5. Automate follow-up tasks by using your CRM or email system to track clients and keep them engaged by regularly providing useful information.

E. SALES ACTIVITY DASHBOARD

This table is largely inspired by a sales training course that was delivered to all relationship managers at a cantonal bank.

It sets out key criteria to consider when preparing for a client meeting, as well as commercial goals to review beforehand:

1. Overall customer development and follow-up.
2. Visit, maintain and develop high-potential clients.
3. Increase business from existing clients while reducing attrition and withdrawals.
4. Strengthening cross-selling (receiving and referring) across departments and complementary products.
5. Streamline alignments between customer needs and bank products, optimize value propositions.
6. As the manager prepares for a second or even a third appointment, he or she must ask himself or herself whether his or her value propositions are coherent.

9 Customer Relationship Management.

WEALTH MANAGER'S REFERENCE POINTS	INDICATORS
Individual performance objectives	ROA (Return On Assets)
Market-specific performance objectives	AUM (Assets Under Management) by market
Net portfolio volume growth	Mesure des différences entre deux périodes données
Evolution of the portfolio's clientele	Number of clients / Volume
Net New Money	Client acquisition Client departures Client erosion
Cross-selling	Referrals to another department Client recommendations
High-potential client development	Visits and follow-up with top 30 clients in the portfolio
Client evolution by commercial portfolio segment	Portfolio segments
Clientèles à fort potentiel / cibles	Contacts / number of visits / meetings held
Client departures / withdrawals	Departures to competitors / Natural withdrawals (taxes, salaries)
New business from competitors	In volume
Client product/service penetration rate	By product / By service
Commercial action plan	Alignment with the bank's commercial strategies

An expert's perspective

Paola has been working with a financial institution in Switzerland for the past seventeen years and is currently a relationship manager specializing in the Latin American market (LatAm).

She shares her day-to-day commercial experience.

What I do before the meeting

Before the first meeting, I need to check whether the prospect is likely to be accepted by our compliance team. I review their profile on World-Check to ensure it meets our standards. I also verify that the industry from which the funds originate is not considered sensitive by our bank.

I also look them up on platforms like LinkedIn, Google, and YouTube to gather further information.

I also take the opportunity to gather further personal and professional information. Public sources are often plentiful — for instance, the company's website usually details their services, how long they've been operating in the market, and who their clients are. I prepare a list of follow-up questions to ask during the in-person meeting. My main interest is in understanding how they built their wealth.

Before each meeting, I already have a fairly strong general idea of who my future client is, even though we haven't yet met. I've learned that even small logistical details really matter. If just one thing doesn't go to plan, it can taint my entire sales approach. let reception know, I book a meeting room for the scheduled time, and I send an invite with the exact address and time; I even send a GPS link for first meetings. On a personal level, on the morning of the meeting, I consider what dress code would be most appropriate for that specific client. It depends whether I'm meeting a man or a woman, an industrialist or a doctor. Before the meeting, I mentally prepare myself. I visualize the interaction and boost my self-confidence. I believe this process helps build trust with the prospective client.

What I do during the meeting

Once notified of the client's arrival, I promptly go to meet them, so they are not kept waiting. I greet them by name, introduce myself clearly, and outline my role at the bank. I tell them it's a pleasure to meet them and I smile, which helps ease the tone of the meeting from the outset. I make sure to keep eye contact, we exchange business cards, and I immediately clarify the structure of the meeting: How long do they have? What do they hope to achieve? If the client tells me they want to open an account, for example to diversify their assets, I explain that I'll need their assistance to complete the KYC accurately. I have a standard set of questions that I tailor to each person:

- How did you accumulate your wealth?
- What is the origin and history of your funds?
- What industry do you work in?
- What are your passions? What's your family background?
- What is your core business? Who are your clients?
- What are your plans, both professionally and personally?

I take a copy of their passport and explain to them exactly what each document is and what it's for. I always set a date for a follow-up meeting. Before we part, I thank them and end on a positive note – for example, by saying that I look forward to working with them and that they can count on my full commitment.

What I do after the meeting

I send a follow-up email the same day or the next, thanking them again for their time and the trust they've placed in me.

I complete the KYC promptly while the information is still fresh in my mind. Once compliance has approved the account opening, I send a confirmation letter along with the bank details for the funds transfer.

Key message

For me, the most important thing is to build and reinforce mutual trust. I aim to leave every first meeting with a clear picture of my client's goals and background, and to have introduced the bank and its main investment options. I make a point of maintaining a personal connection — a message for their birthday, a Christmas card, etc. Each relationship is unique, and that's what I love about this job.

Spring into action!
5 key takeaways and an exercise

FIVE KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. Take care with your first impression; it has a decisive impact on the rest of the negotiation.
2. Never say anything that is more beautiful than silence.
3. Be mindful of creating a sense of trust with your clients.
4. Effective communication comes down to listening well, asking the right questions, and acknowledging what you hear.
5. Always write things down when preparing – for every meeting, with everyone!

EXERCICE

Title: Make a strong first impression.

Aim of the exercise: Know how to act intentionally to trigger a positive reaction.

Instructions:

- Write down three actions you deliberately take during a first contact to create a positive impact with your prospect or client.
- What are your three go-to preparation habits before every meeting?

9

Getting to Know

the client's strongest side

It's a moment of truth — the real self emerges,
and illusions mislead us.
Be true to who you ar!

TEACHING OBJECTIVES

After reading this chapter, you will be able to:

- Discover your clients' explicit and implicit needs.
- Predict their reactions and behaviors by analyzing their interpersonal style.
- Assess the level of closeness or trust you have with your clients.
- Develop an appropriate questioning strategy.

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1. CLIENTS AND THEIR DEEPER NEEDS

What is a deep need? It's a need that a customer is unable to verbalize, and the manager must help him or her to do so.

In the rest of this chapter, we'll look at emotional and implicit needs, as well as more rational and explicit ones.

It is the right balance between different types of needs that leads to a buying decision — and imbalance that causes hesitation.

Identifying a client's deeper needs is a shared responsibility.

The connection must be intimate — all relevant information about the client's life must be known. If something is missing, the investment advice may be flawed.

Wealth managers practice a form of risk education, explaining their own responsibilities to the client, whether moral, professional, or legal.

The relationship between the client and the wealth often resembles active psychotherapy. Expressed needs are emotional (such as asset security), while expectations are highly rational (such as account performance).

Five prerequisites for analysis:

1. **You can detect part of your psychological profile in your history...** Investor history, family history, entrepreneurial history, professional history, intimate and personal history.
2. **Creating a profile** means giving a face to someone you have only recently met. The stakes are high both emotionally and operationally. Profiling involves uncovering a life of work, sacrifice, luck, and adventure. It means integrating the client's psychological dimension into investment proposals.
3. **The wealth manager walks a fine line** to spot potential. They don't want to tread on toes but instead work to build by bringing together what the client says they want with what the analysis shows (sometimes the client's ambitions don't quite fit their actual possibilities).
4. A needs analysis begins by focusing solely on the client.
5. Establishing the investor's profile is the first **key point of alignment** the manager can secure. Defining this profile isn't risky for the client but does involve engagement. The profile will drive the investment proposals.

A STRATEGY TO BETTER UNDERSTAND OUR CLIENTS' DEEPER NEEDS: THE **SPIN** STRATEGY[1]

Situation
Problem
Impact on the client
Need

Each stage of the method:
Stage 1 – Situation: Start by understanding the client's unspoken needs. They might talk about basic concerns with managing their wealth, such as investments, how they see risk, inheritance, or a complicated life story. The RM asks questions to dig into these hidden needs and builds a profile. They then check this profile with the client.
Any clear needs should also be fully explored.
Stage 2 – Problem: The RM focuses on the implicit needs that are causing trouble and makes a list.
Stage 3 – Impact on the client: What are the consequences of these main problems?
The analysis becomes increasingly detailed, as the RM "digs" to find the issues that are central to the client's concerns.
Stage 4 – Need: The RM shows the client the potential benefits of addressing this central issue. How can the bank handle your problem with their in-house experts?

2. THE IMPORTANCE OF CLIENT PROFILING

First and foremost, it's about being in touch with reality, having a lucid analysis of what the client really needs and the objectives they express.
Profiling allows for the anticipation of problematic situations that could emerge from a mismatch between the client's expectations and the practical requirements of managing their capital.

La cohérence dans le temps :

Coherence over time:

Creating a profile requires coherence over time, based on the formula PPF/PPF = 1, which analyses the client's **Professional, Personal, and Financial** situation in relation to the **Past, Present, and Future**.

1 Based on a presentation by Maryse Gabbay, Training Manager at ISFB (Institut Supérieur de Formation Bancaire) in Geneva.

Analyzing over time helps better assess how the client's motivations evolve — in other words, to put them "to the test of time."[2].

Are you someone who plants oak trees?

Three ways to draft a profile:

1. By inviting the client to complete profile questionnaires 1 and 2 (following pages, used in addition to the KYC).
2. After the first meeting, use one of the profile questionnaires as a guide to write their summary.
3. By referring to different sections of the questionnaire during their conversations and gradually builds the profile over the course of the initial meetings (taking as much time as needed).

3. SHOULD YOU BE INTERESTED IN THEIR PORTFOLIO – OR IN THEM?

A wealth investment project is intimately linked to an person's life project. The three phases of analyzing this life project begin well before any discussion of financial products:

The first phase is the origin of the individual's wealth — not from a legal standpoint, but a psychological one. Wealth inherited does not carry the same meaning as wealth earned through hard work.

The second phase involves the individual's experience as an investor — their personal history and journey, appetite for gains, and risk tolerance.

The third phase is how the client envisions the future and the context surrounding that projection (e.g. forthcoming wealth planning stages).

Other factors to consider:

- The client's investment preferences and the reasons behind them (distinguishing between a vague desire and a well-thought-out motivation).
- Their willingness (or not) to maintain control over their investments, and why.
- Their capacity to trust.
- Their level of financial knowledge.
- The amount of time they spend thinking things through before making investment decisions.
- An analysis of the positive and negative aspects of their past banking relationships.

The profile is a relationship between the client and the wealth manager; the client and the bank; and the client and themselves!

2 Participant (Swiss market), "Train to RM" seminar.

The different types of profile:

- Personal relationship profile (person or entity): who they actually are.
- Biographical profile: life history.
- Portfolio profile: expected funds, source of funds, origin of funds, PEP status, risk factors.
- Investor profile.
- Personal data profile.
- Account profile: what the client intends to do with their money.

The more thorough and accurate the analysis, the fewer ambiguous situations will arise in the future.

We provide two complementary charts to help create a client profile (note: there is some overlap).

Questionnaire Profile One:

INFORMATION SOURCES	QUESTIONS TO ASK	INFORMATION RELEVANT TO THE MORE INTIMATE SPHERE	COMMENTS
Personal life	What are the family's life plans?	Plans that will involve life changes.	
	What are the key events in the family's history?	Analysis of family tensions, if any.	Key points that might influence investor behavior.
	Occupations of all family members.	Mention both successes and setbacks in their careers.	
	Nationality	What is the family's origin and history?	From an ethnic and historical perspective, including the roles played by ancestors.
	Where do family members live?	Do they all live in the same place?	Why this choice of location?
	How does the family coordinate its investment activities?	Who has the final say?	Who influences who?
	Are there any structures in place, such as a trust or a family office?	What's the background behind their creation?	
	Does the family have an intermediary advisor?	Why was this consultant chosen?	Will they be a driving force or a resisting force?

INFORMATION SOURCES	QUESTIONS TO ASK	INFORMATION RELEVANT TO THE MORE INTIMATE SPHERE	COMMENTS
Wealth	What is the origin of the wealth and financial situation?	Inheritance, property sale, etc.	
	What are the sources of income?	Pensions, salaries, rents, etc.	
	What is the structure and asset allocation: real estate, portfolio, cash?	Detailed overview of all holdings. Who are the existing financial partners?	Who are your other financial partners and their specializations?
	What is the precise value of the wealth?	Asset allocation and financial statements from other banks.	
	List current financial partners.	What percentage of the wealth is invested with each partner?	
	What is the potential for growth of the current wealth?	Business and investment projects.	
Investments	How are the client's investments currently organized?	What is the meaning of your life?	This fundamental question will define the organization of investments.
	Interest in the economy in general.	How do you keep up with financial news today?	An excellent benchmark for determining the degree of commitment to future investment decisions.
	What are your experiences with investing?	How have you done so far?	Does the client have a clear idea of what constitutes their assets?
	How would you describe your knowledge of financial products and markets?	Are there any investment products you know well? Could you walk me through how one of them works?	Being able to explain an investment product helps assess a person's level of financial knowledge.
	The relationship to risk	When in your life have you taken risks, and which ones?	Biographical analysis is an invaluable tool for measuring risk.
	What time frame are you thinking of for your investments?	Short, medium, or long term?	The time frame also helps assess risk appetite.

INFORMATION SOURCES	QUESTIONS TO ASK	INFORMATION RELEVANT TO THE MORE INTIMATE SPHERE	COMMENTS
	What are your short- and medium-term goals?	How do you define happiness?	Money is merely a means to obtain something in life – could it be happiness?
	Are there any exclusions that should be applied to your investments?	What are your investment objectives?	How do you explain these exclusions – are they based on moral or religious beliefs?
	What are the inclusions...?	How do you explain these choices?	Where do these convictions come from?
	How much cash do you need for your lifestyle?	An answer in figures.	Analysis of the main cash requirements.
	Why not leave your cash in a safe?	What do you want to do? Develop your savings, build up your pension provision, grow an inherited capital?	What is your relationship with money? Is it scary for you or not?
The relationship	What type of reporting does the client want?	Do you need to see me physically, or will a written report suffice?	The nature and volume of information required.
	How often should the client deal with the bank?	Let's set an agenda for the whole year	
	What kind of relationship are you hoping to have with your adviser?	What do you expect from me? How do you feel about our initial conversations?	Would it make sense to have this type of review twice a year?

Following this first analysis we should know[3] :

- The investment objectives
- Time frame
- Management method

- Delegated or engaged management style?
- Risk appetite/aversion
- His/her management style: conservative – balanced – aggressive.

- Diversification
- Foresight

- Key events
- Meaning of life

Questionnaire Profile Two: There is some overlap here, which is intentional to be as exhaustive as possible.

TOPICS TO COVER	QUESTIONS TO ASK	TOPIC'S COMMERCIAL PURPOSE
Who are you and what is the size of your wealth		
Personal situation: All elements included in the KYC	Family situation Marital status Age Children (their future plans, are they dependent?) Children's ages, education? Where are they studying?	Profile building begins. There are many opportunities to genuinely engage with him/her and understand the roots of their decisions.
Cultural profile, biographical approach	What is their education? What is their cultural background? Initial training? Schools and universities attended. Political or community involvement. Religion, social status	Based on their education, the RM can assess the client's initial conditioning and financial knowledge.
Family history	His family background. What did their parents pass down to them?	This emotional aspect fosters intimacy between the client and their RM.
Professional situation	See KYC Are you part of a professional organization?	Assessment of savings capacity and recurring income potential.
Financial situation	See KYC for income and its nature. Distribution of wealth. Do you need access to this capital?	Asset accumulation serves as a sign of the investor's profile.

3 Source: Inspired by BCGE's "best of" training summary (2010).

TOPICS TO COVER	QUESTIONS TO ASK	TOPIC'S COMMERCIAL PURPOSE
Inventory of assets		Focus for future investment advice. Business partners represent potential recurring income and future contacts.
Banking relationships	Who is your primary, sole, secondary, complementary, or specialized bank? Who manages your assets?	Ability to position yourself within the banking relationship. Identifying your future client.
Taxation	What are your tax needs?	Complementary services and client anxiety.
Succession	Have you prepared your succession?	*Liquidity event* Support for preparing your family succession.
Real estate	Are you a property owner?	Personal housing needs.
What kind of investor are you?		
Financial knowledge	See KYC table. Knowledge of financial markets.	How the client gets their information and a review of their level of financial knowledge (including a short test)
Knowledge of the wealth management profession	What do you know about our profession?	Identify any gaps and clarify how our future relationship will work.
Investment experience	What is your investment background? When did you last invest? And in what?	What strategies have you used so far? Tell me about your experiences and how you reacted.
Relationship quality with RMs	What makes a good advisor, in your opinion?	Define your satisfaction criteria. Clarify your expectations regarding the relationship.
What is your management style?		
Time frame (of the investment)	What is your time frame and why? Short / medium / long term	Assess your projects and their timelines. Consider succession plans if there are heirs.
Management style	How sensitive are you to risk? What management approach do you prefer? Hands-on involvement or delegation to specialists?	How do you spend your vacations: trekking in Tibet or relaxing on the beaches of Ibiza? Adventure or caution? Ensure the information you provide is consistent. Derive your investor profile: defensive / balanced / dynamic
Management style	Identify whether they client wants to… 1. Manage their investments independently. 2. Receive advice on managing their investments. 3. Be able to delegate the management of their investments.	Prepare proposals in advance.
At this stage, summarize all the information collected so far and verify it, covering financial status, knowledge, investor experience, and preferred management style and approach.		

TOPICS TO COVER	QUESTIONS TO ASK	TOPIC'S COMMERCIAL PURPOSE
What are your objectives? What is your appetite for risk, or do you prefer to avoid it?		
Investment objectives	Why do you want to invest? To grow your savings / plan for the future / preserve a legacy / for speculation? Preserve your capital with no risk? Earn a return while accepting some risk? Maximize performance by taking bigger risks?	It's important to gauge not only the client's expectations but also how realistic they are regarding potential returns.
Risk tolerance	What's your definition of risk? What do you know about the risk/return trade-off?	Establish the client's risk tolerance boundaries. Explain that risk and return are forever linked. How much loss is the client prepared to endure.
Loss and gain scenarios	If an investment drops by 15%, what would you do? Sell, hold, or invest more? If an investment rises by 15%, what would you do? Sell, hold, or invest more?	Assess the client's awareness of the risk/return balance.
Validate the client's investment goals, assess their risk tolerance, and confirm the management approach: discretionary, advisory, or execution-only		
Summary of the interview Can you describe yourself and the extent of your wealth? What kind of investor would you say you are, and what management approach do you prefer? What are your objectives? How do you feel about risk? Are you risk-averse or risk-tolerant?		

THE ART OF ASKING THE RIGHT QUESTIONS!

Ask the client: "What are your real questions?"
Repeat this several times to check if the same questions keep coming up.

You need to ask what we call "big-picture" questions!

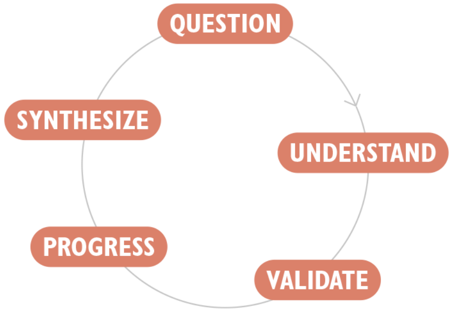
These are short, simple questions made up of just a few words – but each one touches on many important ideas:

"What gives your life meaning?" (my favorite)

"What's your history as an investor?"

"How have you managed your wealth up until now?"

"Thinking about your investments, when was the last time you felt genuinely satisfied?"



A customer is the most important visitor on our premises.
He is not dependent on us. We are dependent on him.
He is not an interruption in our work. He is the purpose of it. He is not an outsider in our business. He is part of it.
We are not doing him a favor by serving him. He is doing us a favor by giving us an opportunity to do so. (L.L. Bean)

4. THE FUNDAMENTALS OF PROFILING

- Creating a profile is much easier when the conversation feels warm, open, and built on trust.
- Make sure the spotlight stays on the client; don't get sidetracked.
- The more personal the relationship becomes, the easier the conversation will flow.

- As the saying goes: "Who writes, reads twice"! *(Quid scribit, bis legit)* Take notes – it's rewarding.
- The client's expectations and demands are the backbone of the commercial discussion.
- Always put your business and its solidity, available resources, and support teams into perspective (you're never alone).

Strategic questions during profile development:

1. How can I build a genuine and trusting relationship with the client?
2. What strategy should I use to encourage them to increase their holdings with us?
3. Why do we not manage all their assets?
4. Are we the client's sole bank or their primary banking partner?
5. Are we the client's go-to or reference bank?

A COUNTERINTUITIVE APPROACH THAT WORKS ALONGSIDE SPIN QUESTIONING...

The client may not reveal everything (voluntarily or not). Identifying, digging out and locating the client's problem is a way of uncovering true needs.
The problem is defined by something negative from the client's point of view (from their perspective), and therefore the absence of something positive.

Questions for digging into pain points:
How is this issue bothering you?
How much does it bother you? Does it keep you awake at night or not?
What are the implications of this problem for your life?
What will be the consequences of the problem if it isn't resolved?

Absence of positives:
What more could you gain? What is the extend of your needs? What benefits will you see once this issue is resolved?
What happens if your needs remain unmet? Why is it important to address this need?
What will you gain once your needs are fully met?

The following text compares client needs 20 years apart, based on an analysis by Berthe Soffer-Smadja, an IBM engineer and Nestlé project manager specializing in customer relations.

Business volume comes from satisfied clients; acquiring a new client costs five times more than maintaining an existing, satisfied one.

Dissatisfied clients don't always make the effort to voice their dissatisfaction by filing a complaint. After all, who tells the restaurant that the dish wasn't quite to their liking?

These customers have a lot of power to harm a brand when they share their frustrations.

With social media, things move fast—customers today are just as "smart" as their phones, always connected and in the know.

A scandal in a Madrid restaurant chain can spread worldwide in under 20 minutes. Information flows both ways: customers get instant news, and their behavior is tracked, analyzed, and monetized.

What were once future trends 15 years ago are now realities. Which ones, though?

- *Continuous connection*
- *Personalized offers*
- *Fast delivery*
- *Real-time order tracking*

Tom Peters told a story about how valuable a client is. Each time a courier came into his office, there was a big sign showing $180,000 — the amount he'd spent with the courier's company over 10 years. That simple reminder would surely bring a smile to many couriers visiting our offices.

Back in 2002, service was judged mainly by the relationship's quality and speed. Today, immediacy is key. The accuracy of information and expertise of the people involved are crucial.

Information is extremely valuable nowadays; it is transformed into "data" and analyzed, "mined" by data scientists who can anticipate future behaviors. This is often relevant and increasingly seen as less intrusive in our lives, where information is already widely accessible, whether we like it or not….

5. UNDERSTANDING THE OTHER PERSON'S PROFILE BY UNDERSTANDING THEIR NEEDS, INDIVIDUALITY, AND "COLORS"

Otherness is about accepting people as they are, embracing their differences – a valuable perspective to bring into the world of sales. It's a human-centered approach that helps us connect more meaningfully with clients.

These differences deserve thoughtful analysis and deeper understanding.

For this, we've drawn on Insight Discovery[4], a respected psychometric tool. Its color-coded profiles offer a clear and memorable way to recognize common client types in private banking.

4 Insight Suisse: Zugerstrasse 70, CH-6340 Baar. Email: office@insightsworld.ch – Phone: +41 (0) 41 768 11 44

The goal is to help relationship managers assign, even roughly, a colour profile to each client based on psychometric indicators. This supports better communication, smoother interactions, and a more pleasant commercial relationship.

Commercial otherness is about being aware of the other person, understanding their style, and adapting to engage effectively.

People tend to show behaviors that feel instinctive. This creates a kind of "outer layer", shaped by their habits, preferences, and inner energy.

Understanding the filters behind these behaviors helps explain not only what people do, but why.

You can get clues about someone's style from their posture, gestures, how they speak, the speed and tone of their voice – even something as simple as a handshake.

Our senses need to be on alert from the very first moment of contact.

The client will forget what the RM said,
but not how they felt in their company!

A. BEHAVIORAL STYLES THROUGH THE FOUR-COLOR MODEL:

Blue style: This person is methodical and precise. They need time to think, they plan their life and activities carefully, and prefer to take their time when completing tasks. They value knowledge, content, and adherence to rules and standards.

Observable traits: Cautious, measured, investigative, and formal.

They might also be: indecisive, dull, suspicious, cold, and reserved.

Green style: This person is guided by strong values, tends to question things, and is realistic and approachable without being arrogant. They value stability and quality service. They are consistent, though sometimes intentionally slow and deliberate.

Observable traits: Caring, calm, patient, and community minded.

They might also be: overly soft, slow, dependent, stubborn, or overly compliant.

Yellow style: This person is self-confident, inspiring, and pleasant to interact with. They tend to see potential and opportunities first, and they instill confidence in others. Time management isn't usually their strong suit.

Observable traits: Sociable, energetic, enthusiastic, and expressive.

They might also be: nervous, restless, indiscreet, flamboyant, and impulsive.

Red style: This person has high self-esteem, speaks clearly, and is ambitious. They thrive on performance and love a challenge; they want everything, and they want it now.

Observable traits: Demanding, competitive, determined, driven, and a natural leader.

They might also: come across as aggressive, overbearing, controlling, authoritarian, and intolerant.

What strategies can wealth managers use to respond effectively to each client's personal style?

Different personality types can respond in various ways – some positively, others more cautiously.

From the very first contact:

Blue style: Maintain a formal and professional tone; slow down and avoid being overly direct.

Green style: Show that you are open-minded and articulate clearly.

Yellow style: Be warm and sociable; start by talking about them.

Red style: Be bold and straight to the point, without waffling.

Listening to each style:

Blue style: wants to know everything down to the last detail.

Your approach: Focus on essential needs, be selective.

Green style: focuses on their values.

Your approach: Pay close attention to signs of impatience.

Yellow style: concentrates on their needs and nothing else.

Your approach: A yellow-style client should be talking for at least 50% of the meeting.

Red style: Active listening can be challenging—it doesn't register strongly with them.

Your approach: Offer positive feedback on their comments.

Create a sales presentation for each style:

Blue style: Provide a well-structured and precise presentation with full documentation. Don't shy away from the details.

Green style: This client needs to feel that their personal concerns are being acknowledged, and that there is openness and mutual trust.

Yellow style: This client enjoys varied discussions and debates, often jumping from one topic to another. They appreciate anecdotes, personal stories, and innovation.

Red style: Time is money, so get straight to the point with a fast-paced delivery and clear proposed solution.

How to handle objections by style:

Blue style: Let them express their issue without pressure, and formally check if your proposal is suitable.

Green style: Avoid being forceful, they will remain neutral; tactfully explore their objections in depth.

Yellow style: Probe to uncover unspoken issues, ask very open-ended questions, present a well-structured argument, maintain some doubt.

Red style: They remain skeptical; challenge them firmly with pointed questions addressing their objections.

What commercial follow-up should look like with each style:

Blue style: Plan useful visits, demonstrate the bank's expertise.

Green style: Personalized visits, maintaining social contact and frequently checking in.

Yellow style: Invitations to events, information on opportunities and innovations, nurturing and enhancing the relationship.

Red style: Be commercially proactive, develop business and talk about performance and track record.

6. BIASES AND A NON-INVASIVE APPROACH

A. THE FIVE POTENTIAL BIASES (DISTORTIONS) WHEN BUILDING A PROFILE

In the process of exploring a client's needs, a manager can lose their way and fall prey to distorted understanding. This is known as a *cognitive bias* – a misleading and seemingly logical thought pattern. Here are the five main types of distortion and how to address them:

Methodological bias: Ask the right people the right questions.

Emotional bias: Personal experiences should not influence perceptions.

Social conformity bias: Clients tend to present themselves in ways they believe are socially acceptable or positively perceived.

Confirmation bias: This is the process of actively looking for evidence that supports an existing assumption.

Anticipated failure bias: When clients are not truly on board with a project and distort their answers accordingly.

B. PRACTICING NON-INVASIVE QUESTIONING

It's a gentler approach to exploring needs – one that takes more time but may be better suited to a relationship that appears more challenging. One useful technique is to avoid starting questions with "Why" or "How," as these often put people on the defensive.

How to dig deeper without offending: situations and questions

My client seems sad	What makes you think they're sad? How can you tell they're sad? How do you personally perceive their sadness? What are you feeling in response?
You need to keep prospecting	Who exactly is responsible for prospecting? Why do you believe prospecting is the answer? What is the goal of prospecting?
I disagree with my client	What exactly do you disagree on? How can you have a productive conversation to find common ground? How serious is this disagreement?
My client is changing their investment style	How will this impact on your relationship? What changes do you need to make in your behavior as their relationship manager? What type of investment style are you now dealing with?
This prospect's behavior annoys me	What is it that annoys you? What do you need to do to stop it?
This client is very aggressive toward me	What makes you feel attacked? Is there something in your behavior that could be triggering this reaction? In what situations do you feel this aggression? What is the client doing that feels aggressive to you?
I'm happy with my relationship with this new prospect	What makes you happy? What makes you say that? What do you think makes a happy relationship?

7. UNDERSTANDING YOUR CLIENT BY BUILDING INTIMACY

The basic principle: The more information I have, the deeper the level of intimacy.

Based on the 36 criteria of the "degree of intimacy" questionnaire, you're going to measure your degree of intimacy with two of your current clients. Take a recent client and a second, older one.

The foundations of this theory:

- Strong proximity usually indicates a strong trust-based relationship.
- Emotional connection enhances trust.
- Today's relationship managers should prioritize the client relationship first, and the portfolio second.
- Proximity involves interest in the client's overall wealth and life goals, not just investment performance.
- Trust is directly linked to the ability to persuade the client.
- If a relationship manager has 60% of assets under discretionary management, that indicates a high level of client trust.

Each question encourages thoughtful reflection on the relationship:

Do we take enough time to "take a break" with our clients and give time to the human relationship?

Do all these answers serve a commercial purpose? Or are they simply indicators of how deep our relationship is?

This questionnaire is part of a so-called *biographical* analysis of the client. The aim is to reach a level of intimacy that creates real comfort for the client – the kind of relationship where they might affectionately say, *"They know everything about me."*

The depth of the relationship is reflected in the client's level of engagement – especially if they begin asking their relationship manager the same types of questions in return.

The overall purpose of the questionnaire:

It's a tool for identifying possible points of connection with your client and establishing common ground.

Have you asked each of these questions at least once in your conversations with the client?

INTIMACY CRITERIA	I KNOW / I DON'T KNOW (YES / NO)	IF I DON'T KNOW, WHAT CAN I DO TO FIND THIS OUT?
Linked to the client relationship		
Their birthday, their partner's birthday, their children's birthdays.		
The make of their car.		
Second home(s).		
Where they last went on vacation.		
Their favorite restaurant and type of food.		
Their favorite sport and any they play.		
I can call them directly without any formalities or intermediaries.		
I know all about their academic and professional background.		
I get a positive response every time I call.		
We speak about their private life.		
I know their priorities in life.		
I don't need to schedule an appointment to see them – I just call.		
We address each other informally (using first-name terms).		
We share the same life values, a nd we've discussed them.		
I know members of their extended family (including first cousins).		
I understand the family dynamics (who's not on speaking terms with whom) and the structure of the family group.		
I know how they made their fortune.		
I am familiar with the details of their life goals.		
Linked to their portfolio		
I know their ethical or ESG (Environmental, Social, and Governance) preferences when it comes to investing.		
They are satisfied with the performance of their portfolio.		
Their portfolio is well aligned with their goals.		
They are satisfied with our services.		
They compare our services to those of the competition.		
I clearly know their short-term financial goals and their long-term ambitions.		

INTIMACY CRITERIA	I KNOW / I DON'T KNOW (YES / NO)	IF I DON'T KNOW, WHAT CAN I DO TO FIND THIS OUT?
Linked to our business relationship:		
We have enough time at each meeting to cover all topics.		
I meet with them frequently (X times per year), and they are satisfied with this.		
They are open to my advice and put it into practice.		
They answer all my questions.		
They readily answer questions about assets held at other banks.		
They easily respond to more personal questions about their affairs.		
They have already provided a referral.		
They consider us their main bank and a strategic partner for investments (they tell us this).		
They are curious about our product and service offerings and ask questions about them.		
They engage in reasonable discussions about fees.		
They provide referrals without needing to be asked.		
They have never complained about my lack of availability.		

8. STICKING POINTS AND OBSTACLES

- **Two key areas to be mindful of:**

– The first is something every salesperson knows: overcoming their fear of selling and letting go of internal hang-ups. What's less often acknowledged is that clients mirror these fears – they too can feel uneasy about making a purchase. This mutual tension can lead to resistance.

– The second is the risk of seeming intrusive. If the relationship manager doesn't clearly explain their approach and working style, the client may feel their boundaries are being crossed.

- **How can the wealth manager help the client to overcome these obstacles?**

– By offering clarity and transparency.
– By encouraging their questions.
– By showing conviction and positive energy.
– By sharing clear goals whenever possible.
– By using plain, accessible language (KISS) and avoiding financial jargon (used by those who think they sound clever when they're hard to understand).

9. A COROLLARY TO NEEDS: OUR CLIENT'S EXPECTATIONS[5]

Private banking clients are increasingly demanding, and they operate on a global playing field.

They are becoming more sophisticated and **financially savvy**.

Much like in the medical field, clients no longer view doctors – or bankers – as the sole **holders of expert knowledge**.

They now see the bank as a **service provider** like any other, and the aura of mystery has faded.

They readily switch providers and compare competing institutions.

Clients now live in an age of instant information – and they expect the same immediacy from their banking relationship.

Their children are spread across the globe, giving them an international outlook and needs to match:

- They want to understand, anticipate, and monitor global developments.
- They want to know how political and geopolitical events will impact their portfolios.
- They increasingly use information technologies and AI as everyday tools.
- They expect their relationship managers to be technically skilled, resilient, loyal, discreet, and available.
- Conversations often happen via WhatsApp, enabling near-instant responses.
- They want access to the best financial products on the market – strong returns with calculated risk, clear and reliable information, and competitive pricing!

The description is not overstated; it simply outlines the trend taking shape. These are the complex dynamics the manager must learn to navigate.

With the competitive environment in their favor, clients' demands on bankers are on the rise (this is an empirical observation over the last 30 years).

The client also wants:

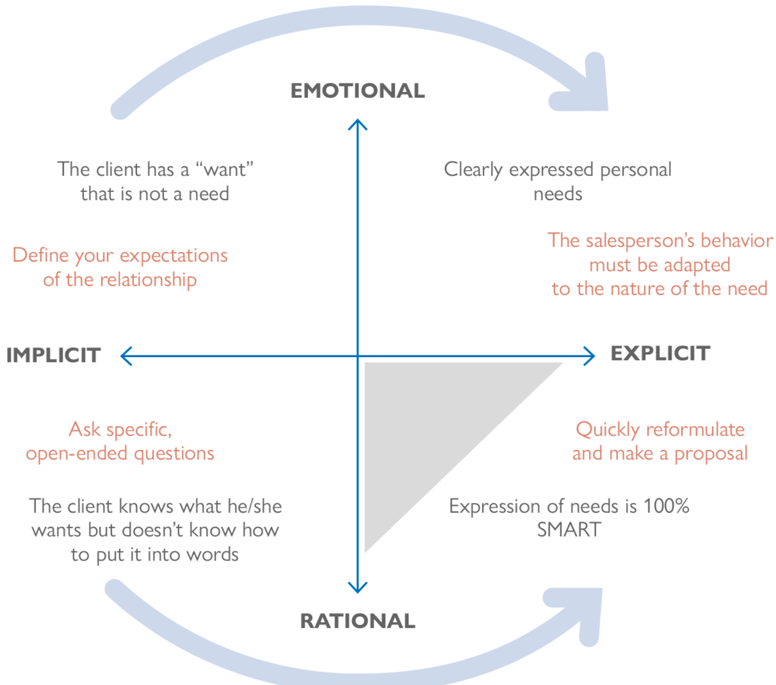
- To feel that every word they say has been heard and taken into account – without dismissal.
- To sense confidence in the analysis and recommendations (not too much uncertainty).
- To be treated as an adult, not as a child being lectured.
- To experience zero condescension.
- To see the wealth manager take immediate action.
- Long-term resolution of their issues – and they appreciate hearing the magic phrase in service quality: *"I'll take care of it personally."*
- The wealth manager to be able to wear a psychotherapist's hat, understand their emotions, stay focused on the interactions, as well as know how to calm their mood swings.

5 Note taken from a recent discussion with a group of RMs from a private bank.

Faced with the power to decide, I have the power to influence.

10. REMINDER OF A CLIENT'S NEEDS

Clients have different kinds of needs, and not all of them are as easy for a wealth manager to work with. When a need is implicit and vague, it leaves space for interpretation, and this can lead to issues and risks. If the client's expectation is emotional, it's even harder to respond. We've identified the best zone for commercial discussions: the explicit and rational quadrant. That's where the sales approach should head, using open questions as the main tool.



"Every sale has 5 basic obstacles:
no need, no money, no hurry, no desire,
no trust" Zig Ziglar (motivational speaker)

Identifying explicit, rational needs involves asking three key types of questions:

1. **Factual questions: Their purpose it t**o take stock of what the client has, is, knows, and does.
2. **Opinion questions: In order** to understand what the client thinks about their situation.
3. **Analysis of pros and cons**: In order to identify advantages, disadvantages, strengths, weaknesses, and problems.
4. **Change-oriented questions:** Are they open to change? Do they already have a solution? If they could improve one thing, what would it be? What would be the consequences of doing nothing?

11. QUESTIONING STRATEGY

The questioning strategy conceptually reflects the knowledge a relationship manager must have to structure their approach. It's about prioritizing and selecting the right questions based on the context and the client. It's about asking the right questions, as well as knowing which ones to avoid.

The themes shown in the example below are not new. What matters is the manager's ability to think, adapt, and construct their line of questioning – to act as a strategist.

The core principles of a good questioning strategy:

1. **The types of questions** you ask are a means of influence. They can be open or closed, upward or downward, positively or negatively framed, triggering, probing, or "hook" questions. The "locomotive" question is the one you ask first – and you then attach "wagon" questions to it!

1. Introduce the questioning by explaining the stage you are at.
2. Alternate between **rational** and **emotional** questioning. Create a relaxed, trusting atmosphere; it should feel like a conversation, not an interrogation.
3. Summarize and rephrase at each step of your questioning strategy, and smoothly transition into the next topic.
4. Let the client's responses guide the way into each new subject, and always acknowledge their questions and requests.
5. Highlight your bank's infrastructure, its legal security, and operational reliability to build trust.

The client has their own motivations.
They follow their own logic and negotiation strategy.
The client doesn't reveal everything; they share what they want,
with whom, and when they choose.

PRIORITIES	TOPICS	QUESTIONS TO ASK
Origins of the relationship with the bank. Getting to know each other. Building trust.	Setting the mood, building confidence. Interview framework. Time available for the interview. Family environment. Professional environment. Life story. Places they have lived. Overview of the bank.	***Motivating questions*** Which sectors are you involved in?
Getting to know the client and their life's project.	Wealth: Components and origins. Assets, "Financial Capacity," Reference Currency.	What is your investment history?
Confirming goals, needs, and all types of expectations.	Objectives, expectations, and outlook for the future, Ongoing or upcoming projects? Income or growth? Time frames involved. Wealth planning. Financial market knowledge assessment.	Summarize, then introduce the next topic.
Strengthen the relationship.	What kind of relationship would you like to have with your banker? Measure satisfaction with current service provider, detect dissatisfaction. How will our partnership be organized? Nature of client involvement.	What makes a good banker? ***Choosing the type of relationship and mandate***
Defining an investor profile.	Relationship to risk: tolerance, appetite, or aversion? Environmental constraints and investment limits.	Needs Products Risks Profitability
Other banking relationships	REVIEW	

RECOMMENDATIONS

Client confirmation of their profile

An expert's perspective

How much importance do you place on emotions during your negotiations?[6]

Whether we like it or not, emotions are part of life and are always present; they are triggered by our thoughts, and during a negotiation, both parties inevitably experience emotions. Learning to manage them is, of course, essential. Emotional regulation is something we begin learning in childhood, but as adults, not everyone reaches the same level of emotional maturity. Managing our emotions begins with knowing how to name them.

For a long time, I found it very difficult to identify a particularly unpleasant emotion I felt after a meeting that didn't result in a signed agreement: the fear of rejection.

As a relationship manager in a private bank, my first negotiation with a prospective client is to open an account. This always involves a meeting, and usually, the prospect decides at the end whether or not to move forward. What's being negotiated or sold isn't just the bank, its fees, and its products; it's also the "privileged" relationship with the relationship manager, in other words, with me. There are, of course, objective and measurable elements involved, but also a deeply subjective dimension. The prospect needs to feel a genuine desire to enter into what may be a long-term relationship with their adviser. In the end, whether they choose to sign or not, the decision always stirs strong emotions in me, both positive and negative, because I inevitably take it personally.

I'd say this is the most difficult emotional aspect to manage, and it lingers despite years of experience – even though one gains perspective over time.

I often meet prospects at times of stress, both positive or negative. The decision to open an account with a new bank usually follows a major life event: an inheritance, the sale of a business, an expatriation, a divorce, or the launch of a new venture. In these emotionally charged moments, clients may make impulsive or extreme decisions. Or, conversely, they may feel paralyzed and stuck in a state of indecision.

Cultural factors also play a key role. Many of my clients are local businesspeople and often quite sensitive and emotionally reactive, especially when they're out of their comfort zone or feeling out of their depth.

When they come to the bank, these emotions can lead them to make decisions that aren't in their best interest. At the start of a meeting, it's best to set things straight, calming any tensions, provide clear guidance, and rebuild the client's

6 Text by Juliette who is an experienced wealth manager and student of my trading course, EMBA 2021.

trust with full transparency. By remaining calm myself, I was able to refocus the discussion, and through empathy, help find the best solution).

When clients come to the bank, these emotions can lead to decisions that may not be in their best interest. At the start of a meeting, it's important to clarify matters, defuse tensions, provide clear guidance, and rebuild the client's trust through transparency.

By remaining calm myself, I was able to refocus the discussion, and, through empathy, help find the best solution.

In conclusion, I believe that with experience, I have become better at identifying, understanding, and thus managing one of my dominant emotions (fear of rejection) as well as those of my clients (sensitive "macho" attitudes).

What would be your ideal behavioral strategy for negotiations?

Things work well when everything unfolds naturally, arguments come easily, and you feel you're moving in the right direction. The emotions involved are a kind of intellectual enjoyment. It's important to guide the client into that same mindset.

The ideal behavioral strategy is to strive for this state of flow, but sadly, it often doesn't happen, and sometimes we lack the necessary energy.

I think the key to getting there is to first build a good foundation: prepare properly, never underestimate the other side, and know how to use all the tools that can keep you on track during the negotiation.

I would also add that if you have a good understanding of yourself, one effective behavioral strategy is to maintain better control of the situation by managing the agenda carefully.

I find that Monday mornings are when I feel most motivated to call clients and make sales, unlike Friday afternoons. So, I recommend planning the week around these energy patterns: use low-energy times for admin tasks and high-energy times for key client interactions. While it sounds simple, it takes experience and self-knowledge to pull off. Early in my career, I wouldn't have managed this. Plus, with instant messaging, we're now constantly connected to clients, making it harder to stick to such a plan.

Spring into action!
5 key takeaways and an exercise

FIVE KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. Know our clients' deepest needs by developing profile questionnaires.
2. Ask "big-picture" questions, one simple question, several concepts.
3. Use color to understand your client profiles.
4. Get closer to your clients.
5. Develop your questioning strategies!

EXERCICE

Title: No needs, no sale!

Aim of the exercise: Learn to explore every possible avenue.

Instructions:

- What five open-ended questions would you ask to effectively explore a prospective client's needs and expectations?
- Note three behavioral characteristics of the last client you met. How did you respond?

10

Building an argument,

USP, and buying signals

Conviction must be intelligent.
The real competitive differences lie in human relationships.

TEACHING OBJECTIVES

After reading this chapter, you will be able to:

- Understand the process of building an argument.
- Apply all the components of persuasive reasoning.
- Use the core concept of C.A.B. (Characteristics – Advantages – Benefits).
- Practice delivering persuasive pitches.
- Make full use of your bank's unique selling points and make the most of every buying signal.

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I. THE BUYING PROCESS IN PRIVATE WEALTH MANAGEMENT

A. TACTICS FOR NEGOTIATING WITH HUMOR AND WIT

The relationship manager must sometimes take a step back to navigate difficult situations and may occasionally resort to a dose of light-hearted, positive "manipulation," as shown in the illustration below. It's not about misleading the client, but about leveraging a touch of (gentle) irony. The negotiator remains discreet, fully transparent, but always slightly theatrical…

TACTICS FOR NEGOTIATING WITH WIT	IMPLEMENTATION (HOW TO DO IT)
"Because I say so…"	Set a firm deadline: You must decide by this date, or everything will fall through
Good cop bad cop	One plays the friendly, understanding role, while the other is intentionally tough.
"Levonetto" – the salami technique	Slice the negotiation into stages. But be careful: don't move to the next "slice" until the current one is fully dealt with.
The charmingly indifferent	Feign a lack of interest to spark urgency or energy in the other party.
"Cash in hand"	When the client takes out cash from their pocket, the salesperson stops making eye contact, creating psychological pressure.
Diverting attention	Break the flow: stand up, pour a drink, switch topics; anything to disrupt the client's rhythm.
"As it happens, the regional manager is in our offices today…"	Bring a senior manager into the negotiation loop, so that he or she can influence the client's decision.
I will never go beyond…	State a firm price limit from the outset.
The breach	Spot a weakness and press on it, with pointed comments or uncomfortable questions!
Reverse reading	Intentionally write down notes so the client across the table can read them upside down.
"Three for the price of two"	Encourage the client to increase volume in exchange for a better rate.
The over-the-top counter	Respond with an overblown counteroffer to underline the lack of realism in the client's expectations.
The final thrust before a yes	One last push: Let's make a final effort – I'll throw this in, and you'll accept my offer.

B. THE CLIENT'S (INVESTMENT) BUYING PROCESS IN WEALTH MANAGEMENT

A client's buying decision is based on a complex mix of impressions, rational reasons influenced by emotions, and the desire to solve a problem.

The relative importance of the factors mentioned will vary depending on the type of investment being considered.

The client faces a complex choice – that of selecting a financial partner. This choice involves three levels: working with a wealth manager, choosing the bank they represent, and deciding on the investment itself.

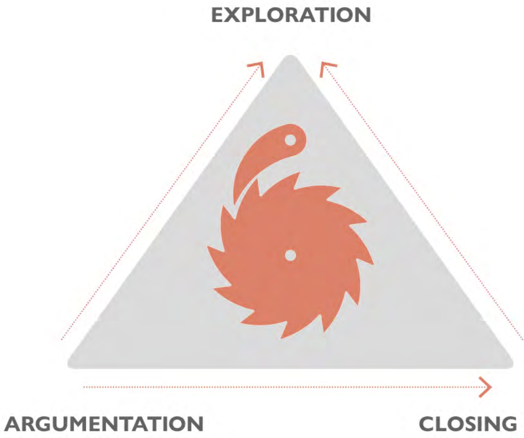
Changing financial partners (changing banks): the decision-making process for a client:

1. They must manage their relationship with their money. This relationship will depend on the origin of their wealth; it is generally easier to relate to wealth earned through a lifetime of hard work than to a large sum inherited.
2. They will need to define their needs based on their life goals ("What am I going to do with all this money?")
3. They must ask themselves whether they are satisfied with their current situation, and if they want to change it.
4. If the client does indeed decide to change banks, it means there was a flaw in the responses they received. The situation was not fully satisfactory.
5. The client believes their problem is significant enough to justify the energy required to change banks.
6. A new wealth manager will then explore their needs again. Will the client tolerate this renewed intrusion into their life?
7. New banks, different problems.
8. This is the stage of the principle decision (Go/No Go): will they move forward or not?
9. They have defined their needs/problems and have a firm intention to resolve them. At this stage, they look for alignment between their newly identified needs and the offers presented. Alignment is not just about matching products to needs; psychological factors also have a major role to play.
10. Upon confirming all criteria, they develop a checklist to compare their needs with the proposed solutions.
11. They are sensitive to the overall handling of their project by the manager. This is the aspect of the business relationship that will ultimately trigger the final decision, assuming all other services are equal.

The biggest challenge for managers is getting their clients to grasp the concept of risk versus return, which, by its very nature, is difficult to fully understand. Play is part of the activities that help humans grow and develop social skills. The hope for gain, the search for security, as well as the need for adventure and challenge make it hard for clients to balance risk against return. It's not easy to understand that investing is not the same as gambling.

2. THE SALES JOURNEY IN THREE PHASES:

Exploration – Argumentation – Closing

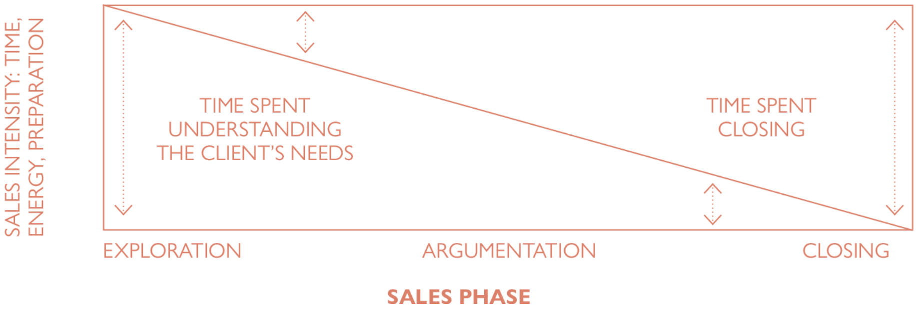


The argumentation phase immediately follows exploration and is directly linked to understanding client needs. It's custom-built because the manager tailors their argument to the different needs uncovered (see previous chapter).

This is where the value proposition happens, the real sales moment where convincing the client is key.

The manager's conviction matters greatly. When the offer matches the client's needs, the rest should flow naturally. There's no need for excessive argumen.

If this stage becomes too intense, it suggests the earlier exploration wasn't complete enough. Consequently, the conclusion phase will have to carry even more weight. The conclusion should be a smooth, logical next step from the earlier stages. These three phases must stay aligned.



The diagram above explains the time spent in the different phases of the sale, and their impact on the ease with which the process can be completed.

3. THE FIVE KEY ELEMENTS OF BUILDING AN ARGUMENT

Of the five components of the sales pitch, two* start with the client: the buying signal and objections.

COMPONENTS	THE COMPONENT'S OBJECTIVE	WHAT THE WEALTH MANAGER MUST DO
Explain	The wealth manager should act as an educator.	They prepare and clearly explain the rationale behind their proposal, following a KISS[1](Keep It Short and Simple) approach.
CAB: Characteristics – Advantages – Benefits	Demonstrate commercial empathy by focusing on the client's best interests in buying the product.	They express the product's features as advantages and link those advantages to the explicit needs expressed by the client (benefits).
USP: Unique Selling Proposition	Share competitive advantages (bank, product, team) and highlight what makes the offering unique.	They demonstrate what their product or institution offers that others do not.
Buying signals*	Identify positive signals the client sends, either consciously or unconsciously.	They detect buying signals and adjust their level of engagement based on the client's cues.
Objections*	Acknowledge that objections are part of the argument-building process.	They use objections as a positive sign to help move the negotiation forward.

A. EXPLAINING EFFECTIVELY, THE QUALITIES OF A TEACHER

For a salesperson, explanation is the cornerstone of any client relationship. People only buy what they understand – with the exception, perhaps, when shopping in a sale. An argument only makes sense if every detail is fully understood by the client. This is the time to be creative and adopt a teaching mindset. Your explanation should be clear enough for a teenager to grasp. For once, focus on method before content. Here are three ways of explaining, followed by two practical examples (based on discretionary portfolio management).

There are three ways to explain a concept:

1. **Use an analogy:** Think of a managed account like a train with multiple carriages: you set your destination, buy your ticket, and then sit back and relax as it takes you there.
2. **Use a structured explanation:** Here are three essential ideas to keep in mind when explaining how managed accounts work…
3. **Step-by-step approach:** What is it? What's it for? How does it work?

1 Keep It Simple Short.

First concrete example:

What is a discretionary portfolio management mandate?

- Our specialists take care of everything, in line with your instructions.

What are the advantages for you?

- Constant monitoring of the market and regular portfolio adjustments.

Why choose a discretionary mandate?

- If you're not a banking professional and you want to sleep well.

What guarantees does it come with?

- Professional portfolio management, time savings, market complexity handled, thorough analysis.

What do we need to know about you?

- Your life goals, time frame, risk tolerance, and your reference currency.

Second concrete example (discretionary mandate)[2] :

A financial product such as the discretionary portfolio mandate is introduced using a CAB argumentation table, highlighting how each feature translates into a tangible advantage for the client.

CARACTÉRISTIQUES	AVANTAGES	SCÉNARIO À SUIVRE
Diversification	Security for your investments.	What returns are you currently seeing with your other bank?
Managed by a professional	You'll have the same portfolio structure as a high-net-worth client. You don't need to follow the financial markets daily.	What do you know about investment funds?
One-time commission on purchase (in case of all-in fee)	Reduces your upfront costs and avoids exit fees.	How important are fees to you?
Selection of over 100 funds (example)	Ensures your investment is aligned with your profile.	What are you primarily looking for?
Minimum custody fees	You save on custody charges.	Highlight this advantage.

2 Inspired by a "best of" course with BCGE.

To present or explain a product, you need to be able to answer the following simple questions:

Before:

- What is it and who is it for?
- What purpose will it serve?
- What's in it for my client?
- How and in what context should it be used?
- Identify the need for explanation.

During:

- Explanations should focus on the client's needs; the teaching relationship is one of support.
- Use a storytelling tone.
- Start with the simplest points, before moving on to the more complex ones.

After:

Check the client's understanding.

B. TEN TIPS FOR EFFECTIVE TEACHING

1. Take the time to ensure your message is clear.
2. Acknowledge what's been said and rephrase key ideas.
3. Use diagrams and visual aids to illustrate your points.
4. Create an image in the client's mind; allow them to visualize.
5. Write things down and make notes as you explain.
6. Move from general to specific (funnel approach).
7. Highlight the advantages.
8. Pace your explanation in line with the client's understanding.
9. Summarize regularly ("In summary…")
10. Respond to the client's need for knowledge and understanding.

Explanations in colors

Use the bank's documents and annotate them with coloured pens or highlighters to make key information stand out. Circle, underline, draw arrows, and highlight figures with short notes alongside.

4. CAB: CHARACTERISTICS – ADVANTAGES – BENEFITS

This phrase contains a method of argumentation in itself. It is a kind of dialectic, a form of language that the seller can use to present their offer (product or service).

What is the mechanism of this dialectic?

It is a process that involves sharing a line of reasoning by choosing an explanatory angle focused on the advantage rather than the feature.

The features are the technical specifications of the product.

The **A**dvantages are the benefits the product provides to the client.

The **B**enefits are the client's explicit needs when they are fulfilled by the product's advantages.

The CAB process is comparable to **commercial empathy**; the manager must understand and integrate the customer's request before responding.

Here is an initial exercise to better understand CAB:

FOR EACH STATEMENT, INDICATE WHETHER IT IS A FEATURE OR AN ADVANTAGE	FEATURE	ADVANTAGE
This development was done in HTML+		
The fact that we are working in project mode allows you to have continuous control over the development's progress.		
We develop internally.		
Because we develop internally, we can guarantee the complete confidentiality of the bank's data.		

In the second test, we added an emotional argument:

You can carry out this exercise by taking one of your products and putting it through this filter.

FEATURES	ADVANTAGE FOR THE CLIENT = COMMERCIAL ARGUMENT	EMOTIONAL ARGUMENT: WHAT MIGHT MY CUSTOMER BE SENSITIVE TO?	MY CLIENT'S POTENTIAL NEEDS	BENEFITS FOR MY CLIENT = ADVANTAGE + EMOTIONAL ARGUMENT + POTENTIAL NEEDS
Your proposal				

The first question our client asks is: how is what the Relationship Manager is telling me good for me?

If no advantages are found, it means the product is not suitable for the client.

A. EIGHT WAYS TO PERSUADE PROACTIVELY

THE HIGHLIGHTING STRATEGY:

The manager adopts such a strong initial stance that arguments become unnecessary. They must be congruent; their words are accompanied by gestures, eye contact, and vocabulary that support their message.

Typical phrases might be:

It's obvious that […]
Based on my recent experiences […]
I can guarantee this is exactly what you need and nothing more…

THE COMMITMENT STRATEGY:

The statement relies solely on facts or on what the client has stated.

Typical phrases might be:

Based on these facts, you can see that […]
We both observe that […]
You yourself have experienced […]

THE TEACHING STRATEGY

The structure of the message creates a sense of clarity and obviousness.

Typical phrases might be:

There are three key points likely to convince you […]
The two essential criteria are […]
The main arguments that matter to you are […]

THE EXPERTISE STRATEGY

The wealth manager draws on the bank's reputation, their own knowledge, and social validation.

Typical phrases might be:

We were awarded best […] this year.
Our specialists are regularly interviewed by the following top financial publications […].

THE ALIGNMENT STRATEGY

The manager points out shared views uncovered during the conversation.

Typical phrases might be:

We clearly see eye to eye on this point […]
I fully share your analysis on […]
I can see we share the same point of view on […]

THE CAUSALITY STRATEGY

The wealth manager uses cause-and-effect reasoning.

Typical phrases might be:

If you […], then I will […]
Your action will lead to […], and your benefit will be […]

THE SOLUTION STRATEGY

This approach involves drawing a logical connection between the situation and the proposals made by the manager.

Typical phrases might be:

I've summarized your stated needs, and here are the two solutions I recommend […].

THE NON-SELLING STRATEGY

The manager acknowledges the strengths of a competitor but, through contrast (or even paradox), highlights all the strong points of their own institution.

Typical phrases might be:

It's true that if you're looking to trade commodities, we're not the strongest option—you'd be better off going to [...]. But for everything else, we're in a much stronger position.

B. WHY PROBING SHOULD BE PART OF YOUR APPROACH

Probing to build a solid (or at least concrete) argument relies on the idea of step-by-step validation. It's like walking through a marsh, where there may be hidden holes – each step is preceded by a cautious prod with a walking stick to check whether the ground is firm.

Probing involves making successive hypotheses to the client until the correct one is confirmed, using an affirmation–confirmation pattern.

- At first contact, the check involves obtaining agreement on the meeting's objective and shared points.
- To fully understand the client's needs, the manager probes by putting forward several possible statements (affirmation–confirmations).
- They then rephrase what's been confirmed to make sure they're going in the right direction and that all needs have been clearly expressed.
- The same probing technique is used when delivering arguments (CAB).

The manager conducts a summary of the conversation, which the client validates. It includes all probed elements and highlights those confirmed by the client.

The result should be a well-defined action plan as a conclusion.

5. A PERSUASIVE APPROACH FOR WEALTH MANAGEMENT: PRINCIPLED NEGOTIATION[3]

This negotiation and argumentation method highlights behaviors that support effective negotiation.

It's more a state of mind than a series of techniques.

The authors begin by debunking common misconceptions about what negotiation is not:

- Negotiation is purely a matter of instinct and intuition.
- Compromise is a sign of weakness.
- You must dominate the weak and come out on top.
- The salesperson is a clever and cunning manipulator, a kind of actor.
- There's no room for emotion in negotiation.

---

3 Roger Fisher et Roger Fisher and William Ury, "*Getting to Yes: Negotiating Agreement Without Giving In*." (1981)

The list of negotiation clichés could go on and on. Yet by contrast, these observations help us redefine what the characteristics of strong argumentation should be.

An undeniable psychological balance

To negotiate well, you need to be mentally sharp and emotionally grounded. These qualities are felt and shared. The manager represents a bank that solves client problems.

- The relationship must be cooperative, not authoritarian; communication should be two-way, with ongoing exchanges.
- Trust is the engine that drives the search for solutions, with both parties taking shared responsibility.
- The best outcome is a mutual agreement, not a unilateral one. To address this reality, principled negotiation offers both a framework for reflection and a basis for action.

A. PRINCIPLED NEGOTIATION IS BASED ON FOUR ESSENTIAL PILLARS[4]

The first pillar is to deal separately with personal and substantive issues. This involves recognizing the emotions of others. The authors integrate the affective dimension into negotiation and the importance of controlling it. "Knowing how to recognize and understand your own emotions and those of others."

The second pillar is to focus on interests rather than positions.

It is the interests at stake that define the conflict, rather than the stated positions. One must remain firm on the issue yet accommodating with the people. This means being both assertive and conciliatory: first saying yes to the person, then yes to the negotiation.

The third pillar is to generate a broad range of possible solutions before making a decision.

Negotiations are often hindered by obstacles such as snap judgments, the belief that there's only one solution, the idea that resources are inherently limited, or the notion that the other party's problems aren't your concern. Overcoming these biases is key to generating real options.

In this context, how can we generate solutions during a negotiation?

By separating idea generation (which is fruitful) from decision-making, which tends to lock positions.

Let your imagination run free to expand the range of possibilities, rather than focusing on a single answer.

Aim for mutual gain, and help your counterpart reach their decision.

4 Guy Deloffre, "Pédagogie de la négociation commerciale", [The Pedagogy of Commercial Negotiation, doctoral dissertation, University of Lorraine]. (2013).

The fourth pillar is to ensure that the outcomes are based on objective criteria.

Finding a neutral method, one not influenced by either side's preferences, is essential. But what method should be used?

Taking turns? Drawing lots? A third-party decision? Or any of the tools used by professional mediators?

What matters is agreeing on the rules before you start, without yielding to undue pressure.

No theory on negotiation has been as influential as principled negotiation by Fisher and Ury. Its strength lies in its simplicity, clarity, and apparent effectiveness. This approach helps define what an ideal negotiation might look like, and in doing so, also provides a way to improve one's own performance.

But… there's a "but"!

- This is a negotiation model heavily influenced by Anglo-American culture.
- The theory does not place enough emphasis on trust, which is an undervalued aspect in Fisher and Ury's model.
- Some more skeptical authors argue that win-win is a naïve concept, since true mutual gain is rare or even non-existent (Cathelineau, 1991).

Once again, this is a distinctly North American model, and one that over-rationalizes how people behave while largely ignoring the psychological dimensions. These are precisely the issues explored in behavioral finance (Kahneman & Tversky, 1979).

The following table compares negotiation methods:

	HARD NEGOTIATION	SOFT NEGOTIATION	PRINCIPLED NEGOTIATION
INNER ATTITUDE	It's a confrontation, with no trust between parties.	Trust is built first, in order to negotiate calmly.	The priority is to find a solution.
OBJECTIVES	I must win, at any cost.	I value the relationship more than the negotiation itself.	I align with the key issues to reach a coherent outcome.
TACTICS	Aggressive, oppressive, threatening, and covert.	Open, non-confrontational, accommodating.	Focuses on concrete issues; tackles problems firmly yet respectfully.
DECISION-MAKING	Low creativity, single option with no flexibility or compromise.	Focuses first on the relationship, then on interests.	Seeks mutual interest and explores alternatives.
DECISION-MAKING	Tends to be radical and lacking nuance.	Looks for the easiest option for both parties.	Seeks solutions that are reasonable and acceptable to all.

Negotiation is not conceived as trench warfare but rather as maneuver warfare. **"How can I win without you losing?"**

It requires constantly objectifying the situation, leaving no room for interpretation, for the benefit of both parties:

- This reflects the respect owed to one's interlocutor, regardless of how the commercial exchanges unfold. The sole focus is on the client's needs and objectives. Everything that could cloud this view (such as fears, doubts, or existential questions of the manager) must be set aside. Objectifying means sidelining the individuals in favor of the solution; this is the core challenge of negotiation.

The guiding principle of this negotiation approach is the well-known "win-win" slogan:

- Negotiators shouldn't limit their search for solutions. The Best Alternative to a Negotiated Agreement (BATNA) shows this creativity and forward thinking. It's the fallback option you want in your back pocket before starting any negotiation, helping with both preparation and confidence.

This way of negotiating emphasizes rational thinking, focusing on people rather than the conflict, and interests rather than positions.

Still, the perception of power plays a significant role.

The greatest power is the one the other side believes you have.

Power is both an objective reality and a subjective consideration. It becomes either a threat or an asset when put into action. During negotiation preparation, the manager must assess the different powers at play.

These powers are evaluated based on their impact on the negotiation:

The client's negotiating weight: Offers tend to be more favorable for very (very) wealthy clients.

The options available to the client: Competition is strong, and the client uses this to their advantage.

The client's knowledge: When they know exactly what they're talking about.

Their social position: Their circle of influence is significant and high quality.

The promise: The client plays on the potential they represent.

Talking about power makes us think a deal might fall apart, especially if one side has a lot more power than the other. To prepare, the manager should ask themselves three questions:

1. Am I ready to walk away?
2. What's my BATNA?
3. How can I apply pressure to make them doubt their choice?

Thinking about power in negotiation is useful for two reasons:

- Everyone has their own personal power – things like personality, ability to handle tough situations, energy to convince others, technical know-how, and even the ability to cause trouble during negotiations.
- Everyone also has a social circle they can rely on, including support from friends and family, social connections, and financial resources.

B. FIVE GOLDEN RULES OF NEGOTIATION[5]

GOLDEN RULE	ACTION PRINCIPLE	TECHNICAL PRINCIPLE	STRATEGIC PRINCIPLE
No. 1 Demand	I demand the maximum.	Dare to be demanding. Focus directly on your top priorities. Compromise comes at the end of the negotiation, never at the start. Analyze the forces at play.	Remove the stigma around negotiating. Be confident you will get at least a minimum. It's easier to come down than to go up—this simple rule of physics applies to negotiation as well. Start with high demands, not conciliatory offers.
No. 2 Argue	I push back on every concession request. **I explain when they ask,** **and I ask when they concede.**	Dig deeper before responding with an immediate counteroffer; always make one last attempt on your proposal before conceding. Argue your case before bargaining, but if you have to bargain, go all in and don't back down! Watch out for negotiators who like to "play games".	Counter fierce energy with a different energy, a demanding one! Do not lose ground by making concessions without receiving anything in return. Time is a friend to be savored by setting yourself apart.

5 *Harvard Negotiation Project. R. Fisher and W. Ury*

No. 3 Balance	I give nothing without getting something in return.	For major concessions: they go first. For minor concessions: I go first! Keep some cards up your sleeve. Practice relational judo. Bring the negotiation onto the emotional level.	Value your offer; don't sell it short. The give-and-take approach is comfortable, balanced, and fair. This action principle sparks the fighting spirit managers need.
No. 4 Ask	I ask for a lot and give in gradually.	Make small concessions first and big ones last. Say NO before saying YES. Beware of irreversible concessions that can't be undone or withdrawn. Don't sign anything before carefully reading every line and word with your finger! Ask about the motivation behind each request. Always move from the easiest concession to the hardest.	Be tactical in how the negotiation unfolds.
No. 5 Commit	I am committed and I make CTAs (Call to Action).	Isolate each point of agreement to firmly establish it. Identify every engagement point and buying signal. Ask AFTB questions or positively framed questions. Dare to close. Stay on your guard until the very last moment; beware of the Columbo effect.	Negotiation is about staying in motion and moving toward action and conclusion.

6. USING A PITCH AS A TECHNICAL TOOL FOR PERSUASION

Definition:

A pitch serves the same purpose as a movie trailer, designed to make people want to see the film. The principle is the same; it should make our client want to learn more. The pitch helps manage the well-known paradox for speakers and sellers: they have a lot to say but very little time.

A pitch is a sales tool, not an advertisement! It must be targeted since every client is unique. It's especially useful during the argumentation phase.

What's at stake with the pitch?

The pitch can serve as an introduction, allowing the wealth manager to highlight key points that will be explored in more detail later. It draws the client in.

A pitch's key principles:

1. It should cover the topic precisely – precision conveys professionalism.
2. It's a way to practice delivering clear, impactful messages.
3. Pitching is the art of being concise. Think short, dense messaging.
4. It serves as a reference point throughout the negotiation.

"If you understand something well, you can explain it clearly – and the words to say it come easily… "(Nicolas Boileau)

Exercise: Practice delivering a product pitch tailored to one of the five following customer profiles:

Annie works in the construction industry as an entrepreneur. Originally an architect, she recently sold her business to a global construction company.

Armand made his fortune in cosmetics with help from his children and is now on the board of a major Swiss pharmaceutical company.

Samir is a computer scientist who made a tidy fortune in cybersecurity.

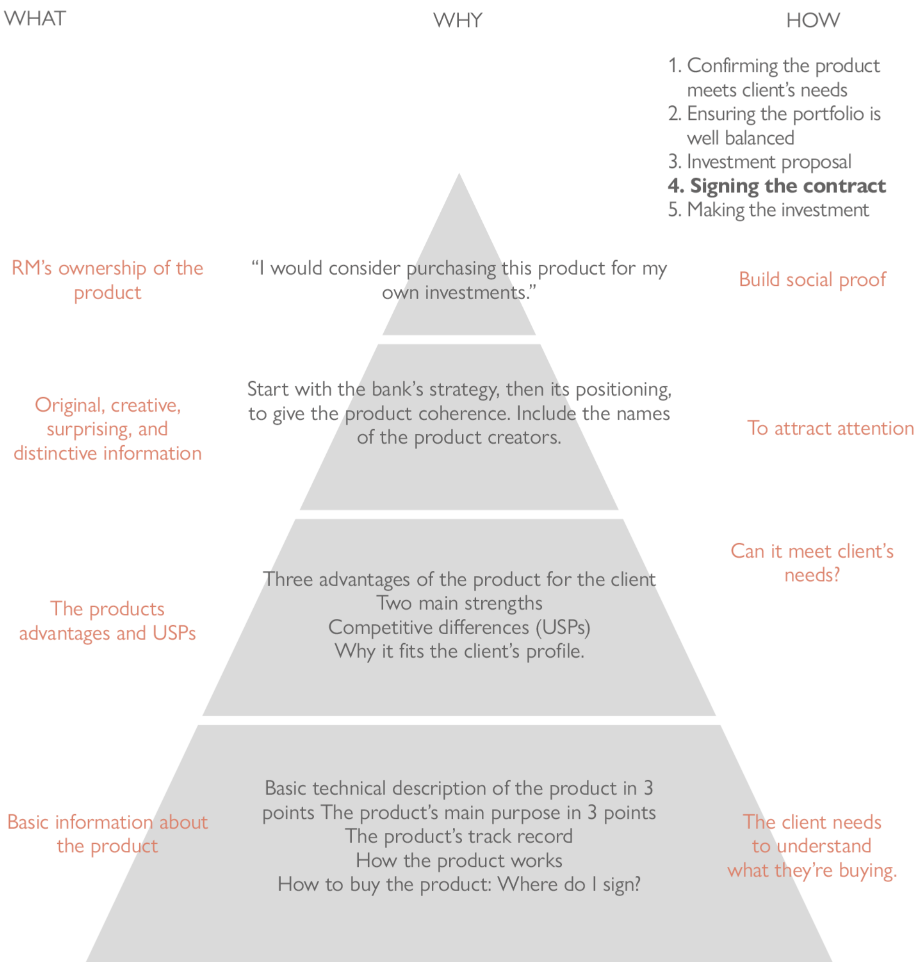
John recently came into a large inheritance. He is a professor of philosophy at the University of Lausanne.

Martha has just retired, following an exceptional career as a senior executive at a multinational company.

THE COMPONENTS OF A **BANKING** PITCH

WHAT	WHY	HOW
		• Speak with energy and conviction • Smile • Eye contact
The RM's tribute to their bank	"I love my bank because…"	Convey your empathy naturally
Original, creative, surprising, and distinctive information	Paradoxically positive: blending classic and modern elements. Decision cycles are very short. Direct access to the owners. They manage their wealth for themselves as well as for you.	To attract attention
My personal USPs in service of the client	Professional experience and expertise. My age, role, title, and education. My team, support resources, and experts. My skills and banking background.	The client needs to understand where they stand
Basic information	Family bank Awards USP 2-3 precise, data-driven facts Some historical background The bank's structure Business sectors Services and types of products	The client takes a utilitarian approach: "What's in it for me?"

THE COMPONENTS OF A **PRODUCT** PITCH



These two pyramids of the bank and product pitch components reflect the hierarchy of Maslow's pyramid. The basic information corresponds to physiological needs, and so on, up to the self-fulfillment needs at the very top of the pyramid.

The following table is used to build a pitch based on the bank's resources.

RESOURCES	ADVANTAGES / STRENGTHS DISADVANTAGES / WEAKNESSES	INFLUENCE ON THE PRIVATE BANKING CLIENT	WHAT THE RM CAN DO
Human	It's a strength: sharing staff to serve a client within the bank.	When expertise has a human face.	The RM must personally introduce the resources available to the client.
Material	Buildings, branches, client lounges.	Giving a tour of the bank is a must – showing the artworks and commenting on them. Offer the catalog.	The client becomes familiar with the premises and feels at home.
Financial	A bank must make money.	The projection effect is guaranteed.	Regularly present the bank's figures.
IT	Depends on how modern it is.	Mobile access is becoming the norm.	IT features illustrate ease of use.
Marketing	It is a strength when marketing is aligned with the RM's behavior.	Market visibility and brand recognition have a positive impact.	The power of image plays its part.
Bank organization	Efficient communication and seamless internal processes are assets.	Clients feel closer when they meet with senior management.	This privileged access to senior leaders helps strengthen AUM contributions.
Competencies			
Managerial	Motivation is evident throughout the value chain.	Clients notice the bank's ability to inspire motivation.	The RM's responses showcase the leadership skills of the management team.
Expertise	The cornerstone of a bank.	The client directly experiences the technical competence of everyone involved.	Technical certifications are becoming essential in private banking.
Market analysis and strategy	Its strength is reflected in the investment proposals.	The client sees the relevance of what is being offered.	The RM should be able to highlight this aspect of the service.
Research and development	The bank sells analytical intelligence.	Share how R&D operates, what it invests in, and what it aims to achieve.	Introduce the R&D leads if possible.

RESOURCES	ADVANTAGES / STRENGTHS DISADVANTAGES / WEAKNESSES	INFLUENCE ON THE PRIVATE BANKING CLIENT	WHAT THE RM CAN DO
External factors			
PESTEL	The political, economic, social, technological, ecological, and legislative environment.	Providing context (especially in Switzerland) reassures the client.	Reminder of the fundamentals of freedom to act, think, and invest.
Attitude to the competition	An RM who knows their market well, positions themselves smartly, and turns it into a strength.	Creates an impression of calm; the best case is when the RM encourages clients to explore competing banks.	The RM's calm attitude toward the competition.
Bank market position	The bank's fundamentals form its unique positioning.	The client must understand the environment they are entering with each visit.	Culture, history, values, strategy, and market stance should be part of the argument.

7. CROSS-SELLING: COMPLEMENTARY AND STRATEGIC PERSUASION

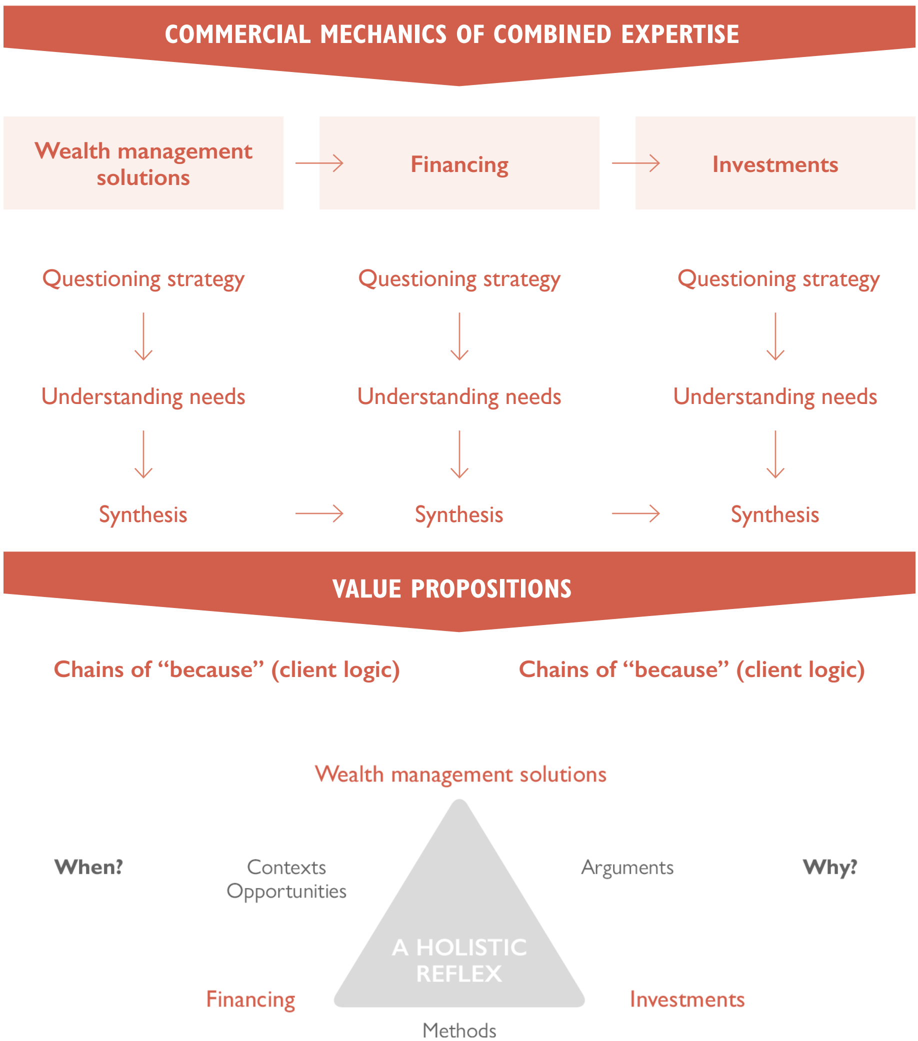
Definition: "*Cross-selling is about finding arguments to be able to sell a complementary product or service in the interest of an existing client.*"

It represents a link between active referral and the network.

Philosophically, cross-selling is about building bridges rather than walls. It is a complementary and interconnected argument. It addresses the following questions:

- How do you logically argue and consider all the ways to move from one product to another?
- How do you move from one banking expertise to another?
- In a bank with three strategic pillars, the diagram below shows how balance and complementarity are sought.

Build bridges rather than walls[6]



In this sense, cross-selling serves as a key driver of the bank's business dynamics.

In the face of increased competition, banks must continuously strengthen their relationships with clients – primarily through service and advice, but also by dedicating more time, offering attractive pricing, and broadening their range of products and services.

Cross-selling acts as a catalyst for customer loyalty.

6 Voss, Chris, and Tahl Raz. *Never Split the Difference: Negotiating as if Your Life Depended on It*, 2017.

"The principle of selling a complementary product to a customer who has already bought."

Client segmentation enables us to identify which of our customers benefit from which products and services, and the manager can deduce cross-selling opportunities for each client: What could we offer them that would meet their needs?

The various dimensions of cross-selling

This combination serves the purpose of persuasive argumentation. It seeks ways to convince a client to extend their purchasing decision.

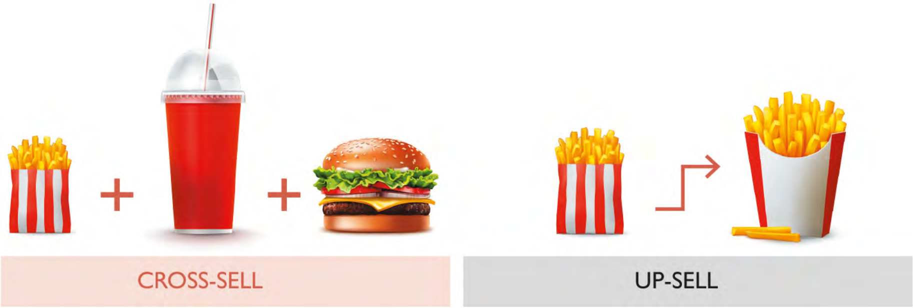
Cross-sell = sell a **complementary** product or service.

Re-sell = sell **again** to retain the client over time (repeat business).

Up-sell = sell **more** of the same thing.

New-sell = sell **something else**.

Stop-sell = *"A 'yes' increases revenue, a 'no' increases profit."*



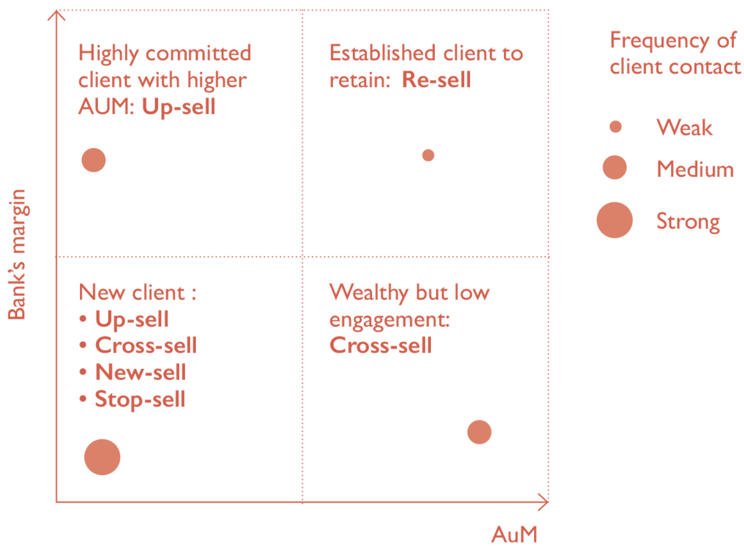
How to ask bridging questions between products and services?

Steps to combine expertise:

1. Define the bank's core expertise areas.
2. Develop a questioning strategy to explore the client's needs within each area (then link them through synthesis).
3. Use the questioning phase to gain a genuine understanding of the client's needs; this is the opportunity to delve into each area.
4. Write a summary for each area and highlight any points of convergence.
5. Build bridges between areas using a chain of "because" statements (to appeal to the client's logical reasoning), leading to a value proposition.

Cross-selling should be used wisely and at the right moment. The following table outlines the various opportunities depending on each client's profile.

Cross-selling: a driver of commercial momentum



8. OUR USP: WHAT SETS US APART?

Definition: USP stands for Unique Selling Proposition. It refers to a competitive advantage or point of difference.

This differentiating factor can exist at three levels (see the table below).

In practice, the notion of "unique" is often interpreted in the banking sector as an *exceptional* proposition, given how similar investment offerings tend to be across the market).

If we can't always be unique, let's be exceptional.

Three levels of competitive advantage:

AREA OF DIFFERENTIATION	UNIQUE SELLING PROPOSITION	HOW TO EXPRESS IT?
Bank		
Product		
Wealth manager (personal USP)		

The stakes

USPs play a crucial role in argumentation. Among five components, the USP is the factor that can "make all the difference." Collectively, the USPs underpin the bank's unique market position.

USP is an innovation[7]

First and foremost, it reflects an actual reality. The client's perception of the USP (across its three levels) is shaped by the manager's suggestions. This is where the manager's creative function comes into play. They need to identify innovative angles to frame their proposals, including:

- Incorporate a fresh marketing concept.
- A presentation that may be new.
- A new client segment.
- A new approach to an existing concept.
- How to stop competitors from gaining positive influence over our client and "trespassing on our turf"?

A. ALSO KNOWN AS THE IRRESISTABLE BUYING MOTIVE

How can we avoid the pitfalls of too much persuasion (excessive sales pitches) when our proposals are intended to be attractive and "irresistible" to a client?

The USP's function is to keep the sales pitch grounded in competitive advantages.

The following key questions are useful to guarantee the"irresistible" part:

- What innovation does my client need?
- What benefit does this argument bring them?
- Are they willing to pay for it?

B. WHAT DO OUR STRENGTHS HAVE ON OUR CLIENTS?

- A direct and indirect financial impact.
- An impact on their freedom to act and their free will (their freedom to decide).
- An impact on their perception of themselves when they acquire this financial product.
- An impact on their perception of themselves when they acquire this financial product.

Sometimes it's our competitors' shortcomings that create our USPs.

Several factors shape the competitive landscape surrounding a client:

1. The intensity of the competition.
2. The arrival of new competitors (managers from other banks), and their commercial aggressiveness.
3. The sales and negotiation strength of other banks.

7 Inspired by a presentation by R. Cohen (Getratex) at a seminar for Siemens.

The USP goes beyond benchmarking; it is objective.
The advantage perceived by the client is subjective.

What can't our competitors copy?

First and foremost, the quality of our service - or rather, its uniqueness and personalization. Competing banks have intelligent, attentive people with good financial products.

The four aspects that cannot be replicated are:

1. Personalized and human-centered customer service.
2. Our culture and values as the foundation of our business relationships.
3. The distinct environment the manager creates and invites prospective clients into.
4. Training focused on both technical expertise and social skills.

SAQ[8] has made no mistake in attaching importance to this commercial dimension.

Efforts devoted to the client experience yield tangible results.

Face-to-face interaction is the best form of advertising; voluntarily engaging with the client, being visible and available, helps to reduce their concerns.

What is difficult to copy is the reliability of interventions, as well as the speed and personalization of the response.

Enhancing client value

The more the manager enhances the quality of their services for clients, the more they increase the intrinsic value of each one.

It is from this client value that word of mouth spreads, referrals are received, and the emotional relationship with the client grows.

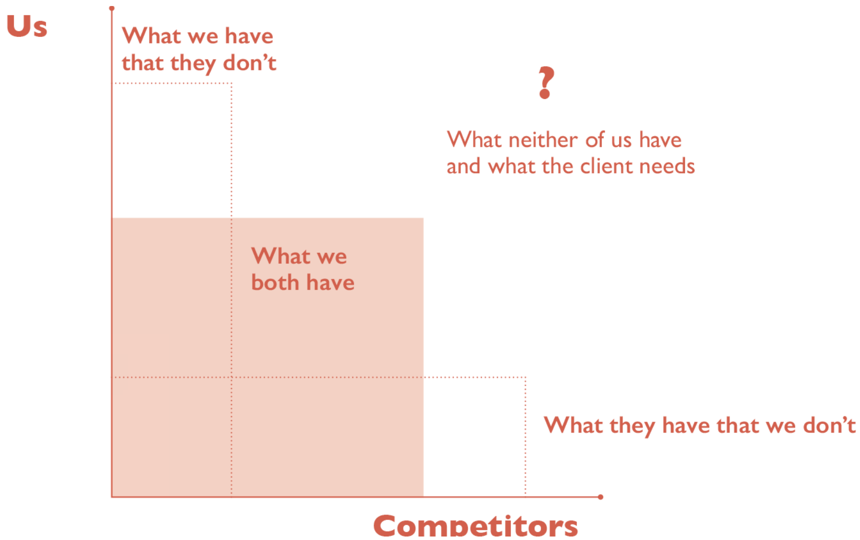
How to make your client feel valued?

- Spend time with them.
- Put aside, at least initially, the concept of profitability to make them feel that serving them is what matters most to us.
- Assist them with all aspects of their investments and even the smallest details of their concerns.

It is through their personality that the manager adds value to the client, creating a personal emotional connection[9].

A great way to keep this positive energy alive is to surprise clients with unexpected perks.

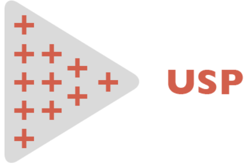
8 SAQ: Swiss Association for Quality.
9 © Tony Hsieh, Leduc. S Éditions, 2011 In *Management*, December 2011.



Summary of techniques for defining a competitive advantage

Statement: The client's gain is the basis of any competitive advantage.

1. Seeking a unique positioning means standing out by identifying all market differences. These differences are either clear and obvious (the true USPs) or created by a combination of unusual points that add up—what we call exceptional. It is a multitude, a cluster of indicators that build the proof of the USP (see figure below), such as:
2. Networking, efficiency, reliability.
3. Very thorough client follow-up; quality of services.
4. Spending time with the client, relevance, knowing how to give the right advice.
5. Explaining each element of the offer in detail.
6. Advising on what is available outside the bank, having established the right partnerships.
7. Direct access to decision-makers and/or owners.
8. Clear pricing policy, with some flexibility.
9. Low staff turnover, quality, and skills of client-facing personnel.
10. Knowledge of all stakeholders involved.
11. Strength of the brand.



It's a bundle of positive points that builds competitive advantage.

You can do a training exercise on differentiation. Here's a framework for reflection in table form:

POINTS OF DIFFERENTIATION/ AREA OF DIFFERENTIATION	KEY DIFFERENTIATORS	KEY PERFORMANCE FIGURES	UNIQUE MARKET POSITIONING
Investment products			
Banking services			
Specific expertise within the bank			
Brand strength			
Analysts/strategists			
Technology and access to information			
Well-known key figures in the market			
Track record			

Personal commitment in the relationship is the strongest USP. Connect on an emotional level—no competitor can rival you there!

9. BUYING SIGALS: A KEY LEVER IN THE SALES CONVERSATION

Definition: This demonstrates the client's interest in what we communicate, do, or propose. "They like it and they either say it or show it." Clients give off buying signals both verbally and non-verbally – through gestures, attitudes, or visible emotions.

The negotiator must remain "on the lookout" for buying signals from the other party!

We build our pitch on the client's positive reactions, which are taken as buying signals:

- A request for a proposal
- A request for a visit
- A positive comment or a follow-up question

- Non-verbal communication
- A compliment is also considered a buying signal!

The approach:

1. Identify verbal and non-verbal buying signals (attitudes, gestures, visible emotions)
2. Acknowledge the signal and explore it further with a question.
3. Build on it and use it to support your argument.
4. Expand on this positive point and ideally get the client to emphasize it themselves.

In the banking sector, a world of nuance and subtlety, picking up on buying signals is essential. Your argument should never be too forceful ("My product is exactly what you need!").

The dual benefit of a buying signal:

- It gives us insight into the client's conscious or unconscious intentions.
- It strengthens the argument by using the most powerful points—the ones expressed by the client themselves.

There are signs of interest, curiosity, purchase, and intention to close.

Signal = springboard = opportunity to respond

What to do once a buying signal is identified?

Clients will send various signals that require a reaction:

- I acknowledge: "Your comment is important."
- I build on it: "Ah yes, thank you for that remark, I would also add that…."
- I extend: "Thank you for your question; let me explain what that is."
- I reinforce it.
- Develop and prolong the buying signal with open-ended questions: "What makes you say that…?"
- Probe further, respond, and leverage it as an argument in your favor.

The manager must employ active listening to detect all buying signals.

These signals prompt a more engaged conclusion and are key to moving forward in negotiations generally, especially in closing and when it comes to garnering active referrals.

Exercise:
What were the main buying signals you detected during your last sales meetings, and what actions did you take afterwards?

Buying signals you've identified in your clients	What steps have you taken to make the most of them?

10. RHETORIC AS A TOOL FOR PERSUASION

Argumentation comes through both how you speak (form) and what you say (content). Rhetoric is part of sales techniques with its methods and strategies.

We'll look at different speaking techniques that help sellers argue their case, focusing on form.

A. STRUCTURING SPEECH: A KEY SKILL FOR WEALTH MANAGERS

To help the client understand and better support their purchasing decision, how should you proceed?

- State the product name and expand by providing the client with a SMART explanation.
- Structure this explanation with a diagram or drawing. Visual aids support understanding.
- Use images, analogies, a technical datasheet, or documentation.
- Bring a lot of energy (synonymous with motivation and conviction) to this phase.
- Verify the client's understanding by asking control questions.
- Share a summary and give a brief recap.
- End with a CTA1[10].

B. WHERE DOES YOUR CONVICTION COME FROM?

Coherent and understandable discourse is what increases the client's desire to buy. How do you build this coherence? By aligning each recommendation with the needs expressed and validated by the client.

Conviction is perceived through other factors such as:

- The manager's personal assurance and self-confidence.
- Their technical mastery (a key criterion).
- Striking the balance between confidence ("I'm sure of myself because I know my subject") and humility.
- The passion expressed for the subject matter, the relationship, or the product.
- Their commitment to meeting the needs of the client and their family.

10 Call To Action.

C. VERBAL CONFIDENCE AS A CONVINCING FORCE

This is a process of self-reflection, concerning the selection of words and their delivery. Conviction emerges when the speaker communicates with emotion, intending to make the meaning of the words "resonate" with sincerity and a sense of passion.

Tactics in speech

The way you order your speech can surprise and throw off the listener.

THE EXAMPLE OF ANTITHESIS

When you start your argument by stating the opposing view, it gives you more space to develop your own point; it's a smart and creative approach.

Example: *You might tell me that the fees are high; well, that's because…*

By stating the obvious and its opposite, the speaker uses a truism and draws on shared understanding.

Example: *Stocks can rise or fall, but there are always ups and downs…*

This involves the conscious use of the word "but" (which tends to limit meaning) instead of the more positive "and."

THE THESIS

Logical reasoning can be used to support the meaning of an argument. One tool of logic is the *syllogism*, which is built on premises:

- Major premise
- Minor premise
- Conclusion

Example: *All Swiss banks are trustworthy [major]. We are a Swiss bank [minor], therefore we are trustworthy [conclusion].*

Demonstration through evidence, by quoting an expert and their *thesis*, presenting a study on the subject, or supporting it with an image or a chart.

REPETITION

Just as there is humor in repetition, there is also power in repeating an argument – *"the message is the massage"* (inspired by Marshall McLuhan). Expolition: repeating the same argument but using different words..

ANALOGY

A is to B what C is to D.

Example: *Your investment will be like a chick in its nest.*

It is the most relevant model – it reflects a real-world situation.

Example: *We offer a portfolio management mandate that is identical in every respect to the one that was named Best Investment of the Year.*

PROVERB

Proverbs reflect popular wisdom and often come across as undeniable truths.

METAPHOR

A metaphor helps explain what you mean by comparing it to something similar – it often adds a poetic feel (and sounds lovely too).

Example: *This idea is like a sun lighting us up.*

D. USING VISUALIZATION TO SUPPORT YOUR ARGUMENT

Creating diagrams and using visual representations greatly supports explanation and helps clarify ideas.

A diagram is a powerful tool that simplifies reality into essential lines, enabling the mind to grasp it more easily."[11]

A diagram serves as an artificial memory; it helps with retention, defines concepts or problems, and clarifies thinking.

Thanks to a diagram, the listener can distinguish between main and secondary ideas. It makes it easy to connect concepts without the need for too many words (a picture is worth a thousand words).

Diagrams help us join the dots between:

- the different types of information that the mind picks up almost immediately,
- new and old information,
- options and their origins.

How is a diagram designed?

- Start by placing the main ideas and key concepts at the center of the diagram.
- Make links between them.
- Qualify each connection and each part, assigning a value or assessment for future decision-making.

11 G. Derache, Lecture on Methodology, February 2007.

It is important to ensure the visual consistency of a diagram with the following options:

- Group the same elements together or separate elements that are opposing12.
- Only use one color per symbolic representation.
- Apply proportional effects to visual symbols to illustrate the importance of information.
- Use pictograms.

The diagram can be created using post-its, with flows that give meaning to the information, or an organizational chart to understand the structure and its decision-making flows.

Other examples include an influence diagram (Kurt Lewin's force field analysis) or a cause-and-effect diagram (Ishikawa diagram).

The text should accompany a diagram with captions; it helps to clarify the meaning and added value of the diagram.

E. NOTE-TAKING IN SALES

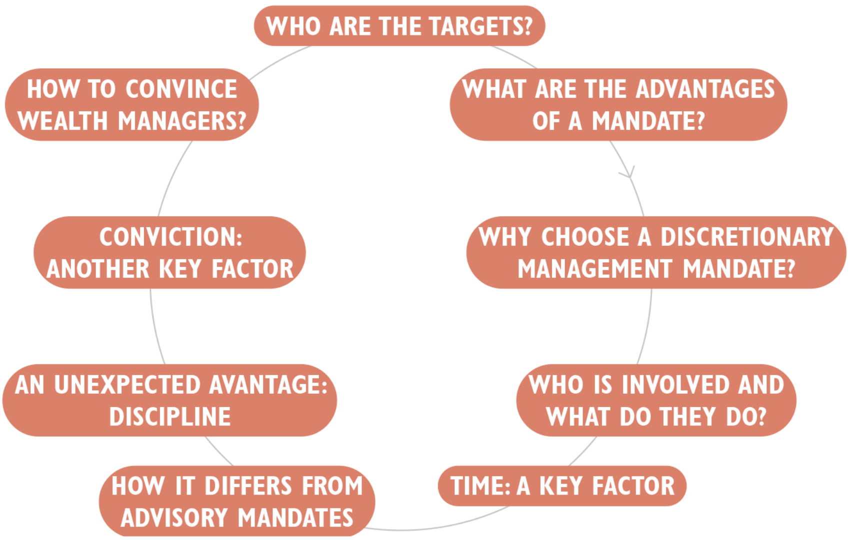
- If I don't take notes, I'll have to accept the fact that I might not remember something, so I regularly summarize during the meeting.
- I always ask my client's permission to take notes.
- I may leave my notes with the client, especially those containing explanatory diagrams.
- I send the client a summary afterwards.
- When I take notes, it creates an image of professionalism and seriousness.

Appendix 1

Specific argumentation on the discretionary mandate

What sales arguments can be put forward in favor of a discretionary mandate?[12]

SUMMARY



I. WHICH CLIENT SEGMENT IS IT FOR?

The discretionary mandate (or portfolio management mandate) is intended for a category of clients who do not have expertise in finance. They may be entrepreneurs or doctors—professionals working outside the financial sector. They are not familiar with the markets and do not have the time or inclination to follow them. Lacking financial expertise, they choose to delegate the management of their assets to the bank's financial experts.

As a result, the client doesn't need to worry about keeping up with market trends.

What are the three deciding factors?

First factor: **Time** – the key question the client asks is: "*Do I have the time to manage my portfolio myself – or do I even want to?*"

12 Based largely on the analysis by Ali Altinsoy of Piguet Galland Bank..

Second factor: **Expertise** – Do I have the necessary knowledge and experience, or the desire to develop them?

Third factor: **Desire** – Even if I have the time and the knowledge, do I actually want to manage my portfolio myself? This factor can easily override the first two.

To put it another way, think of switching between winter and summer tires. I know how to change a tire – I've done it before – and I could easily find the time to do it, say 90 minutes twice a year. But I just don't want to. So, I leave it to someone else: they handle the swap, check the pressure and alignment, store the tires, the lot.

What are the advantages of discretionary mandates for this client segment?

The main benefit is, above all, saving time. But there are others as well:

- The bank helps clients maintain the necessary distance to stay clear-headed in managing their assets.
- Some clients believe they understand their risk profile but end up making decisions that contradict it; when faced with real risk, they can lose their composure.
- The behavioral bias known as the "illusion of competence" is particularly risky when managing assets independently, as in advisory models.

A. PSYCHOLOGICAL ADVANTAGES FOR THE CLIENT

- The client can sleep easy,
- They avoid a behavioral bias: the illusion of knowing the financial markets and being able to make the right decisions.
- Other common behavioral biases include:

– **Herd instinct:** the tendency to follow what others are doing, due to a lack of critical distance.
– **Overconfidence:** after making a few successful investments, a client may believe all their decisions are sound… every time!
– **Polished presentation**[13]: a well-crafted sales pitch – with overly positive framing, persuasive logic, or social proof – can influence investment decisions.

A. TECHINCAL ADVANTAGES

- There is a professional consistency between the client's expressed needs and the strategic allocation that the bank implements within the discretionary mandate (this is a direct response to their needs).

This coherence accounts for approximately 80% of the total product performance.

Analyses are always conducted with a long-term perspective to prevent behavioral biases.

13 Inspired by a presentation on the website onyx-cie.ch

Why choose a discretionary mandate?

If the client has a long-term investment perspective.

If they lack the skills or the desire to manage a portfolio.

If they want their investments to be aligned with market opportunities.

If they want a return consistent with market and risk.

Who does the client really delegate the management of their assets to?

The client delegates management to an entity (not just a single person) which includes:

- The bank itself – its reputation, history, and reliability.
- A CIO (chief investment officer) and their team, who monitor the markets full-time, possess strong expertise, and maintain constant communication with other specialists.
- An investment committee that brings together all the bank's expertise to guide decisions on discretionary mandates.
- A portfolio manager or advisor who acts as the link with the top specialists and also holds comprehensive knowledge.
- A team of investment solution specialists who support the relationship managers and can occasionally join client meetings as needed.

A complete chain of skill and trust is dedicated to serving the client.

2. THE STAKEHOLDERS AND THEIR ROLES

A. THE ROLE OF THE WEALTH MANAGER

The manager's primary responsibility is to thoroughly understand their clients' risk profile. They guide clients toward the risk profile that matches their expectations, objectives, and risk tolerance.

B. THE ROLE OF THE INVESTMENT COMMITTEE

- To develop a strategy and asset allocation that align well with the client's profile.
- Few specialists have perfect knowledge of all financial markets and all types of financial instruments; this diverse expertise is valuable and rests in the hands of professionals.

The experts convene in an investment committee and make investment decisions based on three factors:

- The client's risk profile
- Market data
- The bank's convictions and strategies.

Time frame as a determining factor:

Professionals recommend keeping mandates for between 5, 7 and 10 years, depending on the investment profile. These durations correspond to market cycles. Clients typically adopt a similar time frame when feasible. Time analysis is particularly relevant for discretionary mandates since long-term periods and cycles are systematically considered in the analyses.

Markets are studied over extended periods. An investor entering a bear market cycle might question: "How long will it take before this downtrend ends?" Less sophisticated clients tend to focus on the short term. Their most common mistake is well-known: selling when professionals are buying.

3. WHAT ARE THE DIFFERENCES WITH ADVISORY?

- A discretionary mandate is active and continually reviewed; it is always invested and managed through buying and selling, moving at its own pace of "information and reaction," which is quicker than the longer cycle seen in advisory services.
- Cost is often cited as an objection to discretionary mandates. Advisory mandates tend to be less expensive because they do not have the full infrastructure that manages portfolios.

Clients opting for advisory mandates get advice from their banker, follow the advisor's recommendations, and then make the decisions themselves.

Historical data has demonstrated that clients who delegated investment decisions through discretionary mandates generally saw better returns for the same risk level.

There are several explanations for this:

- There is a discipline within bank-managed mandates, involving a clear contractual commitment with the bank.
- It is essentially a buy-and-hold approach, unless the markets crash and the client panics, asking the bank to sell their mandate. The bank advises clients not to sell. Advisory portfolios often hold a larger cash position and thus contribute less to long-term market performance.

In advisory mandates, there's no one to tell them "Don't sell everything." Clients don't spontaneously have this buy-and-hold discipline.

4. EXAMPLES OF STRUCTURING DISCRETIONARY MANDATES

The most common risk profiles:

- Least risky: Cash management or fixed income
- Income
- Balanced
- Growth or dynamic
- - 100% equities

5. DISCIPLINE: AN UNEXPECTED AND COMPETITIVE ADVANTAGE OF THE DISCRETIONARY MANDATE

Clients with advisory mandates are more psychologically vulnerable. Let's take a hypothetical example: they have established a balanced profile, 50% equities and 50% bonds.

When stock markets decline, they naturally and instinctively reduce their equity allocation immediately, as asset values fall.

In contrast, in a managed mandate, the CIO for a balanced mandate will do exactly the opposite when equities drop – they will buy more to maintain the 50/50 balance.

During a bear market, managed mandates buy equities, whereas in an Advisory profile, around 80% of clients will not buy, will take no action, and will reduce their strategic equity allocation, becoming unbalanced relative to their initial strategy.

Discipline is the main factor and advantage of managed mandates.

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6. RISK AWARENESS IS ANOTHER DIFFERENCE

In advisory mandates, clients also include other instruments, such as structured products, which are less common in discretionary mandates.

The investment committee uses derivatives, but only for tactical allocations; these are not strategic. In advisory mandates, some clients allocate a portion of their portfolio to structured products. They thus take on (sometimes excessive) risks without fully realizing it.

The first key difference in performance between the two types of mandates is the lack of discipline (see previous point).

The second difference is that allocations tend to change more frequently in advisory mandates compared to the allocation defined in a discretionary mandate.

7. THE IMPORTANCE OF SETTING A COURSE

The advantage of setting a course is that you can stick to it.

A market cycle is like a pendulum swing. Starting from a bear market, after some time, the portfolio returns to its starting point. The market eventually appreciates again, and the portfolio follows suit.

Clients with a short-term perspective often get overwhelmed by emotion and may panic, leading to errors (cognitive bias at play).

The importance of conviction:

Let's consider a stock an investor believes in deeply, one in which they have a strong conviction, but which has just dropped 10% and recorded negative performance. The client might think they were wrong because of these short-term results and might choose to sell some or all the shares.

If the stock is within a strategic sector the client has firm beliefs about (for example, artificial intelligence), the real danger is forgetting those convictions and acting against the logic of professional investors. When you have a strong, well-supported conviction, it's better not to sell but to hold on and treat the decline as an opportunity to buy more.

8. HOW WOULD YOU CONVINCE RELATIONSHIP MANAGERS TO ADOPT A COMMERCIAL STRATEGY FOCUSED PRIMARILY ON DISCRETIONARY MANDATES?

First argument: Empirical observation shows that the most commercially successful managers are those who have the majority of their clients under discretionary mandates.

Second argument: The advantages discretionary mandates offer to clients are mirrored by benefits for the managers.

Third argument: Those who design and maintain discretionary mandates have a comprehensive overview and are very well informed.

Fourth argument: Clients investing in these mandates value the quality of the CIO and their teams, which is reflected in the quality of the analyses.

If any managers have reservations, the bank can advise them to consider discretionary mandates as the core of the portfolio, complemented by an advisory mandate.

Fifth argument: Advisory clients tend to view their portfolios more tactically, with a shorter time horizon. Discretionary mandates help retain clients over the long term.

Comparative table between discretionary mandates and advisory mandates in wealth management.

CRITÈRE	MANDAT DE GESTION	MANDAT ADVISORY
Control	• The investor delegates management to a professional who makes autonomous decisions. Little direct control over specific portfolio decisions.	• The investor delegates management to an advisor but can influence decisions. Some degree of control and involvement in investment choices.
Costs	• Fees generally based on a percentage of assets under management (AUM). Possible additional transaction fees.	• Fees based on a percentage of AUM. Possible transaction fees and other associated charges.
Flexibility	• Less flexibility for rapid portfolio adjustments due to rigid contracts. Delays in making changes.	• Greater flexibility to adjust in response to market changes. Some contracts may have restrictions.
Advice and involvement	• Less direct involvement in investment decisions. Professional management without daily involvement of the investor.	• Possibility to express preferences and influence investment decisions. More direct investor involvement in the decision process.
Conflicts of interest	• Risk of conflicts of interest if the manager is incentivized by commissions or specific incentives.	• Similar risk of conflicts of interest, but the investor may have more influence to mitigate these conflicts.
Performance	• Performance largely depends on the skills of the analyst team and CIO. Results may vary.	• Performance depends on the advisor's skills, but the investor can exercise more direct influence. Results may vary.
Learning	• Fewer opportunities for direct learning since management is delegated. Loss of personal experience.	• Greater opportunity for direct learning as the investor can participate in decisions. Potential to develop financial knowledge.
Adaptability to needs	• Less suitable for investors wishing to be more active or with specific needs.	• More adaptable to individual needs. More flexibility to meet specific investor preferences.

An expert's perspective

André Collomé has been a trainer for 25 years, following earlier experience as a salesperson at Rank Xerox, a company well known for its sales techniques. He has worked all over the world, where he has encountered a vast range of commercial cultures. In this piece, he reflects on his unique approach to sales, especially when it comes to identifying client needs.

"I realized through all my experience that approaching the discovery of client needs with a positive angle isn't always the most effective strategy. Sometimes, it's more useful to focus on what's not working – what's painful or what went wrong – to move the negotiation forward. To explore needs effectively, you often need to dig in an unexpected direction – into 'the pain,' as the English say.

The first step is to isolate the problem, understand it, and then dig deeper to confirm that a real issue exists; something negative that, if solved, could help push the negotiation along.

To get to the root of the issue and explore what's not working, you can ask questions like:

- Why does this problem keep you awake at night?
- How does this problem affect you?
- What will be the consequences if you don't solve this problem?
- What will you gain by solving this problem?

Everything centers on the initial negative assumption. I realized that the shift toward finding a positive solution is all the more powerful because of it. This approach has more impact than a more conventional one where we immediately look for (positive) solutions without digging into the root of the pain. Taking a counterintuitive approach has a creative dimension; it frees us from the conventions of a positive framing.

I did wonder how this fit with the training programs I've taught over the years, which were based on positive behavioral models. But while the method focuses on the negative, the aim is still entirely positive. By taking a less conventional path, I often create a surprise that helps people open up – and they engage more freely with my questions.

A second major insight I've had in sales concerns the question of competitive advantage. Are we framing the question in the right way? The very idea of "difference" as a lever for differentiation can be challenged – not to play on words, but to rethink the concept.

I actually prefer thinking in terms of competitive similarity. It's about recognizing the strengths of my products or services—and reflecting on what it means when those strengths aren't so unique after all.

What I have and my competitors also have
What I have that my competitors do not have
What I don't have and my competitors also don't have
What I don't have but my competitors do have

Out of these four scenarios, only one reflects a true point of differentiation.

If those differentiating factors are limited – or simply don't exist – then the real selling point must be found elsewhere. And that 'elsewhere' is the human element.

What truly makes the difference is you, meaning your commercial approach and behavior. Unlike the classic USP model, this approach suggests showing that our products are just as good as the competition's, but that we, personally, are the key difference.

Breaking away from the pack, taking a different approach, and thinking creatively: that's what I believe defines the salespeople of the future."

Spring into action! **5 key takeaways and an exercise**

FIVE KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. Develop a deep understanding of your clients' buying and decision-making processes.
2. Focus your energy on clear explanations and the CAB method when presenting arguments.
3. Use principled negotiation techniques to find balance in commercial discussions and apply the five golden rules.
4. Write and memorize your sales pitches – about the bank, about each of your products and about yourself!
5. Leverage your competitive advantages (USPs), watch for buying signals, and speak with confidence.

EXERCICE

Title: Persuasion is your strongest asset as a relationship manager.

Aim of the exercise: Practice using persuasive techniques to convince.

Instructions:

- What are the three arguments that work best with your clients?
- List the three competitive advantages (USPs) you highlight in your sales meetings.
- What are the three most common buying signals you observe in your prospects?

11

Objections et négociation tarifaire, situations délicates

Objections add flavor to the sales process: they unleash commercial energy, encourage a closer relationship, and bring us face to face with the meaning of selling: convincing!

TEACHING OBJECTIVES

After reading this chapter, you will be able to:

- Respond to objections by affirming the client's value.
- Take advantage of the opportunity it represents.
- Treat complaints as a chance to grow.
- Stay calm and quick on your feet when someone questions the price

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1. WHAT IS AN OBJECTION?

An objection is a piece of information from the client that prevents us from closing the deal. It is a difficulty raised in response to a salesperson's proposal. An objection is also a verbal expression of the client's fear.

There is a difference between the reason for an objection and its nature:
The reason for an objection may be the result of a misunderstanding, a disagreement over pricing, or concerns about how long it will take to recover funds. It rarely stems from behavioral issues like "I don't like the way you're asking your questions …"

The nature of the objection is often more revealing. It usually arises from a fear the client has about making a commitment or investment. In this sense, handling objections often requires a psychological approach.

Explanation, pedagogy, and patience
are the keys to dealing with objections.

The different types of objections
The nature of objections depends on the reasons why a client chooses to object. These can include:

- Areas of uncertainty
- Risks related to your working process
- Budget or pricing concerns (the majority of objections)
- Slow procedures or onboarding delays
- High-risk products
- The bank's current situation, especially if media coverage is negative
- Endless requests for information
- Requests for highly intrusive personal information
- Requests for additional supporting documentation

This is not an exhaustive list, but what all these types of objections have in common is that the client feels rushed, embarrassed or dissatisfied.

Raising an objection requires effort on the client's part
When a client voices disagreement, they're making a psychological effort. That's why objections must be handled gently. The relationship manager needs to recognize the client's momentary vulnerability.

Why do clients raise objections?
They may feel irritated by what they perceive as an intrusion into their personal affairs.
To reassure themselves, out of fear of being misled or taken advantage of.
Due to mistrust, especially if the offer seems *too* appealing,
Sometimes, it's a way to assert themselves or show they know what they're talking about.

Out of antipathy toward an incompetent salesperson.
As a logical reaction to weak or misleading arguments.
To test the salesperson's confidence and responses.
To show indifference: when the client is not motivated, and their needs are not being met.
To seek more information or clarification out of genuine curiosity.
To convince themselves; they need more reasons to move forward.
Out of habit or cultural norms, after all, it costs them nothing.
As a negotiation tactic, to try and get a little extra thrown in.
To avoid saying "no" directly – objection masks a refusal.

2. OBJECTIONS ADD FLAVOR TO SALES

The manager's role is to capture the client's interest; when the client raises an objection, it's often a way of showing they, too, want to be seen as interesting.

Adding flavor to the sales process

This poetic phrase reflects the joy of discussing, arguing, and persuading. But not all managers naturally enjoy this part of the process.

An objection can be a final line of defense before making a difficult decision – a way for the client to give themselves time to think and take a step back.

Another challenge is the wealth manager's own perception. Often, objections feel uncomfortable. But are they really more of a problem for the client or for the manager?

As with any tricky moment, the first step is to turn it on its head and reframe it positively.

3. THE BENEFITS OF CLIENT OBJECTIONS

- When a client raises an objection, they reveal something about themselves. This allows us to get to know them better and to understand their deeper motivations.
- Objections help the relationship evolve during negotiation: we move from seeking a "win-win" outcome to a "give-give" one, where mutual balance becomes a source of satisfaction for both the client and the relationship manager.
- The client provides us with an opportunity to argue, offer clarification and further explanations.
- An objection is something of a springboard to further negotiations. When it's handled well, the end of the negotiation is often within reach.
- Objections are vital; they strengthen the dialog.
- It helps us shift perspective and cross over from the road of complaints[1] ; into the brighter side of constructive dialog.
- Handling an objection means anticipating a situation that is likely to be even more difficult; some objections can turn into complaints.

1 Louis Shorderet's course for Swissair, 1995.

Selling begins when the client says no.

Here's an exercise inspired in part by a training session on objections with a local bank[2]. It's a good warm-up for this chapter!

OBJECTION	YOUR REACTION
You're too intrusive! You want to know everything!	
These questions are too personal and intimate!	
What's the difference between you and my current bank?	
My life is more complicated than what I'm telling you now.	
If I commit to this investment, how many years am I locked in for?	
You're my fourth wealth manager in two years.	
There is not much diversification in my portfolio; too many in-house products.	
Your current HR policy is tough, with managers leaving and employees being made redundant. What's going on?	
Your name is often in the press these days.	

4. WHAT'S THE DIFFERENCE BETWEEN A COMPLAINT AND AN OBJECTION?

They both concern situations that, at first glance, are perceived as **negative.**

The same paradoxical concept applies to both. They are each an opportunity to move the business relationship forward in the right direction: towards clarification.

2 PG banking sales training, 2019.

A complaint relates to a service that has allegedly malfunctioned and is factual.

An objection is a disagreement about an element of the negotiation, an obstacle on the road to conclusion.

An objection is always twofold, often paradoxical. It encompasses two complementary components: a request and a hint.

A request from the client who wants an answer on a specific point, which is essentially also a buying signal. The client shows interest in the manager's proposal and has a need for information. An indication of a possible improvement directed at the manager. This improvement can concern the sales process, the product, or the relationship. By raising an objection, the client also reveals their position ("they come out of the woodwork").

An objection is an opportunity to improve our commercial relationship.

When faced with an objection, the manager must assess what it's really about:

- Is it a request for information?
- How important is the objection: minor, significant, or crucial?
- Is the psychological impact noticeable or not: manageable, paralyzing, or traumatic?

Reactions to avoid when emotional signs are present during an objection:

- Becoming defensive.
- Refusing to consider that the client might actually be right.
- Avoiding asking questions that provoke the client.
- Saying "no, that's not true," as this implies dishonesty.

How should you react to client objections?

The most common and straightforward method is the objections table (similar to the one shown in the opening pages of this chapter). The table you create with your client's possible objections allows you to be prepared to respond, save time during discussions, and appear confident when the client shows signs of hostility.

Four general concepts:

- Be proud of your price.
- Stay in close contact with your client.
- See the objection as an opportunity; bounce back by highlighting the benefits of your offer and continually focus on what is advantageous for your client.
- Don't persist stubbornly; be graceful. This door may close, but others will open in the future.

Concepts are general considerations that provide a mindset, while techniques offer responses to specific situations. It is the combination of the two that gives you the flexibility to adapt your replies.

"A DECLARATION OF THE CLIENT'S RIGHTS:

For the client, the company is me!

They must be accepted as they are.
They never cause trouble.
They have the right to know less than I do.
They have the right to make mistakes.
They are the meaning of my work and often its content."

5. WHAT TO DO FIRST WHEN HANDLING AN OBJECTION

The first thing to do is to respect the client's objection. There's nothing worse than denial. Don't systematically respond to objections. Some objections deserve no response at all! These are objections made in bad faith, jokes, or "automatic" objections at the start of the interview...

Listen carefully and let the client speak without interrupting them.

Show the client that we have understood their concerns and that we respect their point of view.

I understand your point of view, I see what you mean,
Your comment is interesting…
You're right to value…
You're right to ask me this question…,
You're right to make this comment,
This observation…

Understanding doesn't mean sharing your opinion.
It's understandable that you feel this way at the moment…
I've also had that question…

The aim is to convince, not to defeat!

A. BASIC REFLEXES WHEN HANDLING OBJECTIONS

1. Respond briefly to the objection.

Keep your response concise and to the point. The more arguments you provide, the greater the risk of triggering another objection and entering a contentious debate… Move on immediately after your response.

Don't leave a long silence after your answer, since the client could think you're awaiting a negative reaction, as in a confrontational situation.

2. Avoid long-winded discussions, and avoid expressions such as:

"No," "disagree," "not at all," and "that's not true." These can all lead to confrontation.

Choose instead expressions such as:
"I completely understand what you mean; you certainly have good reasons to think that way…"

3. Listen attentively and let the client say what they've got to say.

Let your client express all their criticisms without interruption. Don't respond immediately to the first objection; it could be masking a more critical one. Adopt a listening stance (eye contact, nodding, brief acknowledgements such as "I understand…" and "I see…"). Time is your ally: the objection weakens as the client expresses it (it deflates).

Dealing with the most common objections:

We always consider attitudes before techniques. It is attitude that drives sales reflexes and spontaneity in sales interactions.

Attitudes

1. Acknowledge the objection, take it into account but verify it! Is it really an objection or just a passing remark?
2. "Is this a dealbreaker for you?" Some clients raise objections to test the relationship.
3. Don't deny an objection.
4. Identify the objection to determine its weight in the decision-making process.
5. Work out how important this aspect is in the purchasing decision.

Ten techniques to master

1. **Transform negative points into positive ones**. The transformation phrase "thanks to the fact that…" helps the client see the positive and interesting side of their own objection. For example: "The delivery time is a bit long, but it guarantees it is transported safely."
2. **Drown the objection** in a flood of positive points to balance it with advantages. For the client, this is the principle of saying, "I'll make my buying decision if there are more advantages than disadvantages."
3. **Anticipate, prepare for,** and respond to all possible objections. Stay one step ahead of them and "take the wind out of the sails" of any client who might raise an objection that you know, in advance, is likely to come up during the exchange.
4. **Isolate the objection*,** meaning you assume everything else is satisfactory. "So, if we put the delivery time to one side, does our proposal work for you?" If the answer is yes, you've managed to isolate the objection.
5. **Exaggerate the objection,** so that the client can naturally counter it themselves by putting it into perspective.

6. **Counterbalance with another advantage:** "It may be more expensive than our competitors, but we also have a quality label that they don't have…"
7. **Preparation** is always the key to success; before the meeting, anticipate by listing the most common or challenging objections and practice your responses.
8. **Accept the objection:** "You're right to ask that question; it's a good one / an excellent remark…" The client will feel respected and valued.
9. **Dig into the objection and ask the client:** "What exactly do you mean? Could you be more specific? That would help me respond accurately…"
10. **Sidestep the objection:** It was just a passing remark.

ISOLATING THE OBJECTION

The client disagrees on one point, ***but they agree on everything else!***

"If we put the price to one side, do you like everything else about our proposal?" You isolate the issue and see if that's the only sticking point!

If there are other issues, you can then deal with each objection one by one. This approach brings clarity to the negotiation. You isolate the objection, strengthen agreement on everything else, then come back to the objection. It works especially well when price is the issue.

6. HOW TO HANDLE OBJECTIONS CONCERNING PRICE

Handling a pricing objection reflects a gap between the value a client assigns to a product and the price set by the bank.

Price discussions always relate to expectations. A satisfied client doesn't argue about price.

Most of the work on pricing "plays out" early in the relationship.

Banking services come at a cost. These prices are decided by people, not computers (at least not as of 2024).

Price should not be seen in isolation; it doesn't appear out of nowhere. It represents value and reflects the added benefit a product or service brings to the client. It is tangible.

Be kind.

We always suggest approaching price discussions with an open and tolerant mindset. Clients are allowed to negotiate!

Perhaps they don't yet fully understand the true value of what the advisor is offering.

If a client is fussy about pricing, begin by praising them (it explains how they got rich!) for their persistence. If they negotiate that hard, it's because they're serious about spending their money (or that spending their money is a very serious matter).

"Talking about price is not the same as negotiation."

Clients understand that the more assets they place with you, the better terms they can expect. Equally, the wealth manager must now exactly how much room for maneuver there actually is.

In practice, it's the Head of Private Banking who defines these limits. For example:

- The advisor can independently offer a 15% discount.
- For a 20% discount, the team leader must approve.
- For a 25% discount, the Head of Private Banking must grant authorization.

Ideally, one should know at what point the deal stops being profitable. Saying no can be a powerful sales behavior – if you can justify it with numbers.

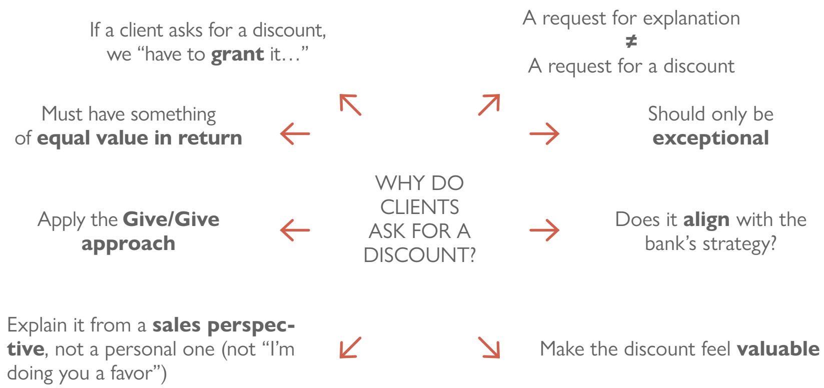
The reasons behind pricing:

- The time and effort dedicated to creating the client's file.
- The high caliber of our staff; top talent comes at a cost.
- The coherence and suitability of the investment team's recommendations.
- The fee structure reflects a VIP service level, similar to that of a five-star hotel.

What motivates a client to begin negotiating fees? (Refer to point 1 in this chapter)

REASONS FOR NEGOTIATING PRICE (RATIONAL AND EMOTIONAL)	HOW TO RESPOND
They compared our rates with those of our competitors.	By how much, and compared to whom, are we more expensive?
They claim to have a better offer.	Could we take a look at it to compare?
He is uncertain about his return on investment or because he doesn't fully understand.	What's not clear to you about your investment?
None of those reasons; it's just part of their DNA …	We have to "haggle," play the game

Yes increases sales, while No increases profit.



A. PRACTICAL ASPECTS OF PREPARING FOR PRICE NEGOTIATION

Prepare clear benchmarks such as:

- **A target price:** this is the fee level you would be satisfied with;
- **An opening price:** the initial offer you will make (often referred to as the list price);
- **A conditional price:** this is a pricing table where the fee varies according to quantity.

Think ahead about potential levers beyond pricing, such as:

- Pricing on a Lombard loan or other ancillary credit
- Currency exchange rate conditions
- Access to insurance reserved for VIP clients
- Exclusive event invitations
- Knowing your own limits in fee negotiations
- Assessing your ability to walk away
- Recognizing that any fee reduction offered should be time-limited and positioned as exceptional, not to become the norm.

Being prepared means taking stock of the following elements:

- The bank's USPs, the CABs of products and services (to balance price objections).
- My client's sociogram (the buying decision flow chart).
- Potential cross-selling opportunities with the client.
- Analysis of captive areas within the client's setup – your points of anchorage in the commercial relationship.
- Key client parameters: volume, history, types of services provided, and achieved performance.

SEVEN TIPS FOR PREPARING A PRICE

1. Ask yourself: could I walk away from this client if I had to.
2. Define your list price, target price (based on client profile), and your absolute minimum.
3. Enter the negotiation with a firm stance, such as: *"I will never go below 15%. Let's begin negotiating…"*.
4. Know where your red line is.
5. Prepare yourself mentally not to drift into a negotiation on principles.
6. Evaluate the weight of the objection: Is it a deal-breaker or just a hurdle to overcome?
7. Acknowledge the discount request: Recognize the client's right to negotiate on price and respond constructively.

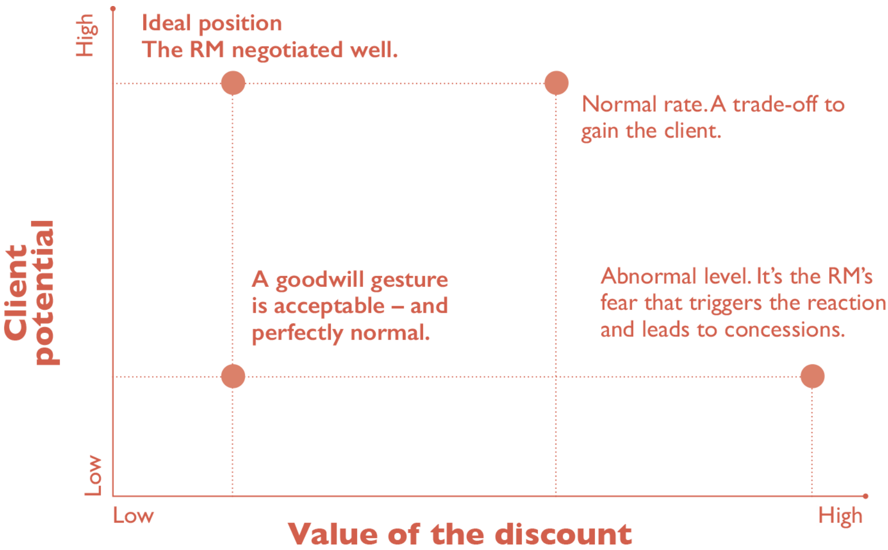
Well-known tactics for price negotiations[3]

- Price should be the final topic in a negotiation; granting a discount is the most costly concession.
- Always put pricing into perspective by linking it to expected profitability.
- Assess the client's full potential; any concessions should reflect that potential.
- Request something in return from the client in exchange for any pricing advantage.
- A manager who knows their red lines has the upper hand and avoids future internal issues.
- The adrenaline of bidding wars often leads to regret – don't let yourself get carried away.
- As the deal nears agreement, momentum builds – but this shouldn't lead to unnecessary price cuts. The wealth manager must stay focused and clear-headed.

The search for balance

The solution lies in the search for balance. Balance between energies and interests. Each party takes a step towards the other. Both parties are 50% of the way there. The concessions or services you might offer your customer may be of relative or even standard value to you, but of great value to your client.

3 Inspired by an excellent training course from Tack International: *"Value-Driven Negotiation"*. See: www.tacktmiglobal.com



B. THE PSYCHOLOGICAL DIMENSION OF PRICE NEGOTIATION

1. When the manager highlights their ethical responsibility towards the client, negotiating the price takes on a more personal dimension.
2. Remind the client of the cost savings made during the course of the relationship.
3. The RM has the ability to transform this almost-complaint into a business review.
4. The secret to explaining tariffs is effective teaching.
5. Having several people involved in a price negotiation: multiple perspectives, and the group approach reassures both parties.
6. It's advisable to revisit and raise tariffs that have historically been kept low (like an initial discount or exceptional case) when the market is on the uptrend.
7. The client may end up accepting; they're fed up, want to wrap it up, and are ultimately satisfied. Wearing them down works; the "broken record" technique is effective.
8. The RM may feel exposed and sometimes even attacked by a client who starts negotiating the bank's fees. They might take it personally. The client reveals their interests, personality, and motivations.

C. A FEW PSYCHOTHERAPEUTIC TIPS TO HELP THE RELATIONSHIP MANAGER

ISSUES	PSYCHOLOGICAL DIMENSION
Reflect on your own perception of price	Understand your stance to negotiate better.
Forget your shyness and dare to negotiate	Manage your personal obstacles.
I do better or I do nothing	Support your client in their approach (if they negotiate, so do I)
Fairness in the relationship	Feeling of justice. *What would you consider fair and reasonable?*
Be willing to lose a little to gain more	Establish a long-term relationship.
Why is the competition offering you such terms?	Relationship to reality.
I want to see the competitor's offer	Test the client's trustworthiness and credibility.

Be firm when it comes to increasing rates.

It's a common situation: you take over a client portfolio, and your predecessor granted "exceptional" rates. How should you go about regularizing the situation?

- Start by comparing the current rate with the standard price list.
- Compliment the client on their effective negotiation skills with the previous manager.
- Resist intimidation from forceful or abrupt behavior.
- Suggest gradually increasing the low rate over an agreed period.
- Schedule a rate adjustment while granting the client extra time: "You can keep the current rate for another year, but next year on this date, we will return to the standard pricing."
- Suggest trade-offs to keep the tariff unchanged, like increasing asset volume.
- Modify the scope of services offered at the existing reduced tariff.
- Review all services provided positively and ask why the client refuses to adjust rates: "If we're not at the standard rate, I must have made a mistake…"
- Stay firm but flexible on pricing.

To "sell off cheaply" means to act on a fear based on unproven reasons.

What should you do when there is competition with another bank?
It's advisable to present a pricing comparison table alongside the client to highlight transparency. The table is simple: a line on the left for our bank's name, on the right the competitor's. The manager will inquire about the competitor's rates and specify all parts of their offer to ensure a like-for-like comparison.

How to make up a price difference with a competitor?
- Put the price into perspective: how much per year, per month and per day?
- Emphasize speed of execution and quality of service.
- Encourage them to take a longer-term view; their approach to price negotiation is short-term.
- Try to be the last to make an offer; you'll have more influence based on the general principle that whoever speaks last is often right.
- Put your cards on the table and get straight to the point.

Concrete arguments carry little weight compared to the quality of a trust-based relationship.

D. THE GENERAL PRINCIPLES OF PRICE NEGOTIATION

Be precise in your definition of the quality criteria that correspond to the requested price:
- the level of information that the client will receive.
- the regularity of meetings.
- the type of follow-up offered to the client.

Clients may not fully grasp the value behind advice. The elements that constitute this value build the price; these are mainly the behaviors expected.

EXPECTED BEHAVIORS OF THE ADVISOR	HOW TO REACT
Perceive price negotiation as a positive thing.	Adopt a tolerant attitude: *"I understand that you want to negotiate fees, and that's completely normal…"* Make sure the client fully understands the value of our advice.
Use time as a lever when it comes to price negotiation.	The objection loses importance as the client expresses it (it deflates), and the client tires out…
Practice active listening.	Listen to the client without interrupting, understand the reasons for the request, make notes if necessary and rephrase.
Who takes the initiative in price negotiation?	Always the client, never the wealth manager. We negotiate the price only if there's a reason to do so.
Compensate in both directions rather than lowering fees. The wealth manager provides added value.	A service instead of a price reduction *(provided by the RM)* Additional volume for lower rates *(provided by the client)*

Things to watch out for:

Each time a price objection is raised, the manager responds by pointing out a key competitive edge.

Price negotiation is based on a well-known sales adage: "Let's compare like with like." The salesperson draws the customer's attention to what needs to be compared.

What are the dangers of price negotiation?

- Allowing the focus to drift from negotiating the price to the interpersonal dynamic or stance adopted in the negotiation.
- Making a concession without explaining it.
- Failing to set boundaries or a clear framework for the negotiation.
- Be careful not to concede too quickly; and if you do, don't do it too early.
- Confusing the three types of pricing: 1) Target price, 2) Market price, 3) Negotiated price.

A client who is (very) focused on price…

Here's an example of how the dialog might go:
"When it comes to your relationship with your bank, is price the only factor that matters?"

If the answer is yes, try a little provocation:
"Am I to understand that the quality of the advice, the financial soundness of the bank and the quality of the services are of no importance to you?"

An analogy can also be used to illustrate this point:
"Criticizing our pricing is like blaming your family doctor—who's looked after you for years—for prescribing the medicine you genuinely need, simply because it's expensive."

Use a counter-attack:
"Considering the growth of your assets since you've been with us, doesn't this price revision seem reasonable?"

E. CLASSIC NEGOTIATION TECHNIQUES

The reflex should be to respond to every discount request with a clear argument. Explain *why* the price is what it is, focusing on value for money.

It's expensive:
Expensive compared to what?

Expensive compared to who?

It's too expensive:

What makes you say that?

It's very expensive:

The client is interested but may not have the budget.

You're more expensive than…

What exactly are they offering at [competitor]… ?

You're still a bit expensive…

Likely a "yes in principle," with some hesitation around pricing.

The most effective technique for countering price objections: isolate the objection

Isolating the objection will enable you to focus on the objection itself, while assuming that all other negotiation points have been accepted.

If the client says "no" on just one point (the price), this can be interpreted as a "yes" to everything else. The advisor should then reinforce the agreed-upon positives and concentrate on the one remaining objection—the final hurdle before closing the deal.

F. SUMMARY OF PRICE NEGOTIATION

PRICE NEGOTIATION STRATEGY	HOW TO DO IT
Put the price in perspective	Break it down: how much per year, per month, per day?
Client is focused on the short term; shift the perspective to the long term Compensation happens over time.	Price only makes sense in the context of a long-term relationship. Use this as a chance to extend the relationship, increase volume, or request an additional concession.
Compare like with like.	I'll fight for you, but I need your help. Please share what the competition is offering.
Give and take.	If I reduce my price, I'll need something in return.
Try to be the last one to make an offer.	Ask the client to gather all other offers and come back to you afterward.
Price demands are weak compared to the strength of the relationship	Anticipate pricing concerns from the very beginning; make a strong first impression.
Focus on the relationship.	If the client is asking about price, they may be questioning the relationship. Ask: "Have I done something wrong?"
The wealth manager's added value. What more can you do for the same price?	The added value from the quality of the relationship can legitimize price differences. Strengthening the quality of the relationship makes negotiation easier.
Argue your case instead of offering a discount.	Reiterate the bank's Unique Selling Points (USPs). Show the client all the services and added value they're getting – something they won't find elsewhere.

All the alternatives to a price reduction:

ALTERNATIVES	ACTIONS
Alternatives to YES, but…	How much, and in exchange for what?
Yes but… with compensation	Ask for an active referral.
Yes but… I'll provide additional services	What services? Make it clear this is temporary, with an end date on the benefit granted.
Yes but … Compensation based on volume	Let's consolidate more of your assets with our bank.
Alternatives to NO	
No	Explain why not.
No and…	Increase your added value for the client. Invite them for lunch! Offer a full financial review.
No and…	What am I offering in return? If I give something else, what would that be?

Precautions to take if I align myself with competitors' proposals:

Be prepared to step up and fight for the client; set modesty aside when business is on the line. I'm willing to accept a short-term loss if it means keeping the client.

Could this be the stepping stone to a more substantial relationship?

Secure a firm agreement to increase volume before lowering your offer.

If I grant a discount, I confirm it in writing, set a deadline, stress it's a one-off, and highlight its value.

7. HOW CAN I BE SURE I'M ON THE RIGHT TRACK WITH MY FUTURE CLIENT?

The prospect appears to be very interested in your investment proposals and yet they don't sign......

The indecisive client persists but doesn't commit.

Ask yourself the following questions:

WHO HAS THE POWER TO DECIDE?

This is a common question when a manager meets with members of the same family ("cluster": a group of clients or investors sharing similar characteristics or common financial needs). Within a single unit—whether family or professional—there are both informal and apparent sources of power.

According to Michel Crozier4, the right connection is not necessarily "hierarchical"; it's not always the person with the highest rank who holds the influence or decision-making power. In private wealth management, it is essential to remain vigilant in identifying who actually holds the most significant levers of influence.

AM I DEALING WITH THE RIGHT PERSON?

To act effectively, this is also a key factor in successful negotiation.

HAVE I FULLY GRASPED THEIR NEEDS?

This is the purpose of the needs exploration phase. Ask about explicit needs, but also understand and feel implicit and emotional needs.

WILL MY OFFER SATISFY THEIR NEEDS?

It needs to meet their needs both in terms of content as well as form.

Content:
Your offer should cover each need and respond to it precisely, in the words of your (future) client. It should start with the general context and then move on to the finer details of the request.

The devil's in the detail - and so is excellence!

It's important to showcase the cultural compatibility between you both.

Demonstrate your commitment; your client needs to see themselves in your offer. It should reflect their identity and priorities.

4 Michel Crozier, *Le phénomène bureaucratique (The Bureaucratic Phenomenon)* Seuil, 1963.

On the presentation:
It's imperative that you avoid using financial jargon; your client won't understand what you're talking about. The client should recognize themselves in the tone, visuals, and wording of your proposal. The look and layout of the offer matter – it must be accessible to a non-specialist reader. Clients without specialist knowledge (80% of private wealth management clients) skim-read; they won't go through every detail. Include frequent summaries to help clients quickly grasp the key points.

You've recognized that the key challenge lies in balancing substance and style. If you've reached the point of making an offer, it means real progress has been made in the sales dialog.

IS IT THE RIGHT TEMPO, IS IT THE RIGHT TIMING?

It's the difference between speed (or the rhythm of an activity, tempo) and choosing the right moment to carry out an action (timing). When it comes to your proposals, this question must be addressed before sending anything. The exact same offer, if sent at the wrong time, can be either well received or completely rejected.

CLIENT OFFERS

A request for a proposal can be very tactical; the client wants to evaluate you and see how your proposals take shape. They want to compare with another bank to understand your working logic.

Sometimes, a request for an offer is the result of your sales skills.
You have been very convincing and attractive enough for the client to want to learn more.

Meeting a real need
You have matched the client's clear needs with the advantages offered by your products. This is the ideal commercial situation; the conclusion is near, but nothing has been signed yet.

Competitive bidding
There is a concrete project, and a formal call for tenders has been issued. Several banks are competing, and you have to fight to win the contract. In this context, preparation time should be tripled!

Tips for your proposals

- Structure your explanation from general to specific.
- Set the stage with positive points before making your offer.
- Propose only one product and stand by it with conviction.
- Include and make use of a simulation.
- Visualize the process; prepare and sketch it out in advance.

THE (VERY REAL) FEAR OF BEING USED AS A BENCHMARK

A relationship manager may legitimately ask themselves a rather blunt question:
Am I just being used as a benchmark, a decoy for the other offers they've requested?

Signs of a benchmark or "alibi" request

1. Is there a competitor in the picture? If so, who?
2. How far along is the client in their decision-making process?
3. They appear to know the file well and are familiar with technical terms.
4. They listen but remain very firm and guarded.
5. This is the first time they've asked for this kind of offer.
6. Their timing seems vague, with no deadline or sense of urgency.
7. Their reaction to your technical explanations.

11 bis

Difficult and delicate situations

It's during tough times that the true intentions of collaboration become clear.

TEACHING OBJECTIVES

After reading this chapter, you will be able to:

- Faire face à une impasse.
- Reprendre un portefeuille en toute quiétude.
- Gérer un client qui s'énerve.
- Traiter une réclamation.

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Difficult situations

They require hindsight and reflection in order to react in the most appropriate way.

I. WHAT TO DO WHEN A NEGOTIATION REACHES A DEADLOCK?[5]

In difficult situations, there is a deadlock. It differs from an objection by being more categorical, more specific, and more incisive.

What type of deadlock might a wealth manager have to face?

- The client issues a firm and blunt rejection of your offer.
- There seems to be no chance of making even the smallest impact with this client group.
- The client drags out their decision, accepts it, then reverses or withdraws it.
- A proposal is turned down with no explanation.

The first reflex of a good negotiator is to anticipate and make sure you don't reach a deadlock. Always leave a door open and provide a way out.

Your behavior is the first response.

When you're stuck in a deadlock, how you approach the conversation matters just as much as the arguments you use.

What behaviors can influence your client (who is the one creating the deadlock)?

1. Control the situation with your composure.
2. The self-assurance you are able to demonstrate.
3. The creativity that allows you to offer new alternatives to the client. Blend these three elements to deal with a deadlock.

Keep communication flowing.

Use communication tools – active listening first and foremost, ask open-ended questions to dig deeper, and rephrase what you've understood. It's a classic approach, but it works almost every time.

Listening and dialogue help ease tensions in a difficult commercial exchange. A creative proposal can redirect the conversation toward a more positive direction.

5 Inspired by *Management* magazine, October 2010: "The Keys to Successful Negotiation."

Be smart.

Sometimes, a little cunning can help…

- Make a concession that isn't really one, in exchange for something else.
- Use a smokescreen: change the subject or ask distracting questions to buy time.
- Be deliberately skeptical of every idea your client suggests.
- Flatter the client (carefully!) but remember: *"Flattery works best on those who want to believe it."*
- Make bold, assertive statements to take a strong stance in the negotiation.

2. TAKING OVER A PORTFOLIO FROM A DIFFERENT RELATIONSHIP MANAGER

This situation forces changes on clients that they did not ask for.
There are many reasons for this, which are well known.
Whenever there's a change in relationship manager, clients often react negatively; they might feel uneasy about the unexpected change and could interpret it as a lack of consideration.

Clear and transparent communication is the best way to address a client's concerns when their account is taken over by someone new.

The possible explanations? A dynamic job market, retirement, or an internal transfer. However, it's useful to provide your client with additional reassurance: let them client know you feel confident and happy in the bank and have no plans to leave.

In this type of situation, clients need three times more communication than usual.

What principles should be followed when a new wealth manager takes over?

- Speak clearly and directly; be honest about the situation.
- Don't judge your predecessor.
- Provide solid reasons why it is in the client's interest to stay with the bank. Offer reassurance.
- When taking over an account, adopt a natural attitude: stay positive, talk as little as possible, listen actively, and ask questions.
- If the client has complaints, listen, show empathy, acknowledge them, and be aware of their history with the bank. If the change surprises them, explain the context (e.g. the previous RM only stayed a year).
- Demonstrate your own expertise.
- Arrange joint meetings with a member of management to highlight the bank's stability.
- Reassure them immediately that the bank is reliable and here for the long term.

What makes you anxious is anxiety itself.

3. HOW TO DELIVER BAD NEWS?

The wrong approach is to bury bad news within too broad a context and beat around the bush; the bad news is most often poor performance.

Such a situation naturally causes concern and will provoke increased attention and curiosity from the client.

Be mindful of your words; starting with something like "It's great that you're here" might actually make the client more anxious.

Start the meeting by setting expectations with a phrase like, "The circumstances aren't in our favor." Revisit the explanation of the context for difficult situations, mention factual and rational elements to ease the client's legitimate anxiety based on the international situation, and remind them of their initial objectives. Give the client some breathing space and be careful not to impose your own emotions by saying things like, "Let's not panic!".

It's best to anticipate situations, as bad results can happen gradually. It's best to contact the client before they contact you and be proactive when performance dips.

When providing an overall explanation, using a chart that includes good years is a clever strategy, as is using market benchmarks like Performance Watcher.

Older clients tend to have more perspective on potential losses, having experienced previous financial crises.

Review the history of the relationship.

Explain the decisions as they were made, detailing the bank's decision-making process and the rationale behind each investment committee action. Clients may ask questions like: "Why didn't you sell when you saw the decline coming?" or "Why didn't you buy when the market was rising?" You need to be able to explain the timing and logic behind the bank's decisions.

Preparing for bad news:

<u>Communicate</u>: Keep the client regularly informed in advance to avoid any surprises, even if direct contact is difficult.

<u>Prepare</u>: Study the account thoroughly (history, composition, performance against benchmarks, etc.); gather all necessary information from the bank's departments.

Do not arrive with loose or separate sheets. Instead, bring a properly bound folder showing the client's name and the date of the meeting. This creates a more serious impression and feels much more professional.

We no longer live in a world of singularity but in a plural one. Having two people present for such an announcement demonstrates the bank's serious commitment.

Five open-ended questions to ask yourself before the meeting:

1. How could this bad news be turned into an opportunity?
2. How can I make my explanation as clear as possible?
3. When can I inform the client as soon as possible after receiving the news?
4. How do I personally feel about making this announcement?
5. Who from the bank (e.g. a technical expert) could join me for this conversation?

Guidelines for handling tough conversations

WHAT TO DO	WHAT TO SAY
Make yourself available.	"If we need more time, we'll schedule another appointment"
Don't shy away from the client/ prospect.	No rescheduling.
Stating my positive intention helps shape my positive behavior.	"We'll find a solution together."
Be prepared in writing and give the client advance notice (a warning shot)	Break the news in person, not over the phone.
Take note of the key points and bring all supporting documents with you.	"I've brought all the paperwork with me; please feel free to take a look."
Have a backup plan ready to help turn the situation around.	"Here is what I propose."
Stay focused and don't introduce other topics during the meeting. Deliver the most difficult news right at the beginning.	Structure the meeting: "I have two pieces of information to share with you."

Twelve questions to ask yourself before the meeting:

1. Are the causes clear?
2. Am I responsible? Is the bank responsible?
3. Were the standards and principles clearly defined?
4. Did I provide all the information the client needed?
5. Have I provided sufficient guidance?
6. Are there any conflicts between this client and the bank?
7. Is the client responsible?

8. Does the client have any personal issues?
9. Does the client have enough experience?
10. How are they like to react?
11. How might it affect our business relationship?
12. What is the worst-case scenario (BHS[6])?

Psychological reactions to bad news (both the client's and the RM's)

When announcing a performance decline to a client, the client appreciates sensing that the manager shares some of their concern. This psychological approach is important.

They could be anxious because of scary headlines, like fears of recession, stock market declines, war, or rising oil prices.

Client reactions

- A wave of emotion creates a shock.
- They may go into denial.
- They might generalize ("It's the same everywhere, anyway.").

RM reactions

- Fear of the consequences the bad news might cause.
- The client may sense the manager's discomfort.
- The manager themselves may struggle emotionally.

A few tips

- Remind the client why the portfolio was built this way.
- Frame the situation within a long-term strategy.
- Take a step back with your explanations.
- Avoid negative preambles such as:

"*I have bad news for you; you might be disappointed or even angry with me, but it's not my fault…*"

Negative words create a negative mindset that puts the client on the defensive, ready to attack.

- Explain: the client will magnify the effect if they don't understand the cause!
- Stop the negative spiral in their imagination by announcing positive elements or explaining your approach (looking ahead).

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6 *Black Hole Strategy* which means the worst that can happen to us.

Guidelines for handling a specific meeting: a rate increase:

WHAT TO DO	WHAT TO SAY
Highlight the importance of the meeting and client.	*"We're going to have an* ***important discussion****."*
Ask a closed question to gain initial agreement.	*"Do you agree in principle that transparency in our business relationship is vital?"*
Present the information (the decision) clearly and get straight to the point.	*"We have decided to implement a mortgage rate increase, and I will explain why."*
Let the client react and then explain the situation.	Remain silent and wait for their reaction.
Ensure they understand your explanation.	*"Is my explanation clear to you?"*
Look ahead to the future.	*"How can we work together to make sure this doesn't impact your portfolio management? Let's set up a follow-up with clear goal."*
Advisor and client commitment to the action plan (previous point); it's time to "shift" into action	*"Here's my proposed action plan"*

If the client chooses to close their account, keep the lines of communication open. This way, the client will remember (and pass on) the image of a trustworthy bank, not a manager who's trying to run away or just get by.

4. WHAT TO DO WHEN A CLIENT GETS ANGRY

Causes could be the bank's slow reaction in turbulent markets, disappointing results, or unfavorable public disclosures concerning the bank.

How should you react?

- React quickly in order to reassure them, and then see them in-person as quickly as possible.
- They need to get their anger out so let them speak.
- Explain the investment strategy by placing it within a long-term perspective.
- Bring in a specialist to explain the investment decisions.
- Bring a senior manager.
- Request a face-to-face meeting.

One common problem is when a client sees their portfolio drop and then asks why the bank didn't respond earlier. The investment policy expert needs to explain the bank's positioning:

- Review the client's fundamental needs and the choices made; put these into perspective with their reaction.
- Their reaction is a well-known bias in behavioral finance – the individual response to market fluctuations.

Writing things down helps prepare for tricky situations ahead. Keep detailed records of meetings.
The RM should approach clients who get upset and haggle over every cent with kindness and not take it personally or engage in their tactics.

Clients can get annoyed if the RM pushes too hard early on, bombarding them with all the compliance requirements.
By pressing the client to reveal too much with multiple requests, the RM risks putting themselves in a weak position and having to concede.

How should you react in this situation?

Every request should be clearly explained.

Each document has a story that needs to be told.
There is a contrast between everyday services, like buying a plane ticket, which are increasingly simple, and opening an account, which remains complex. Many forms still need to be completed.

One approach is to prepare the client psychologically beforehand by warning them that the upcoming period of form-filling and administrative tasks may be challenging.

What to do when faced with a rude client?

There are limits to every situation; it's up to you to set yours.

HISTOIRE

This is the remarkable story of a husband who brings his wife to meet his private banker and requests a commission for the introduction. He then painstakingly negotiates every fee, passing all the extra charges onto his wife's account without her knowledge. How do you react to such shameless behavior?

These are the types of situations where it becomes necessary to say no and refuse to endorse such behavior. Initial client behaviors and warning signs can be a preview of what's to come.

Even if I lose, the lesson remains.

5. WINNING BACK LOST CLIENTS – A GUIDE FOR RELATIONSHIP MANAGERS

PROBLÉMATIQUES	ACTIONS À MENER	COMMENTAIRES
Measures to take when an account is closed	**Review and analyze** the client's file, including all anomalies, incidents, and history. Review the client's needs and initial investments.	React very quickly by making direct contact
	Analyze the causes: What is the reason for the closure? What is the quality of the relationship with the relationship manager? How plausible are the reasons given by the client. How difficult is the closure?	Having a clear protocol of actions and questions to ask will make managers' work easier and streamline reactions.
Arrange a personal	Can the client be retained? Is it worth fighting to keep the client? **During the meeting:** Directly address the problems or reasons for departure. Steer the discussion towards finding a solution to see if there is an opening for recovery Make concessions. Understand the real reasons and learn from them openly with the client. Detect any remaining dissatisfaction. This is a good moment to gather information about the competition.	Call the client immediately. Introduce yourself and show empathy. Show genuine sincerity and let the client see that this situation is painful for us too.
The situation still offers some opportunities.	Express regret and acknowledge mistakes; try to make amends. If possible, explain why the situation didn't work out. Try to re-engineer the client's needs (start from scratch).	This is a time for honest exchange and making amends with the client… to explore any remaining opportunities. The only goal is to win the client back.

Conclusion and action plan.	Agree on the points discussed and put them in writing straight away.	Provide written confirmation of the terms and concessions offered to the client.
If they leave anyway…	Schedule a follow-up to stay in touch. Include the client in a mailing list for exclusive updates. Continue treating them as a client so they still feel part of the community.	Keep in touch with the client to stay fresh in their memory.

6. MANAGING CLIENT INDIFFERENCE

Because recognition plays a big role in motivation, a manager overlooked by a disinterested client can understandably feel hurt, frustrated, or slighted, which may cause their commercial enthusiasm to wane!

But why might a client be indifferent toward their manager? Several reasons include:

- They're satisfied with their main bank.
- They don't realize that we can improve their banking relationship.
- They don't understand the differences we can make.
- They're satisfied with the current situation and don't understand all the issues involved.

Client indifference has a special impact on a manager. The result is that they either lose motivation or, conversely, increase their determination and effort to convince the client to improve things.

How do you know if a client is indifferent?

When they start showing us certain signs, such as a lack of interest in discussing their expectations or problems.

When they express their dissatisfaction and explain why.

When they feel satisfied with their main banking relationship and are resistant to any new proposals.

The important thing is not to rush them but to begin by congratulating them on the quality of the relationship they have with their current banker.

Acknowledge their wise decision and their ability to appreciate good service. It's tactful to help them realize that building a strong banking relationship is difficult and that they are right to have high standards.

After these preliminaries, you can open the discussion by asking: "*Would it be alright if I asked you a few questions to help improve your banking relationship today?*"

Questions:

- What brings you satisfaction in your banking relationship today?
- What aspects of your wealth management are you dissatisfied with?
- What has made your banking relationship a success?
- How might openness and a diversity of banking advice be beneficial to you?
- What additional services would you like to have?
- Are you satisfied with your financial investments?

Indifferent clients generally don't express any specific needs. The strategy, in this case, is to take a broader view of their situation, stepping back to encourage the client to move from their personal context to their banking matters.

The manager needs to distinguish between an expressed need that can be met (the ideal scenario) and a potential opportunity to support the client in a more subtle way.

Uncovering such opportunities involves digging deep and exploring every possible angle.

The consequence strategy

This strategy involves highlighting all the potential risks the client may be exposed to.

This strategy – like all scare tactics – is risky.

What's the process?

Ask questions to identify any gaps or weaknesses in the client's current setup. Highlight the consequences of the current situation and help the client visualize the risks if they take no action.

If a problem or shortcoming is identified, ask follow-up questions to explore and expand on that weakness:

"How does this affect you? How serious is this situation, and what impact does it have on the management of your assets?"

Summarize the key issues the client has shared, give them a moment to reflect, then start exploring possible solutions and options.

FIVE TIPS FOR HANDLING DIFFICULT INTERVIEWS

1. BE EMPATHETIC
Help your client take a longer-term view. Use both verbal and non-verbal active listening.
2. UNDERSTAND AND EXPLAIN
Explain the facts clearly, acknowledge emotions. Never improvise; make sure you've prepared your points in writing.
3. STAY POSITIVE, NOT EMOTIONAL
Use this as a chance to reanalyse part of the client's assets. Say "Yes, and…" instead of "Yes, but…"
Aim to add value.
4. AVOID SURPRISES
Negative information is easier to accept when expected.
It can be a chance to adjust the investment profile realistically.
5. FIND THE SILVER LINING!
Even bad news can have a positive side.

7. I SHOULD HAVE SAID NO…

There are situations where our thoughts only catch up after the fact – a classic case of "staircase thinking."
In both professional and personal contexts, a relationship manager may look back and regret not having said no – to a client, a prospect, or a business partner.
This hindsight raises an important question:
In certain tricky situations, wouldn't it be wiser to say no from the start?

YES increases sales and NO increases profits!
(It's worth repeating!)

Saying yes requires no special skill—it's easy!
Saying no is harder. We fear **disappointing** others, damaging our image, or being judged.

So how do you say no the right way?
1. Match your tone and attitude to your client's.
2. Listen carefully and ask for clarification if needed.
3. Say no clearly, positively, getting straight to the points.
4. If they insist, repeat your message calmly like a broken record.
5. Share your feelings but don't over justify; only explain what's strictly necessary!

6. Repeat your refusal in a constructive way (offer an alternative, for example).
7. Finish by proposing a relevant solution or offer.

SEPT BONS CONSEILS DE LA PART D'UN AMI *COMPLIANCE OFFICER*

1. Collect all the bank's functional organization charts to answer the question "who does what with what technical skills?"
2. Provide timely reminders about the legal aspects of the commercial relationship.
3. Explain the bank's status with specific examples: characteristics, advantages, disadvantages, etc.
4. Explain the mechanism of responsibilities between the client and the manager. Clearly explained co-responsibility builds trust: what you must do, what I must do.
5. Maintain a list of forms with simple explanations; be ready to present and pitch each one. Inform the client about the documentation they will receive after each meeting.
6. Use KYC as a commercial tool for mutual understanding; also share relevant information about yourself with the client.
7. Know all the internal resources within the bank you can rely on.

8. COMPLAINTS

It's all a matter of perception! We are operating within the same paradigm as objections. The way we perceive a complaint will influence the behavior we adopt when handling it.

This is the central concept: Complaints are an opportunity to improve.

This is not an easy path; there's a paradox to resolve. A complaint is an exchange based on conflicting views. Why should we see complaints as opportunities?

- They provide a chance to build client loyalty if the complaint is handled well.
- They help discover errors and fix malfunctions within our organization.
- They allow us to improve processes.
- They provide an opportunity to deepen our relationship with clients; solving problems together makes us closer.

- They showcase our ability to respond quickly and adapt.
- They help identify new business opportunities.
- They provide the rewarding feeling of doing a good job professionally.

If the institution's policy emphasizes this concept, relationship managers will seize every opportunity to bounce back. To implement this policy, sales meetings serve as the forum to discuss recurring complaints. This centralized approach makes it possible to resolve problems "once and for all," and to define common policies for redressing grievances.

A satisfied client will tell 10 people, but an unhappy client may tell 50!

The nature of the complaint

Here's a "special" question to ask a salesperson: "Who is your most dangerous client?"

The response is the client who says nothing – the good, loyal client. They are considered secured and captive, which is why we tend to overlook them.

Let's talk about the best client: who would that be? The one who says nothing, or rather the one who won't let anything slide and who will make complaints? It's clear that the best client is the demanding one, because they help you improve.

In the context of a complaint, clients' emotions are often running high.

The psychological dimension: Show your client they matter and take responsibility for their case; sometimes compensation isn't enough to fully satisfy a complaining client.

What not to do:

- Do not deny the situation.
- Don't shift responsibility back to the client: *"I don't understand; this is the first time someone has complained about this…"*
- Don't embarrass the client by proving them wrong with a detailed explanation ending in a "case closed.
- Don't tell them they don't have the right to be angry: *"Is it really worth getting worked up over this?"*

When a client starts a complaint, they enter a particular emotional state; should we match that emotional frequency?
One approach is to "let it go" by giving up any opposition, agreeing with the client even if they are wrong, and smoothing the situation as diplomatically as possible.

A. KINDNESS STRATEGIES

This is an influence technique already discussed in Chapter 6.

The fundamentals of this strategy are as follows:

- Don't get into a "fight": when faced with a complaint, use relational judo to calm things down.
- Denial and downplaying the facts only serve to aggravate the client's anger.
- Take responsibility: as soon as a problem is shared with you, it becomes yours until it's resolved.
- Handle the situation with a smile, and never shift the blame to the competition by criticizing them.

One psychological pitfall to avoid is identification: When a client complains about our service or an investment choice, and something has not gone as planned, we may be tempted to take the criticism personally. Identification means internalizing the complaint and, as a result, feeling targeted or attacked.

The alternative is to take a more objective stance by taking a step back and assessing the situation with professional distance.

Language traps to avoid when dealing with a complaint:

- Minimization: "a little bit", "a little visit".
- Overly formal or patronizing politeness: such as *"Forgive me for asking…" or "Would you allow me to…".*
- Negative language: using words like *"problem," "trouble," "risk," "danger", or "You wouldn't want that, would you?".*
- Hesitant or evasive language: *"Maybe," "I don't know," "possibly," "it's not me," "it's not my fault…"*
- Suspicious language: *"Trust me," "Honestly," "I made the same investment myself…" …*

Be aware of the impact of the words we speak.

B. KEY TIP FOR HANDLING COMPLAINTS: ALWAYS FACE THEM!

Listening requires constant discipline.

When a client speaks, they often send out warning signals – "messages in a bottle" – without even realizing it. Pay close attention and let them speak without interrupting.

Listen to everything the client has to say – major complaints often have a natural tendency to deflate on their own. The issue raised may be unusual, imagined, or even exaggerated. However, it's important to let the client fully express their grievances. Once they've said everything on their mind, you can begin to help.

At this point, it's about joining the conversation in a way that encourages and channels their flow of words. You can intervene using phrases such as:
- I am not sure I understand; tell me more about it.
- I can see this point matters to you.
- Could you give me an example?
- Now I completely understand what you mean.
- Let's look together at the options available to us.

This way, you're more likely to be seen as an ally.
You need to help the client realize they'll achieve better results by cooperating with you rather than arguing.
This approach, based on mutual acceptance and support, tends to be highly effective.

You don't persuade a client by overwhelming them with logical reasoning, words, or arguments. It's comments and signs of agreement that are more likely to steer the discussion towards a constructive solution.

Acknowledging the client's perspective and using positive body language to offer reassurance and encouragement are key to directing their attention toward resolution rather than dwelling on the unpleasant aspects of the problem.

In short, a good listener:
- lets the client speak without interrupting, allowing the complaint to be fully expressed.
- tries to intuitively pick up on signs of disappointment and frustration.
- works to defuse the situation and prevent it from escalating unnecessarily.
- records the facts in writing, as well as identifying the who, what, where, why, when, and how.
- takes all appropriate and possible actions.
- establishes clear timeframes.
- keeps the client informed of the process, the steps taken, and the final outcome.

C. WHAT ARE THE MAIN STEPS FOR HANDLING A COMPLAINT?

QUOI ?	COMMENT ?
Listen attentively	If the client seems agitated, let them tell their story a second time. Tune into their emotions and reflect them back in words. Show empathy; put yourself in their shoes so they feel understood.
Keep your cool	Show it through your tone and body language: speak slowly, remain composed, act with kindness and compassion.
Stick to the facts	Don't make assumptions – rely on facts and figures. Be as clear and accurate as possible in your analysis.
Summarize what you've heard	Play back the key points and check that you've understood them correctly; make sure you're in sync with the client.

Express your regrets	Whether or not you're at fault, take ownership of the issue and stay involved until it's fully resolved.
Set clear objectives and create an action plan	The solution should feel fair and reasonable. Find common ground, and above all, make concrete commitments. This includes defining actions, assigning responsibilities, and setting deadlines.
Thank your client…	…for taking the time to let you know something wasn't working properly.
Follow up…	…using whichever communication method you prefer.

D. LA RÉCLAMATION À DISTANCE AU TÉLÉPHONE OU EN VISIOCONFÉRENCE

QUOI ?	COMMENT ?
A smile can be heard	Even over the phone! It affects your tone and sets a calm tone for the conversation.
Listen actively	Take notes while the client speaks; writing helps sharpen your focus. Wait for the second sentence before responding.
Acknowledge…	… when needed, by nodding verbally with phrases like "I see," or "That's interesting." Match your client's tone with supportive expressions.
Be empathetic	Try to understand the root of their dissatisfaction.
Check you've understood	Repeat what they said in your own words.
Reassure them	Tell them they've come to the right person — and that you're confident you can resolve it.
Apologize…	…even if you're not directly responsible for the error.
Look for a solution…	…with full commitment. Take visible action so the client sees that you're working on it.
Follow up	Thank the client and check in a few days later to make sure everything is now fine.

Remotely, regardless of the medium used, perceptions tend to be heightened and reactions more abrupt and direct.

An expert's perspective

Ali is an expert in client relations, having had a career on the front line before specializing in banking marketing.

The importance of personalization[7]

I had a client who regularly placed orders on one of his portfolios, mainly in equities and occasionally in bonds. We had a good relationship, and he was very satisfied with the quality of our service. Based on his assets and activity, he benefited from special brokerage terms and a small discount on recurring fees.

One day, he began placing options orders and asked about the terms and commissions. I responded clearly and promptly. He replied, half-jokingly but with a hint of seriousness, "That's tourist pricing!"

I told him I'd get back to him. In the end, I called him back and offered a small discount, which satisfied him, and he started trading options with us.

The lesson from this seemingly ordinary story lies in the experience we create for our clients (and prospects) when we talk about pricing.

It is essential to personalize pricing – meaning it should reflect the relationship (existing or developing) and the level of service, rather than simply quoting from a factsheet.

Adapting how we present the offer and the pricing attached to it creates a personalized experience and helps avoid making a client (or prospect) feel like they're being treated like a tourist!

7 Anecdotes shared by Ali Altinsoy.

Spring into action!
5 key takeaways and an exercise

FIVE KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. To break a deadlock, maintain steady communication with your clients.
2. Prepare for difficult conversations in writing, and always anticipate them.
3. The tougher the situation, the bigger your smile; if a client gets upset, calm them with your response.
4. When dealing with a lost or indifferent client, be proactive and act immediately.
5. Complaints are a chance… to improve.

EXERCISE

Title: Turning objections into opportunities.

Aim of the exercise: To know how to turn an objection to your advantage.

Instructions:
- List the five main objections you encounter and give an answer for each one.
- When faced with a pricing objection, what are your first three reflexes?
- In one sentence, describe your attitude when faced with a complaint or a tricky situation.

12

Closing the deal

and client follow-up

Closing the deal and following up are the first steps toward building a new kind of business relationship. Dare to close!

TEACHING OBJECTIVES

After reading this chapter, you will be able to:

- Oser conclure en temps opportun et sans inhibitions.
- Repérer les signaux de conclusion.
- Activer les mécanismes de la conclusion.
- Pratiquer toutes les techniques de conclusion.
- Assurer un suivi, gage de succès.

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An end in itself?

Is closing a deal an end in itself, or rather the sealing of an agreement oriented toward the future?
If the sales process has been carried out with care and commitment, and all stages have been respected, then the conclusion becomes merely a formality.

Its purpose is to achieve consensus and set the direction for further negotiation. Failure is still possible; the deal might not close.
Closing represents a transition to action, a means of overcoming hurdles. It brings agreements and common ground to light. Closing is about offering support, not applying pressure, as the other person reaches their decision.

Closing the deal is the first step in a new relationship.

To get a deal done, closing takes skill and strategy. It's the final part of a conversation. The manager must show determination to close. Like judokas use "grappling," the manager must hold on to the client and keep the pressure on.

The closing phase is about overcoming barriers – the biggest being our reluctance to ask. Often, good manners hold us back!

1. THE RIGHT MOMENT TO CLOSE THE DEAL IS... NEITHER TOO EARLY NOR TOO LATE

The biggest challenge in closing is knowing when the time is right. In theory, this is simple. In practice, however, closing is a matter of opportunity but also of intuition. You need to trust yourself and recognize the signals to begin the closing sequence.
You can tell the ***right moment*** is near when:

- **The client seems to be interested** and their questions become more and more specific.
- They start to talk about pricing.
- Their body language shows interest.
- If they were referred by a business partner, they're usually ready to close.

Conversely, it is NOT the right moment when:

- The manager notices the client is unconvinced, becoming distant and showing little interest.
- The client steers the conversation toward more general topics.
- The client displays excessive politeness, thanking the manager for coming.

The right time is also…

- When all the steps of the sales process have been completed:
– We've uncovered the client's needs and buying motivations.
– Our arguments have clearly had an impact.
– We've addressed all objections.
- When we've identified and acted on buying signals and closing cues:
– The client spontaneously agrees or clearly states a buying decision.
– Their facial expressions and body language show strong engagement.

But also…

The client asks you for something specific.

The client may express it as a thought: *"That sounds quite good…"*

- Or through a token objection for reassurance: *"Everything looks perfect, but…"*

2. ROUND-UP OF BUYING SIGNALS

There are non-verbal signs that indicate readiness to close:

A facial expression (eyebrows, eyes, mouth…).

A body movement (the client leans forward, toward you).

A change of attitude:

- The talkative client goes quiet, or the quiet one starts talking.
- The restless client calms down, or the calm one becomes more animated; they move closer to the salesperson or, on the contrary, lean back and pull away.
- They start taking notes.
- They look through the documentation with interest and handle it (as if they were already a client.
- A relaxed smile appears.
- Eye contact becomes more direct.
- They settle more comfortably in their chair.
- They order another drink; they start to feel at home.

There are also verbal closing signals (which tend to be more explicit):

- Successive approvals of the proposed products and services.
- Questions about commercial terms.
- Acceptance of pricing or a request for a discount.
- Asking for references from other clients.
- They ask about training or information sessions offered by the bank.
- The client engages with the product by asking a series of detailed questions.
- They tell us about very specific needs (e.g., investment constraints).
- They express interest in visiting the bank (for example, to view the artwork on display).

- They want to meet the team of specialists (portfolio manager, advisors, tax experts, etc.).
- They ask how funds will be transferred and request administrative details.
- They ask whether the bank can handle the full process of transferring assets from their current bank.
- They raise questions about how future contact will be managed: remotely or in person at the bank?
- They ask for reassurance or confirmation of our unique selling points (USPs).
- They switch from speaking in the conditional to using the future tense.
- Their questions become increasingly precise.
- They say: "I agree."

After each contract is signed, send a personalized thank-you letter.

3. THE MECHANICS OF CLOSING

The wealth manager identifies closing signals and then moves toward the closing phase.

If signals are strong and frequent, it's a *PULL* situation; the client is giving positive signs and inviting the close.

They are drawing us in.
If signals are weak or unclear, it's a *PUSH* situation and the manager needs to apply closing techniques to guide the client toward a decision.

How do we know we're in the pull zone? (This is the right moment!)

We can tell by the stage we're at:

- All stages of the sales process have been completed.
- Our arguments have clearly had an impact.
- We've dealt with any objections.
- A purchasing decision has been clearly expressed.
- We detect closing signals.

Through closing signals (see point 2): Close, but not too quickly…

The moment of closing is delicate. It calls for both elegance and a calculated distance in order to preserve the trust built with the client:

A seasoned wealth manager might say: *"Take your time to think it over. Let's meet again next week…"*
Paradoxically, though, if the context is right, they should also be ready to move forward and suggest taking action:*"Shall we go ahead and finalise your account opening?"*

The wealth manager must be able to *sense* whether the client is ready to close.

During this critical phase, several precautions should be taken:

- **Stay alert** and **never give up**!
- A change in circumstances, such as commission rates or a new account manager at a competing bank, can be enough to make the client back out.
- **Always maintain a point of contact!**
- By keeping in close touch with the client – by phone, regular mailings, or in-person visits – you preserve the opportunity for a positive outcome.
- Keep in **mind the "last chance" technique:** It involves asking the client for a favor, such as: *"Please don't sign anything without discussing it with me first. If you have another offer that is better, I'll recommend it over my own, because I put your interests before my commercial goals."*
- **Be ready to walk away:** This is the manager's key strength to avoid being on survival mode with the client. They should explain their position and any refusal, then possibly switch to the last chance approach.

The "passive manager" was so passive
that he died!

4. THE FIVE MAIN CLOSING TECHNIQUES, FROM THE SIMPLEST AND MOST ELEGANT TO THE MOST PERSISTENT

A. THE YES COLLECTION

What is it?

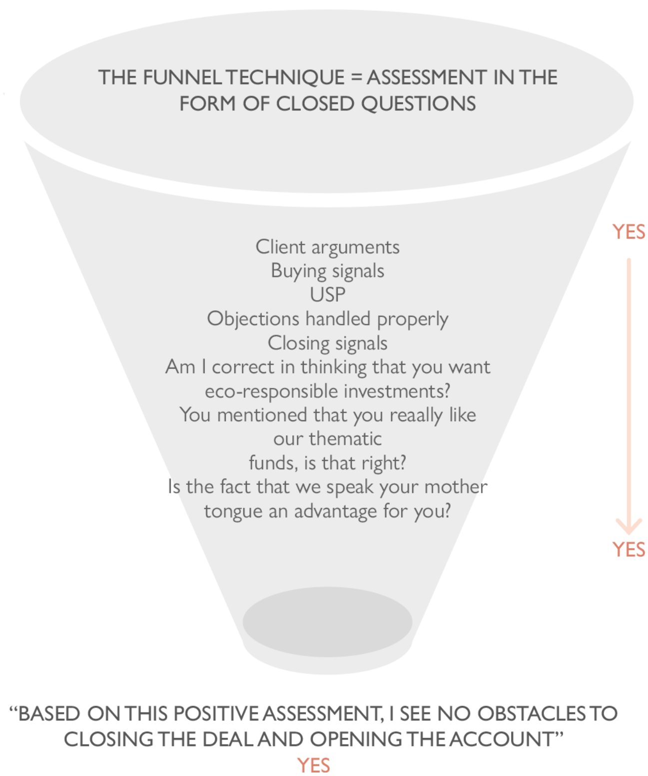
Conduct a recap using closed questions (the manager seeks YES answers) focused on the arguments the client raised during discussions, as well as their preferences, buying signals they sent, USPs they acknowledged, and closing signals they gave.

What's the purpose?

To create a psychological effect through a series of YES responses from the client, leading them to make a decision after multiple affirmatives.

How does it work?

The relationship manager asks positively framed closed questions to collect YES answers from the client.



B. AFTB (*ASKING FOR THE BUSINESS*)

CAUTIOUS AND INSIGHTFUL TECHNIQUE

What is it?

Guiding the client toward a buying decision.

The relationship manager asks a question; if the client answers, they reveal their stance.

Why use it?

To help the client open up and move toward a decision, without applying pressure.

How does it work?

The RM asks open-ended questions:

- Very direct:

– What are the chances of us working together?
– What is your decision?

If we agree on this, can we go ahead and sign?

- More subtle:

– What information do you still need to make a decision?
– What would you need from me to consider me your partner now?
– What are your decision criteria?

If I make a statement, I risk a refusal.
If I ask a question, I only risk a conversation.

This closing technique is our favorite: it's both subtle and direct. It encourages shared responsibility by prompting the client to take a position – and therefore to commit.

Here are other examples of **AFTB** questions:

- Closed question: Do you agree with our approach?
- Breaking down the agreement: Where… On what date… How do you see […]?
- Anticipation: Regardless of […], what would you personally do?
- Implication: Putting aside the commercial terms for a moment, on a technical level, which partner would you choose?
- Constructive: What would it take for us to work together?
- Control: What is preventing you from giving me your agreement today?
- Before I go, I'd like to know which parts of my proposal you're unsure about.

AFTB questions must be followed by silence, to give the client space to respond. The key idea behind it is to shift the burden of argument; it's now the client who makes the case by taking a stance.

C. COMMITMENT AND PRIMING

What is it?

Commitment: The RM commits personally, encouraging the client to do the same.

Priming: Helping the client picture themselves as a client, supporting their decision-making (e.g., through a free assessment)

Why use it?

The client starts to behave *as if* they've already said yes…

The RM's positive energy becomes contagious.

It's about behaving as if the decision has already been made (a bit like counting your chickens before they hatch…).

How does it work?

The RM:

"Here's what we'll do — I'll prepare all the account opening documents for you, and you'll just need to sign them."

"I've asked our Portfolio Manager to carry out a complimentary analysis of the best options for your portfolio…"

"I've already registered you for an exclusive event the bank is organizing for its clients."

"I've added you to our distribution list for investment recommendations — it's reserved for our valued clients."

After all your efforts, it's now your client's turn!

D. OFFERING ALTERNATIVE SOLUTIONS

What is it?

It's an alternative way of analyzing two opposites:
- the positives and the negatives,
- the pros and cons.

Why use it?

At this stage, the RM can emphasize the benefits and expand on them with an additional explanation.

The customer can be subtly offered a choice between two alternatives, both of which lead to a purchase.

How does it work?

The aim is to show that there are far more advantages than disadvantages, and to follow up with a concrete call to action.

The principle is the same as when arranging a phone appointment using the so-called favorable alternative approach.

- The key is to present two options, both of which involve a purchase:
  - Shall we meet again to sign this week or next?
  - For our future meetings, would you prefer them to take place at the bank or at your home?
  - As for the transfer of your funds, would you like us to handle it, or would you prefer to do it yourself?

Presenting two well-framed choices improves the likelihood of a favorable outcome. Even if the client rejects both, the sales process doesn't come to a halt.

Along the same lines, there's the "don't-miss-this-opportunity" technique. For example, offer a preferential rate if the client commits immediately, or just before a price adjustment. This creates a sense of urgency that may encourage a quick decision, but it must be handled with caution.

E. THE HARD SELL

What is it?

Two last-resort techniques.

High-pressure tactics and strategic excuses are used only when all other methods have failed.

While they can be effective, they should be seen as last-ditch options.

Why use it?

Helping a very hesitant client make a decision by applying pressure.

How does it work?

High-pressure approach: Once it becomes clear that the client is still undecided (after many meetings), the RM takes stock of the relationship, revisiting the original request and goals.
At this point, the RM notes that all objections have been resolved and then raises the question of trust:

"Mr/Ms Client, do you trust us? If you do, then I invite you to finalize things by confirming your agreement on..."

The hesitant client persists but still won't sign.

Reminder of the 3 key principles of the closing phase:

- If the earlier phases have been handled properly, the closing phase is shorter and can even become a mere formality.
- Buying signals must be identified and leveraged to turn them into closing signals, so that closing simply confirms the client's intentions.

- Recognize "Push and Pull" dynamics to guide clients toward the close, then apply appropriate closing techniques.

It's the relationship manager's drive and commercial energy that carry the client into the closing zone and help them reach a decision. Some RMs are naturally proactive in sales and don't even need to "formally" close. I've seen managers who, quite naturally, say to their clients: *"Here's what we're going to do now… We'll go ahead and complete the paperwork to open your account."*

Closing is greatly simplified when the manager shows real assertiveness.

THE FINAL WORD ON CLOSING

It's during this delicate phase that each RM will be able to test his or her negotiating style and approach. They'll be able to put their sales "signature" to the test.

The way in which the RM chooses to close a deal is especially meaningful. Clients of private banks are used to being treated with discretion; the culture and environment are often more refined and intimate. An aggressive sales style would feel out of place and would not align with the expectations of these clients.

The closing phase must therefore be in harmony with the style and culture of private banking.

The title of the chapter on closing in my first book on sales was: *"Persistence and Elegance."*

The RM must be determined, committed to their convictions and commercial goals — but must also show restraint, moderation, sensitivity, and elegance!

5. WHAT TO DO NEXT

The RM wraps things up by confirming the decisions made by both sides. The simplest way to do this is by providing a summary — a recap of the key points discussed. You can either deliver the summary yourself or ask the client what they've taken away from the meeting (in which case, you'll fill in the gaps as needed).

This type of summary is very similar to a formal meeting record or sales meeting minutes, with a structure such as:

Who is responsible for what, and by when?

After a sales conversation, you might expand these minutes to include:

Who said what, when, and why?

Sending the summary to the client for confirmation helps prevent misunderstandings about investment decisions that can arise months down the line. This follow-up method is a great way to keep the conversation going and agree on the next steps — whether that's a second meeting, sending documents, or meeting with a tax specialist.

It's also advisable to take the opportunity to end the meeting on a positive note and with a word of thanks.

When the relationship with a client is nurtured in a concrete, clear, and effective way, the client feels valued. Being visited or kept informed makes them feel appreciated, acknowledged, and important.

The post-interview follow-up is also the ideal time to carry out a self-evaluation of your own performance.

A. WHAT QUESTIONS SHOULD YOU ASK YOURSELF FOR SELF-EVALUATION?

- How does the client feel after our conversation?
- What did I learn about them?
- What did I do well?
- What objectives did I really achieve?
- Did I make any mistakes?
- Did I forget anything?
- Did I keep my composure?
- Was I unsure of myself or, on the contrary, overconfident?
- Was I insecure or overconfident?
- Did I talk too much and not listen enough?
- Did I talk too much about myself and not enough about them?
- What should I do differently or better next time?
- What should I do now? In the future?

An expert's perspective

Here's a testimonial from François N., a former wealth manager at a well-known bank. With his broad experience in business development, he reveals his closing strategies.

Closing isn't the end; it marks the start of an exciting journey with a new client or the launch of a new project with an existing one. The latter is more common; with experience, I have fewer and fewer new clients. If you do your job well, you just need to consolidate your portfolio, and referrals will come naturally.

My experience with closing mostly involves presenting new investment proposals to existing clients. I know my clients well — their lives, their ways of thinking, what they like and dislike. I have cultivated in them a mindset that encourages doubt and questioning (a concept that was instilled in me long ago by the author of this book).

This approach works really well in the long run because the decisions are thoughtful. My clients don't make spontaneous or impulsive investments, and emotional reactions to trendy fads are out of the question. To close the deal, I know I have to focus on a key part of the product's pitch. I watch how they react during the presentation and come back later to those particular points.

My client knows that I respect their freedom to choose. I'll suggest they take some time to think things over, even if they want to go ahead right away. They also know that I will challenge them and encourage them to form their own opinion. Sometimes, clients don't want to think too much and use a phrase I really dislike: "Just do what you'd do yourself." I always reply that I'm not them, and it's not my money.

When they make a hasty decision, I ask them to send me a confirmation letter. My experience leads me to exercise a healthy skepticism about human nature. I often say to them, somewhat jokingly at the start of our relationship:
"Never trust me completely and always be demanding."
I focus again on these little details that grab my attention, like traffic lights telling me if I can go ahead (green) or if I should stop (red). I watch their facial expressions first, especially their eyes, which never lie. I'm no NLP[1] expert, but I can tell when someone's gaze is avoiding eye contact or, on the other hand, intense. Eyebrows speak volumes too, as does the mouth, which might flash quick signs of disapproval. If you're really observant, you can pick up on these reactions. Body language is very expressive as well. When the proposal doesn't appeal to them, most clients tend to lean back slightly in their chair, as if seeking support.

1 NLP: Neuro-Linguistic Programming.

The easiest reactions to read are shifts in behavior: maybe they start taking notes, ask how much it costs, or comment on the product — whether positive or negative. When I spot these small cues, like a raised eyebrow, I follow up with questions to dig deeper into what I think they're feeling.

I sometimes get it wrong and read too much into a client's behavior. That's not a problem; I'm very transparent and respond honestly: "I thought you were reacting to my proposal." It's a chance to bounce back with a very direct question: "What's stopping you from going ahead and accepting this mandate?"

Over time, I've become more straightforward in my approach; if I sense interest, I cut to the chase.

The worst that can happen is that the client says no, but that doesn't affect the trust between us. I don't waste time anymore with overthinking or clever maneuvers.

Spring into action!
5 key takeaways and an exercise

FIVE KEY TAKEAWAYS

Spot all closing signals and move forward; dare to close.

1. Bring your client into the closing zone using either Pull or Push techniques.
2. Use every closing tool you've got – especially the "Yes" collection and the AFTB technique.
3. Draft meeting summaries whenever possible to anchor decisions and commitments.
4. Follow-up is to sales what oxygen is to the human body!

EXERCICE

Title: Closing the deal marks the start of a new relationship.

Aim of the exercise: Learning to close in the most natural way possible.

Instructions:

- What two techniques do you use to help guide your clients toward making a purchase decision?
- How do you organize client follow-up in practice?

13

Presenting the bank

and public speaking

Presenting the bank is an exercise
that reflects the manager's personality.
Own your role and make it your own!

TEACHING OBJECTIVES

After reading this chapter, you will be able to:

- Use all components of your bank's presentation.
- Prepare for both standard and exceptional speaking engagements.
- Consider how to manage your personal brand image.

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1. INTRODUCTION TO PUBLIC SPEAKING IN A BANKING CONTEXT

There are many different situations and chances when an RM might have to give a presentation. It could be in front of a group, some of the institution's clients, or just one person on their own. Sometimes the RM will have support materials; other times, they won't. It's essential that they develop their public speaking skills to handle all situations.

Practicing public speaking also brings extra benefits, such as greater fluency, clearer thinking, and body language that supports speech. Each of these elements makes it easier for clients to understand you.

Public speaking is inseparable from the broader thinking around sales methods. It serves as the vehicle for the entire sales pitch. It represents the form – in contrast to the techniques outlined in this book, which represent the substance.

The way in which you speak has a significant impact on how a sales conversation unfolds.

Even the best message collapses if it's not delivered well.

The wealth manager is an "agent of clarity," helping the client see themselves more clearly. Their role is to structure their speech in a way that supports the client's understanding. By doing so, they help the client gain clarity.

To do this well, the RM should keep the following key balances in mind:

- a balance in speaking time,
- a balance in the types of questions asked,
- a balance between making proposals and responding to the client,
- a balance between body language and posture between both individuals.

Maintaining these balances allows you to:

- Deliver a coherent presentation.
- Prepare your content effectively.
- Reflect on the impact and meaning of your message.
- See and use the space more effectively.
- Engage with the audience to help maintain balance.
- Add emphasis and variation to your speech.
- Adopt a "teaching" tone that aids the audience's understanding.

2. PUBLIC SPEAKING IS STRUCTURED LIKE A COMMERCIAL EXCHANGE

The structure of a commercial presentation intended for a client has certain features. Wealth managers who adopt these key characteristics will go on to develop a working model with automatic habits.

Reflex 1: Understanding the reasons for your speech:

- Identify why you are speaking.

Is your goal to:

- Convince your audience?
- Share information?
- Attract attention?
- Convey an emotion?
- Encourage action?

Reflex 2: Factors you be clear on before you start speaking:

- The time available;
- The size of the audience;
- The tools or visual aids will you to hand;
- How experienced or knowledgeable your audience is;
- The appropriate level of language to use;
- Whether there any family or professional relationships in the room
- Whether there are any allies or potential opponents in the audience.

If you're short on time, it's better to send one single message rather than rush and send 10!

Reflex 3: The classic structure of a presentation

1. Gather your arguments and collect the information you'll use to reach your goal.
2. Organize these arguments in a logical sequence that lead up to a call to action (CTA). At this stage, list facts, supporting evidence, your key strengths (USPs), weaknesses (objections you've already addressed), fallback arguments, and possible concessions.
3. Think about how to present your message in a way that aligns with your audience. Should your delivery be expressive and energetic, or more low-key? Consider your voice, gestures, pace, and tone.
4. Write down your talk. The best way to overcome the fear of "going blank" or struggling to express yourself is to write everything down. It's a way of offloading your emotions. It can also be useful to rehearse in front of a trusted and friendly audience.

When it comes to structure, there's no ideal number of sections in a presentation. However, experience shows that four parts tend to work well:

- an introduction
- two main development sections
- a conclusion

NINE TIPS FOR WRITING A PRESENTATION

1. Define your objective.

2. List all the questions your presentation should answer.

3. Gather all available information, with no sorting, no discarding, and no rejecting at this stage.

4. Step back and put the material aside briefly.

5. Check for relevance and eliminate anything that doesn't help answer your questions.

6. Organize the remaining content into categories: key ideas and secondary points.

7. Write the main body of your presentation.

8. Clean it up — polish your language, fix grammar and spelling.

9. Structure your presentation with a title, table of contents, introduction, and conclusion.

Reflex 4: Take special care with your introduction, it's the first act of selling to your audience. You're essentially selling the topic and making them want to hear more (a lot like a pitch).

Your introduction might include:

- Presenting the overall issue, explaining the topics, and showing why they matter to your audience.
- Delivering a strong opening line, which acts as a "hook" to capture interest.
- Outlining the structure of your talk and teasing the key messages of each part.
- Letting them know how long it'll take (the shorter the better!).
- Explaining how the session will unfold, including whether there'll be an opportunity to ask questions at the end.

The introduction is like a handshake between the speaker and the audience. It is, let's repeat, the part that deserves the most attention during preparation.

"I say what I'm going to do, I do what I say, I say what I do."

Reflex 5: The two development sections

The two central sections of your presentation are designed to convey messages and incite action. Here, your language should be persuasive, and your delivery must reflect that aim. As a speaker, you need to be aware of how you use your voice, tone, volume, and pace.

Now is the time to bring in your arguments that you identified during the preparation phase. They should flow logically and form a clear line of reasoning. It's a good idea to start with the weakest argument and leave the most convincing until last.

The conclusion

The conclusion is the last thing your audience will hear, and the part they're most likely to remember. It should be the "highlight" of your presentation, the most important moment. A good conclusion briefly summarizes your main points, brings energy and clarity in terms of both the content and its delivery, and ends with a direct call to action.

3. THREE RHETORICAL TECHNIQUES TO GET YOUR MESSAGE ACROSS

1. A picture is worth a thousand words. This saying sums up the power of the visual. Like an analogy or a metaphor, an image carries meaning. The aim is to spark the imagination of your audience.
2. Commercial empathy is about putting yourself in your audience's shoes. Think carefully about which arguments will have the greatest impact, whether that's a key statistic or a powerful phrase. The same topics will be approached differently depending on who is sat in front of you. Who are they? What's the context? Your delivery needs to adapt.
3. Storytelling is about holding attention by sharing anecdotes or real-life stories, using humor, or even asking rhetorical questions to keep your audience engaged.

If I have doubts, they'll have doubts!

As a speaker, my behavior has a direct impact on how the audience behaves. What I feel, they will feel.

4. MANAGING THE GROUP

In any client group, opinions will vary, and it's perfectly normal for some people to express them. The entire philosophy behind handling objections is equally relevant here. Reactions are often nuanced. Some audience members may support or oppose your ideas, while others remain passive or engaged. You'll also need to pay attention to the undecided.

It's a classic technique in any public speaking scenario to engage allies first. Their early support helps anchor your argument and form a defense against dissent. The undecided require clarification and validation of their understanding, and this often nudges them toward commitment.

A skeptic might not adopt your ideas, but as long as they're not hostile, just showing you understand their position usually keeps things calm.

Someone who's clearly unhappy is another matter, and they'll likely try to throw you off. The best move is to take charge early and ask them to save their questions until the end.

Original presentation technique

This method involves building an interactive presentation by inserting questions throughout. These questions are addressed at your client, allowing you to maintain their attention and ensure they're following. It helps the relationship manager keep a tight connection with the client.

THE STRUCTURE OF YOUR PRESENTATION	QUESTIONS TO ASK YOUR CLIENT	POSSIBLE REACTIONS
Who are we? Our history, my background.	What is your history as an investor?	Show appreciation for the client's journey.
How do we operate?	How do you manage your investments?	The RM confirms they have understood the client's response.
Why work with us?	What are you ideally looking for?	The RM confirms shared objectives and expectations.

You need to be passionate, not just talk about your passion.

5. IMPROVISATION

It's the form of speaking we're most often called upon to do. Every day, we're asked to speak about a topic without having prepared in advance.

Preparing for improvisation

Improvising assumes you already know your material — you can't improvise on… nothing.

There are several ways to kick off an improvised speech:

1. Emotional opening – *"I liked this because…"*
2. Rational opening – *"This issue can be approached from two angles…"*
3. Digression – Starting with a broad idea and narrowing down to a clear conclusion.
4. Narrative opening – *"I remember when…"*

Three ways to structure your thinking during an improvised speech:

- **Chronological structure:** the simplest way to present a story or event, in time order.
- **Categorical structure:** Organizing ideas by order of importance.
- **Association of ideas:** linking concepts together based on a personal or subjective connection.

The five approaches to improvisation:

Sequential approach:

– "Thank you. I'd like to say three things /make three points / present two ideas."

Goal-Based Approach (Goal, Means, Timeline):

– What's the goal? How do we get there? When do we act?

DAO Approach:

– **D**efinition (What are we talking about?)

– **A**nalysis of the topic

– **O**pinion or recommendation.

Chronological Approach:

– Yesterday, today, tomorrow…

Narrative approach:

– A symbol, metaphor, or proverb to weave your message and hold the listener's interest.

We suggest mixing and matching these methods to create an improvisation style that works for you.

6. TABLE SHOWING THE MOST INFLUENTIAL PARAMETERS FOR PRESENTING A BANK

We carried out an in-depth analysis of the commercial literature from 15 major banks and extracted the following parameters:

PARAMETERS	PURPOSE AND OBJECTIVE	COMMENTS OR QUESTIONS
The bank's history.	Brief history including key dates.	Who are the bank's owners? Are they easy to reach?
The bank's values, culture, and working philosophy.	Describe how these are lived and expressed within the organization.	What is the bank's vision for the future? What values does it publicly promote?
The bank's commitments in line with its identity.	Commitments to responsible investment, philanthropy, social causes, or sponsorship efforts.	Give one or two concrete examples.

PARAMETERS	PURPOSE AND OBJECTIVE	COMMENTS OR QUESTIONS
The bank's geographical location and its advantages.	If the headquarters is in Switzerland, deduce the advantages of Switzerland (stability, chocolate, etc.)	Mention geographical locations.
The bank's business areas and competencies.	How does the bank respond to its clients' complex requests?	The different business lines and their main functions.
The bank's organization and structure.	Present an organizational chart if relevant.	Highlight the robustness of the organization.
Introduction to staff directly in contact with the manager.	If possible, include a photo to put a face to a name.	Internal bank documentation.
Key figures representing the bank (net results).	Main results as well as total AUMs, equity capital, and various ratios.	The bank's diversified activities for clients from all sectors.
The bank's network and presence in its home country.	Its local and international presence.	Its international presence if relevant for the client.
Financial scope.	Financial weight of each subsidiary.	Competitive benchmark with other banks in the market. If relevant, ratings from major agencies.
Local and international competitors.	Who are they? Foreign banks playing in the same category or not?	How does the bank position itself against competitors? Its place in the local or international market.
Clear and successful strategies implemented by the bank.	Demonstrate the most judicious past decisions.	Provide concrete examples.
Positioning of each entity and their product preferences.	Specific positioning of each entity in terms of client specialisation, products/services, and expertise.	The bank's positioning and promise to reassure clients.
Client distribution by entity.	Figures and trends. Number of clients (if relevant) and geographical segmentation.	Client structure and diversity. AUM segmentation. Who are the target/preferred clients?
Client profiles by wealth bracket.	Understand the product breakdown and sales efforts.	Present typical profiles offered (conservative, dynamic, growth, etc.) in various currencies.
Relationships between subsidiaries.	Beneficial synergies to clients.	To recommend a more practical connection to the client.
Is the bank affiliated with a large group?	If yes, what partnerships exist?	List the advantages of the large group.

PARAMETERS	PURPOSE AND OBJECTIVE	COMMENTS OR QUESTIONS
The bank's strategies that have led to success.	Highlight all awards received by the bank or its experts.	Show pictures and videos.
The bank's business model.	How is it organized around the client?	Provide concrete examples.
Discretionary mandates, advisory offers, and trading (execution only)	Include a track record of the past 10 years.	Present a table for each mandate showing: maximum and minimum performance, duration, advantages and disadvantages, levels of volatility and risk.
Mandates – how do they work?	A kind of user guide for choosing: "We advise, you make the decisions."	List the different mandates and their characteristics.
Annual costs of mandates	Demonstrate transparency.	Show the relevant document, provide examples.
Complex collaboration possibilities.	Engineering and financing (private equity, private assets).	Share success stories.
Administrative procedure.	Which documents need to be signed and why.	Provide an estimated timeframe.
How are investment decisions made?	The role and composition of the investment committee.	Personal introduction to the CIO, if possible.
Specific expertise the bank can offer clients.	Share a list of experts and their specialties.	Preferably an in-person introduction or, failing that, a photo.
Highly specialized client groups.	Expatriates, nursing services, legal and tax services.	Family office services.
Access to all the possibilities offered by the bank.	Provide a comprehensive table of products offered and cross-reference with the types of clients who can access them.	Same for services: financial planning, estate planning, foundations, real estate, art advisory, risk management, asset management, wealth management, solutions for complex situations…
Sales argument: Why choose our bank?	Strengths, unique selling points, the most precise arguments.	Presentation of arguments.
The commercial approach: How does the client choose their type of management?	Techniques used to assess wealth situation, risk and return objectives.	What choices are available to clients and how are they determined during the sales process?

7. THE BASIS OF PUBLIC SPEAKING: BRAND IMAGE

Here's a quick reminder of the bank's positioning and the main ideas behind its linked to image.

Every organization has a brand image. It serves as the driving force behind the impact the bank aims to make in the market. The key to a strong brand image is maintaining consistency between perception and reality. A powerful image helps create value. This applies both to the bank itself and to individual wealth managers, each of whom must maintain and build their personal brand.

Questions to ask about your brand image:

Your brand values:
What are your key values and why are they important?

What emotions would you like to convey to your customers?

What do you want them to connect with?

Your commitments and promises:
What are your commitments to your clients? What are you prepared to promise them to keep them satisfied?

The purpose of your role as a wealth manager:
How do you see your role?

How would you like your brand to evolve over time?

What future goals would you like to achieve?

Implementation—your approach to action:
What is your action plan?

How will you bring all the previous answers to life through practical application?

8. TEN TECHNIQUES TO KEEP THE AUDIENCE'S INTEREST ALIVE

1. Enthusiasm is contagious, especially when the speaker is truly interested in the topic; this positive feedback loop drives engaging exchanges.
2. Start by clearly stating the goal of your presentation and keep reminding your audience of it during and at the end of your talk. Ask yourself, "What do I want my clients to take away from this?"
3. Have a structured plan and follow a clear presentation outline. This prevents listeners from getting lost and keeps their interest alive. The presentation should proceed logically, step by step. This is what will capture and maintain the audience's attention. The plan should ideally be visible or announced in advance to help follow it effortlessly.
4. Keep on track and avoid going off on too many tangents.
5. Pay attention to your audience's rhythm. Tailor your talk to what interests them and relate your message to their experience, so they really feel involved:

- Begin with their needs and expectations.
- Remind them of the background, why it matters to them, and how it benefits them.
- Take into account their experience and knowledge.
- Discuss the decisions to be made and the actions to be taken.

6. Awaken your listeners' curiosity with open rhetorical questions. Build anticipation ("I'll be talking soon about…"). Grab attention by using something unexpected and don't be afraid to surprise. At the same time, familiar elements also keep people interested.
7. Use variety in your physical expression and gestures, voice and eye contact, tone, and speaking pace.
8. The form of your speech can change throughout the presentation, using Use simple storytelling tricks. Bring in vivid images, anecdotes, and real stories. Aim for the flow of a story instead of standard narration.
9. Humor is a powerful tool for conveying messages but use cautiously as it can backfire if misused. Authenticity is always the best approach during a presentation.

PRESENTATION EVALUATION GRID

The different ways our bodies reveal the things we don't say…[1]

	PASSIVE OR ACTIVE	MANIPULATEUR
EYES	Evasive, elusive, downcast. The more people like each other, the more they make eye contact. The better eye contact people have, the stronger and more effective they are considered by others.	Evasive or domineering depending on the circumstances.
POSTURE	Slumped, head down, shoulders drooping, body folded in on itself. Head upright and gazing into the distance.	Sagging or imposing depending on the other's weaknesses.
GESTURES	Anxious: excessive or minimal gestures, twisting hands, covering the mouth, retreating movements, lowered head, slumped shoulders, crossed arms for self-protection, gestures indicating resignation, shrugging, hesitant movements.	Assertive, passive, or aggressive gestures, depending on the person's weaknesses.
FACIAL EXPRESSION	Overly smiling or overly serious, attempting to mask true feelings. Faint, hesitant smiles when angry or criticized; raised eyebrows (e.g., awaiting reproach), rapid facial expression changes.	Masks objectives; reveals only what impresses.
VOICE	Low, overly soft, whiny, constricted throat, diminishes verbal impact, trembling, flat, monotone, falling pitch at the end of sentences.	Too soft or too loud, depending on the desired effect on the other person.
MODE OF EXPRESSION	Hesitant, interrupted by frequent pauses, abrupt changes in tempo; frequent throat clearing.	Flattering, insinuating, falsely intimate, deliberate hesitations, theatrical, exaggerated emotion.

To conclude this chapter on speaking, here's a simple exercise you can do in the privacy of your bathroom, in front of a mirror. You need to "walk the talk" to get your message across. A strong voice goes hand in hand with a strong gesture. Speech comes from the body, but the body also speaks. This is an excerpt from the famous "nose monologue" in Cyrano de Bergerac by Edmond Rostand (Act 1, Scene 4)[2].

Classic but so effective.

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1 Boisvert, J., & Beaudry, N. (2024). *S'affirmer et communiquer* ("Assertiveness and communication). Montréal, QC: Éditions de l'Homme.
2 Translated from the French by Gladys Thomas and Mary F. Guillemard

"Ah no! young blade! That was a trifle short!
You might have said at least a hundred things
By varying the tone. . .like this, suppose, . . .
Aggressive: 'Sir, if I had such a nose
I'd amputate it!'

Friendly: 'When you sup
It must annoy you, dipping in your cup;
You need a drinking-bowl of special shape!'
Descriptive: ''Tis a rock!. . .a peak!. . .a cape!
—A cape, forsooth! 'Tis a peninsular!'
Curious: 'How serves that oblong capsular?
For scissor-sheath? Or pot to hold your ink?'
Gracious: 'You love the little birds, I think?
I see you've managed with a fond research
To find their tiny claws a roomy perch!'
Truculent: 'When you smoke your pipe. . .suppose
That the tobacco-smoke spouts from your nose—
Do not the neighbors, as the fumes rise higher,
Cry terror-struck: "The chimney is afire"?'
Considerate: '

Take care,. . .your head bowed low
By such a weight. . .lest head o'er heels you go!'"

Have fun!

An expert's perspective

Insights from a branch manager at a Swiss bank.

Lewin's analysis and the constellation of influences surrounding our clients.

A striking real-life case of a poorly handled failure …

The RM established a thoroughly positive connection using sound sales techniques. His client, who had a distinguished career in the city police force, was persuaded by all the RM's solid arguments. The agreement was signed, and the client transferred funds to the bank. Everything went smoothly. This was no mean feat, as the client had to change his primary bank, which is never easy. The relationship remained friendly, although the client was known to be cautious.

After a week, the manager received a surprising call from his client, who suddenly seems distant and cold. The RM responded in the perfect way by visiting the client's home, where they met face to face. The client announced his departure, offering superficial counterarguments that the RM handled easily. Despite this, the client still left the bank. This was a highly skilled manager, so what went wrong?

A factor prior to the decision:

The RM should have analyzed all the client's areas of influence (Lewin's analysis). They must assess the client's fears and their susceptibility to influence. When these vulnerabilities are detected, the RM must take necessary precautions: verify several times and even have the client sign to ensure commitment. They need to know every facet of the client's personality.

A factor after the decision:

The RM did not attempt to confront the client with their values – those of personal commitment, keeping one's word, and signing a contract. He did not appeal to this aspect to try to win the client back once more.

Sales lesson:

When losing a contract, the RM should insist on understanding the deeper reasons: "I respect your decision, but the way you respect me is by telling me why."

We spent a lot of time studying this case. The philosophical manager said he was playing the long game and believed the client would come back in a few years.

Spring into action!
5 key takeaways and an exercise

FIVE KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. Public speaking reflects our full personality and reveals all our intentions.
2. Structure your talks to make your message easier to understand.
3. Prepare every time, whether you're meeting one person or a roomful.
4. If you doubt yourself, they will too!
5. Use the techniques you've learned to consciously maintain your audience's attention.

EXERCICE

Title: I don't represent the bank; I am the bank!

Aim of the exercise: Embed key reflexes in your public speaking.

Instructions:

- Write a rough outline for a bank presentation.
- Is it sufficient? What's missing?
- What are the three techniques you use in your presentations to capture your audience's attention?

14

Cultural awareness, etiquette, and time management for wealth managers

Beyond acculturation, cultural adaptation
is an operational skill for managers.
Knowing how to behave and respecting social norms
is the height of good manners.

TEACHING OBJECTIVES

After reading this chapter, you will be able to:

- Take control of how your own image.
- Observe proper etiquette, dress codes, and general courtesy.
- Communicate thoughtfully and with restraint.
- Manage your commercial time effectively.

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I am the bank!

The wealth manager's role involves representation and interpersonal contact, regularly meeting clients from a variety of cultures and professional backgrounds. To these clients, they embody discretion, trust, and reliability – qualities the clients expect to perceive without a word being spoken.

A wealth manager must be able to manage their image effectively

This is a highly regulated profession, with strict codes of conduct. The stakes are high.

Appearance is of vital importance, as it reflects the cultural context in which one evolves.

A manager personifies their institution and its values, which can help build consistent and persuasive commercial arguments.

A bank's culture is expressed through the personal style of its manager. There must be consistency at every level:

- in the meeting spaces,
- in the objects and materials used,
- in the documents shared,
- and in conduct during interactions, especially in respect of dress codes.

Each time the manager meets with a client, they are like a walking advertisement for their bank.

The image we project is shaped by a multitude of elements that may align or clash. Depending on their background, education, and culture, our clients or colleagues will either relate to or feel distanced from the image we present. If they see something of themselves in us, like a reflection in a mirror, the response will be positive. If not, the relationship manager will need to overcome that initial obstacle.

What are the key points to watch out for and the codes to follow?

1. Overall, awareness and management of one's image.
2. How you approach others at events: making contact, keeping the right distance, starting a conversation, and knowing how to leave.
3. Dress codes.
4. Classic standards of courtesy, such as the art of language, the art of conversation, and common pitfalls to avoid.

1. IMAGE IS PART OF A SALESPERSON'S CAPITAL

Wealth managers cannot not communicate. They are not an image; they have an image!

- But does that mean they are trapped by it – enslaved by the expectations of their environment, with no room for maneuver?
- Will they lose their identity by following all our etiquette recommendations to the letter? (The answer is no.)

SICILIAN PROVERB

"If you throw spaghetti at the wall, some of it will stick."

It's the number and volume of contacts that determine the success rate in sales. The refinement and nuance of selling come into play afterwards.

The dangers of dissonance

Your image makes an instant impression. When there is dissonance, the judgment formed is hard to reverse and technical skills alone won't be enough. A salesperson's credibility is largely shaped by the first impression they make.

Because this is how trust is built: highly competent individuals with a poor image can ruin a meeting and make strong performance go unnoticed. High-quality service can be completely overlooked due to poor appearance.

By reflecting on brand image and respecting established codes, banks gain free and powerful advertising.

We're not all on equal footing when it comes to the ideal image spread by social media. What truly sets us apart is how well we understand the cultural codes of our clients. We each have our own strengths, but everyone can build credibility by learning and applying these codes.

The power that comes from birth, name, title, education, and wealth is something we inherit;

authority, on the other hand, is something we build.

That is the focus of this chapter on image.

Knowledge of social codes is what we call good taste or good manners[1]. Ces deux notions changent et évoluent en fonction des cultures et des pays. La connaissance et le respect des codes sont des signes d'appartenance et d'adhésion à un groupe.

These two concepts vary and evolve across cultures and countries.

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1 E. Lussetti, "Etiquette and Protocol" course, CAS 2008. Inspired by the work of Marie Louise Pierson, *L'image de soi (The Image of the Self,)* Éditions d'Organisation.

Knowing and respecting social codes are signs of belonging and commitment to a group.

The aim isn't to put you in a box or force you to conform, but to find harmony between your personality, the codes of those you interact with, and the culture of the institution you represent. We do not believe in perfect appearances.

For any manager who cares about their image, the real question is:

Are you aware of the message your personal image is sending?

2. MEETING PEOPLE AT AN EVENT

This section expands on concepts already covered in Chapter 7.

The most common situation for a manager is to attend an event (in the broadest sense of the word) with the goal of making as many connections as possible, even though *quality* is always preferable to *quantity*. If your organization is hosting the event, your role becomes especially key: personally welcoming new guests, thanking attendees (some of whom may have traveled far), helping with initial logistics (cloakroom, orientation, etc.).

Your presence is about building bridges between guests.

A. INTRODUCING SOMEONE YOU KNOW TO SOMEONE ELSE

What are the rules of introduction at an event?

- Newcomers are introduced to those already present.
- A man is introduced to a woman.
- A junior employee is introduced to a superior.
- A younger person is introduced to an older person.
- A colleague or superior is introduced to a client.
- A guest or business contact is introduced to an official.

Introductions should be simple and direct, without any embellishment or exaggeration (e.g. "*May I introduce Mr X*"). Commercially motivated introductions should always take place in a business context; outside of such settings (e.g. in a church or at a funeral), it would be inappropriate to introduce someone to another.

B. INTRODUCING YOURSELF DIRECTLY TO SOMEONE

When you don't have the advantage of being introduced by another guest, introduce yourself directly in a positive and gracious manner.

Approach with a warm smile and an open attitude.

Do not interrupt an ongoing conversation; wait for a suitable moment to greet the person or people, thanking them for allowing you to introduce yourself. In this situation, effective conversation openers include:

- Begin with eye contact, which is the first point of connection.
- Say your first name clearly, then your last name, and mention your company.
- Stay focused on faces and names to help you remember them.

If someone introduces you, keep your response natural and straightforward (e.g., "*Hello Mr X, it's great to meet you…*"). It can be helpful to learn a bit about the person beforehand if you know you'd like to speak with them.

Give them your full attention, get them talking about themselves, ask questions – that's the key to forming a connection. If you can then introduce them to someone you know, you've made a strong connection.

C. INTRODUCING YOURSELF TO A GROUP

At an event, you may target a group of people you'd like to build a relationship with. There is always a moment where you can join in; it's just a question of waiting for the right opportunity. Establish eye contact with one or more people in the group, smile, walk over, and introduce yourself. Positioning yourself within their line of sight is a smart strategy. Be sure to observe cultural norms around personal space. If someone can help you "ease" into the group, that's ideal.

Bring two drinks and offer one to someone in the group – it's a clever and nearly foolproof way to start a conversation.

D. FIRST CONTACT WITH A GROUP

Once you've made contact, if a handshake is culturally acceptable, extend your hand – gently and without pressure – to respect the person's personal space. A well-executed handshake plays a crucial role in conveying a positive impression to your conversation partner.

Try out your handshake with a colleague to check if it feels right. It should be neither too limp nor too forceful. Make eye contact with the person as you shake their hand. The handshake embodies the third principle of the iceberg theory. Sometimes it's the tiniest thing that makes all the difference, for better or for worse, like a grain of sand or a drop of oil in the gears.

Over time, conventions about who should extend their hand first – and to whom – have tended to fade. What matters is that your intention is positive and visible; a smile can make up for many breaches of etiquette.

Greetings

Greetings should follow basic rules of courtesy, such as:

- A man should greet a woman first.
- A younger person should greet an older person first.
- An employee should greet their manager first.

Greetings are not always formal; a nod, a smile, and eye contact may sometimes be enough.

The next step is to start a conversation with your contact. The most effective approach is one that puts the other person at the centre of the conversation. Ask open-ended questions about them, their presence at the event, and their interests in relation to it.

Do your homework beforehand so you're able to hold a conversation and engage in an exchange about the artist, the conference, etc.

When attending an event, clients watch how you behave. They're trying to work out whether or not you belong in their world.

Mistakes to avoid:

- Skip the buffet: consider yourself on a diet during the event. Nothing looks worse than a manager clinging to the buffet table, stuffing themselves with canapés….
- Avoid chatting with colleagues: your focus should be on the guests.
- Be careful not to dominate the conversation; give your clients plenty of room to talk.
- Pay attention to any clients standing alone. Make an effort to go and speak to them.

3. DRESS CODES

Looks can be misleading. We all know the sayings: "don't judge a book by its cover," "things aren't always what they seem," and "the clothes don't make the man." Yet in the professional world, the reality often tells a different story.

These codes act as signposts that help people feel part of the same world.

It's essential to stand apart from exclusive groups that tend toward introversion.

Clothing plays a significant symbolic role in society – military uniforms, academic robes, and religious dress all convey both identity and function.

Contemporary fashion trends blur traditional lines, as women's styles increasingly incorporate masculine elements.

So where does the manager fit into all this?

The best strategy is likely minimalist attire. Discretion in every aspect and neutral colors help convey a message that the focus is on the client. The message is clear: "*I'm here to help you be yourself,*" both in terms of personality and investment choices.

True elegance lies in subtlety and refinement, which your clients will notice instantly.

Good clothing stores always have a salesperson ready to give you sound advice.

There are many image experts out there, but here the goal is simply to raise awareness. One key point to consider is the accessories you use in sales meetings, such as pens, notebooks, and watches. These should be high quality but never flashy.

Let's just point out the worst options:

- Clothes that are too revealing for women.
- Anything transparent.
- Too many sequins, to many accessories, too much of anything…
- Any kind of sloppiness.
- Avoid tie clips for men; they're unnecessary and outdated.

Clothing carries symbolic meaning; it represents belonging to a social class, a role, a position, or a group (such as the banking community, for example).

Clothing also influences behavior through the sensations it provides, such as comfort, colors, and style. It helps us to project an image, but it's up to the wearer to demonstrate consistency between what they wear and who they are. Clothing is an expression of the identity claimed by the wearer. We are first seen, and the gaze of others both worries us and affirms our existence[2].

4. THE MOST CLASSIC RULES OF COURTESY

A. OUTDOORS AND IN THE CAR

Occasionally, we find ourselves walking a client a few steps down the street after a meal, escorting them to a taxi. Such acts of courtesy come from common sense and genuine care for others – something that's a bit easier for old scouts like me. Our education has taught us the many small polite gestures that make everyday life more pleasant.

Our client should walk on the right side, except if that side borders the road, in which case we take it.

Ladies are always granted the place of honor, regardless of circumstance.

When driving with a client, it's important to suppress any aggressive instincts and avoid any discourtesy. After all, driving can be a harsh reveal of one's true character!

2 E. Lussetti, course "Etiquette and Protocol," CAS 2008. Inspired by the book by Marie Louise Pierson, *L'image de soi*, (*Self-Image*), Éditions d'Organisation.

B. STAIRS AND ELEVATORS

Who goes first? While etiquette usually requires you to let your client go first, on a staircase the opposite applies. For safety reasons, the client should follow behind you (though rules vary by country). It's courteous to offer the stairs if there are no more than three floors to climb. In an elevator, comfort and personal space take priority. It's best not to enter an elevator that is already crowded. Common courtesy applies: offer discreet greetings when entering and exiting.

C. IS GALLANTRY STILL APPRECIATED?

Gallantry today can sometimes backfire on those who practice it. We should be cautious in how we use it. Above all, gallantry is a sign of respect, not dominance, toward women. Showing respect to a female client is never outdated. Courteous gestures of gallantry include:

- Letting her go first through a door.
- Leading the way in a restaurant.
- Pulling out her chair for her.
- Helping her with her coat.
- Opening and gently closing her taxi door.
- The same recommendations apply to elderly people.

Mobile phone use during client meetings is simple: It should be avoided except when making a call to assist the client (such as scheduling an appointment with an external expert). The phone should be kept out of sight, or at least kept discreet. If the call is urgent, a prior apology is necessary.

D. GIFT-GIVING AND WHEN TO DO IT

After being invited by a client to their home or a restaurant, it is courteous to send a thank-you note. Nowadays, this can be done through the social media platform you use to communicate with your client. Sending a handwritten note on your company letterhead might be a bit much (though it certainly has its charm). Saying thank you takes your relationship to a more personal level. The thanks should happen in two steps: first in person, then in writing. It's purely a matter of social courtesy, with no underlying commercial purpose.

A small thoughtful gesture always has an effect that far exceeds its value. The small gift (we stress small, as expensive gifts are no longer allowed) also demonstrates a good understanding of the client. The manager knows or discovers what the client appreciates. For example, a small lead soldier worth a few dollars given to an enthusiastic collector can open doors in a way that no other gesture could.

E. TABLE MANNERS[3]

Surely there's no need to restate that punctuality is the hallmark of courtesy?

Sharing a meal with clients creates an unusual level of closeness, so be mindful of basic hygiene: nails, ears, hair, and breath. Helping your female neighbor with their chair might feel quaint, but it will still be appreciated. And always keep your phone off the table.

Keep your hands on either side of your plate. Always bring cutlery to your mouth, not the other way round. Use your cutlery starting from the outside and working in. Hold the knife in your right hand, and the fork in the right hand too, when used alone. Never put the knife in your mouth. At the end of the meal, place your knife and fork side by side on your plate. The good news is that it's okay to cut your salad with your knife!

Place your napkin neatly on your lap and return it to the table once the meal has ended. Wait for the hostess to begin eating before starting yourself. When food is passed, take a modest portion. It is also the hostess who indicates when the meal is over. Any thanks or compliments about the meal should be expressed privately.

You're quite exposed in conversation, so turn towards the people next to you, ask questions, show interest, and be an attentive listener. Grand gestures or overly loud or animated speech should be avoided.

5. THE ART OF LANGUAGE

Language is the clearest reflection of who we really are.

Our voice delivers our message; it can instantly irritate a client or, conversely, charm another. Language reveals our origins, whether regional, cultural, or social. It's also the delicate art of punctuation; a misplaced comma can alter the meaning entirely. We can easily fall victim to a wrongly placed comma or an awkward turn of phrase, which betray the clumsiness of a pretentious speaker.

What matters most in a business relationship is choosing the right tone when speaking to prospects. Being understood is key, as is maintaining consistency between how we speak and who we are. Any mismatch can seem absurd, like an adult speaking like a teenager. Conversation is a delicate and nuanced art.

Its well-known secret: start with neutral subjects (travel, the arts), show genuine interest without being nosy, and opt for open-ended questions.

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3 In Bilan Luxe, article by Olympia Wolff, inspired by the book by Bernard de Muralt: *Usages du Monde* (*Customs of the World*). *Le Savoir-vivre dans un monde sans frontières* (*Etiquette in a World without Borders*), Licorne Publishing. www.courtoisiesavoir-vivre.ch

Ten recommendations to refine your language[4] :

1. Use correct grammar and vocabulary.
2. Gather your thoughts before you speak, to ensure clarity and avoid hesitation.
3. Keep things balanced; exaggeration can often appear unrefined.
4. Remain modest and positive (no gossip or backstabbing), as this is the best way to gain acceptance from others.
5. Keep a certain distance: being overly familiar is not good in business relationships.
6. Engage in meaningful conversation; avoid clichés and empty small talk.
7. Avoid sensitive topics such as religion, politics, or personal family matters.
8. Steer clear of funny stories that may be inappropriate or misinterpreted.
9. Ensure everyone in the group has the chance to speak.
10. Never stop listening!

6. TIME MANAGEMENT FOR WEALTH MANAGERS

If I offered you Warren Buffett's fortune – over 100 billion dollars – but in exchange, you'd have to be his age, 92, what would you choose?

I imagine you'd turn down that offer, for one obvious reason: time. It's the most valuable thing we have.

Time is perceived differently across cultures and individuals, but the way it passes is objective. A wealth manager must solve the equation: getting everything done within the time available. Understanding how time is perceived is essential for managing one's schedule effectively. In our line of work, time is almost always seen from a long-term perspective, just like most investments. Short-term thinking rarely works. The first point of harmony to find with a client may well be around tempo: finding the right rhythm to sync with your client's pace.

1. From the start of the client relationship, agree on how time will be managed: how many meetings you'll have, how long they'll be, and how often.
2. Lock in the next meeting before the current one ends; it's a simple, effective way to stay on track.

Wealth managers need to consider time from multiple angles:

1. The cultural dimension: using time as a lever in negotiation.
2. Time management in relation to commercial effectiveness.

4 Course by Eléonora Lussetti on etiquette in private wealth management, CAS 2009: "Image et style, conseils en image personnelle" ("Image and Style, Personal Image Advice.")

A. THE CULTURAL DIMENSION

Time management begins when scheduling appointments. It's important to take into account local scheduling constraints that can differ between regions (such as religious holidays or vacation periods).

Depending on the culture, appointments may be booked well in advance or finalized upon arrival. For instance, in Asia, itineraries are generally planned well in advance, whereas in Middle Eastern countries, it's advisable to schedule and confirm meetings after arrival. To work around this "Mediterranean" style of planning, one technique is to organize a trip once several important appointments are secured, then fill in remaining meetings upon arrival. Leaving some buffer time is essential to accommodate unexpected delays.

B. MEETING DURATION

The average meeting lasts about one hour. It's wise to allocate one-and-a-half-hour time slots.

Meetings may be longer in the Middle East, where the length often inversely correlates with the client's delay. Availability is crucial. In the Far East, meeting durations are usually set in advance.

In some countries, meetings traditionally take place over lunch or dinner, providing additional opportunities to gather information. It's important to keep your commercial objectives in mind.

Punctuality

You could write a whole book on this subject. Punctuality is an expression of culture: a delay seen as unacceptable in Paris or Geneva is often the norm elsewhere. It's important not to impose your own standards of punctuality; the African saying "In Africa, I am African" reminds us to respect cultural differences in time perception when abroad.

Cultural differences may call for flexibility in timings. However, the manager should not lose themselves completely in the local culture; they are there to serve the interests of their client and bank. Maintaining work discipline is essential.

C. USING TIME AS A LEVER FOR NEGOTATION

Lever #1: Using the calendar effectively. Keep your calendar up to date with available business slots, blackout dates, and pre-scheduled bank events.

- When setting up a meeting, be proactive and suggest dates first instead of waiting to respond. The person who takes the initiative in suggesting meeting dates stays in control and subtly secures priority by offering a favorable alternative.

- Block out buffer time before and after your business meetings in your calendar.

Lever #2: Preparation time. Turning time management into a sales asset can be done by sending an agenda or meeting plan ahead of your appointment. This preparation should be blocked off in your calendar as a task in its own right.

- To make the most of your time, understanding the client's objectives makes preparation easier, alongside your own operational goals.

Lever #3: Ask three questions.

Make it a habit, a kind of mantra your clients will come to recognize:

- What's the goal of the meeting?
- What preparation can be done beforehand?
- How long will our meeting last?

Lever #4: Follow-up time after meetings. The question of having two separate calendars – one personal and one professional – is outdated. Two calendars mean twice the risk of mistakes. Electronic calendars make it easy to distinguish and note family commitments, vacation dates, and take these into account when scheduling client meetings. They also allow you to say no to client requests when there is already a private or professional commitment.

Lever #5: Factor in travel time. Create a structured relationship to save time and stay on track. A clear framework helps you avoid getting side-tracked and ensures conversations stay results driven. Meeting the objectives gives you an extra competitive advantage.

Part of this framework includes considering travel and journey times.

- An annual meeting schedule with each client is fast becoming essential. Planning business trips should be one of the first steps when starting the business year.

The question of priorities

The basic distinction between what is urgent and what is important helps us to organize ourselves more efficiently. An action plan comes from combining tasks, a deadline, and the level of priority the client assigns to each.

Asking what should come first is a question to put to your client directly:

What matters most to you?

During sales meetings, time becomes a reflection of our efficiency. Every buying signal should trigger action. By restating the signal, the manager clarifies the client's need and assigns a deadline.

How can we build our "magic" list, or sales network? By meticulously collecting every contact, every handshake, every business card handed out. It's a very time-consuming task, and the foundation of your sales pyramid. It requires constant discipline and a well-organized calendar.

D. MANAGING TIME IN RELATION TO SALES EFFECTIVENESS

2. Segment my client portfolio	1. Have a vision of my business development **Strategic level**	3. Set achievable and realistic goals
	The advantages of my sales performance	
4. Formalize my work processes and identify relevant actions	**Operational level** 6. Monitor and evaluate the achievement of my objectives, analyze my performance regularly.	5. Plan my work, my actions, and my schedule

To remain effective in our role as relationship managers, we must have a clear map of our responsibilities:

- Defining our roles, missions, actions, and objectives.
- Managing our network and client portfolio.
- Managing our priorities and time, as well as identifying the right performance dashboards.
- Organizing our files efficiently.
- This map forms the foundation for structuring our professional time.

Stay focused on your value-added contribution:

- Prioritize the development of the skills that drive your performance.
- Don't overload your calendar with activities that bring no added value to your clients.
- Make full use of the resources provided by your institution. List and review them regularly.
- Plan your commercial activities rigorously and carve out time for reflection and strategic thinking.

WHEN TO PLAN

Think about the most opportune time to book sales appointments:

It's in July, oddly enough)!

There are plenty of reasons why: the weather is good, clients are often more relaxed and open to stepping back, and everyone is eager to wrap things up before heading on vacation...

E. SACRIFICED ACTIVITIES AND THE RELATIONSHIP TO ACTION

Here's a tough exercise. If you approach it diligently, it will give you real insight into how you relate to action. Action is what connects theory to real-world practice in sales.

Consider this scenario: You have a list of clients you ought to approach for active referrals. Will you take action right after making that decision, or are you already finding ways to put it off?

Delaying tasks takes a toll on our mental energy. Why don't we move into action quickly and decisively?

One explanation is procrastination – the tendency to delay tasks that should be done immediately. Another reason lies in our inability to tap into the motivational levers that drive us to take action. Our relationship with action influences how commercially effective we are, which is why this exercise can help us understand what stands between us and action.

The exercise consists of answering a series of four questions, moving from the most general to the most personal. These questions are meant to shake us up:

Why didn't I do this sooner?

Sacrificed Activities Exercise:

List 1

Think and write down two tasks you've been putting off **at work**.

It might be a project you were supposed to start, a suggestion you meant to make, a misunderstanding with your manager that still needs to be addressed, an overdue report, updates you haven't completed, or clients you've been meaning to follow up with.

List 2

Think about and write down two tasks you've been putting off **at home** – things you've delayed for weeks or even months. These could include repainting the kitchen, tidying the garage, or putting together furniture for your children.

Next, think about all those things you often say you'll do "when there's time," and jot them down.

List 3

Take a moment to list two things you've been meaning to do for ages in your **personal life.** This might be things such as catching up with someone over the phone, replying to that long-overdue email, planning a family get-together, finally organizing that promised trip with your kids, having neighbors round, or helping out with a project for your local club.

List 4

Think about and write down two things you've always **meant to do someday** – things like taking that drama class, going on that cultural trip you keep postponing, breaking bad habits, learning a new language, or fulfilling a childhood dream you promised yourself.

Exercise debrief:

WHAT IF… you did what you set out to do?

How will those pending tasks become reality?

We suggest you take each of your answers and set a deadline to complete them. Schedule each activity in your calendar.

If you can't decide after 10 minutes, feel free to remove it.

Use the following table to help you:

Do what I set out to do!

My sacrificed activities I ought to, I want to, I hope to…	**The method** How do I go about… ?	**The priority** How important is this activity?	**The date** When will I do it?

Giving meaning to our actions: the theory of movement

Selling is all about getting moving.

You need to shift from being a stationary manager (sitting) to a more active state. Being constantly on the move means staying motivated.

Every stage of the sales process should end with forward movement, with a Call to Action (CTA).

The relationship manager has two main options: either they can stay on standby, waiting for the client to make the first move, or they can take the lead by being proactive. This might involve providing useful information, inviting the client to events, and other thoughtful gestures.

Our relationship with time reflects how we move forward.

In sales, "*when*" should be a key focus. Timing and follow-up go hand in hand – and follow-up only exists in relation to time.

Movement is also about moving from uncertainty to certainty. The RM must track down the gray areas and relate them to implicit and explicit needs.

Go from wishy-washy to certainty.

Situations that are "wishy-washy" are comfortable for clients. It spares them from having to make any firm or binding decisions.

Clients fear change

They are in an emotionally vulnerable state due to the uncertainty inherent in financial investments. It is a world that is both complex and unpredictable.

The factors that create a sense of vulnerability for clients include:

- the bank's broader context;
- a change in relationship manager;
- changes to the physical environment (e.g. when renovations are taking place at the bank, clients become uneasy).

Only babies with full diapers welcome change!

7. ELEVEN REFLECTIONS ON TIME IN WEALTH MANAGEMENT

1. Consider your own and your client's biorhythms when organizing sales meetings.
2. The difference between action and activity: an action is an activity with a deadline added.
3. We look at our calendars several times a day; that's why your client portfolio must be reflected in it in full.
4. We don't know what the future holds; that's why we should never close doors that might reopen years later. Always part ways with elegance. We live in villages where everyone knows everyone else and meets up again years later.
5. Respect both your time and your client's. If the potential just isn't there, be transparent about your reasons for stepping back. The client has every right to hesitate and take their time, especially when the decision involves something as emotional as their money.
6. Support your client through uncertainty. Reassure them that hesitation is human and stay alert for the right moment to offer creative proposals.

7. Negotiations should happen at the right time and in the right setting. Don't rush into them unprepared.
8. Restrict your proposals to a limited period to gauge the strength of your counterpart's decision-making (their conviction).
9. There should be no such thing as a client who is not visited; having a client means maintaining regular contact at varying intervals depending on their importance!
10. Every client has their own pace and rhythm; everything the client does has meaning, so it's important to understand it or, if not, to ask them. Clients always have concerns beyond the bank. Never show that you are rushed or desperate. Being attentive means never being abrupt and taking your time at every stage. You must hurry slowly!
11. Looking ahead to the future brings us closer to the client.

An expert's perspective

I'm a wealth manager, and in two years I'll retire. I'll finally have the time I lacked throughout my career. This profession has given me a lot: meaningful human connections and material rewards. But I've always felt the pressure of time. Only recently have I realized how unnecessary that pressure was. Why was I always chasing time, when most of my clients didn't feel that urgency or expect it from me? Why didn't I ask them how they related to time?

I had two choices in my relationship with clients: wait for their requests or be proactive by providing them with relevant information. I chose the latter.

My attitude toward time was a bit chaotic; I viewed it as the expression of motion. The "when" obsessed me in business. A big part of my commercial success was due to carefully tracking each of my contacts. I always ensured I was aligned with my clients. I carried a little voice inside me that kept whispering, "Time's running out…" But in truth, it was only me who felt that pressure. While clients appreciated my obvious thoroughness, it was my discipline they respected, not the pressure I put on myself. All that effort, and for what?

If I had one regret, it would be not having given more thought to managing my time. For example, I was frequently out of sync with my natural rhythm. I tackled administrative tasks in the morning when my mind was sharp, but client meetings were held in the afternoon, right after lunch.

I didn't make enough use of my diary as a reference point; I relied too much on my assistant and not enough on myself to plan my time carefully. It's only been in the past few years that I've taken a moment each night to organize the following day, or sometimes on Monday for the week ahead. The results have been remarkable: I'm finally productive! I realize my schedule reflects my strategy. Ideally, most of my time should be dedicated to those I love. How many times, out of habit, did I stay late at the office… for no reason? I regret the time I didn't spend with my beloved wife or my children when they were younger.

On the commercial front, I was much more skilled. I knew how to negotiate at the right time and in the right setting, an art I balanced with patience and agility. I was fast to suggest creative ideas as soon as an opportunity appeared. Like with client visits ("If you don't visit your client, you risk losing them"), I adapted to the pace and needs of each person. Commercial time was no secret to me, but my personal happiness? I neglected it without even realizing.

I should have taken my time to find the balance between these choices, which, in the end, weren't so hard to make. As Edith Piaf sang, "Non, je ne regrette rien" ("No, I regret nothing,"), I just want to share with you my thoughts on time. That's what the author intended – to share with an experienced manager. To you, the readers, my message is hopeful: don't make the same mistakes I did!

Spring into action!
5 key takeaways and an exercise

FIVE KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. You do not represent your bank; you are your bank for your clients.
2. At events, hand out your business card and be visible (but not too visible...).
3. What you wear says a lot about you. Keep that in mind each morning before meeting a client.
4. Be mindful of your behavior and language when dining with clients!
5. Better time management means more time to spend on commercial activities.

EXERCICE

Title: Elegance and tenacity.

Aim of the exercise: Be self-aware and mindful of your time.

Instructions:

- Describe your image as a relationship manager in two lines, then describe the image your bank aims to project. Do they match?
- Name three things you do in meetings that show you know and follow the codes?
- List your three main habits in managing your commercial time.

Conclusion

"Banking is a simple, stupid business."
Edmond Safra

This quote from one of the most prominent bankers of the 20th century highlights the deeply psychological dimension of the profession.

How has this profession evolved over the past 40 years, and how might it change in the four decades to come? As a conclusion, I would like to share my forward-looking answer to this question, based on all the empirical observations I've made during my work in the banking sector.

Several years ago, wealth managers lost the most prestigious aspect of their role: autonomy in investment decisions. This change was ushered in by the rise of centralized management, and reinforced by banks' intensive promotion of discretionary mandates, which clearly served their own interests.

The client relationship has become a team effort. Specialists are now part of the client-facing process, which that wasn't necessarily the case a few years ago. This shift has significantly enhanced both technical competence and the service quality offered by Swiss banks.

The future holds even more personalization, thanks to AI and automation, with relationship managers increasingly incorporating technology into their day-to-day activities.

Artificial intelligence won't spell the end of wealth managers. On the contrary, in a few years it will relieve them of tedious administrative tasks, allowing them to devote more time to the human connection their clients value.

People need to talk, to let go of their worries, to vent a little, and to feel a genuine human connection. They want to feel valued, sipping coffee in an elegant lounge, to be listened to, and to be seen as a person.

Repetitive tasks and endless administrative paperwork will gradually disappear. The time previously spent on non-relational duties will give way to human interaction. With regulations becoming stricter and compliance requirements staying high, managers will need to build even stronger relationships with their clients. Trust makes it much easier for clients to accept limitations.

The future points toward a hybrid approach, blending artificial intelligence with human insight. It is essential that AI serves people, not that people serve AI.

Banks are working to streamline their digital interactions, which will help bring relationship managers closer to their clients. This is not always for the better; they'll be permanently "on duty," available around the clock and expected to respond instantly to all commercial requests.

Client behaviors are shifting in this direction: new generations have a different sense of long-term planning, with shorter horizons. They are tech-savvy and favor immediacy, which they consider a key aspect of quality service.

Young generations have deeply embraced ethical and sustainable standards as essential for their investments. Is this an indication that they will be more attuned to how banks react to worldwide issues?

Fintechs and other new entrants in finance are driving a wave of innovation, making creativity and innovation essential skills for banks. As a result, wealth managers will have to consistently surprise their clients to maintain their edge.

Amid these waves of modernity, there remain constants: the bank's stronghold (in Switzerland) is its ability to manage risks and safeguard clients' assets.

One foot in the past and the other firmly in the future, that's how the bank has managed to thrive for 300 years. Geopolitical challenges have heightened focus on financial risk management and increased the value of financial centers already regarded as secure.

But what does the future hold?

The banking world is one of the most competitive there is, with managers constantly seeking to deliver added value. Banks are pushing the boundaries of service sophistication, which is an excellent sign for the future of the profession. Private bankers today are almost family officers. Their commercial approach has taken on a distinctly Swiss character – discreet but persistent. The perception of client service is evolving; for many, their client's life goals and personal wellbeing now come before capital gains. Wealth takes precedence over the portfolio. The manager becomes their client's right-hand person, helping to plan long-term business ventures, retirement, and tax efficiency.

The client relationship requires constant care. It's similar to Schopenhauer's porcupine dilemma: like all mammals, porcupines huddle for warmth, but risk injuring each other with their quills. If they move too far apart, they get cold. So, they constantly adjust to find the right distance. The same goes for client relationships; too close, and objectivity is lost, much like Icarus flying too near the sun. Too distant, and the relationship becomes bland and meaningless.

These paradoxes are becoming increasingly common among relationship managers, such as the tension between being a generalist or a specialist.

The generalist is someone who knows nothing about everything, while the specialist knows everything about nothing... And then there's the question of loyalty: where should it lie first? With the client, whom the manager hopes will follow them throughout their career? Or with the bank, which feeds them?

They embody their bank in their role as a "one-stop shop." Wealth managers don't just represent the bank; they are the bank. Ultimately, they are often alone in front of clients and must place full trust in their internal support teams.

They work in a fast-moving environment, with clients whose circumstances are always changing. That means constantly reviewing and analyzing needs, much like Sisyphus, endlessly pushing his stone uphill.

To make things even more complex, more and more external advisors now step in to structure and mediate the relationship between client and bank, which is an emerging trend in private wealth management.

For over 25 years, the competition to recruit relationship managers has been fierce. Salaries have skyrocketed but are ultimately capped by the bank's profitability. It is increasingly difficult to recruit managers because their clients simply no longer want to move from one bank to another. This kind of "move" typically only happens once.

Attracting international talent in asset management and technology is another challenge to be addressed. The (typically Swiss) inward-looking tendency is fading within banks, and that's definitely a good thing. Certifications of all kinds have been a positive force in the banking sector, highlighting commercial skills. And that's precisely where the core challenge lies: developing a proactive commercial mindset. That is the goal of this book.

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Acknowledgements and credits

The purpose of this book

This book is about passing things on – I see myself simply as a conduit for knowledge. I've received, and now I share.

I've always favored structure to make things clearer and easier to understand, rather than long-winded narratives or rhetorical flourishes. This book is meant to be discussed and challenged – its value will come from the debate it sparks.

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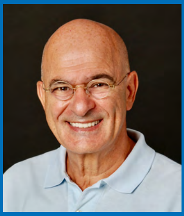

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